# Tools to Design a Biomimetic Humanoid Robot Actuated by Pneumatic Artificial Muscles and a Synthetic Neural Network

by

Ben Bolen

A dissertation submitted in partial fulfillment of the
requirements for the degree of

Doctor of Philosophy
in
Mechanical Engineering

Dissertation Committee:
Alexander Hunt, Chair
Bin Jiang
Radhika Reddy
David Turcic

Portland State University
2026

©Copyright by Ben Bolen
July, 2026
All Rights Reserved

## Abstract

Biomimetic robots offer a platform for studying neuromechanical control through experiments that would be impractical or unethical with living subjects. This dissertation advances a long-running effort at Portland State University to build a humanoid robot, from the trunk down, actuated by pneumatic artificial muscles and controlled by a synthetic neural network. The isometric force of Festo braided pneumatic actuators (BPAs) was characterized over a wide range of resting lengths, contractions, and pressures using a custom test jig. The analysis produced novel equations for the maximum isometric force as a function of resting length and a three-coefficient nondimensional force surface that predicts isometric force from relative strain and relative pressure. The actuator model was carried to the joint level through isometric knee torque experiments on two test stands: a simplified pinned knee and a biomimetic knee with a migrating instantaneous center of rotation. This approach isolated the sources of prediction error, revealing constant length offsets, series compliance in brackets and artificial tendons, and a loss of usable actuator length when BPAs wrap around the joint. The biomimetic knee driven by optimized BPA placements was shown to meet or exceed human isometric knee torque over most of the range of motion. Tools were created for curating relevant neuromechanical research, as well as simulating neuromechanical models based on human and robot biomechanical models.

**Dedication**

*

Darian

azīzam, jānam,

nūr-e cheshmam — the light of my eyes

qorbānat beram

Bābā kheyli dūset dāre

↘ ↘ ↘

*"Los corazones obreros que laten*

*por nuestra causa, felices serán.*

*Si entusiasmados y unidos combaten,*

*de la victoria, la palma obtendrán."*

## Acknowledgments

This work was funded by the Department of Mechanical and Materials Engineering at Portland State University, the National Science Foundation (NSF) grant for NeuroNex: Communication, Coordination, and Control in Nervous Systems (C3NS) #2015317, NSF grant #1943483, and the NIH BUILD EXITO program (grant numbers 5RL5GM118963-06, 5TL4GM118965-06, 5RL5GM118963-07, and 5TL4GM118965-07).

I would like to thank my advisor, Dr. Alexander Hunt, for his guidance, patience, and the freedom to pursue this project, and my committee members — Dr. Bin Jiang, Dr. Radhika Reddy, and Dr. David Turcic — for their time and thoughtful feedback.

I am grateful to my collaborators and labmates: Mohammad Elzein and Lawrence Pang for their work on the actuator characterization experiments; Lindie Burgess and Connor Morrow for their work on the knee torque experiments; Cody Scharzenberger for building the DoggyDeux platform and for his assistance proofreading; Alex Steele, who designed the initial biomimetic four-bar knee linkage used in the torque tests and generously shared solid models and prototype experience; and Jasmine Bradley, whose work reworking the figures improved their aesthetic quality and accessibility for readers with color vision deficiencies.

Finally, I thank my family for their support throughout this long process.

# Contents

**Abstract** **ii**

**Dedication** **iii**

**Acknowledgments** **iv**

**1 Introduction** **1**

1.1 Motivation . . . . . 1

1.2 The Biomimetic Humanoid Robot Project . . . . . 3

1.3 Problem Statement . . . . . 4

1.4 Research Objectives . . . . . 5

1.5 Dissertation Organization . . . . . 6

**2 Background** **9**

2.1 Biomimetic and Musculoskeletal Robots . . . . . 9

2.2 Actuation Technologies and Artificial Muscles . . . . . 10

2.3 Braided Pneumatic Actuators . . . . . 12

2.4 Modeling BPA Force–Length–Pressure Behavior . . . . . 15

2.5 Human Lower-Limb Biomechanics and the OpenSim Benchmark . . . . . 17

2.6 Neural Control of Locomotion: CPGs and Sensory Feedback . . . . . 21
2.7 Synthetic Nervous Systems and the Sensory Afferent Database . . . . . 23
2.8 Simulation Tooling: From OpenSim to MuJoCo . . . . . 25
2.9 Testing Neuromechanical Hypotheses on Robots: The Ethical Case . . . . . 28

**3 Materials and Methods** **32**
3.1 Overview . . . . . 32
3.2 Actuator Force Model . . . . . 33
3.3 BPA Isometric Force Characterization Experiment . . . . . 35
3.4 Robot Leg Model and Knee Test Stands . . . . . 36
3.5 Knee Torque Data Collection and Equipment . . . . . 41
3.6 Hybrid Torque Calculation Method . . . . . 43
3.7 Improved Torque Model . . . . . 43
3.8 Optimization Algorithms and Cost Functions . . . . . 56
3.9 Balance Platform and Inverted-Pendulum Testbeds . . . . . 59
3.10 Prior Neuromechanical Simulation: The AnimatLab Bipedal Walker . . . . . 61
3.11 Preliminary Neuromechanical Simulation Workflows . . . . . 63
3.11.1 AnimatLab Body and Controller Organization . . . . . 64
3.11.2 MuJoCo Conversion and Synthetic BPA Knee . . . . . 65
3.11.3 Simulink SNS Library and Reflex Topology . . . . . 69
3.11.4 Cross-Platform Verification of the Contact-Driven Rhythm Core . . . 73
3.11.5 Spiking-Neuron Mirrors of the Simulation Models . . . . . 73

**4 Results** **78**

4.1 Completed Foundation Studies . . . . . 78
4.2 BPA Force Characterization . . . . . 79
4.2.1 Maximum Force at 620 kPa . . . . . 79
4.2.2 Force as a Function of Pressure and Resting Length . . . . . 82
4.2.3 Maximum Contraction at 620 kPa . . . . . 82
4.2.4 Force as a Function of Pressure and Contraction . . . . . 84
4.3 Isometric Knee Torque . . . . . 87
4.3.1 Flexor on Pin Joint . . . . . 87
4.3.2 Extensor on Pin Joint . . . . . 90
4.3.3 Extensor on Biomimetic Knee . . . . . 90
4.3.4 Flexor on Biomimetic Knee . . . . . 92
4.4 Follow-Up Identification and Route Redesign . . . . . 96
4.4.1 Redesigned-Route Results on the Gait2392 Robot-Body Model . . . . 98
4.5 Balance Platform and Inverted-Pendulum Demonstrations . . . . . 102
4.6 Preliminary Neuromechanical Simulation Recordings . . . . . 103
4.6.1 Cross-Engine Verification of the Contact-Driven Rhythm Core . . . . 103
4.6.2 Headless Validation of the AnimatLab Reference Models . . . . . 105
4.6.3 BPA-Actuated Walker in MuJoCo . . . . . 106
4.6.4 Gait-Validation Sweep against the Locomotion Reference Library . . 107
4.6.5 Comparison of the Production Walker Variants . . . . . 109
4.7 Spiking-Neuron Mirror Results . . . . . 111
4.7.1 MuJoCo Spinal-Network Mirror . . . . . 111
4.7.2 Simulink Spiking Demonstration Twins . . . . . 114

4.7.3 AnimatLab Spiking Conversions . . . . . 118

**5 Discussion** **121**

5.1 Effects of Resting Length . . . . . 121

5.2 Nondimensionalized Force Prediction . . . . . 124

5.3 Comparison with Other Published BPA Models . . . . . 125

5.4 Implications for Real-Time Control and Simulation . . . . . 129

5.5 Biomimetic Artificial Muscle Analogy . . . . . 130

5.6 Sources of Error in Isometric Torque Generation . . . . . 131

5.7 Synthesis: From Actuator Characterization to Neuromechanical Control . . 133

5.8 What Spiking Changes and Does Not . . . . . 135

5.9 What Mono- and Bi-Pulley Routing Buys . . . . . 137

**6 Future Work** **140**

6.1 A Neuromechanical Simulation Pipeline . . . . . 140

6.1.1 From OpenSim to MuJoCo . . . . . 141

6.1.2 Coupling the Synthetic Nervous System . . . . . 141

6.2 A Two-Layer CPG with Sensory Feedback . . . . . 143

6.2.1 Architecture . . . . . 144

6.2.2 Sensory Feedback Channels . . . . . 144

6.2.3 Verification Tests . . . . . 145

6.3 Extending the Sensorium: Vestibular, Ocular, and Cerebellar Contributions . 146

6.4 Physical Realization: A Treadmill Robot with Real-Time Neural Control . . 147

6.5 Toward Dynamic Whole-Body Maneuvers . . . . . 148

**7 Conclusion** **149**

**Bibliography** **152**

**Appendices** **168**

A Appendix A: Muscle Force and Joint Torque Calculations . . . . . 169

A.1 Human muscle force calculations . . . . . 169

A.1.1 OpenSim Thelen2003 and Millard2012 Formulations . . . . . 169

A.1.2 OpenSim Moment Arms and Human Torque Targets . . . . . 170

A.2 Muscle Model Formulations and Cross-Platform Force Comparison . . . . . 171

A.2.1 MuJoCo Muscle Actuator (as converted) . . . . . 171

A.2.2 Cross-Platform Force Comparison . . . . . 171

A.3 BPA Force Model Implementation . . . . . 173

A.3.1 Goodness-of-Fit Metrics . . . . . 173

A.3.2 Strain Measures . . . . . 173

A.3.3 Normalized Force Surface . . . . . 175

A.3.4 Maximum Force . . . . . 176

A.4 Muscle Path Length and Moment Arm . . . . . 176

A.5 Compliance Model Implementation . . . . . 177

A.6 Wrapping-Loss Implementation . . . . . 179

B Appendix B: Neuron Model Equations . . . . . 180

B.1 Spiking Neuron Model . . . . . 180

B.2 Non-Spiking (Graded) Chemical Synapses . . . . . 181

B.3 Relation to the SNS-Toolbox Implementation . . . . . 182

B.4 Spiking-Mirror Implementation, Calibration, and Verification . . . . . 183
B.4.1 Adapting Integrate-and-Fire Cells and Hybrid Synapses . . . . . 183
B.4.2 Calibration of Record . . . . . 185
B.4.3 Verification Gates of the MuJoCo Mirror . . . . . 185
B.4.4 AnimatLab Conversion Variants . . . . . 186
B.5 Connectomes of the Spinal-Network Models . . . . . 188
C Appendix C: Model Geometry, Bracket Frames, and Compliance Parameters . 194
C.1 Static BPA Pathway Data . . . . . 194
C.2 Joint Transformation Matrices . . . . . 198
C.3 Bracket Reference Points and Frames . . . . . 199
C.4 Stiffness Arrays and Compliance . . . . . 200
C.5 Adopted Correction-Term Values . . . . . 202
C.6 Redesigned Extensor Route Geometry . . . . . 204

# List of Tables

2.1 Coefficients of the 10 mm Festo BPA pressure model of Equation (2.1), corrected from Hunt et al. [2017a]. . . . . 17

4.1 Maximum force equation coefficient values with confidence intervals (CI) and goodness-of-fit measures. Equation (3.5) is compared to data taken at 620 kPa. Equations (4.1) and (4.2) are compared against maximum force from using the Festo tool. It was not necessary to fit an adjusted $R^2$ in these cases. . . . . 83

4.2 Normalized isometric BPA force equation (Equation (3.4)) coefficient values and goodness-of-fit measures. . . . . 83

4.3 Optimized coefficient values for flexor and extensor configurations. $X_0$ is a constant length offset (in meters), $X_1$ and $X_2$ are stiffness values (in N/m) in the bracket's X and Y directions, respectively, and $X_3$ is the unitless wrapping factor. . . . . 88

4.4 Goodness of fit for the improved torque model across test configurations. RMSE and maximum absolute residual are in $N \cdot m$. . . . . 94

4.5 Bi-pulley batch on five muscle sites of the robot-body model's OpenSim leg (2026-09-26). Objective 101 is the batch's infeasibility sentinel; all five runs closed with a nonpositive torque margin. The soleus and tibialis-anterior runs converged feasibly (pattern-search exit flag 1), and their objectives are the normalized torque shortfalls; the remaining three runs exited with flag $-2$. 101

4.6 Gait-validation sweep of the four production walking configurations against the 43-cycle locomotion reference library. The score is the production pipeline's cycle-shape kinematic score (0 denotes perfect agreement); the tuning-reference score is each configuration's evaluation on the tuning pipeline's walking reference, and the library mean averages the same score over all 43 references (among genuine gait cycles, higher scores indicate closer agreement). . . . . 108

4.7 Pathway-removal sweep on the tuning-reference evaluation. The score is the production pipeline's cycle-shape kinematic score (0 denotes perfect agreement; $-25$ is the fixed no-cycle fallback, a failed evaluation that scores above every genuine gait in this table). The full-model rows repeat each configuration's unmodified production evaluation. . . . . 110

4.8 Untuned spiking mirror versus its non-spiking twin at the same winner parameters, ground evaluation (16 s). The cycle knee minimum and stance fractions are computed over detected gait cycles; the kinematic score is the cycle-shape error metric of the production pipeline (0 denotes perfect agreement; higher scores indicate closer agreement). The spiking mirror carries mapped parameters only, with zero re-tuning. . . . . 114

4.9 Knee-reflex demonstration, committed baseline versus spiking twin at the matched operating point (5 s runs; settle statistics over the last 2 s). . . . . 116

4.10 Beverage-holding demonstration, committed baseline versus spiking twin (10 s pour; sag measured after 2 s). . . . . 118

4.11 AnimatLab spiking conversions versus their graded baselines (5.1 s headless runs; joint ranges in degrees where the rhythm survives). The thresholds-only ablation converts the neurons but keeps the graded synapses. . . . . 119

5.1 Goodness-of-fit comparison for the Bolen, Sárosi, and Martens and Boblan models at different resting lengths (in mm) for 10 mm and 20 mm BPAs. RMSE and maximum error are reported in newtons, and FVU denotes the fraction of variance unexplained. . . . . 126

# List of Figures

2.1 Kengoro human-mimetic musculoskeletal humanoid . . . . . 11
2.2 Representative robotic actuator technologies . . . . . 13
2.3 Festo braided pneumatic actuator assembly . . . . . 14
2.4 Overview of the BPA force-characterization study . . . . . 18
2.5 Laboratory biped skeleton and OpenSim muscle model . . . . . 19
2.6 Steele biomimetic knee mechanism . . . . . 20
2.7 Locomotor circuit architecture synthesized from the literature . . . . . 24
2.8 Decerebrate cat treadmill experiment, restored footage frame . . . . . 30

3.1 A picture of a BPA in the isometric force test stand with components labeled. 37

3.2 **(A)** CAD solid model assembly of the revolute joint knee in the test stand. **(B)** 1-DoF pinned-joint robot knee in the test apparatus with important components labeled. Leg is shown with 30 degrees flexion, i.e. $\theta_k = -30^\circ$. **(C)** Picture from isometric torque testing. Setup shows the revolute knee configured for a test of the extensor BPA. The knee is flexed with $\theta_k = -120^\circ$. Also note the compressed shape of the inflated BPA on the knee during this high degree of flexion. . . . . 39

3.3 ICR for biomimetic robot knee as a function of knee angle. Measured from $\theta_1$ on the tibia. Plot is overlayed on model of the knee at $\theta_k = 0^\circ$ (solid line), and $-60^\circ$ and $-120^\circ$ (dotted dash lines). White circles represent measured points in $-15^\circ$ increments from $-150^\circ$ to $-15^\circ$, $-5^\circ$ increments from $-15^\circ$ to $0^\circ$, and then at $2^\circ$, $5^\circ$, and $10^\circ$. . . . . 40

3.4 Two-rotation construction of the bracket frame . . . . . 47

3.5 Bracket frame orientations for: **(A)** flexor configuration on the pinned knee, **(B)** extensor configuration on the pinned knee, **(C)** flexor and extensor configurations on the biomimetic knee with $\phi$10 mm BPAs, and **(D)** flexor configuration on the biomimetic knee with the $\phi$20 mm BPA. . . . . 48

3.6 Two-bracket deflection and force-path projection . . . . . 55

3.7 BPA-actuated inverted-pendulum testbed . . . . . 62

3.8 AnimatLab walker and controller hierarchy . . . . . 66

3.9 AnimatLab controller reference schematics . . . . . 67

3.10 AnimatLab working-project interface . . . . . 68

3.11 MuJoCo model representations . . . . . 70

3.12 Simulink SNS library and neuron implementation . . . . . 71
3.13 Complete Simulink knee-reflex topology . . . . . 72

4.1 Results for finding the relationship between $F_{620}$ and $l_0$. (**a**) $F_{620_{10}}$ as a function of $l_0$, at $P_{620}$. Dashed line is the $F_{620_{10}}$ data from Festo. Solid line is the fit from Equation (4.1). (**b**) $F_{620_{20}}$ as a function of $l_0$ at $P_{620}$. Dashed line is $F_{620_{20}}$ data from Festo. Solid line is the fit from Equation (4.2). . . . . 81
4.2 Results for finding the relationship between $F_{620}$, $l_0$, $P_{620}$, and $\epsilon_{620_{10}}$. (**a**) Isoclines of the surface fit for $F_{620_{10}}(l_0, P_{620})$. (**b**) $\epsilon_{620_{10}}$ versus $l_0$ at $P_{620}$. Although there is a general trend of longer resting lengths producing more contraction, no conclusive relationship between $\epsilon_{620}$ and $l_0$ could be deduced from this experiment. The error bars show the effect of being $\pm 1$ mm in measuring $l_0$ and $l_{620}$. . . . . 85
4.3 Surface fit for $F^*(\epsilon^*, P^*)$. Solid lines are from our model. Dashed lines from Festo supplied data. In total, 537 data points were collected and used to fit the 3D surfaces (321 data points for $\phi 10$ mm BPAs and 216 data points for $\phi 20$ mm BPAs). In total, 80% of these data were used for training, and 20% were used for validation. For figure clarity, not all data is included and plotted circles represent collected data at $\pm 10$ kPa of the stated pressure. (**a**) Fit data for $\phi 10$ mm Festo BPAs. (**b**) Fit data for $\phi 20$ mm Festo BPAs. . . . . 86

4.4 Results for the pinned knee joint using flexor BPAs. Dashed black line shows the torque predicted with our original model. Blue dots are the experimentally measured torque. Yellow dots represent the hybrid method of calculating torque. The magenta line represents the predicted torque. **(A)** Measured and pre-optimized torque prediction for the 48.5 cm BPA. **(B)** Measured and pre-optimized torque prediction for the $l_0 = 45.7$ cm BPA. **(C)** Theoretical and measured torque for the $l_0 = 48.5$ cm BPA using optimization results. **(D)** Predicted measured torque for the $l_0 = 45.7$ cm BPA using the optimization results . . . . . 89

4.5 Pinned knee torque versus knee angle with the extensor BPAs. Blue dots are experimentally measured data, yellow dots are hybrid calculated torque, black dashed line is the original predicted values, and magenta line is the optimized predicted torque. For resting lengths, **(A)** 48.0 cm, **(B)** 45.7 cm, **(C)** and 41.5 cm. . . . . 91

4.6 Measured versus expected isometric torque results using a $\phi 10$ mm, $l_0 = 51.8$ cm extensor BPA on the biomimetic knee. Measured results are blue dots. Original prediction is a dashed black line. Optimized prediction is a solid magenta line. Hybrid calculation shown in yellow dots. . . . . 92

4.7 A configuration that is particularly hard to model. The BPA passes between the femoral condyles close to ICR. . . . . 93

4.8 Biomimetic knee torque for **(A)** $\phi$10 mm $l_0 = 41.5$ cm flexor BPA with a 21 mm artificial tendon. Blue dots show the measured torque values. Magenta line is the predicted torque using the improved BPA characterization and optimization from the previous sections. The dashed light orange line shows the torque predicted using only the improved BPA characterization. **(B)** $\phi$20 mm $l_0 = 42.0$ cm flexor BPA with a 15 mm artificial tendon uses the same colors for 620 kPa results. Human values are given as a black dotted line. Due to the BPA exceeding the ultimate strength of the femur, torque measurements were taken at $P < P_{620}$ to show the desired RoM is achievable. Results for torque measurements at 560 kPa, 421 kPa, 325 kPa and 281 kPa (from left to right, respectively), are shown as pink dots. . . . . 95

4.9 Preliminary AnimatLab hip, knee, and ankle recordings . . . . . 104

4.10 W2L rhythm-core traces across engines . . . . . 105

4.11 Constant-drive rhythm, non-spiking versus spiking . . . . . 113

4.12 Ground gait, non-spiking winner versus untuned spiking mirror . . . . . 115

4.13 Simulink knee-reflex twin, baseline versus spiking . . . . . 117

5.1 Comparison between measured and predicted BPA force at varying amounts of contraction and pressure. A $y = x$ perfect fit line is added for reference. The BPAs compared are: (**a**) $\phi$10 mm, $l_0 = 0.257$ mm, (**b**) $\phi$10 mm, $l_0 = 0.233$ mm, (**c**) $\phi$20 mm, $l_0 = 0.300$ mm, and (**d**) $\phi$20 mm, $l_0 = 0.450$ mm. . . . 127

# 1 Introduction

## 1.1 Motivation

Biomimetic robots provide a platform for investigating how mechanical structure and control interact to generate movement, offering complementary insights to simulation-based studies [Andrews, 1985, Millard et al., 2013, Arnold et al., 2010]. Wheeled robots remain the platform of choice in structured environments, where their speed, efficiency, and payload capacity are difficult to match; in the unstructured terrain of the natural and built world, legged machines hold the advantage, and biomimetic legs that reproduce human force capabilities have the potential to excel where wheels cannot [Frey et al., 2026, Ha et al., 2025]. Musculoskeletal humanoids and limb systems driven by tendon-like actuators have been shown to support biologically meaningful experiments on motion generation, internal force transmission, and neural control hypotheses [Asano et al., 2017, 2019, Hitzmann et al., 2018, Liu et al., 2018, Chen et al., 2019]. The dual perspective of using robots to learn about biology, and using biology to design more adaptive robots, has been emphasized in both biomimetic robotics and biomechanics [Ijspeert, 2020, Asano et al., 2017]. With such robotic systems, experiments can be performed that would not be practical or ethical with human test subjects, such as removing a specific muscle from the system or blocking a sensory feedback pathway. Experiments of this kind allow direct testing of how the components of the neuromechanical system interact, and they offer new opportunities for testing neural control theories that are faster and cheaper than human

observation studies [Shin et al., 2018, Goldsmith et al., 2021, Schilling et al., 2022].

Artificial muscles are a key enabling technology for this class of robot. Among the available actuation technologies, McKibben-style braided pneumatic actuators (BPAs) combine low mass, high force-to-weight ratio, and intrinsic compliance with a force–length curve that qualitatively resembles that of skeletal muscle [Liang et al., 2020, Hunt et al., 2017a]. BPAs have been used in quadrupedal robots [Aschenbeck et al., 2006, Hunt et al., 2017a, Scharzenberger, 2019], musculoskeletal humanoids [Asano et al., 2017, Hitzmann et al., 2018], and dexterous manipulation systems [Chen et al., 2019]. However, BPAs also differ from biological muscle in important ways: their maximum tensile force occurs at resting length rather than at an optimal fiber length, their maximum contraction ratio is substantially lower than that of human muscle, and their force output is a highly nonlinear function of internal pressure, contraction, and loading state [Hunt et al., 2017a, Sárosi et al., 2017, Liang et al., 2020]. The author's experience with 10 mm actuators made this gap concrete: manufacturer specifications overstate the force and contraction available at the short resting lengths a leg design requires, published models fitted at one cut length do not transfer to other resting lengths, and designs based on those specifications delivered less range of motion and joint torque than intended. Designing a biomimetic robot around BPAs therefore requires quantitative, predictive models of the actuator and of the joint torques it can produce.

## 1.2 The Biomimetic Humanoid Robot Project

This dissertation is part of a long-running effort at Portland State University to build a biomimetic humanoid robot from the trunk down, actuated by pneumatic artificial muscles and controlled by a synthetic neural network (SNN). The project is deliberately iterative. Knowledge from biomechanics and neuroscience guides the design of robots intended to perform complex tasks in unstructured environments with improved efficiency, balance, adaptability, and resilience. Those robots then become physical models with which biological hypotheses can be tested, validated, and refined through controlled changes that would be impractical or unethical in living subjects. The resulting biological insight informs the next generation of robot design, and lessons from both directions can be translated into improved prosthetic and orthotic devices.

The present work builds directly on a series of studies by the author and collaborators. In the author's master's project, the kinematics and dynamics of a biomimetic robot leg were matched against the Gait2392 OpenSim model, artificial muscle attachment and wrapping locations were determined for the robot legs, and MATLAB tooling was developed for evaluating muscle lengths, moment arms, and isometric joint torques over the full range of motion [Bolen, 2019, Bolen and Hunt, 2019]. That work showed that simply transplanting human muscle attachment locations onto a BPA-actuated robot does not reproduce human torque profiles; the placement optimization that closes this gap was completed during this dissertation and is summarized with the results in Section 4.1. In parallel, a biomimetic four-bar knee linkage with a migrating instantaneous center of rotation was designed and validated by Steele [Steele et al., 2017, Steele, 2018, Steele

et al., 2018], and a canine-inspired quadruped platform, Muscle Mutt, formerly called DoggyDeux, was developed with antagonistic BPA pairs and synthetic neural network control [Scharzenberger, 2019]. That platform extended an earlier AARL demonstration of central pattern generator control of a pneumatically actuated robot [Hunt et al., 2017b].

### 1.3 Problem Statement

Within this context, three gaps stand between the existing robot design and a robot that can walk under neural control.

First, the actuator force models available at the start of this work were inadequate for design purposes. The manufacturer's simulation tool over-predicts the force of short BPAs by large margins, and the published empirical models are fitted to a single resting length each, so they do not accurately predict how force changes when a designer chooses a different actuator length [Sárosi et al., 2017, Martens and Boblan, 2017, Hunt et al., 2017a]. Because muscle resting length is one of the primary degrees of freedom available to the robot designer, this gap blocks rational actuator selection.

Second, actuator force alone does not determine joint torque. The robot knee applies BPA force through brackets, artificial tendons, and wrapping paths. It was unknown how much these effects reduce usable torque relative to the rigid-body prediction, or how to best correct for them. Additionally, the biomimetic knee's optimized muscle routing [Morrow et al., 2020] had never been validated experimentally or compared against human isometric torque data.

Third, no simulation pipeline existed for closing the loop between a musculoskeletal

robot model of this kind and a biologically realistic neural controller. The Neuromechanical Modeling literature provides the ingredients — two-level spinal CPG architectures [Rybak et al., 2006, McCrea and Rybak, 2008], neuromechanical simulation frameworks [Markin et al., 2010], and synthetic nervous system tooling [Nourse et al., 2023] — but they had not been assembled for a BPA-driven bipedal robot with human-like routing.

### 1.4 Research Objectives

This dissertation addresses the first two gaps experimentally and develops the tools and framework needed to investigate the third. The objectives are:

1. **Characterize the isometric force of Festo BPAs** with uninflated diameters of 10 mm and 20 mm over a wide range of resting lengths, contractions, and pressures; derive improved maximum-force and normalized force–strain–pressure models; and compare them against existing models (Chapters 3 and 4, Section 4.2).

2. **Validate and improve the prediction of isometric knee torque** produced by BPAs on pinned-joint and biomimetic four-bar knees; identify and model losses caused by constant length offsets, series compliance, and actuator wrapping; and compare the resulting torque envelopes with human capabilities (Methods Sections 3.4, 3.5, 3.6, 3.7, and 3.8; Results Section 4.3; and Discussion Section 5.6).

3. **Develop tools and a framework for neuromechanical control** of the humanoid robot by converting its OpenSim musculoskeletal model to MuJoCo, implementing an SNS-Toolbox two-level spinal CPG with proprioceptive and heel/toe contact feedback,

and establishing a staged tuning and verification workflow (Methods Section 3.11, Results Section 4.6, and Discussion Section 5.7).

## 1.5 Dissertation Organization

Chapter 2 establishes the technical and scientific context for the dissertation. Sections 2.1–2.4 review biomimetic and musculoskeletal robots, pneumatic artificial muscles, and models of BPA force–length–pressure behavior. Section 2.5 introduces the human lower-limb biomechanics and OpenSim models used as design benchmarks. Sections 2.6–2.8 then describe spinal CPG architectures, sensory feedback pathways, the Sensory Afferent Database, synthetic nervous systems, and the OpenSim-to-MuJoCo simulation tools that support neuromechanical control. The chapter concludes by explaining how robotic systems can provide repeatable platforms for neuromechanical experiments that would be impractical or unethical to conduct on living subjects.

Chapter 3 describes the experimental, analytical, and computational methods developed to connect actuator behavior to joint performance and neuromechanical control. Sections 3.2 and 3.3 present the BPA force model and the isometric force-characterization experiment. Sections 3.4 and 3.5 describe the pinned-joint and biomimetic four-bar knee test stands and the isometric torque measurements. Sections 3.6–3.8 present the hybrid torque calculation method, the correction terms for constant length offsets, series compliance, and actuator wrapping, and the optimization of actuator routes. Sections 3.9–3.11 document the balance and inverted-pendulum testbeds, the earlier AnimatLab walker, and the OpenSim-to-MuJoCo and SNS-Toolbox workflows used to construct and evaluate

the neuromechanical models.

Chapter 4 reports the experimental and computational results. Section 4.1 summarizes the completed foundation studies, including the Sensory Afferent Database and the previously developed modeling tools. Section 4.2 presents the BPA force-characterization data and evaluates the resulting maximum-force and nondimensional force models against the manufacturer's and published models. Section 4.3 reports the isometric knee-torque measurements, identifies the correction terms required to reconcile rigid-body predictions with experimental data, and evaluates their transfer to the biomimetic knee. It also compares the resulting torque envelopes with human benchmarks. Section 4.6 reports the associated follow-up identification and actuator-route redesign. Sections 4.4 and 4.5 document the balance-platform demonstrations and the neuromechanical simulation recordings.

Chapter 5 interprets the results across actuator, transmission, joint, and controller scales. Sections 5.1–5.3 examine the effects of actuator resting length, the nondimensional force formulation, and its relationship to previously published BPA models. Sections 5.5–5.7 evaluate the biomimetic artificial-muscle analogy and the physical sources of error in isometric torque prediction, including series compliance, actuator wrapping, and transmission geometry. Sections 5.4 and 5.8 discuss the implications of the validated models for real-time control and synthesize the force-characterization, knee-torque, sensory-database, and neuromechanical-modeling contributions into a unified actuator-to-controller design methodology.

Chapter 6 presents concrete research opportunities enabled by the models, experiments, and software tools developed in this dissertation. Sections 6.1 and 6.2 explain how researchers can use the OpenSim-to-MuJoCo conversion, SNS-Toolbox coupling,

and two-layer CPG implementation on a reproducible musculoskeletal platform. These tools support controlled comparisons of spinal architectures, sensory-feedback pathways, neural lesions, and stimulation protocols. Section 6.3 describes extensions incorporating vestibular, ocular, and cerebellar contributions, while Section 6.4 identifies ways to deploy the framework on embedded hardware for real-time control of physical BPA-driven robots. Section 6.5 extends these tools to gait transitions, reactive balance, and dynamic whole-body maneuvers. These directions are modular applications of the completed work through which future investigators can reuse, compare, and expand the dissertation's validated actuator models, joint models, experimental methods, and neuromechanical-control tools.

Chapter 7 consolidates the dissertation's principal contributions. It summarizes the improved BPA force models and the experimentally corrected prediction of isometric knee torque. It also reviews the validation of the biomimetic knee and optimized actuator routing and the tools developed for neuromechanical simulation and control. The chapter emphasizes the resulting actuator-to-joint design methodology and explains how the completed experimental and computational foundation supports both improved biomimetic robots and controlled investigations of neuromechanical hypotheses.

Appendix A documents the BPA force implementation, muscle-path and moment-arm calculations, compliance model, and wrapping-loss calculation. Appendix B provides the spiking- and non-spiking-neuron equations used by the synthetic nervous system tools and relates those equations to their SNS-Toolbox implementation. Appendix C records the static BPA pathways, joint transformation matrices, bracket reference frames, stiffness and compliance parameters, and adopted correction-term values.

# 2 Background

## 2.1 Biomimetic and Musculoskeletal Robots

Biomimetic robots offer many potential applications, ranging from assisting in factories and environmental exploration to serving as physical models of human movement. By developing high-fidelity biomimetic robots, we can perform tests that help improve our understanding of both biomechanics and the underlying neuromechanical systems that control movement [Shin et al., 2018, Asano et al., 2019, Ijspeert, 2020, Goldsmith et al., 2021, Hunt et al., 2017b, Schilling et al., 2022]. A few such biomimetic robots exist, such as the impressive Kengoro and Kenshiro robots of Asano et al. [2017] and Asano et al. [2019], which have proportionally human bodies, anatomically correct musculotendon arrangements, rolling-sliding joints, and joint ranges and output power comparable with human-measured values; their artificial muscles are implemented with brushless DC motors, wires as tendons, gears, and integrated tension measurement. A dog-like robot developed by Aschenbeck et al. [2006] and actuated with Festo BPAs was used to show how central pattern generators provide robust locomotion patterns that are adaptive to perturbations in ground speed [Hunt et al., 2017b]. Robots built with artificial muscles thus provide opportunities to investigate how muscles are controlled to produce desired motions; however, artificial muscles do not exactly replicate muscle properties, and existing robots do not capture all of the degrees of freedom and joint torques of the animal limbs they mimic.

Figure 2.1 illustrates the human-scale skeletal structure and tendon routing of this approach.

## 2.2 Actuation Technologies and Artificial Muscles

A wide range of actuation technologies have been explored in robotics, including electric motors, hydraulic systems, smart-material actuators, and artificial muscles [He and Gao, 2020, Liang et al., 2020]. Electric motors are widely used due to their controllability and maturity, but they are limited by thermal constraints, gearing requirements, and reduced compliance compared to muscle-like actuators [Veale and Xie, 2016, Suzumori and Faudzi, 2018]. Hydraulic actuators offer exceptionally high power density and have enabled highly dynamic legged systems, but they remain relatively heavy, less efficient than biological muscle, and require a dedicated fluid infrastructure [Suzumori and Faudzi, 2018]. Dielectric elastomer actuators (DEAs), a class of electronic electroactive polymers, contract by a different mechanism: an applied voltage squeezes a soft polymer film between compliant electrodes through electrostatic stress, and the thinning and radial spreading of the film produces strains that can exceed biological muscle [Madden et al., 2004]. Comparative studies report high specific work and good bandwidth for DEAs [Liang et al., 2020], but kilovolt-range driving voltages, electromechanical instability, and the compliant-electrode requirement have kept them out of legged robots. Closer to muscle, series-elastic and pneumatic actuators trade peak force and bandwidth for compliance, a trade that wearable and rehabilitation robotics exploit because force control and backdrivability matter most when a machine interacts with a human [Aksöz et al., 2019, Leibach, 2020,

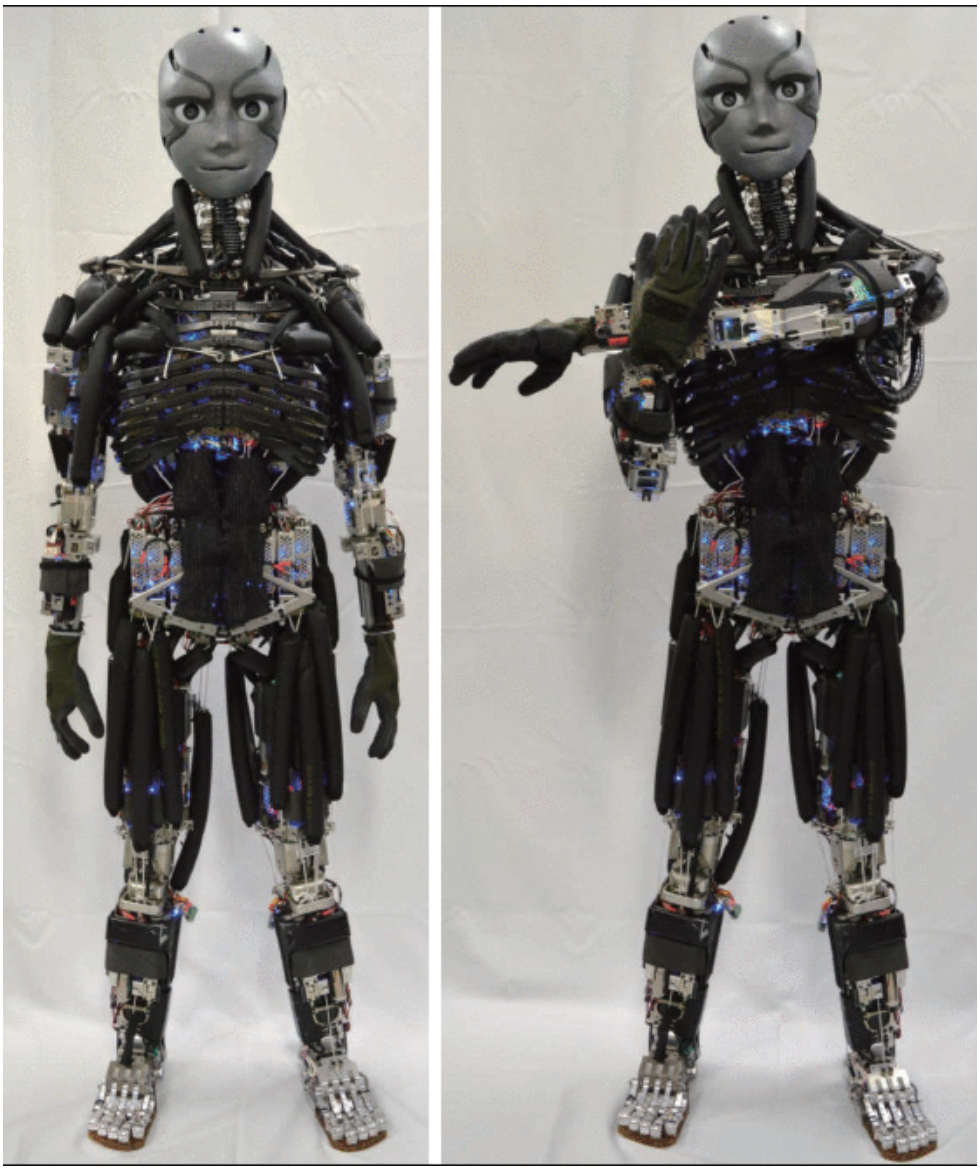


Figure 2.1: Kengoro human-mimetic musculoskeletal humanoid in neutral and upper-limb poses, illustrating its human-scale skeletal structure and densely routed tendon-driven musculature [Asano et al., 2017].

Li et al., 2020]. A recent review of pneumatic artificial muscle technology documents continued progress in actuator design and in assistive applications [Zhagiparova et al., 2025]. None of these technologies yet combines muscle-like force, strain, and compliance in one actuator, which is the combination a biomimetic humanoid leg demands and that braided pneumatic actuators approximate most closely.

Figure 2.2 compares the operating mechanisms of these actuator technologies.

## 2.3 Braided Pneumatic Actuators

In contrast to the technologies above, McKibben-style braided pneumatic actuators (BPAs) combine low mass, high force-to-weight ratio, and intrinsic compliance with a force–length curve that qualitatively resembles that of skeletal muscle [Liang et al., 2020, Hunt et al., 2017a]. A BPA consists of an inflatable bladder inside a braided sleeve; pressurizing the bladder expands the bladder radially and contracts the sleeve axially, producing tensile force. As shown by Chou and Hannaford, the force–length relationship of McKibben actuators is governed by geometric constraints imposed by the braided shell, leading to a nonlinear dependence of force on actuator length through the braid angle [Chou and Hannaford, 1996]: actuator force is proportional to pressure and to a nonlinear geometric term $(3\cos^2\theta - 1)$, which governs both the maximum contraction limit and the curvature of the force–length relationship. Predicting their force as a function of length and pressure is therefore the first improvement of the torque tools developed in this dissertation, and the state of that prediction is the subject of the next section.

Figure 2.3 shows the commercial actuator assembly used in the laboratory.

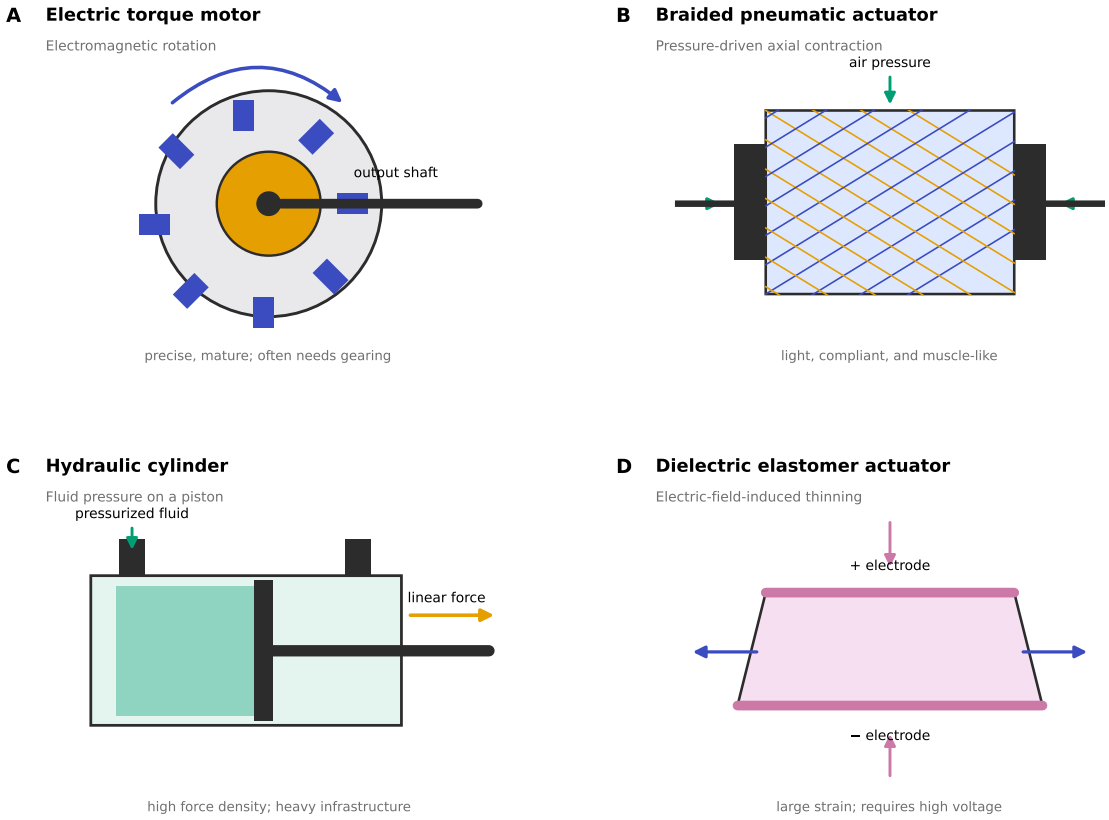



Figure 2.2: Representative operating mechanisms for robotic actuators. **(A)** An electric torque motor produces controlled shaft rotation. **(B)** A braided pneumatic actuator shortens as internal pressure expands its sleeve radially. **(C)** A hydraulic cylinder converts fluid pressure into linear piston force. **(D)** A dielectric elastomer thins and expands laterally under an applied electric field. The panels use a consistent schematic style to emphasize the distinct energy-conversion mechanisms and design tradeoffs summarized in the text [Suzumori and Faudzi, 2018, Liang et al., 2020].

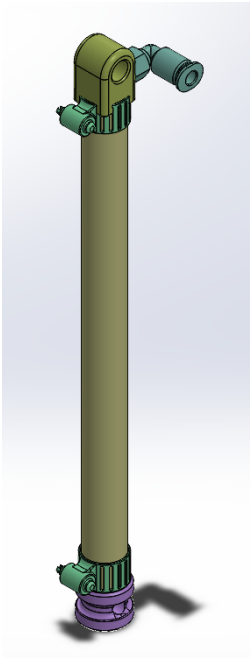


Figure 2.3: CAD representation of a Festo DMSP braided pneumatic actuator with the mounting and pneumatic connections used in the laboratory assembly [Festo AG & Co. KG, 2026]. The long cylindrical body contains the bladder and braided sleeve; pressurization through the end fittings converts radial expansion into axial contraction.

However, BPAs exhibit several important differences from biological muscle. First, BPA maximum tensile force occurs at resting (i.e., uninflated) length ($l_0$) rather than at an optimal fiber length [Liang et al., 2020]. Second, their maximum contraction ratio is substantially lower than that of human muscle, presenting challenges for achieving biomimetic joint ranges of motion [Hunt et al., 2017a, Sárosi et al., 2017, Liang et al., 2020]. Third, BPAs have a highly nonlinear dependence on internal pressure ($P$), contraction ($\epsilon$), and loading state [Hunt et al., 2017a, Martens and Boblan, 2017], which complicates control and motivates high-fidelity force–length–pressure modeling. Despite these differences, their muscle-like properties have made them attractive for biomimetic quadrupeds [Aschenbeck et al., 2006, Scharzenberger, 2019], humanoids [Asano et al., 2017, Hitzmann et al., 2018], and musculoskeletal arms [Kurumaya et al., 2016, Chen et al., 2019].

### 2.4 Modeling BPA Force–Length–Pressure Behavior

Previous studies have generated empirical models of the force–length–pressure relationship of BPAs. Sárosi et al. [2017] discuss several high-fidelity BPA force models. They present a static force model with a 21-coefficient polynomial function for a Festo MAS-20-200N (i.e., $\phi$20 mm, $l_0 = 200$ mm) with an impressive $R^2 = 0.9994$, as well as Sárosi's static force model for a Festo DMSP-20-400N-RM-RM (i.e., $\phi$20 mm, $l_0 = 400$ mm), with six coefficients and a $R^2 = 0.9995$ [Sárosi, 2012, Sárosi et al., 2013]. Martens and Boblan present an even more accurate model, in terms of absolute error, using five coefficients for a DMSP-10-250 (i.e., $\phi$10 mm, $l_0 = 250$ mm) and a DMSP-20-300 (i.e., $\phi$20 mm, $l_0 = 300$ mm) [Martens and Boblan, 2017]. However, as demonstrated in this work, different resting

lengths produce different force–length curves, preventing the use of these single-length models for designing systems with different resting lengths.

Hunt et al. [2017a] looked at six resting lengths of $\phi 10\,\text{mm}$ Festo BPAs, accounting for differences in maximum contractile percentages, and elucidated the force-length-pressure relationship. In particular, for a given contraction percent and force $F$ (in Newtons), the scalar pressure $P$ (in kPa) required to produce this force for a $\phi 10\,\text{mm}$ Festo artificial muscle can be determined by solving the equation:

$$P = P_0 + k_F\,F + k_S\,S + P_t \tan\left(c_a\left[\frac{\epsilon}{\epsilon_{\max} - k_E\,F} - c_b\right]\right) \tag{2.1}$$

where $F$ is the required force, $\epsilon$ is the contraction, $S$ encodes hysteresis ($S = 1$ shortening, $S = -1$ lengthening, $S = 0$ static), and the seven coefficients are defined in Table 2.1. The coefficients have been updated with corrected values, as those reported in Hunt et al. [2017a] contained typographical errors. The contraction $\epsilon$ and the maximum free-load contraction at 620 kPa, which appears as $\epsilon_{\max}$ in Equation (2.1), are defined in Section 3.2, together with the relative contraction $\epsilon^* = \epsilon/\epsilon_{620}$ on which the force surface developed in this dissertation is built. Because Equation (2.1) expresses pressure in closed form as a function of force and contraction, it can also be solved onto a grid of pressures and contractions to build a force–pressure–relative-contraction lookup table for design studies.

Festo provides a manufacturer tool, MuscleSIM, for predicting force as a function of pressure and contraction [Lang, Robert, 2005], but experimental comparisons indicate that it does not adequately account for variation in $l_0$ or actuator-specific contraction limits. Comparisons with experimental data indicate that none of the existing models effectively

Table 2.1: Coefficients of the 10 mm Festo BPA pressure model of Equation (2.1), corrected from Hunt et al. [2017a].

| Symbol | Value | Role |
|---|---|---|
| $P_0$ | 254 kPa | pressure offset |
| $k_F$ | 1.23 kPa $\mathrm{N}^{-1}$ | linear force-to-pressure gain |
| $k_S$ | 15.6 kPa | hysteresis offset (sign of $S$) |
| $P_t$ | 192 kPa | tangent-term amplitude |
| $c_a$ | 2.03 | contraction-shape coefficient |
| $c_b$ | 0.46 | contraction-shift coefficient |
| $k_E$ | $0.331 \times 10^{-3}$ $\mathrm{N}^{-1}$ | force-dependent reduction of usable contraction |

take into account differences in maximum force due to initial actuator length, and the Hunt model was taken with low external forces ($\leqslant$106 N), so it is unclear how well it captures actuator behavior at higher forces. Chapter 4 compares these models with data collected for this dissertation and develops an improved characterization.

Figure 2.4 summarizes the force-characterization workflow developed in this dissertation.

## 2.5 Human Lower-Limb Biomechanics and the OpenSim Benchmark

Designing a biomimetic leg requires a quantitative benchmark of human muscle–joint behavior. This dissertation uses OpenSim [Delp et al., 2007, Seth et al., 2011, 2018] and the Gait2392 model, which descends from the interactive lower-extremity model of Delp et al. [1990] and includes musculoskeletal geometry from Hoy et al. [1990], planar knee kinematics from Yamaguchi and Zajac [1989], and a lower-limb model with 23 degrees of freedom and 54 musculotendon actuators [Arnold et al., 2010]. Muscle moment arms, force-generating properties, and functional roles in such models have been characterized

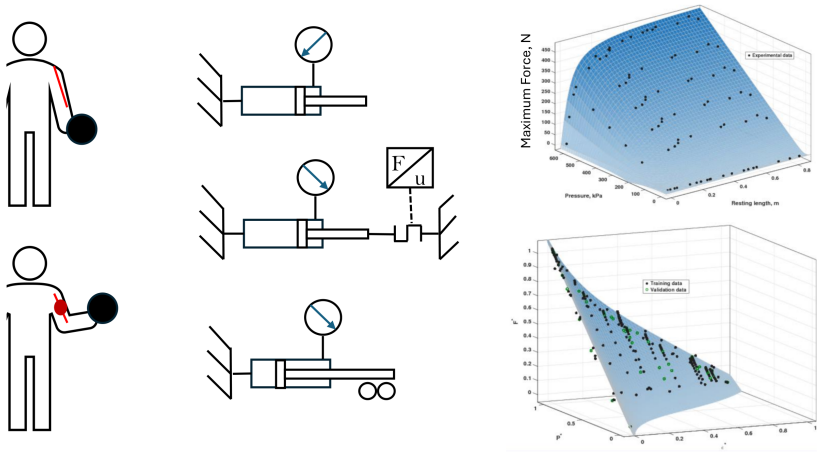



Figure 2.4: Overview of the BPA force-characterization study. Biological-muscle inspiration and the laboratory test apparatus lead to measured force–length–pressure data and fitted force surfaces used for actuator and robot design.

extensively [Zajac and Gordon, 1989, Brand et al., 1982, Menegaldo et al., 2004, Millard et al., 2013, Sherman et al., 2013, Suderman and Vasavada, 2012], and standard reporting conventions for kinematics and joint mechanics are established by the International Society of Biomechanics [Wu and Cavanagh, 1995, Wu et al., 2002, 2005, Derrick et al., 2020]. The human knee is itself a complex joint: its instantaneous center of rotation migrates posteriorly with flexion, a behavior captured by four-bar linkage descriptions of the joint [Romero et al., 2020, Steele, 2018].

Figure 2.5 places the laboratory's bipedal skeleton beside the OpenSim muscle-routing reference developed for it.

Steele's biomimetic knee joint supplies the physical knee used in this dissertation [Steele et al., 2017, Steele, 2018, Steele et al., 2018]. It is a one-degree-of-freedom four-bar linkage whose crossed links reproduce the posterior migration of the human knee's instantaneous

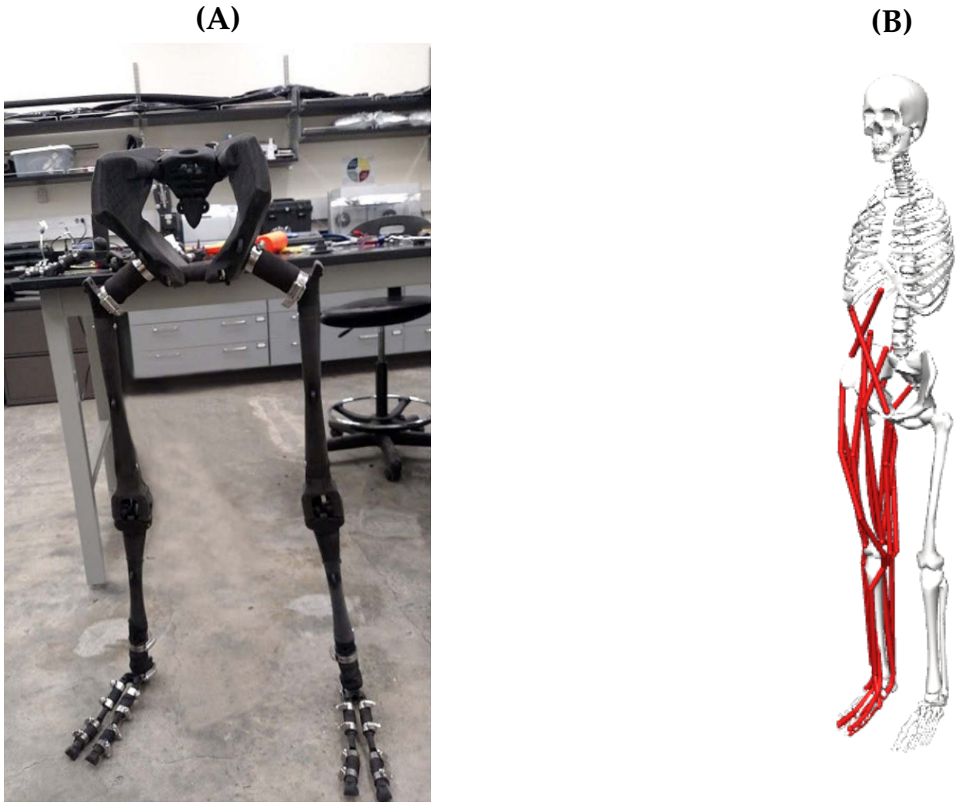



Figure 2.5: **(A)** The laboratory bipedal skeleton (actuators not installed in this view). **(B)** The Gait2392-derived OpenSim model used to develop its muscle routing; the view exposes the retained lower-limb musculotendon paths used as biomechanical design references [Bolen and Hunt, 2019, Morrow et al., 2020].

center of rotation (ICR) during flexion, so the rolling-and-sliding behavior of the human joint emerges from the link geometry itself rather than from cams or gear profiles. Because the ICR migrates, muscle moment arms about the knee change with flexion angle in a human-like way, which is exactly the behavior a torque prediction tool must capture. The biomimetic knee tests of Chapters 3 and 4 therefore exercise the corrected torque model against this geometry, and Figure 2.6 summarizes the mechanism.

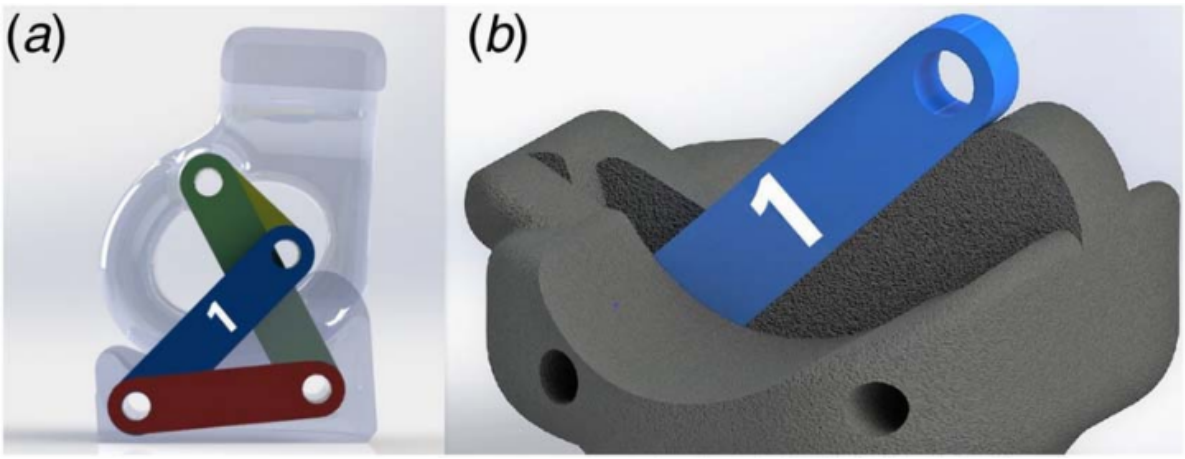



Figure 2.6: Biomimetic knee mechanism. **(a)** Sagittal cutaway at full extension showing the crossed four-bar linkage. **(b)** Exploded view of the mechanical stop. Reproduced from Steele et al. [2018, Fig. 6] under CC BY 4.0.

In the author's master's work, muscle lengths, moment arms, and isometric joint torques were computed over the range of motion for both the Gait2392 model and a PAM-actuated robot leg model, demonstrating that several robot muscle torque profiles could closely match the human model while many fell far short for part of the RoM [Bolen, 2019, Bolen and Hunt, 2019]. Hand placement of muscle origins and insertions was a painstaking and iterative task. Chapter 3 discusses the algorithms used to optimize these origin and insertion locations.

## 2.6 Neural Control of Locomotion: CPGs and Sensory Feedback

Locomotion in mammals is driven by spinal central pattern generators (CPGs), neural circuits that can produce alternating rhythmic activity of flexor and extensor motoneurons in the absence of rhythmic input and proprioceptive feedback [Brown, 1911, Rybak et al., 2006]. The modern architectural understanding of mammalian locomotor CPGs comes largely from the modeling work of the Rybak group and collaborators. Rybak et al. [2006] proposed that the locomotor CPG consists of two levels: a half-center rhythm generator (RG) and a pattern formation (PF) network, with reciprocal inhibitory interactions between antagonist neural populations at each level. This two-level organization explains, among other phenomena, spontaneous deletions of motoneuron activity during fictive locomotion in which the locomotor period and phase are maintained, and it permits independent control of the level of motoneuron activity and of step-cycle timing. McCrea and Rybak [2008] reviewed the electrophysiological support for this organization, and Rybak et al. [2015] related the model architecture to genetically identified spinal interneuron classes. Left–right coordination is provided by commissural pathways between the two half-centers [Molkov et al., 2015, Danner et al., 2016], and the rhythmogenic core of the CPG continues to be refined experimentally [Rancic and Gosgnach, 2021]. Neuromechanical models coupling these spinal circuits to musculoskeletal dynamics have shown how afferent feedback shapes CPG output [Markin et al., 2010, Shevtsova et al., 2016]. Physiologically plausible neuromechanical models of human locomotion continue to dissect the relative roles of reflexes and CPGs [Di Russo et al., 2023], and biomechanics and sensory feedback have been shown to regularize the behavior of different CPG architectures [Deng et al.,

2022].

Sensory feedback is not a passive correction layer but an integral part of locomotor pattern generation. Reviews of afferent control of the CPG [Van de Crommert et al., 1998] and of muscle proprioceptive feedback and spinal networks [Windhorst, 2007, 2022] summarize the classical picture: group Ia afferents from muscle spindles signal muscle length and velocity, group Ib afferents from Golgi tendon organs signal force, and group II afferents signal length, with load-related feedback playing a role distinct from length-related feedback during locomotion [Dietz and Duysens, 2000]. Removing proprioceptive feedback degrades locomotor patterns in mice [Akay et al., 2014]; proprioceptive input regulates and adapts locomotor activity [Lam and Pearson, 2002]; and the relative contributions of proprioceptive and vestibular systems to locomotion are the subject of ongoing study [Akay and Murray, 2021, Akay, 2020]. Of particular relevance to the tests planned in Chapter 6, tonic central and sensory stimuli have been shown to facilitate involuntary air-stepping in humans [Selionov et al., 2009], demonstrating that simple graded stimulation of motoneuronal and rhythmic circuits can elicit stepping-like output — an experiment readily reproduced in simulation by tonic stimulation of pattern-formation and rhythm-generator populations.

Two-layer CPG organization has also informed the AARL's own neuromechanical modeling. In preliminary work, the author and Morrow constructed a planar bipedal walker in the AnimatLab neuromechanical simulation environment [Cofer et al., 2010], with a nine-segment, sagittal-plane biomechanics after the bipedal model of Li et al. [2017] and a synthetic nervous system whose rhythm-generator, pattern-formation, and sensorimotor networks followed the rat hindlimb two-layer CPG of Deng et al. [2019].

That model produced alternating, stepping-like activity and motion while suspended in the air, and preliminary results were presented by the author at the 2021 NIH BRAIN Initiative Investigators Meeting [Bolen and Hunt, 2021]. Its limitations — hand-tuned neural parameters and untuned afferent feedback — shaped the approach of Chapter 6; the model is described in Section 3.10.

## 2.7 Synthetic Nervous Systems and the Sensory Afferent Database

For robots, these biological architectures can be implemented as synthetic nervous systems (SNSs): networks of conductance-based spiking and non-spiking neurons that are small enough to run in real time yet biologically grounded enough to be compared against animal data. The Quinn Lab and others have pursued this approach across several platforms: CPG-based neural control of a pneumatically actuated dog robot [Hunt et al., 2017b], analytically designed dynamic neural networks for human balance control [Hilts et al., 2019](AARL), the rat hindlimb modeling program that supplies this dissertation's controller architecture (a full-muscle rat hindlimb model and its moment-arm analysis [Young et al., 2019], and the two-layer CPG neuromechanical walker built on it [Deng et al., 2019]), and the DoggyDeux quadruped designed for SNN control [Scharzenberger, 2019](AARL). Related controllers from the wider neuromechanical community include sensory-entrained CPG control of bipedal walking [Li et al., 2017], inter-leg coordination analyses in stick-insect-inspired controllers [Nourse et al., 2019], reinforcement-reflex hybrids in insects [Goldsmith et al., 2021], and adaptive hindlimb walking controllers [Schilling et al., 2022]. The SNS-Toolbox [Nourse et al., 2023] makes such networks

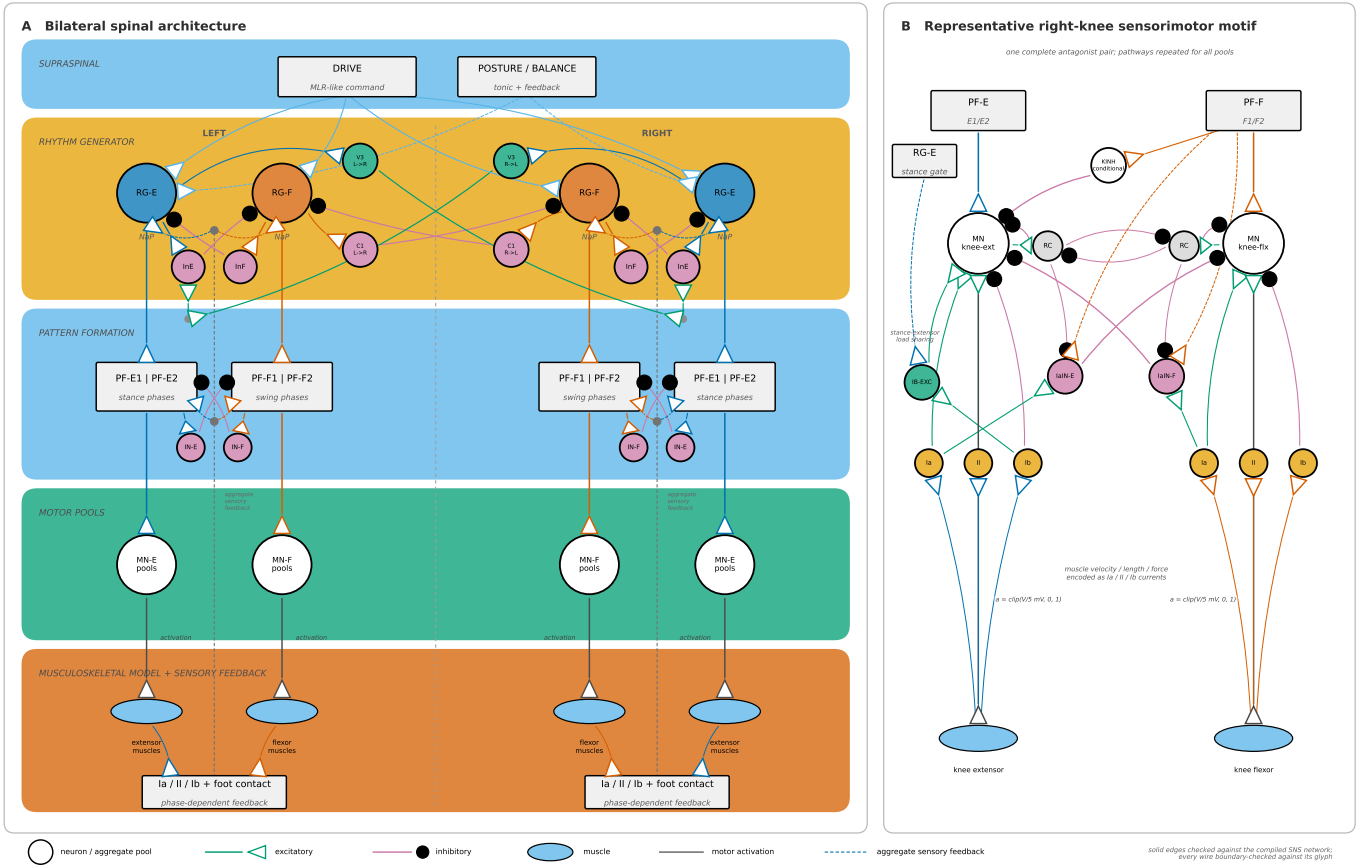



Figure 2.7: Locomotor circuit architecture synthesized from the literature. The bilateral organization combines rhythm-generation, pattern-formation, motoneuron, commissural, and proprioceptive pathways used across two-level CPG and neuromechanical models [Rybak et al., 2006, 2015, Shevtsova et al., 2016, Deng et al., 2019]. The detailed knee-control motif makes the reciprocal antagonist and sensory pathways explicit.

practical: it is an open-source Python package that simulates hundreds to thousands of spiking and non-spiking neurons in real time or faster, supports multiple software and hardware backends including GPUs and embedded platforms, and couples directly to physics simulators such as MuJoCo for musculoskeletal control. The neuromorphic legged-locomotion field this toolbox serves is growing: Szczecinski et al. [2023] survey its past, present, and future, and physical testbeds in this lineage now extend from insect-scale models to a robotic cat hindlimb [Armstead et al., 2025].

The biological data needed to parameterize such networks are scattered across hundreds if not thousands of papers. To address this, the Sensory Afferent Database (SADb) was developed within the AARL's NeuroNex Communication, Coordination, and Control in Nervous Systems (C3NS) effort as a structured, model-oriented resource characterizing sensory afferent properties across animals and their role in motor control [Bolen et al., 2023]. A follow-up study evaluated AI-assisted literature triage for expanding the database, finding that current tools can accelerate population of the database but still require substantial human oversight for accuracy [Bolen and Hunt, 2024]. The SADb and the locomotor neurophysiology literature it organizes — including the two-level CPG architecture, Ia/Ib/II feedback pathways, and contact-related reflex modulation — directly inform the sensory feedback design implemented in Section 3.11 and evaluated in Section 4.6.

## 2.8 Simulation Tooling: From OpenSim to MuJoCo

Two open-source ecosystems anchor the simulation pipeline developed in this dissertation. OpenSim [Delp et al., 2007, Seth et al., 2018] provides the biomechanical modeling side:

musculoskeletal models with anatomically accurate geometry, muscle routing, and force-generating properties, along with tools for analyzing moment arms and isometric torque. MuJoCo [Todorov et al., 2012] provides the physics-engine side: fast, accurate simulation of rigid-body dynamics with contacts, along with muscle-like actuators that include activation dynamics. MyoConverter bridges the two by converting OpenSim 4.x musculoskeletal models to MuJoCo format with optimized muscle kinematics and kinetics [Caggiano et al., 2022, Wang et al., 2022]. Combined with SNS-Toolbox's MuJoCo backend [Nourse et al., 2023], I used these tools to convert the AARL's modified OpenSim leg model to MuJoCo, couple it to an SNS network with Ia, Ib, and II proprioceptive channels plus contact sensors, and run the full neuromechanical loop faster than real time (Methods Section 3.11; Results Section 4.6).

Neuromechanical simulation — the coupling of a musculoskeletal model to a model of the neural controller that drives it — has advanced along three partially overlapping lines. The first line embeds reflex physiology directly into the controller. The muscle-reflex walking model of Geyer and Herr [2010] demonstrated that positive force, length, and velocity feedback around each muscle, organized with simple interlimb coordination, is sufficient to produce self-stabilizing human-like walking dynamics and realistic muscle activations without any central pattern generator. That model became the reference point for a generation of reflex-based neuromechanical controllers, including the cat hindlimb models of Section 2.6 [Markin et al., 2010, Shevtsova et al., 2016] and their extensions. Hybrid work makes the complementarity of the two strategies explicit: Haeufle et al. [2018] combined feed-forward muscle activations with neuronal reflex feedback in simulated human walking and found that the robustness benefit of each depends on which muscle

carries it.

The second line replaces hand-designed circuitry with machine learning. Song et al. [2021] trained deep reinforcement learning policies on a physiologically realistic musculoskeletal model in OpenSim, reproducing human kinematics and muscle activations across locomotion tasks, with the learned policy re-usable for experiments that would be difficult in the laboratory. This approach inherits the fidelity of the musculoskeletal model but encodes control in opaque function approximations: the trained policy can reproduce behavior, but the individual "neurons" of the controller do not correspond to identifiable physiological circuits, so the class of scientific questions it can answer — lesions, deletions, pathway stimulation — is narrower than its behavioral repertoire. Recent perspectives on predictive musculoskeletal simulation [De Groote and Falisse, 2021] place both learned and optimal-control approaches in the same frame: the models are mature, and the open problems are the cost of solving them and the biological interpretability of the control they find.

The third line, in which this dissertation sits, is biologically grounded synthetic nervous systems: controllers whose neurons and synapses are explicit, conductance-based, and mapped to identified physiological circuits, simulated at speeds sufficient for real-time robotics [Nourse et al., 2023]. Hierarchical CPG control is meanwhile spreading to bipedal-capable musculoskeletal models — motor-module bipedal walkers [Ichimura and Yamazaki, 2019], two-layer rhythm-generator and pattern-formation control of a musculoskeletal macaque model [Nishizaki et al., 2026], and two-level CPG control of muscle-driven robotic hind legs [Fukuoka et al., 2021] — though always in simulation with generic musculature or on non-humanoid platforms; a two-layer SNS driving a

custom-anatomy, artificial-muscle humanoid leg remains unclaimed. What distinguishes the present program from all three lines is the combination it attempts: an anatomically grounded controller (two-layer CPG with Ia, Ib, II, and contact feedback), a biomechanically validated pneumatic model (Chapters 3–4), and an eventual physical robot. Simulation speed is the practical enabler: the MuJoCo backend evaluates the musculoskeletal loop faster than real time on commodity hardware [Todorov et al., 2012, Caggiano et al., 2022], and SNS-Toolbox sustains real-time or faster network evaluation from workstations down to embedded boards [Nourse et al., 2023]. A single overnight run can therefore sweep thousands of parameter combinations or execute hundreds of simulated gait cycles per condition — throughput that no human-subject or animal protocol could match, and that transforms lesion and stimulation studies from bespoke demonstrations into statistically powered experiments.

## 2.9 Testing Neuromechanical Hypotheses on Robots: The Ethical Case

The experiments this research program is designed to enable — deleting a muscle from a limb, blocking a sensory pathway, lesioning part of a rhythm generator, applying tonic stimulation to spinal circuits — cannot be performed on healthy humans. Invasive intervention on the human neuromuscular system is limited to clinical populations, is tightly constrained by ethics review, and permits neither the within-subject control nor the reversibility that neuromechanical hypotheses demand. The same experiments in animals also carry real moral cost, and their justification is governed by the Three Rs framework: replacement of animal subjects with non-animal methods, reduction of the numbers re-

quired, and refinement of the remaining procedures [Russell and Burch, 1959, Tannenbaum and Bennett, 2015]. A robot that implements a validated neuromechanical hypothesis is precisely such a replacement method: every deletion, lesion, and stimulation experiment that runs on the synthetic nervous system is an experiment that does not require a living subject, and the robot population can be duplicated exactly, so that "subjects" are statistically identical across conditions — a form of reduction no breeding colony can offer. Refinement follows as well: the failure modes of these experiments damage hardware, not tissue.

Figure 2.8 shows what that accounting leaves out. The image is a frame from footage of a real decerebrate-cat experiment, the class of preparation on which the field's understanding of spinal locomotion has been built since its beginnings [Brown, 1911, Decerebrated]: a living cat, its forebrain disconnected by a brainstem transection, walks the treadmill because the circuits below the cut still walk. The published record of this work is drawn almost exclusively in schematic, labeled boxes for half-centers and color-coded reflex arcs that are honest about the circuitry and silent about the animal. The figure is included as the counterweight. It is the only image in this dissertation that is neither a model, nor a measurement, nor a diagram; it documents what the experiments looked like, and therefore what a replacement method stands in for.

For a robot to serve as a replacement subject, however, it must first earn standing as a scientific model. Webb's influential analyses of bio-robotic methodology [Webb, 2001, 2002] argue that a robot is a good model of biological behavior when the mechanism it implements is tested at the same level of organization as the target phenomenon — matching dynamics, control structure, and sensory ecology rather than surface appearance.

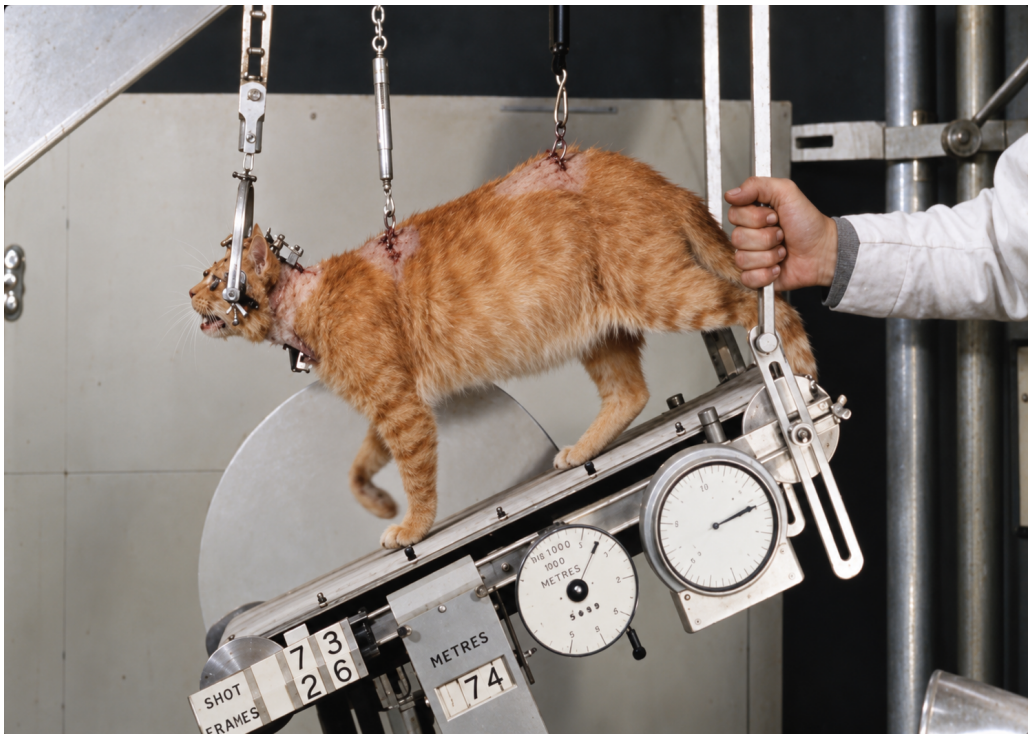



Figure 2.8: Frame from archival footage of a decerebrate-cat treadmill experiment [Decerebrated], restored and machine colorized; color and fine detail are inferred by the restoration rather than recovered from the source. Shown as documentary context for the replacement argument of this section, not as gait evidence.

The validation chain of this dissertation is constructed to that standard: the actuator force model is validated against bench data (Section 4.2), the joint torque model against isometric measurements and human torque envelopes (Section 4.3), and the neuromechanical controller can be verified against published tonic stimulation and deletion phenomena [Selionov et al., 2009, Rybak et al., 2006] before any locomotion tuning is attempted. Only then can a robot experiment be read as evidence about the hypothesized biological circuit rather than about the robot.

The argument is ultimately bidirectional, completing the loop described in Section 1.2. Experiments that are unethical, impractical, or statistically unreachable in humans and animals become routine on the robot; the resulting insights into neuromechanical control feed back into biology, into the design of the next robot iteration, and directly into prosthetic and orthotic devices that face the same problem of controlling muscles-like actuators for human users, whose central pattern generator controllers are an active topic in lower-limb exoskeleton research [Duan et al., 2024, Pery et al., 2026]. The ethical case and the scientific case are the same case: the robot is the instrument that makes these experiments possible.

# 3 Materials and Methods

Publication note: Sections 3.2–3.3 and the actuator characterization results reported in Chapter 4 appeared in Bolen et al. [2026] (Bolen, Elzein, Pang, and Hunt, *Actuators*, 2026). Sections 3.4–3.7 and the knee torque results reported in Chapter 4 are also the subject of an unpublished manuscript in preparation by Bolen, Burgess, Morrow, Elzein, Pang, Scharzenberger, and Hunt [Bolen et al., 2025]. This manuscript has not been submitted for publication. For both works, B.B. performed the conceptualization, methodology, software, validation, formal analysis, investigation, data curation, visualization, and original draft preparation; M.E., L.P., L.B., and C.M. contributed methodology, software, investigation, and data curation; and A.H. supervised the work, administered the projects, and acquired funding. All co-authors contributed to writing, review, and editing.

## 3.1 Overview

The experimental program of this dissertation proceeds from the actuator to the joint. Because the robot joints are driven by braided pneumatic actuators (BPAs), the foundation of any torque prediction is an accurate model of the force produced by a single actuator as a function of its length, pressure, and contraction. To measure artificial muscle force as a function of length and pressure, we built a test jig from extruded aluminum and 3D printed parts. Festo BPAs with 10 mm and 20 mm uninflated diameters were tested with various resting lengths and different amounts of contraction. These data are used to

develop an improved model that more accurately predicts maximum muscle force based on the resting length $l_0$, current muscle length $l_m$, and pressure $P$ (Sections 3.2 and 3.3).

With the actuator model in hand, the focus shifts to the joint. This study begins with building a jig to measure knee torque produced by BPAs at various knee angles ($\theta_k$). With the expectation that measured torque will be less than that predicted by the model, the robot muscle arrangement and knee design are simplified to elucidate the variables that most affect the results. Two distinct joints are used and tested: a simplified pinned knee joint and a biomimetic knee [Steele, 2018]. Each joint is driven by a single flexor and a single extensor muscle. Variations were made to the muscle origin/insertion locations, resting lengths, diameters, and whether they used an artificial tendon. The results are compared with two models, and the new data are used to create an improved torque model that accounts for system compliance and muscle wrapping (Sections 3.4–3.7). The corrected model also provides the torque evaluator for redesigning BPA attachment locations and actuator lengths against human knee torque targets (Section 3.8).

### 3.2 Actuator Force Model

The actuator force model used throughout this dissertation is described here. First, the amount of contraction $\varepsilon$ in a BPA is calculated as

$$\varepsilon = \frac{(l_0 - l_m)}{l_0} \tag{3.1}$$

where $l_0$ is uninflated resting length of the BPA measured from hose clamp to hose clamp. Current muscle length is $l_m$.

Similarly, $\varepsilon_{620}$ is the amount of contraction in a BPA without external load when inflated at 620 kPa, calculated as

$$\varepsilon_{620} = \frac{(l_0 - l_{620})}{l_0} \tag{3.2}$$

where $l_{620}$ is the muscle length measured at 620 kPa and free from external loads.

The amount of relative contraction of a BPA $\varepsilon^*$ can then be calculated by dividing equation (3.1) by (3.2), such that

$$\varepsilon^* = \frac{\varepsilon}{\varepsilon_{620}} \tag{3.3}$$

describes the BPA's current contraction as a normalized percentage of it's total.

The amount of normalized isometric force $F^*$ in a Festo BPA is then calculated as

$$F^*(\varepsilon^*, P^*) = \begin{cases} c_0 \cdot \left(\exp(-c_1 \cdot \varepsilon^*) - 1\right) + P^* \cdot \exp\left(-c_2 (\varepsilon^*)^2\right) & \text{for } F^* > 0 \\ 0 & \text{for } F^* \leqslant 0 \end{cases} \tag{3.4}$$

where $P^*$ is pressure $P$ normalized by 620 kPa. BPA diameter dependent coefficients are determined by the actuator characterization experiments reported in Chapter 4 (Table 4.2).

The maximum force $F_{max}$ in a BPA is calculated as

$$F_{max}(l_0, P_{\max}) = a_1 \cdot P \cdot \arctan\left(a_2 \cdot P \cdot (l_0 - 0.0075)\right) \tag{3.5}$$

with coefficients determined by the actuator characterization experiments reported in Chapter 4 (Table 4.1). When maximum system pressure is set to $P = 620$ kPa, $F_{\max}(l_0, 620) =$

$F_{620}(l_0)$. Multiplying (3.4) by (3.5) yields

$$F(\varepsilon^*, P^*, l_0) = F^*(\varepsilon^*, P^*) \cdot F_{620}(l_0) \tag{3.6}$$

as the equation for isometric force $F$ in a Festo BPA.

### 3.3 BPA Isometric Force Characterization Experiment

To measure artificial muscle force as a function of length and pressure, we built a test jig from extruded alumnium and 3D printed parts. Festo BPAs with 10 mm and 20 mm diameter were tested with various resting lengths and different amounts of contraction. These data are used to develop an improved model that more accurately predicts maximum muscle force based on $l_0$, current muscle length $l_m$, and pressure $P$. The results are compared with existing models and the new data are used to create an updated model.

A test jig was made of 80/20 brand 1515 series extruded aluminum (Figure 3.1). Artificial muscles were placed vertically in the jig one at a time. The upper end was attached to a load cell. Force data was collected using a CALT DYLY-103 100 kg S-shaped load cell for the $\phi$10 mm BPAs and a Loadstar RAS1-2HKS-S for the $\phi$20 mm BPAs. The was load cell was used in conjunction with a HX711 Load Cell Amplifier. Pressure data was obtained from a Freescale MPX5700 GP 5 V pressure sensor. Building air supply pressure was controlled with two pressure regulators in series. The first was a Parker model 20R113GC $0 - 120$ psi pressure regulator. The second was a Husky 3/8 in. High Performance Air Regulator HDA72200. A Festo VTUG-10-MRCR-S1T-26V20-T516LA-UL-532S-8K valve manifold VTUG-G was used to deliver air from the pressure regulator to the actuator. This

manifold is comprised of eight two-in-one bidirectional normally closed Festo VUVG-S10-T32C-AZT-M5-1T1L valves.

Pressure and load cell amplifier data were sent to MATLAB 2021b via an Arduino Uno style Sparkfun BlackBoard C microcontroller. The computers that used MATLAB were running either Windows 10 or Windows 11. During phases when the Arduino was collecting force and pressure data to send to MATLAB, the Arduino would also trigger (via MATLAB) an Onsemi 2N4401 NPN transistor to make the valve manifold open or close the valve. For other data collection, the valve was manually opened and closed.

The inner distance between the hose clamps on each BPA was measured with a FANUC tape measure to determine the muscle's length $l$ and resting length ($l_0$). This is how Festo AG & Co. KG [2026] defines $l_0$, although in Hunt et al. [2017a] it was measured to also include end cap length. We then inflated each BPA to $P_{620} = 620\,\text{kPa}$, with one end allowed to move freely in the axial Degree of Freedom (DoF), and measured the length $l_{620}$ to calculate maximum contraction at 620 kPa using Equation (3.2). The distance between the crossmembers was then controlled to obtain different amounts of contraction, the muscles were inflated to various pressures, and the contractile force was recorded at the pressure–contraction pairs. This was done for $\phi$10 mm BPA resting lengths ($l_0$) of 112 mm–518 mm. For $\phi$20 mm BPAs, resting lengths ($l_0$) of 300 mm–509 mm were used.

### 3.4 Robot Leg Model and Knee Test Stands

The primary components of the robot leg are the knee joint, femur, tibia, BPA assemblies, and artificial tendons (Fig. 3.2**A–C**). The artificial bone components are 3D printed using

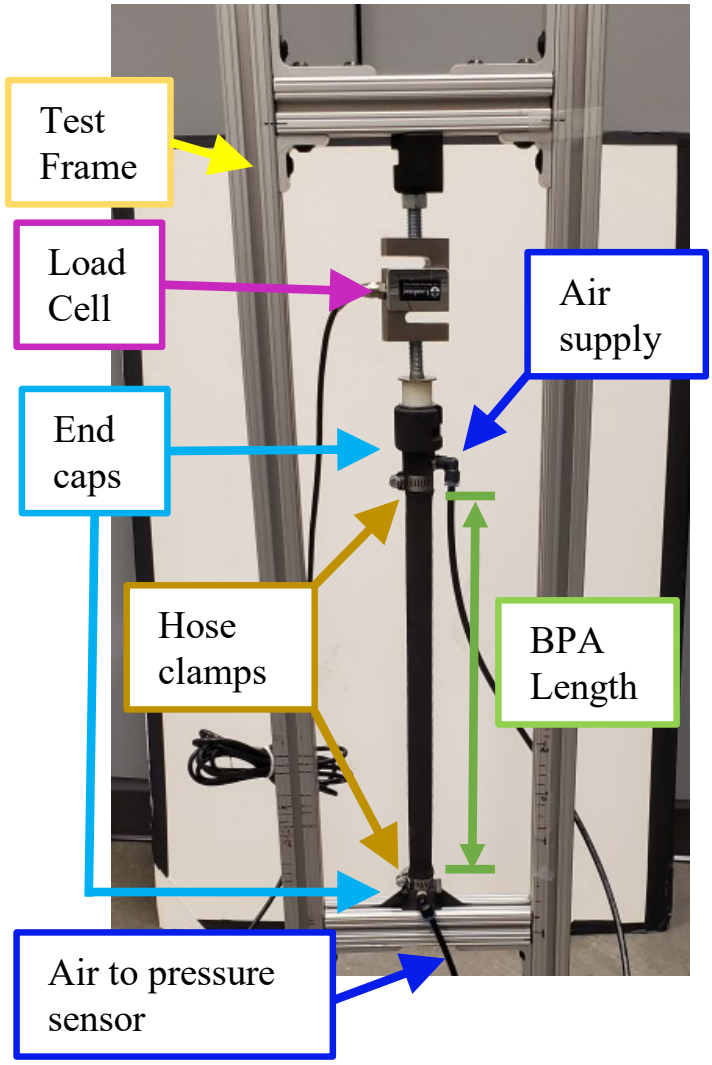



Figure 3.1: A picture of a BPA in the isometric force test stand with components labeled.

a combination of Onyx, carbon fiber, and high-strength high-temperature fiberglass on Markforged Onyx One and Mark Two printers, as well as machined links for the knee mechanism. Onyx is a proprietary Markforged material that consists of chopped carbon fiber in nylon. Artificial tendons are made with Shimano bicycle brake cable.

The leg assembly geometry and dimensions are based on bones scans of a 6 ft (1.83 m) tall person [Bolen and Hunt, 2019, Seth et al., 2018, Delp et al., 1990, 2007]. Two knee joints were tested, one pure rotational joint, and one biomimetic joint with rotation and translation. Each joint is driven by two antagonistic Festo actuators. Both robot joints have the same center of rotation in the femur frame at $\theta_{\mathrm{k}} = 0\,\mathrm{deg}$.

Details on the biomimetic robot knee used in this study can be found in Steele [2018], Steele et al. [2017, 2018]. In brief, this 1-DoF joint (Fig. 3.3) uses a four-bar linkage to change the effective moment arm during rotation. The intersection point of the internal crossed links define the instantaneous center of rotation (ICR). This causes the joint ICR location in the femur frame to translate posteriorly in the $X$ direction and distally in the $Y$ direction except for a brief proximal move near full flexion. Reference coordinate frames are given by Wu and Cavanagh [1995], Wu et al. [2002]. This is similar to how the human knee behaves [Bolen and Hunt, 2019, Morrow et al., 2020, Seth et al., 2018, Delp et al., 2007, 1990]. The correct location of the ICR is important for both theoretical and experimental torque calculations.

Uniarticular knee extensor and knee flexor are used to actuate the joint. Each knee joint type is tested using $\phi 10\,\mathrm{mm}$ Festo BPAs. With this size BPA the muscles were used in a singular configuration. The biomimetic knee joint is tested using a $\phi 20\,\mathrm{mm}$ Festo BPA. The extensor is actuated with two BPAs in parallel, and the flexor is actuated with two BPAs in

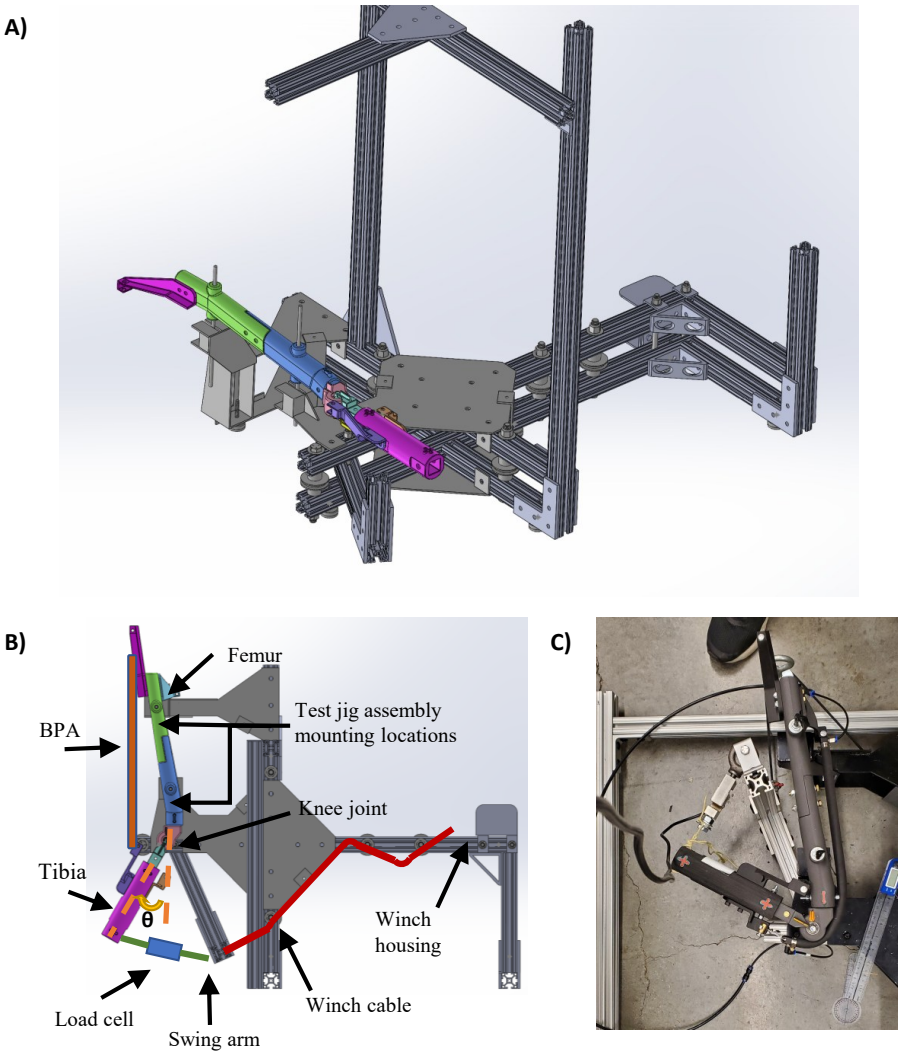



Figure 3.2: **(A)** CAD solid model assembly of the revolute joint knee in the test stand. **(B)** 1-DoF pinned-joint robot knee in the test apparatus with important components labeled. Leg is shown with 30 degrees flexion, i.e. $\theta_k = -30^\circ$. **(C)** Picture from isometric torque testing. Setup shows the revolute knee configured for a test of the extensor BPA. The knee is flexed with $\theta_k = -120^\circ$. Also note the compressed shape of the inflated BPA on the knee during this high degree of flexion.

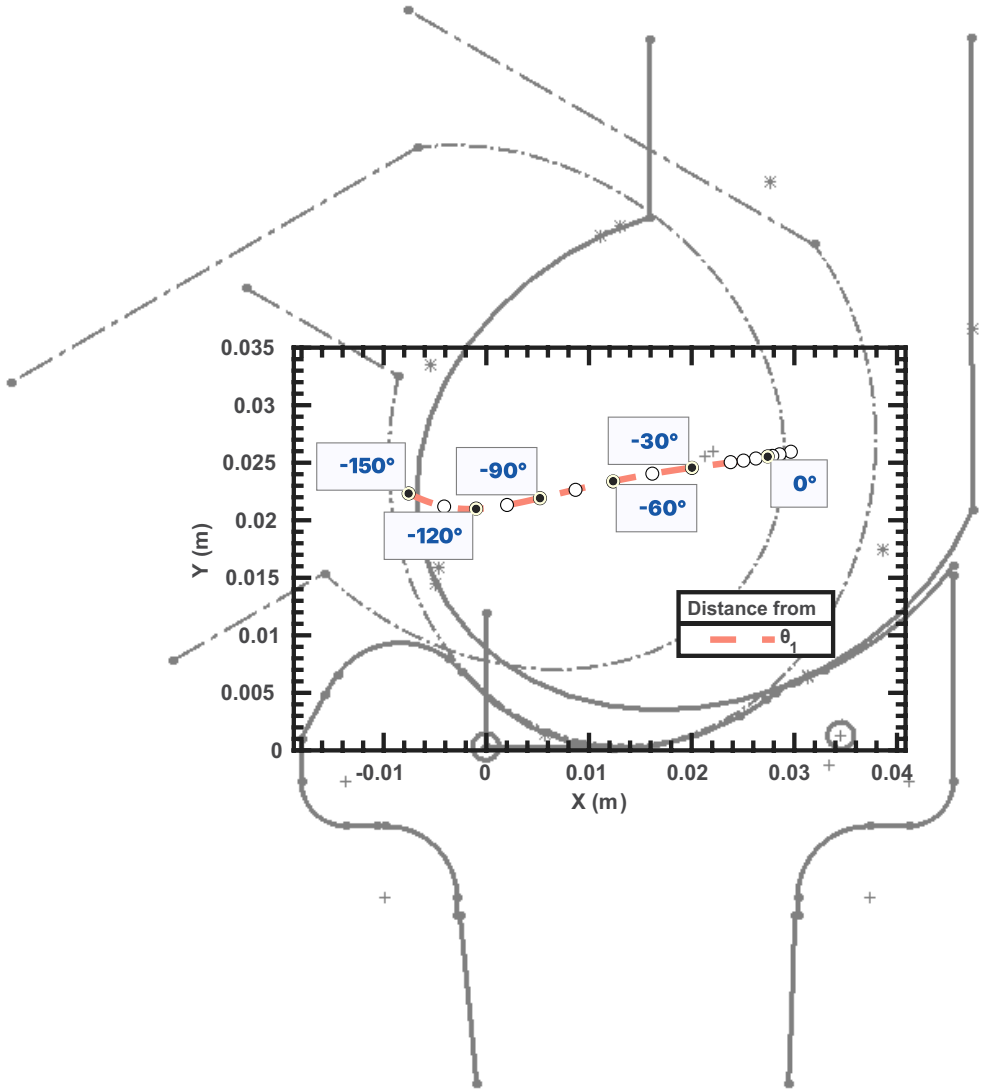



Figure 3.3: ICR for biomimetic robot knee as a function of knee angle. Measured from $\theta_1$ on the tibia. Plot is overlayed on model of the knee at $\theta_k = 0^\circ$ (solid line), and $-60^\circ$ and $-120^\circ$ (dotted dash lines). White circles represent measured points in $-15^\circ$ increments from $-150^\circ$ to $-15^\circ$, $-5^\circ$ increments from $-15^\circ$ to $0^\circ$, and then at $2^\circ$, $5^\circ$, and $10^\circ$.

with pathways mirrored about the $Z$ axis. Each artificial muscle is pinned at the muscle origin location on the femur while the other end is either pinned or attached to the muscle insertion location on the tibia via an artificial tendon.

Moment arms are calculated using vector components between muscle locations and the joint's instantaneous center of rotation (ICR). Given a vector $\vec{d}$ from a joint to the line of action of the force vector $\vec{F}$, the moment arm $\vec{r}$ is the shortest distance to this line of action. In this study, it is calculated using the method specified by Young et al. [2019]. The scalar moment arm, $r_k$, about the $z_k$ axis (i.e., the $Z$ axis in the knee frame) is calculated as

$$r_k = p_{\vec{proj},xy} \cdot \frac{\vec{p_f} \times \hat{z_k}}{\|\vec{p_f} \times \hat{z_k}\|} \tag{3.7}$$

where $p_{\vec{proj},xy}$ is the free muscle segment projected onto the $XY$–plane, which is normal to the joint axis. $\vec{p_f}$ is the projected muscle segment vector. Moment arm is calculated in the tibial body frame.

Details of the existing model and the torque calculation methodology in the modeled robot are given by Bolen and Hunt [2019], Morrow et al. [2020].

### 3.5 Knee Torque Data Collection and Equipment

A test jig was built to collect knee torque measurements at different knee angles over its range of motion. The test stand frame is made predominantly out of 80/20 1515 series extruded aluminum components. The knee joint is free to rotate the tibia while the femur is fixed to the frame. A force sensor has one end connected to the tibia and the other is connected to a swing arm. The swing arm is tied to a winch with 3/16 inch Kevlar rope

from Quality Nylon Rope routed over intermediate idler pulleys (see Fig. 3.2**B** and 3.2**C**). At each measured position of $\theta_k$ the winch would be locked and the BPA would be inflated and then deflated. This test procedure kept the measured results as isometric as possible. The knee joint is co-axial with gravity to eliminate gravitational torque (see Fig. 3.2**A** and Fig. 3.2**C**).

Force data was collected using one of two different sensors. The first is a MODERN STEP 300 kg digital crane scale. The second force sensor is a CALT DYLY-103 100 kg S shaped load cell. The load cell is used in conjunction with a HX711 Load Cell Amplifier. Pressure is measured with a Freescale MPX5700 GP 5 V pressure sensor. Building air supply pressure is controlled with two pressure regulators in series. The first is a Parker model 20R113GC $0 - 120$ psi pressure regulator. The second is a Husky 3/8 inch High Performance Air Regulator HDA72200. A Festo VTUG-10-MRCR-S1T-26V20-T516LA-UL-T532S-8K valve manifold was used to supply air to the actuator. Pressure and load cell amplifier data are sent to MATLAB via an Arduino Uno style Sparkfun BlackBoard C microcontroller.

The length measurements were made using a tape measure. When there was sufficient curvature in the BPA during knee extensor torque tests, a flexible piece of string was used to mark the axial length and then transferred to the tape measure. Angle measurements were taken with a Medigauge digital electronic goniometer or with MALENOO analog goniometers of 6, 8, or 12 inch lengths.

### 3.6 Hybrid Torque Calculation Method

A Hybrid Torque calculation method was developed to help uncover inconsistencies between the model and recorded torque values. This method measures the actual muscle length and angles of the robot to calculate force and joint torque. With this method, it is easier to determine which parts of the torque equation did not achieve their predicted value and provide a correction to that part of the equation. The classical mechanics way to calculate the torque $\vec{M}$, about a joint is to take the cross product of distance, $\vec{d}$, and force, $\vec{F}$

$$\vec{M} = \vec{d} \times \vec{F} \tag{3.8}$$

where distance $\vec{d}$ and force $\vec{F}$ are described in the previous section. Knee torque is the scalar torque $M$ about the $Z$ axis, which can simplify Eq. 3.8 to

$$M = r \times F \tag{3.9}$$

where $r$ is the moment arm measured by a tape measure, and $F$ is the scalar force, calculated by measuring the BPA's $P$, $l_0$, $l_{620}$ and $l_{\mathrm{m}}$ values and using the model fit equations determined in the following section.

### 3.7 Improved Torque Model

The classical kinematic torque model assumed rigid links and inextensible muscle paths. Data collected during the first flexor experiments (Chapter 4) showed that this assumption does not hold for a pneumatic system: measured muscle lengths were consistently shorter

than predicted, and measured torque deviated from prediction in a load-dependent manner. This section describes the corrections that were developed to account for a constant length offset, series compliance in the attachment hardware and artificial tendons, and the loss of usable muscle length when a BPA wraps around the joint.

These corrections are deliberately formulated to be identified from experiment rather than derived analytically, because the physical effects they represent are distributed and not separately measurable. The lumped compliance absorbs the cantilevered three-dimensional-printed attachment brackets, whose geometry is a printed CAD part rather than a prismatic beam with a tractable second moment of area, together with the bone fixtures, the cable winch of the test stand, and the artificial tendon. Predicting that aggregate stiffness from first principles would require finite-element models of each component with material properties (anisotropic printed polymer, braided sleeve, construction-dependent tendon stiffness) that are themselves unmeasured. The correction terms therefore parameterize only what the torque model needs: $\chi_0$ absorbs the constant length discrepancy observed at zero load, $\chi_1$ and $\chi_2$ are effective stiffnesses in the bracket frame's principal directions, and $\chi_3$ scales the wrapping-length loss. Each is identified by global optimization against the measured torque rather than solved in closed form, for two reasons. First, the terms enter the prediction through an implicit force balance, because the compliance displacement depends on the force that it itself modifies, so the inverse problem has no analytic solution. Second, the parameters are only jointly identifiable: preliminary fits showed that widely different stiffness pairs can reproduce the training tests nearly equally well, so the adopted solution must be selected by cross-validated prediction on held-out tests rather than by residual minimization alone, which is what the multiobjective

Pareto-front procedure of Section 3.8 provides.

Analysis of measured muscle length data shows that it was consistently shorter than the predicted muscle length at all joint angles. This shorter length results in less muscle force, a shifted RoM, and less torque in the experimental setup. That this shorter length occurs when $\varepsilon = 1$ and $F = 0$ indicates that a constant length offset should be used. Therefore, to produce an improved torque prediction model, $l_{\mathrm{m}}$ was recalculated as

$$l_{\mathrm{m}} = l_{LMT} - 2\, l_{fitting} - \chi_0 \tag{3.10}$$

where $l_{LMT}$ is the path length of the musculotendon from origin to insertion point, $l_{fitting}$ is the length of the end caps, and $\chi_0$ is a constant length offset.

Additionally, as the muscles produce more force, compliant components in the limb segments and attachment hardware deform. This deformation changes the effective braided pneumatic actuator (BPA) length, which alters contraction and therefore changes the force predicted by the BPA model. This effect is most apparent at high forces and low contractions. To correct this error, we approximated the combined hardware compliance using Hooke's law in the bracket's principal directions.

A local bracket frame was established at the attachment bracket. The $\hat{x}_{br}$ axis was aligned with the vector from the bracket reference point to the BPA attachment point and represents the stiffest direction of the bracket. The $\hat{y}_{br}$ axis was chosen to point in the posterior direction with respect to the tibia frame, corresponding to the primary cantilever bending direction (see Fig. 3.5), while the $\hat{z}_{br}$ axis completes the right-handed frame. The bracket stiffness matrix is modeled as a diagonal matrix to reflect independent stiffness

components along its principal axes:

For the two-rotation evaluator, the bracket frame was constructed from the vector joining the bracket origin to attachment point $\mathbf{p}_A$ or $\mathbf{p}_B$. The first rotation, through $\theta_z$ about the fixed space-frame axis $\hat{z}_s$, points the intermediate axis $\hat{x}_1$ toward the sagittal-plane projection $\mathbf{p}_{A/B}^{\text{sag}}$. The second rotation, through $-\theta_y$ about the current axis $\hat{y}_1 = \hat{y}_{br}$, brings the final bracket axis $\hat{x}_{br}$ into alignment with the full three-dimensional point vector. Figure 3.4 shows these geometric targets. The resulting orientation and homogeneous transform are

$$\mathbf{R}_{s,br} = \mathbf{R}_z(\theta_z)\mathbf{R}_y(\theta_y)^T, \qquad {}^s\mathbf{T}_{br} = \begin{bmatrix} \mathbf{R}_{s,br} & \mathbf{p}_{br} \\ \mathbf{0}^T & 1 \end{bmatrix}. \tag{3.11}$$

$$\mathbf{K}_{br} = \begin{bmatrix} \chi_1 & 0 & 0 \\ 0 & \chi_2 & 0 \\ 0 & 0 & \chi_1 \end{bmatrix} \tag{3.12}$$

The corresponding local compliance matrix is

$$\mathbf{C}_{br} = \mathbf{K}_{br}^{-1} \tag{3.13}$$

Force vector in a body's frame can be written as $\mathbf{F}$. The force applied to the bracket was expressed in the bracket frame as $\mathbf{F}_{br}$. This force vector can be written in terms of its magnitude and unit direction as

$$\mathbf{F}_{br} = \|\mathbf{F}\|\,\hat{\mathbf{u}} \tag{3.14}$$

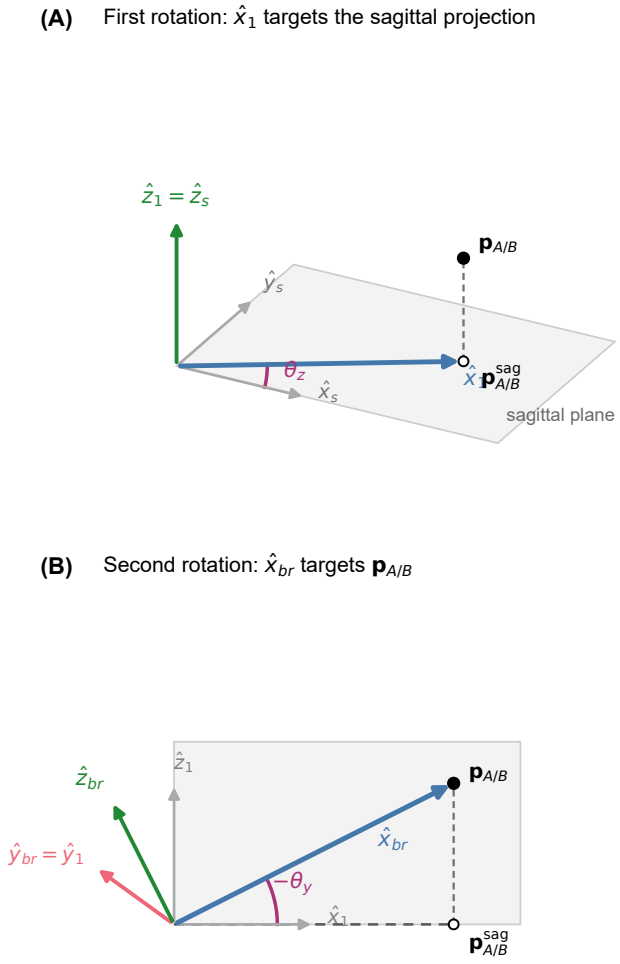



Figure 3.4: Two-rotation construction of the bracket frame from attachment point $\mathbf{p}_A$ or $\mathbf{p}_B$. **(A)** Rotation through $\theta_z$ about fixed $\hat{z}_s$ aligns $\hat{x}_1$ with the point's sagittal-plane projection. **(B)** Rotation through $-\theta_y$ about current $\hat{y}_1 = \hat{y}_{br}$ aligns $\hat{x}_{br}$ with the full point vector.

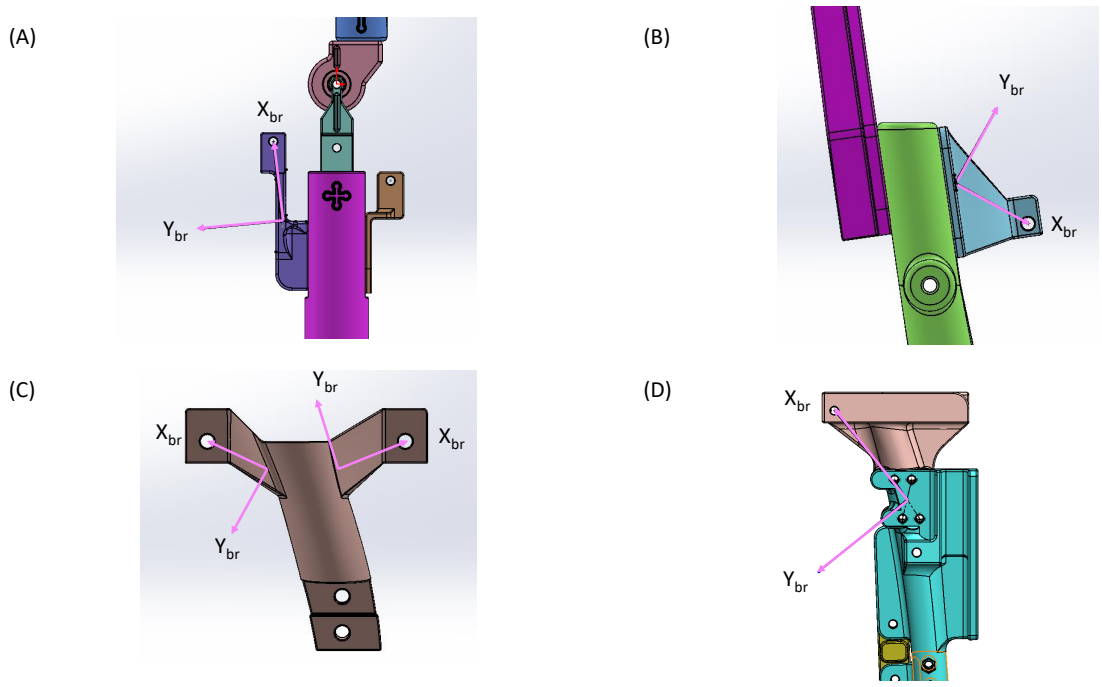



Figure 3.5: Bracket frame orientations for: **(A)** flexor configuration on the pinned knee, **(B)** extensor configuration on the pinned knee, **(C)** flexor and extensor configurations on the biomimetic knee with $\phi$10 mm BPAs, and **(D)** flexor configuration on the biomimetic knee with the $\phi$20 mm BPA.

where $\hat{\mathbf{u}} = [u_x, u_y, u_z]^T$ is the BPA force direction expressed in the bracket frame. The bracket deflection vector, $\boldsymbol{\epsilon}_{br}$, was calculated from Hooke's law as

$$\mathbf{F}'_{br} = \mathbf{K}_{br}\, \boldsymbol{\epsilon}_{br} \tag{3.15}$$

Solving Eq. 3.15 for the bracket deflection gives

$$\boldsymbol{\epsilon}_{br} = \mathbf{K}_{br}^{-1}\, \mathbf{F}' = \mathbf{C}_{br}\, \mathbf{F}' \tag{3.16}$$

Substituting Eq. 3.14 into Eq. 3.16 gives

$$\boldsymbol{\epsilon}_{br} = \left\|\mathbf{F}'\right\| \mathbf{K}_{br}^{-1}\, \hat{\mathbf{u}} \tag{3.17}$$

For the diagonal stiffness matrix in Eq. 3.12, Eq. 3.16 is equivalent to the component-wise expression

$$\boldsymbol{\epsilon}_{br} = \begin{bmatrix} F'_{x,br}/\chi_1 \\ F'_{y,br}/\chi_2 \\ F'_{z,br}/\chi_1 \end{bmatrix} \tag{3.18}$$

Although $\boldsymbol{\epsilon}_{br}$ is a three-dimensional deflection vector, the BPA force model depends on the scalar change in effective BPA length ($\delta$). Therefore, only the component of $\boldsymbol{\epsilon}_{br}$ along the BPA line of action directly changes the effective BPA length. This scalar bracket deflection is the projection of $\boldsymbol{\epsilon}_{br}$ onto $\hat{\mathbf{u}}$:

$$\delta_{br} = \hat{\mathbf{u}}^T \boldsymbol{\epsilon}_{br} \tag{3.19}$$

Substituting Eq. 3.16 into Eq. 3.19 gives

$$\delta_{br} = \hat{\mathbf{u}}^T \mathbf{K}_{br}^{-1} \mathbf{F}' \tag{3.20}$$

Using Eq. 3.14, Eq. 3.20 becomes

$$\delta_{br} = \left\|\mathbf{F}'\right\| \hat{\mathbf{u}}^T \mathbf{K}_{br}^{-1} \hat{\mathbf{u}} \tag{3.21}$$

The scalar stiffness along the BPA line of action due to the bracket compliance is therefore

$$k_{\hat{u},br} = \frac{\|\mathbf{F}'\|}{\delta_{br}} = \left(\hat{\mathbf{u}}^T \mathbf{K}_{br}^{-1} \hat{\mathbf{u}}\right)^{-1} \tag{3.22}$$

This projected-compliance form is used because the force is applied along $\hat{\mathbf{u}}$, while the bracket is allowed to deflect independently along its local $\hat{x}$, $\hat{y}$, and $\hat{z}$ directions. The reduced-order Hooke's law expression for the bracket deflection along the BPA line of action is therefore

$$\left\|\mathbf{F}'\right\| = k_{eq}\, \delta \tag{3.23}$$

where $k_{eq}$ is calculated with (3.22) when there is no artificial tendon. When an artificial tendon was used, it was modeled as an axial spring with stiffness $k_{ten}$. Since both bracket deflection and tendon stretch reduce the effective BPA length along the actuator line of action, their scalar compliances were added in series:

$$k_{eq} = \left( \frac{1}{k_{br}} + \frac{1}{k_{ten}} \right)^{-1} \tag{3.24}$$

Since $\delta$ is the scalar compliance displacement along the BPA line of action, then the compliance-corrected active BPA length used in the force balance is

$$l_m(\delta) = l_m(0) - \delta \tag{3.25}$$

where $l_m(0)$ is the initial muscle length calculated from (3.10).

For a specified set of correction parameters, the following calculation solves the attachment-compliance displacement at each knee angle; it is distinct from the optimization that identifies those parameters from experimental torque data (Section 3.8). The corresponding relative contraction is $\varepsilon^*(\delta)$. Since the BPA force depends on contraction, and contraction depends on the compliance displacement, $\delta$ was found using the Newton-Raphson method to solve the nonlinear force-balance equation

$$F_{\max} \cdot F_{\mathrm{BPA}}(\varepsilon^*(\delta), P^*) - k_{eq}\,\delta = 0 \tag{3.26}$$

After solving Eq. 3.26, the corresponding force magnitude was used in Eq. 3.16 to compute the vector bracket deflection. This deflection was transformed back into the limb reference frame and used to update the BPA attachment location. The routed BPA length, force direction, moment arm, and torque were then recalculated using the updated attachment location. In the present implementation, the optimized stiffness terms $\chi_1$ and $\chi_2$ were treated as effective compliance parameters for the attachment system rather than direct measurements of an isolated bracket. This allowed unmodeled compliance in the

surrounding hardware to be represented by the reduced-order stiffness model.

Multiobjective optimization using `gamultiobj` in MATLAB was used to determine the length offset ($\chi_0$) and the stiffness terms ($\chi_1$ and $\chi_2$) until the error between the model and the experimental data was minimized for the $l_0 = 48.5\,\text{cm}$ flexor BPA (Fig. 4.4**C**). Because the bracket forms an arch shape and extends for 75 mm in the $Z$ direction, the extensor configuration required an additional correction. The inner side of a BPA that bends over the joint experiences less tensile stress than the outer side, creating a force imbalance and a loss of part of the arc length of the BPA as usable length. An additional optimization term $\chi_3$ was introduced to capture this wrapping loss, such that

$$\Delta l = \begin{cases} \chi_3 \; R \; |\theta_{\text{wrap}} - \theta_{\text{k}}| \; \zeta^2 & \theta_{\text{k}} \leqslant \theta_{\text{wrap}} \\ 0 & \theta_{\text{k}} \geqslant \theta_{\text{wrap}} \end{cases} \tag{3.27}$$

where $\Delta l$ is the change in usable length of the BPA, $R$ is the wrapping radius. $\theta_{\text{wrap}}$ is the knee flexion angle when the BPA starts to bend over the knee joint, determined from solid modeling. $\zeta$ is the additive complement to relative strain, such that

$$\zeta = 1 - \varepsilon^* \tag{3.28}$$

Combining (3.28) into (3.27), and subtracting $\Delta l$ from (3.10) yields

$$l_{\text{m}} = l_{LMT} - 2\, l_{fitting} - \chi_0 - \Delta l \tag{3.29}$$

The optimization algorithm was again `gamultiobj` in MATLAB. This time, the muscle

origins bracket was chosen. The bracket frame is shown in Fig. 3.5**B**. Since the bracket forms an arch shape and extends for 75 mm in the $Z$ direction, for this configuration, we set $\chi_2$ in the $X_{br}$ direction, and $\chi_1$ in the $Y_{br}$ and $Z_{br}$ directions. The optimization algorithm for this set solves for the best average goodness-of-fit (GoF) measures RMSE, FVU, and maximum absolute residual for two BPAs, while the third one was held out. Three independent rounds of optimization were performed, so that one of each of the BPAs could be held out as validation. Then we picked the solution with the shortest distance between the average normalized GoF and the validation data, while also requiring improved GoF values for all the individual BPAs, with the exception of maximum absolute residual on the $l_0 = 48.0$ cm BPA.

This initial identification was subsequently extended to the full archived test sets in two stages. First, the flexor model was given a second compliant bracket at the origin-side attachment (a hip-frame cantilever carrying the BPA origin), so that the compliance of both ends of the actuator path is represented; the stiffness pair $(\chi_1, \chi_2)$ is shared by the two brackets in fixed axis assignments (Appendix C, Table C6), leaving a three-term fit $(\chi_0, \chi_1, \chi_2)$. The flexor fit was cross-validated over the five pinned-knee flexor tests, holding out the encoder-corrected 47 cm test as validation. Second, the extensor refit locked $(\chi_1, \chi_2)$ to the flexor front values — enforcing a single stiffness pair across the flexor and extensor configurations — and solved only the extensor-specific terms $(\chi_0, \chi_3)$ on the six-test extensor validation pool, with the extensor length offset allowed to take negative values. The bounds and the adopted values of both stages are recorded in Appendix C (Tables C7 and C8); the fit outcomes are summarized in Section 4.4.

Figure 3.6 distinguishes the three-dimensional displacement of each bracket from the

scalar displacement along the BPA force path. For bracket $j$, the displacement resolves into components $\eta_{1,j}$, $\eta_{2,j}$, and $\eta_{3,j}$ along the local bracket-frame basis, whereas only its projection $\delta_{br,j}$ along the corresponding force direction $\hat{\mathbf{u}}_j$ changes the actuator length. The two bracket projections act in series with the tendon elongation $\delta_{\text{tendon}}$:

$$\begin{aligned} \boldsymbol{\eta}_{br,j} &= \sum_{i=1}^{3} \eta_{i,j} \hat{\boldsymbol{e}}_i^{(j)}, \\ \delta_{br,j} &= \hat{\mathbf{u}}_j^T \boldsymbol{\eta}_{br,j}, \qquad j \in \{1,2\}, \\ \delta_{\text{series}} &= \delta_{br,1} + \delta_{\text{tendon}} + \delta_{br,2}. \end{aligned} \tag{3.30}$$

The goodness-of-fit metrics used to judge the optimization results are the root mean square error (RMSE), the fraction of variance unexplained (FVU), and the maximum absolute residual, each computed between the measured and predicted isometric torque over the tested range of motion.

Each metric isolates a different aspect of disagreement between the two curves. RMSE reports the overall magnitude of the error and, when the curve shapes already agree, is dominated by the remaining level offset. FVU normalizes the error variance by the variance of the measured torque, making it scale-free: it asks whether the prediction reproduces the variation of the measurement rather than whether it is close in absolute units, is the complement of the Nash–Sutcliffe model efficiency [Nash and Sutcliffe, 1970], and takes values below one when the prediction outperforms the mean of the measurement itself. The maximum absolute residual is a worst-case local measure. A small shift of the predicted curve along the knee-angle axis produces large pointwise residuals where the torque gradient is steep and small residuals elsewhere, so this metric is sensitive to phase

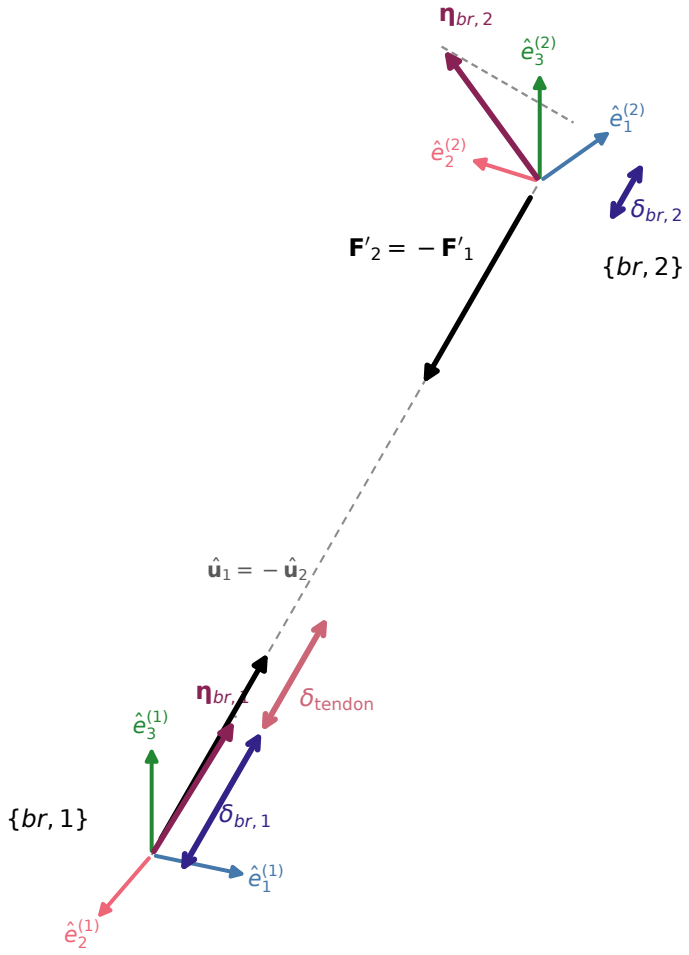



Figure 3.6: Two-bracket deflection and projection along the BPA force path. The force vectors at $\{br, 1\}$ and $\{br, 2\}$ point toward one another and satisfy $\mathbf{F}'_2 = -\mathbf{F}'_1$. The bracket projections $\delta_{br,1}$ and $\delta_{br,2}$ are offset from the corresponding coordinate frames for clarity, and tendon elongation $\delta_{\text{tendon}}$ continues collinearly from $\delta_{br,1}$. Colors follow a color-vision-deficiency-safe palette and are redundant with labels and line weights.

misalignment while responding only weakly to uniform level offsets.

This interpretation follows the standard decomposition of curve-comparison error into offset, amplitude, and pattern components [Taylor, 2001]: the mean square error between two curves separates into the squared mean offset, an amplitude mismatch, and a residual shape term. An equivalent three-term formulation, splitting waveform similarity into offset, amplitude, and shape, underlies the linear fit method developed for clinical gait waveform comparison [Iosa et al., 2014]. The metrics used here map onto this decomposition, with RMSE carrying the level disagreement, FVU the shape and amplitude agreement, and the maximum absolute residual serving as the phase-sensitive worst case. FVU is treated as the primary criterion because it is the only one of the three that is directly comparable across tests with different torque scales.

### 3.8 Optimization Algorithms and Cost Functions

Two distinct optimization problems underpin the results of this dissertation and the design framework built on them. The first is the identification of the correction terms of Section 3.7 ($\chi_0$, $\chi_1$, $\chi_2$, and $\chi_3$) from the pinned-knee test data. The second is the redesign of the biomimetic knee route geometry — the BPA origin $\mathbf{p}_1$, insertion $\mathbf{p}_{\text{end}}$, resting length, and tendon length (Appendix C) — so that the flexor and extensor configurations meet or exceed human knee torque capability over the range of motion. Both are carried out in MATLAB [The MathWorks, Inc., 2025].

The correction-term identification is a genuine multiobjective problem: candidate parameter sets are judged simultaneously on RMSE, FVU, and maximum absolute residual

(Section 3.7). It is solved with the genetic multiobjective solver `gamultiobj`, an implementation of the elitist nondominated-sorting genetic algorithm NSGA-II [Deb et al., 2002, The MathWorks, Inc., 2025], which returns a Pareto front of parameter sets from which the adopted solution is selected by the holdout-validation procedure described above. The optimizer parameterization (length offsets in centimeters, stiffnesses on a logarithmic scale) and its bounds are recorded in Appendix C.

The route redesign replaces the multiobjective formulation with a single scalar cost assembled from weighted penalty terms, because the route prediction (contact activation, wrapping, and compliance correction) is expensive to evaluate and only moderately smooth. The cost has the form

$$J = w_w\, J_{\text{worst}} + w_t\, J_{\text{torque}} + \textstyle\sum_a J_a + J_{\text{geom}} + J_{\text{len}}, \tag{3.31}$$

where $J_{\text{worst}}$ is the largest fraction by which robot torque falls short of the human target at any angle across the range of motion, weighted heavily ($w_w = 10^5$); $J_{\text{torque}}$ is the mean-squared shortfall fraction ($w_t = 10^3$); the $J_a$ are configuration-specific auxiliary penalties described below; and $J_{\text{geom}}$ and $J_{\text{len}}$ are regularizers that keep the endpoints and actuator lengths near their seed values. Human torque targets are computed from the Gait2392 lower-extremity model [Delp et al., 2007, Seth et al., 2018]: the flexor is graded against the biceps femoris short head and the extensor against vastus medialis. Each target is a maximum-isometric torque curve: OpenSim moment arms, obtained as the partial derivative of muscle-tendon length with respect to the knee coordinate, $r(\theta_k) = \partial l_{\text{MT}} / \partial \theta_k$, are evaluated across the range of motion and multiplied by each muscle's maximum

isometric force (provenance and exported tables in Appendix A). Hard constraints (bone clearance, wrap feasibility, actuator strain and contraction limits, tendon geometry) are enforced alongside the cost, and any candidate whose prediction fails is rejected with a prohibitive penalty.

The solution pipeline is common to both configurations. Each run begins with a full sanity evaluation of the seed design and a small smoke test of the solver setup, then executes `surrogateopt` — MATLAB's surrogate-assisted global solver for expensive black-box objectives, which builds a spatial interpolation surrogate over sampled candidate points and searches it adaptively [The MathWorks, Inc., 2025] — for 7,000 evaluations in parallel, and finally refines the best feasible point with `patternsearch`, a derivative-free mesh-adaptive direct search method [Audet and Dennis, 2006, The MathWorks, Inc., 2025], for 15,000 further evaluations. The entry scripts and their cost functions are archived with the code (`Opt_run.m`, `Opt_run_Ext.m`).

Although both configurations share this pipeline, their cost functions differ in ways that reflect the mechanics. The flexor BPA routes around a single moving wrap point, so clearance from the tibia and femoral condyles is enforced by continuous signed-distance constraints, and its cost adds an off-axis torque penalty (torques about the joint axes other than the knee axis, relative to the original single-BPA route) and a penalty if the wrap fails to release cleanly as the knee extends. The extensor BPA wraps over the front of the joint through as many as seven sequential contacts, so clearance is enforced instead by the contact-elimination rule that governs the route, and its cost penalizes torque overshoot above the human curve and excessive actuator contraction, which risks bottoming out at high flexion. The flexor target also carries a required torque margin above the human

curve — 1% in the initially reported redesigns, 5% in the adopted campaign — whereas the extensor target was the raw human curve in the initial redesigns and carries the same 5% required margin in the adopted campaign; both are set by a single `requiredTorqueMargin` knob in each configuration's context builder. With two BPAs per joint, the flexor route is mirrored about the mid-sagittal plane and the two actuator forces are summed, while the extensor model scales the force of a single shared route by the actuator count.

### 3.9 Balance Platform and Inverted-Pendulum Testbeds

In parallel with the knee test stands, the author, together with McNeal and Williams, developed a family of hardware testbeds for the balance problem encountered by a humanoid: a robotic inverted pendulum actuated by BPAs at the ankle and standing on a motorized oscillating balance platform [Bolen et al., 2024b,a,c]. The testbeds deliberately reduce the robot to a single actuated joint and a single sensory question: which measurement of body orientation, fed through which feedback law, holds the leg upright on a moving support? This reduction allowed vestibular and proprioceptive feedback strategies to be exercised in hardware and provides a baseline for the full-body comparisons defined in Chapter 6. Three generations were built (Figure 3.7).

All three generations share one control template. A microcontroller reads body orientation, compares it against an upright set point, and commands the antagonist BPA pair with a correction proportional to the measured angle error: the command to one muscle of the pair is increased while the command to its antagonist is decreased by the same amount, about an equilibrium at which both valves sit half open, so that one muscle pressurizes as

the other vents. Because the valves are on/off solenoid valves supplied from a manifold, the proportional command is realized by time-proportioning — pulse-width modulation of the valve duty cycle — with the switched pressure routed to the BPA chambers through a transistor-array driver stage, and with chamber pressures monitored by pneumatic pressure transducers. The pressure–force dynamics that this pulse-modulated scheme excites are modeled in companion work [Elzein et al., 2025].

The first generation used a hinge ankle driven by an antagonist pair of 20 mm BPAs acting as plantarflexor and dorsiflexor. Its ankle angle could be measured by a shaft encoder mounted on the hinge axis, estimated from an inertial measurement unit (IMU) mounted on the tibia, or both, selectable as the feedback source for the proportional law; the IMU angle was obtained by integrating the gyroscope angular rate after a static bias correction, with the accelerometer available as a gravity reference. The distinctive feature of this generation is its transmission. The two BPAs operated in parallel on a four-wheel block-and-tackle — a reverse-pulley system — mounted on the foot, with the artificial tendon reeved through the pulleys and inserting on the tibia. Reeling the tendon through the pulley train multiplies the tendon travel delivered at the joint at a proportional cost in transmitted force and an increased reaction force carried by the foot; the design consequences are examined in Section 5.6.

The second generation, IP 2.0, replaced the hinge with a ball-and-socket ankle, so that the foot could combine plantarflexion and dorsiflexion with inversion and eversion. Three muscles were attached: one soleus-type plantarflexor, and two dorsiflexors — one routed to act as an inverter and one as an everter — arranged so that the muscles can act antagonistically against one another as the demanded ankle orientation changes; in

the controller, the two dorsiflexors shared a single complementary command against the plantarflexor. A ball-and-socket joint presents no shaft on which a rotary encoder can be carried, so angle feedback in this generation was IMU-only.

The final balance platform stands the inverted pendulum, its ankle driven by an antagonist BPA pair, on a motorized platform that oscillates the support surface beneath the foot. An IMU on the tibia serves as a pseudo-vestibular sensor, feeding the same proportional law. This is the configuration in which balance was demonstrated both on flat ground and under the oscillating support (Section 4.5).

### 3.10 Prior Neuromechanical Simulation: The AnimatLab Bipedal Walker

Before the simulation pipeline of Chapter 6 was defined, the author and Morrow built a neuromechanical model of a bipedal walker in AnimatLab, a 3D graphics environment for constructing biomechanical systems actuated by synthetic neural systems [Cofer et al., 2010].

The biomechanical model consisted of nine rigid bodies — pelvis, thigh, shank, foot, and toe segments — connected by sagittal-plane hinge joints with human-like rotational capabilities and actuated by antagonistic pairs of Hill-type muscles at the hip, knee, and ankle. The toe joint, the author's addition to the Li design, carried a passive spring instead of a muscle pair, simplifying the system. The mechanics followed the suspended bipedal walking model of Li et al. [2017], whose CPGs were entrained by heel and toe mechanosensory receptors and hip-angle position sensors standing in for the group-I loading, cutaneous, and hip-joint afferents of the biological scheme — muscle afferents

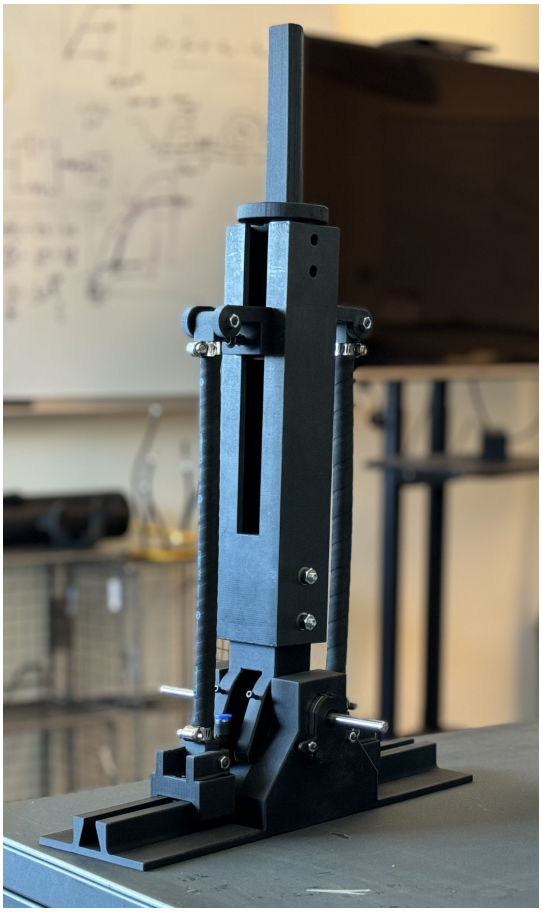


Figure 3.7: The BPA-actuated inverted-pendulum testbed. The pendulum shank rides on a hinge ankle above the foot assembly, and braided pneumatic actuators route down both sides of the shank to the foot, forming the antagonist ankle pair. Photograph from the AARL Inverted Pendulum project repository.

were not modeled — and it is worth noting that the Li model required support against falling: a system with only planar joints cannot actively balance side to side.

The synthetic nervous network was built from non-spiking, leaky-integrator neurons and followed the two-layer CPG organization of Deng et al. [2019]. A rhythm-generator layer set the timing of the system; a pattern-formation layer reshaped the timing signals into phase-appropriate activation of antagonist muscle groups; and a sensorimotor layer containing Renshaw-cell-like recurrent inhibition drove the motor neurons. The sensorimotor layer received Ia (length and velocity) and Ib (tension) afferent feedback from the muscles, but the feedback gains were never systematically tuned, and no ground-contact signals were modeled. Every applied current, synaptic weight, and muscle-tension parameter was set by hand: each was adjusted by trial and error, one at a time, until the three layers oscillated in phase and the motor neurons produced stepping-like activation of the muscle pairs. That hand-tuning consumed the bulk of the project's effort, left no record of the sensitivity of the behavior to individual parameters, and did not generalize when new feedback pathways were added — limitations that directly motivated the systematic, verification-first tuning approach of Chapter 6.

### 3.11 Preliminary Neuromechanical Simulation Workflows

Preliminary simulation workflows were assembled to support future integration of the BPA mechanics and synthetic nervous system (SNS). The figures in this section document the biomechanical representations, controller organization, and software implementation. Their purpose is to identify what was constructed; quantitative validation remains

separate.

### 3.11.1 AnimatLab Body and Controller Organization

The walker representation and controller hierarchy are shown in Figures 3.8 and 3.10. The hierarchy separates rhythm generation, hip control, and knee–ankle pattern formation within left- and right-side neural subsystems. The current AnimatLab working model was instrumented for a new 10 s phase-1 run recording joint, neural, contact-sensory, and body-motion channels. This run was used to inspect recorded signals and simulation behavior, without treating it as evidence of stable walking or effective ground-contact gating. It is distinct from the earlier walker study described in Section 3.10. Preliminary joint-motion results are reported in Section 4.6.

Since that run, the working model has been reorganized into a complete bilateral network. The right-side rhythm-generator, hip, and knee–ankle subsystems were mirrored from the left, inhibitory commissural pathways were added between the two rhythm generators, and each leg gained four biarticular muscle pathways (gastrocnemius, biceps femoris short head, semimembranosus, and rectus femoris) with human maximum isometric forces from the Gait2392 data set. The reorganized project opens in the AnimatLab environment without errors and exports a standalone simulation that runs headless. Its rhythm-generator half-centers hold a static latch under the tonic drive levels tested so far rather than oscillating, so conductance tuning toward robust oscillation is the active step; no locomotor claim is made for the reorganized model beyond its verified assembly.

Figure 3.9 illustrates the rhythm-generator, pattern-formation, and sensorimotor or-

ganization at the neuron and synapse level. These reference schematics complement the subsystem view by making the antagonist pathways and sensory connections visible.

### 3.11.2 MuJoCo Conversion and Synthetic BPA Knee

A reproducible OpenSim-to-MuJoCo conversion workflow was assembled using scripted model repair, MyoConverter, and a documented software environment. Separately, a custom quasi-static BPA model was ported from MATLAB to Python and coupled to MuJoCo tendon kinematics to compute actuator forces and their joint contributions. A minimal SNS with reciprocal inhibition drove a synthetic knee with antagonistic flexor and extensor BPAs. Figure 3.11 distinguishes the converted robot from this separate knee demonstration. The demonstration establishes a controller–actuator–joint interface; it does not establish SNS control of the converted Gait2392 robot or validation of correction-factor-based MuJoCo torque predictions.

At the time of writing the conversion stage is complete and verified: the converted model carries all 92 muscle-tendon actuators with attachment geometry audited against the OpenSim source, and the joint sign conventions of the robot's modified paths were audited dynamically (from simulation torques rather than static model tables, because coupled path points move). The BPA port reproduces the MATLAB force calculation, including the correction-factor force balance. An SNS-Toolbox network couples to MuJoCo at a 0.1 ms neural step, with muscle force feedback entering as Ib afferent input. On this coupling, a 406-neuron two-layer spinal network has been assembled for the converted model — per-leg rhythm-generator half-centers, four phase-shifted pattern-formation

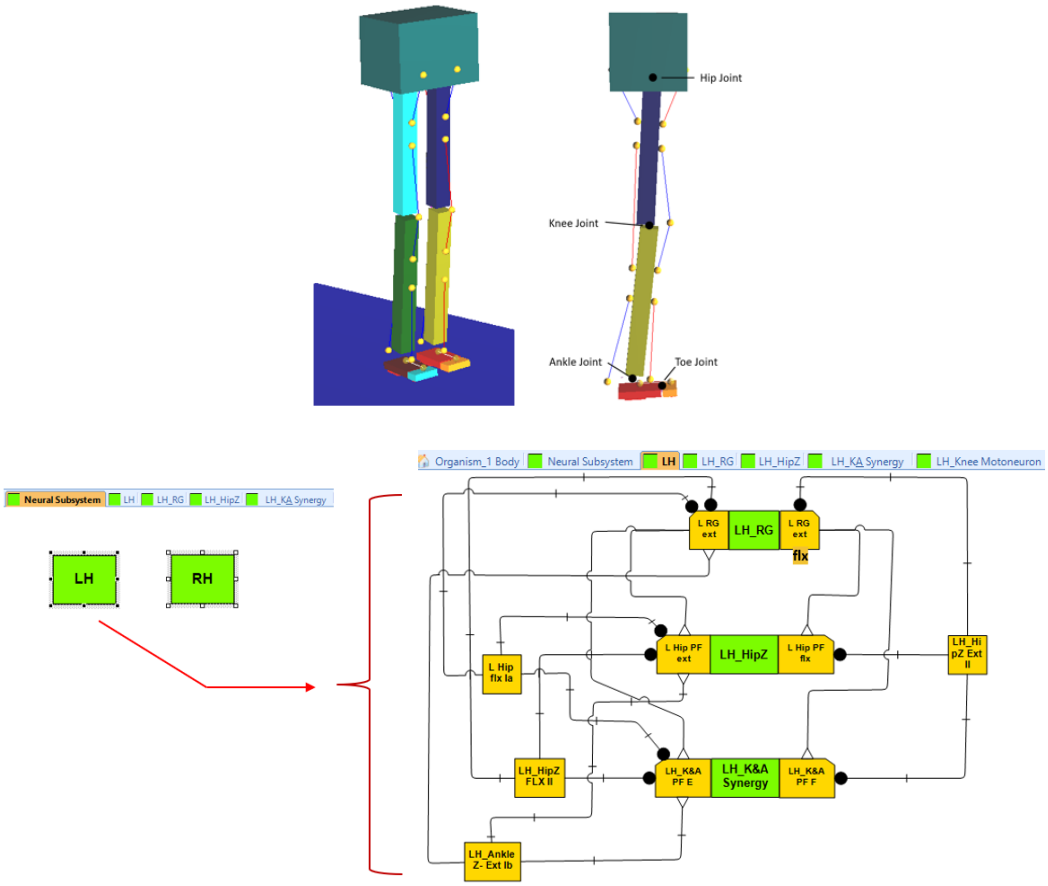



Figure 3.8: AnimatLab model and architecture illustrations. Top: the segmented walker and labeled hip, knee, ankle, and toe joints. Bottom: the left/right subsystem organization and an expanded view of the left-side rhythm-generator, hip, and knee–ankle modules. These architectural views describe model organization and are not snapshots of the phase-1 trajectory.

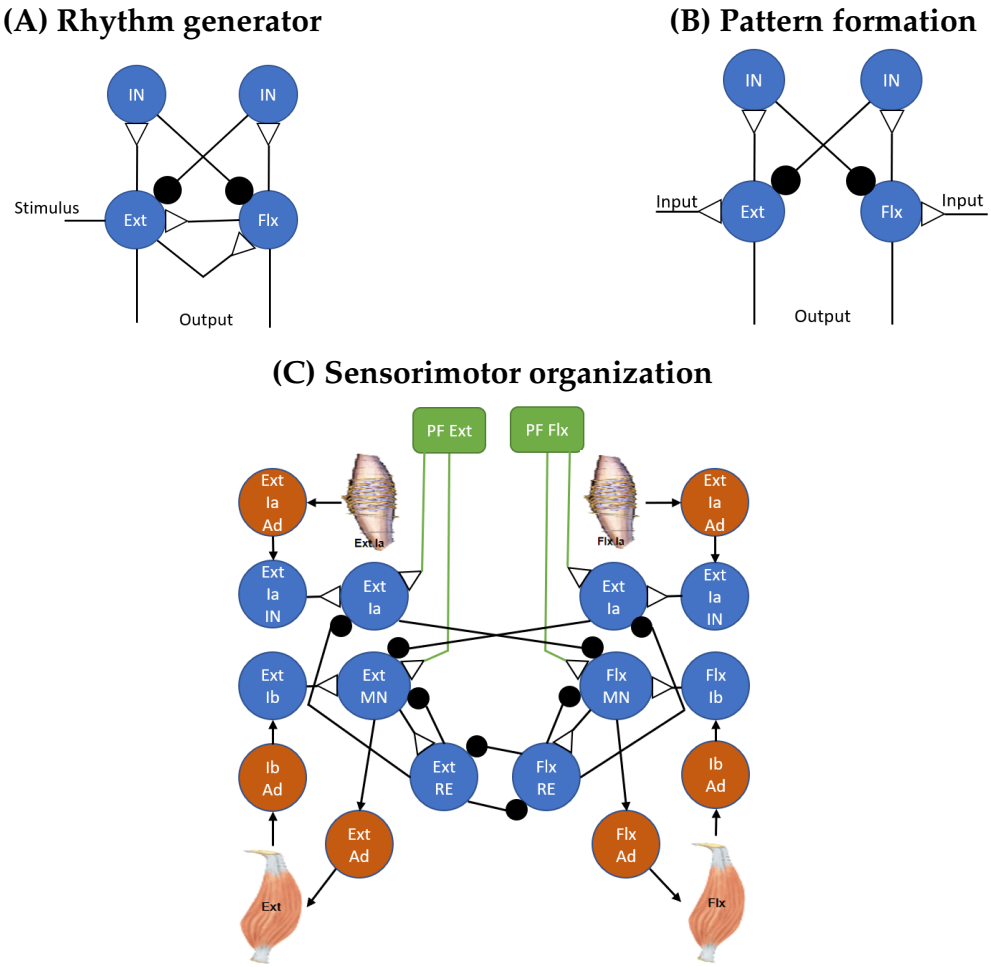



Figure 3.9: Reference schematics of **(A)** rhythm generation, **(B)** pattern formation, and **(C)** sensorimotor organization. Ext and Flx identify antagonist extensor and flexor pathways; IN denotes interneurons, MN motor neurons, and Ia and Ib muscle afferent pathways. Open triangles and filled circles distinguish excitatory and inhibitory synaptic connections. These schematics illustrate controller architecture and are not readouts from the phase-1 run.

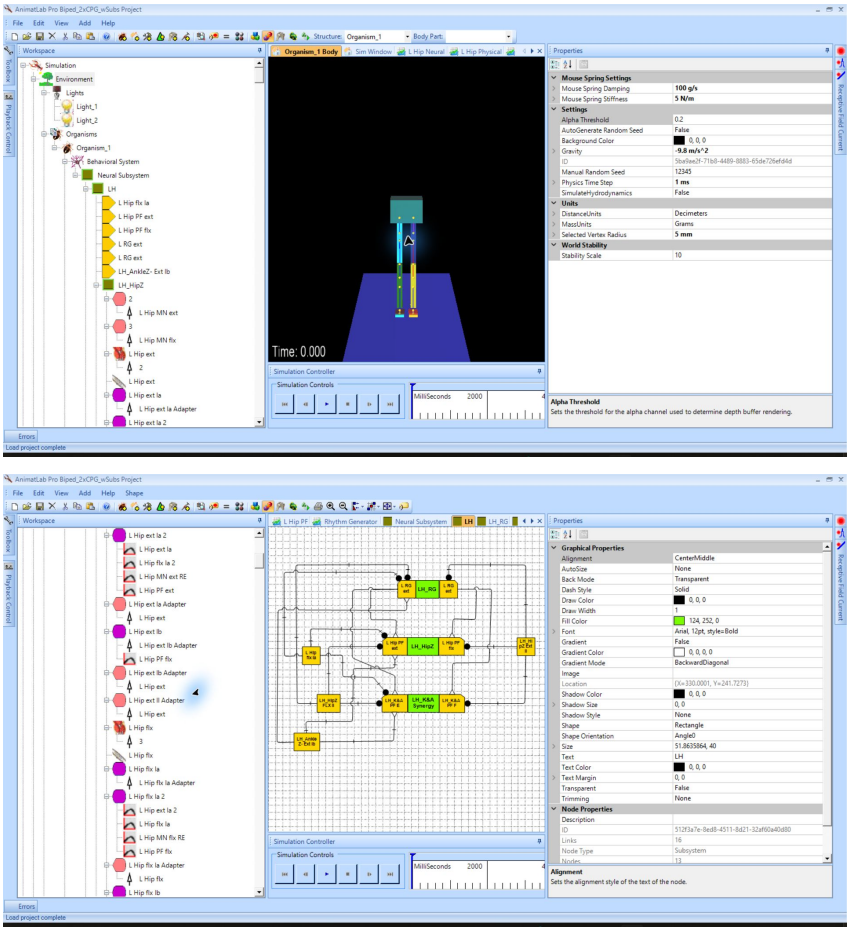


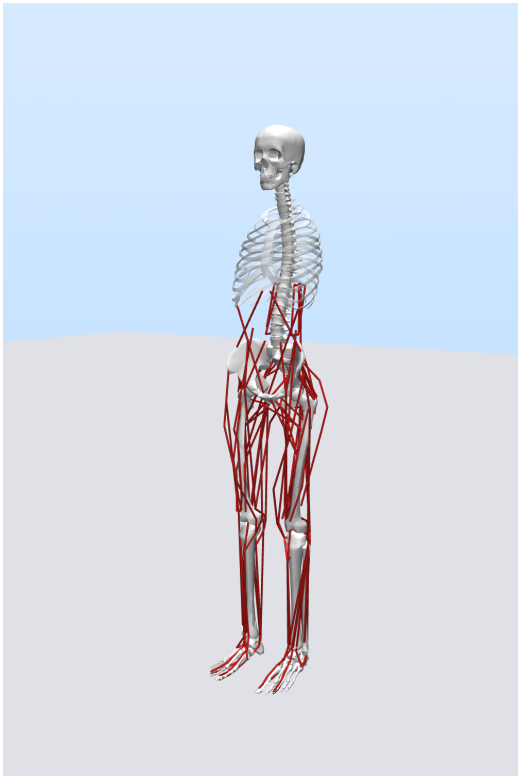

Figure 3.10: The saved AnimatLab working project opened in the application: the biomechanical body at initialization (top) and the expanded left-side controller subsystem (bottom). The workspace tree and property inspector expose the relationship between the body, sensory pathways, and neural modules. These interface captures were acquired without running a new simulation.

groups per leg, motoneuron pools for all actuators, and Ia, Ib, and II afferent populations — and its rhythm generator has been verified in isolation to oscillate at an approximately 0.9 s cycle with the two legs in antiphase under tonic drive. Full-body closed-loop co-simulation is not yet running: leg-joint states develop non-finite values during longer simulations, with the foot-contact meshes the primary suspect under investigation.

### 3.11.3 Simulink SNS Library and Reflex Topology

A seven-block Simulink SNS library was also created, comprising a non-spiking neuron, a graded chemical synapse, a spiking leaky integrate-and-fire neuron, Ia and Ib afferents, activation dynamics, and a placeholder BPA force block (Figure 3.12). These components were connected in a reduced-order knee-reflex topology with antagonist actuation, stretch feedback, autogenic inhibition, and reciprocal inhibition (Figure 3.13). The library and the reflex demonstration run in base Simulink without additional toolboxes; the block icons derive their excitatory/inhibitory symbols automatically from the synapse sign, in a color-blind-safe palette, and the journal figures regenerate from scripts. The route for coupling the model to CAD was settled on URDF export from SolidWorks followed by Simscape Multibody import, and the import path has been verified on a trial knee assembly; the tendon hardware is modeled in CAD but not yet inserted into the assembly. The model retains provisional mechanical parameters, the BPA force block remains a placeholder, and the saved runs are not used to establish quantitative knee-regulation performance.

**(A) Converted robot**



**(B) Synthetic BPA knee**

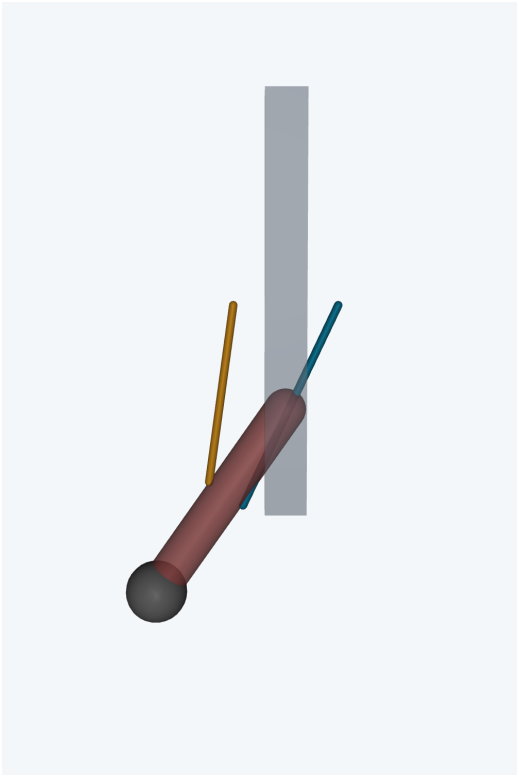


Figure 3.11: Native MuJoCo renders of **(A)** the converted Gait2392 robot at its saved reference pose, with muscle paths visible, and **(B)** the independent synthetic antagonist-BPA knee at an illustrative static angle of $-35^{\circ}$. Cyan and gold identify its named flexor and extensor tendon routes; transparency exposes the routes through the view. The models are not shown to the same scale. These views document model construction, not SNS control of the converted robot or validated torque predictions.

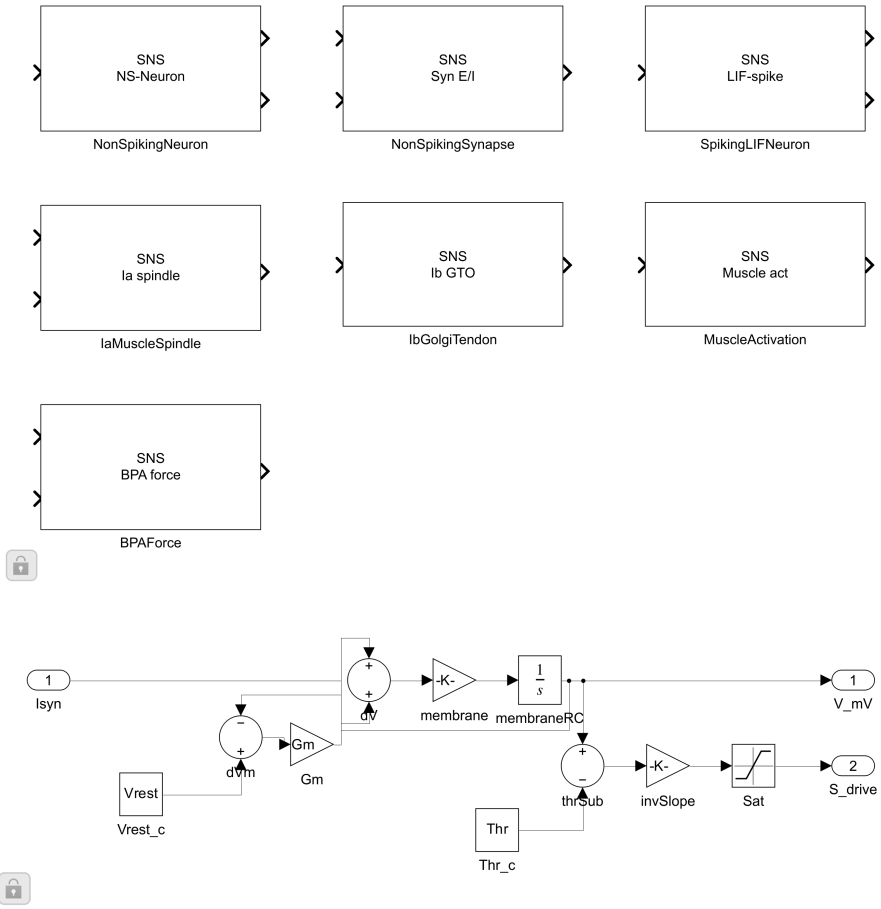



Figure 3.12: Native Simulink diagram exports showing the seven masked library blocks (top) and the internal implementation of the non-spiking neuron (bottom). The library blocks are arranged in a compact display grid for legibility. The BPA force block remains a placeholder. These implementation views do not establish quantitative knee regulation or a completed CAD-coupled Simscape Multibody model.

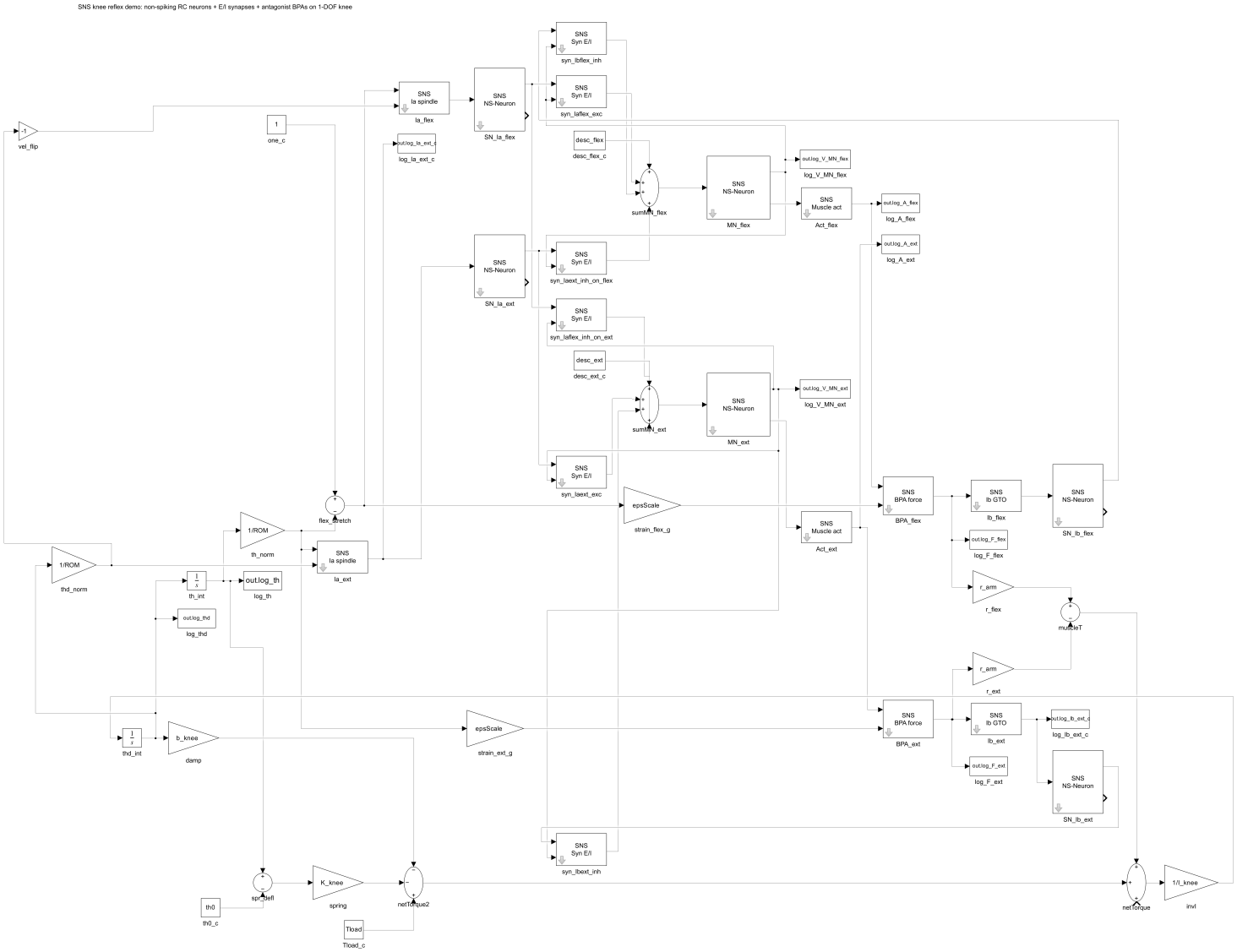



Figure 3.13: The complete reduced-order knee-reflex model exported from Simulink. The diagram connects Ia and Ib sensory pathways, excitatory and inhibitory synapses, antagonist motor neurons, activation and BPA force blocks, and the joint dynamics. Blocks and wires were arranged for display; source and destination ports were checked to confirm unchanged connectivity. Mechanical parameters and the BPA force block remain provisional.

### 3.11.4 Cross-Platform Verification of the Contact-Driven Rhythm Core

Because the neuromechanical toolchain assembled here spans several simulation engines, a verification protocol was defined around the contact-driven rhythm core of the two-layer W2L walker architecture: four persistent-sodium half-centers (one extensor/flexor pair per leg) plus graded pattern-formation and sensory cells, driven by heel-contact mechanosensory feedback. The same core was implemented twice from a common connectivity specification — as a NumPy reference integration through the SNS-Toolbox backend, and as native Simulink blocks from the SNS library of Section 3.11 — and both were driven with an identical protocol: a 12 s run at a 2 ms neural step, tonic drive with a brief kickoff pulse, and alternating 1 Hz heel-contact trains. Agreement was scored on rhythm-generator burst period, left–right antiphase correlation, burst counts, and full-trace correlation against the NumPy reference. The archived AnimatLab reference models (the bilateral contact-driven model, the modern W2L model, and the Li walker) were additionally re-run headless from their standalone simulators with instrumented charts, so that engine-level agreement and network-level agreement could be separated. The protocol covers the rhythm core and the archived models only; full-network and whole-body behavior are reported as limitations alongside the results in Section 4.6.

### 3.11.5 Spiking-Neuron Mirrors of the Simulation Models

The controllers documented above all compute with graded (non-spiking) neurons, in which the membrane potential itself is the analog activity variable that drives the plant. To test that the conclusions drawn from those models are not artifacts of graded coding,

spiking-neuron mirrors of all three simulation families were built, following one hybrid doctrine: the motor-neuron layer stays non-spiking, because the musculoskeletal plant consumes a continuous activation command, while the afferent encoders, rhythm-generator half-centers, pattern-formation cells, interneurons, and commissural cells become leaky integrate-and-fire neurons operating at real membrane-potential ranges — spikes above, analog voltages into the plant [Szczecinski et al., 2023, Nourse et al., 2023]. Event-based coding is expected to matter most in the afferent and rhythm layers, where mechanosensor onsets and phase transitions are discrete events, and least at the motor-neuron output, which the muscle activation dynamics low-pass filter anyway.

The MuJoCo–SNS-Toolbox mirror (`build_network_spiking.py`) reproduces the production spinal network of Section 3.11 population for population and connection for connection, and is selected at build time by a single environment-variable switch so that the default build path is untouched; that the non-spiking pipeline is unchanged was proven by re-running its defaults gate and baseline evaluation to bit-exact agreement. Because SNS-Toolbox 1.5.2 ships no spiking bursting-neuron class, the rhythm-generator half-centers are adapting integrate-and-fire cells: burst termination is carried by spike-frequency adaptation of the firing threshold, whose time constant reuses the analog network's persistent-sodium inactivation value so that tuned adaptation values transfer between the two builds. Spiking cells rest at $-70\,\mathrm{mV}$, spike at $-50\,\mathrm{mV}$, and reset to $-60\,\mathrm{mV}$, with a tonic bias current parking their equilibrium a few millivolts below threshold — the analog cells' near-threshold operating point. The network sub-steps at 0.5 ms (four sub-steps inside each 2 ms plant step) so that spike timing is resolved without changing the plant integration, and non-spiking readout taps are appended for the runner's stance

gates and neural logging so that all existing analysis code reads analog levels unchanged.

The mirror's synaptic weights are set by a calibration script rather than by hand. Spikes onto the non-spiking motor neurons are calibrated by mean conductance, so that a steady presynaptic train reproduces the non-spiking steady-state motor-neuron voltage (calibration residuals at or below $3 \times 10^{-4}$ mV); synapses between spiking cells are calibrated by firing-rate transfer (a 40 Hz source drives its target at 40 Hz, and a calibrated inhibitory synapse silences a 40 Hz-driven cell); the graded-to-spiking command pathway is scaled from the measured afferent current-to-rate map. The full calibration of record, with the measured residual of every factor, is tabulated in Appendix B (Table B3).

In the Simulink family, three blocks were added additively to the SNS library of Section 3.11 (fifteen blocks at the time of writing): a `SpikingNeuron` with the same internal synaptic summation as the non-spiking block, an event-wired `SpikingSynapse` whose conductance jumps by a fixed increment per presynaptic spike and saturates at its maximum, and a `HybridSpikingSynapse` that carries the same conductance dynamics onto a non-spiking postsynaptic cell. The blocks were verified against the analytic single-spike conductance decay (maximum deviation $6.2 \times 10^{-7}$ µS), against a verbatim port of the SNS-Toolbox update equations on a hybrid two-neuron circuit (identical spike count and maximum spike-time deviation 11.75 µs), and against the SNS-Toolbox numpy backend itself (mean interspike-interval difference 0.19 µs). Spiking twins of the knee-reflex and beverage-holding demonstrations were then built by copy-and-patch: only the sensory interneuron layer and its synapses are replaced by spiking cells, while the motor neurons, muscles, joints, and measurements are identical to the committed demonstrations, and the twin is run at an operating point matched to the baseline gains.

In the AnimatLab family, spiking copies of the runnable standalone exports were produced by scripted conversion of copies, leaving every original file untouched: neuron thresholds are moved from the graded regime (unreachably positive) into the spiking regime, every graded chemical synapse type is re-emitted as a per-spike synapse with the same identity and amplitude (interpreted as a per-spike conductance increment with 10 ms decay), and the per-connection class tag that AnimatLab stores independently of the synapse type is flipped to match. A calibrated variant sets each cell class's threshold just below its measured graded peak, and an ablation that converts the thresholds but keeps the graded synapses isolates which change does what. Each copy passes a structural validator (neuron, connection, synapse-type, chart, and stimulus sets identical to its original, and every class tag consistent) and runs headless to its configured end. The 2023 spiking walker model of the same lineage, which was tuned as a rate code from birth, serves as the spiking reference baseline for this family.

Each mirror is verified against its non-spiking twin by a fixed gate set rather than by inspection: a topology gate requires the connection multiset to be identical between the two builds under three gain configurations; a rhythm gate requires self-sustained alternating rhythm under constant drive with the period within 20 % of the analog build; a basin gate requires the rhythm to persist under 1 % multiplicative jitter on every scalar parameter; an air-regime smoke gate compares cadence, duty, and joint ranges of the deafferented suspended-air preparation; and a regression gate requires every committed non-spiking artifact to reproduce its recorded values exactly with the spiking blocks present in the library. The mirrors carry mapped parameters only — no new tuning was performed — so their results (Section 4.7) establish what transfers structurally and what requires re-tuning,

and any fresh tuning campaign is future work.

# 4 Results

Publication note: Section 4.2 and the associated figures and tables appeared in Bolen et al. [2026] (Bolen, Elzein, Pang, and Hunt, *Actuators*, 2026). Section 4.3 and the associated figures and tables are also the subject of an unpublished manuscript in preparation by Bolen, Burgess, Morrow, Elzein, Pang, Scharzenberger, and Hunt [Bolen et al., 2025]. This manuscript has not been submitted for publication. Author contributions for both works are stated in Chapter 3.

## 4.1 Completed Foundation Studies

Four studies completed during this dissertation establish the foundation for the results that follow. First, the placement optimization of Morrow, Bolen, and Hunt found artificial muscle attachment locations that reproduce human torque profiles and ranges of motion about the trunk and leg joints [Morrow et al., 2020]; it converted the earlier finding that transplanted human attachment locations do not transfer directly to a BPA-actuated robot [Bolen, 2019, Bolen and Hunt, 2019] into a usable design tool. The route redesigns of Section 4.4 rerun that tool under the corrected torque model. Second, the Sensory Afferent Database organized sensory-afferent literature into a structured, model-oriented resource [Bolen et al., 2023], and a follow-up study evaluated AI-assisted literature triage for expanding it [Bolen and Hunt, 2024]; those data inform the sensory channels of the neural controller. The database has since been audited and expanded into a curated laboratory

tool: of the 943 papers in the audited corpus, 833 carry structured curation notes, 95 carry an afferent classification, and 363 carry notes translating each pathway toward robot or simulation use, packaged with the corpus citation graph (18 topic clusters, 11,130 directed citation pairs) as a self-contained explorer for lab use. Third, an inverted-pendulum balance platform with BPA-driven plantarflexion and dorsiflexion demonstrated pseudo-vestibular feedback using inertial measurement units [Bolen et al., 2024b,a,c]. Fourth, companion work by Elzein, Lutz, Bolen, and Hunt produced a state-space, optimization-based model of pressure and force dynamics in pulse-modulated BPAs [Elzein et al., 2025], supplying dynamic actuator behavior beyond the static force characterization reported below.

## 4.2 BPA Force Characterization

This section reports the results of the isometric force characterization experiments described in Section 3.3. First, maximum isometric force at 620 kPa is modeled as a function of resting length. The remaining data are then normalized to build a predictive force surface, and the resulting model is compared with the manufacturer's tool and with other published BPA models.

### 4.2.1 Maximum Force at 620 kPa

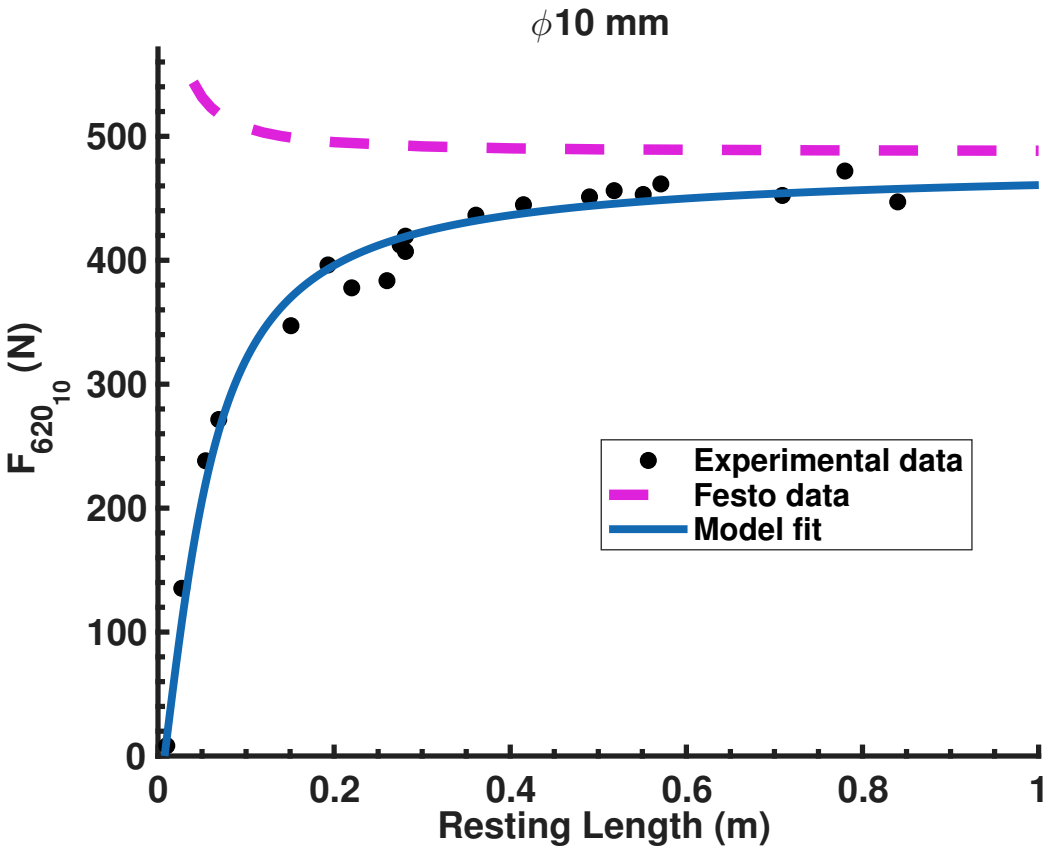
Data of the maximum force from BPA characterization tests of the 10 mm and 20 mm diameters at 620 kPa show a dependency on resting length (Figure 4.1). This is a previously unreported characteristic of these artificial muscles. Detailed analysis of the Festo tool [Festo AG & Co. KG, 2026] does in fact predict a change in maximum force with the

resting length; however, the Festo tool predicts increased force with shorter lengths, while our collected data indicate decreasing force with shorter lengths. The data show a force response resembling an arctan curve along the $l_0$ dimension. Using the Nonlinear Least Squares method and a Least Absolute Residual robustness, we fit an arctan curve to the data to get the maximum force at 620 kPa given a resting length as:

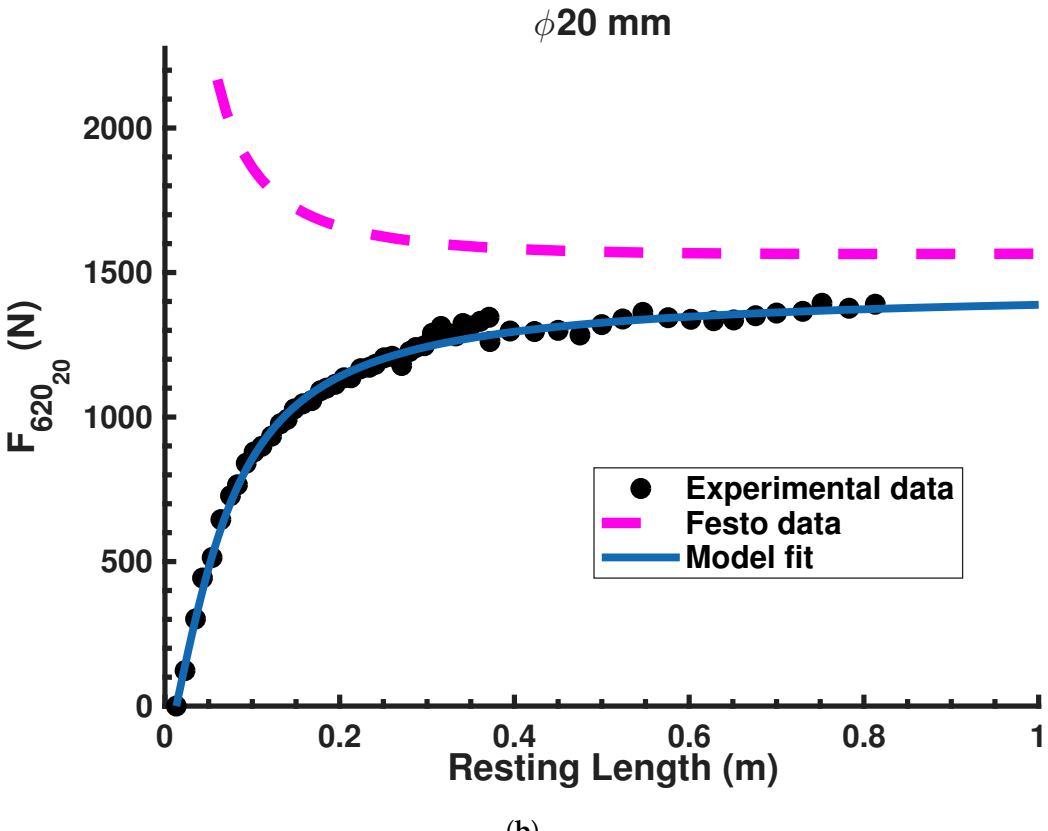
$$F_{620_{10}} = 303.5\,\mathrm{N} \cdot \arctan\left(19.03\,\mathrm{m}^{-1} \cdot (l_0 - 0.0075)\right) \tag{4.1}$$

$$F_{620_{20}} = 922.4\,\mathrm{N} \cdot \arctan\left(15.37\,\mathrm{m}^{-1} \cdot (l_0 - 0.013)\right) \tag{4.2}$$

The length is offset by 0.0075 m and 0.013 m because solid modeling showed that the end caps contact each other at these lengths. At these lengths, the actuator would not be able to contract to produce force.


$\phi$10 mm
500
400
300
200
100
0
$F_{620_{10}}$ (N)
0
0.2
0.4
0.6
0.8
1
Resting Length (m)
Experimental data
Festo data
Model fit

(a)


$\phi$20 mm
2000
1500
1000
500
0
$F_{620_{20}}$ (N)
0
0.2
0.4
0.6
0.8
1
Resting Length (m)
Experimental data
Festo data
Model fit

(b)

### 4.2.2 Force as a Function of Pressure and Resting Length

Data from BPA characterization tests of the 10 mm muscles resulted in force–pressure pairings for different muscle resting lengths ($l_0$) (Figure 4.2a). Similar to the maximum force data, these data show a force response resembling an arctan curve along the $l_0$ dimension with a more linear response to changes in pressure. Using the Nonlinear Least Squares method and a Least Absolute Residual robustness, we fit an arctan curve to the data to get the maximum force given a resting length and pressure as described by the model form given in Section 3.2: where $a_1 = 0.4895\,\mathrm{N\,kPa^{-1}}$ and $a_2 = 0.030\,68\,\mathrm{kPa^{-1}\,m^{-1}}$ for the 10 mm actuator, and $a_1 = 1.49\,\mathrm{N\,kPa^{-1}}$, $a_2 = 0.0248\,\mathrm{kPa^{-1}\,m^{-1}}$ for the 20 mm actuator. Goodness-of-fit measures are given in Table 4.1; throughout this dissertation, goodness of fit is reported as the root-mean-square error (RMSE), the adjusted fraction of variance unexplained (FVU, for which $R^2 = 1 - \mathrm{FVU}$), and the maximum absolute residual, as defined alongside the reference implementation in Appendix A.

### 4.2.3 Maximum Contraction at 620 kPa

Figure 4.2(b) shows an attempt at a linear fit for maximum contraction at 620 kPa ($\epsilon_{620}$) as a function of resting length ($l_0$). Error bars have been included to show the effect of $\pm 1$ mm accuracy with measurements of $l_0$ and $l_{620}$. There was a large amount of variance in the data, with the linear fit giving an adjusted $\mathrm{R}^2 = 0.4124$ and an RMSE $= 0.0083$. Since there is no direct, predicable relationship between maximum contraction and $l_0$, this value should be recorded in each muscle used on a robot to best predict the force it may produce at different pressures and contraction.

Table 4.1: Maximum force equation coefficient values with confidence intervals (CI) and goodness-of-fit measures. Equation (3.5) is compared to data taken at 620 kPa. Equations (4.1) and (4.2) are compared against maximum force from using the Festo tool. It was not necessary to fit an adjusted $R^2$ in these cases.

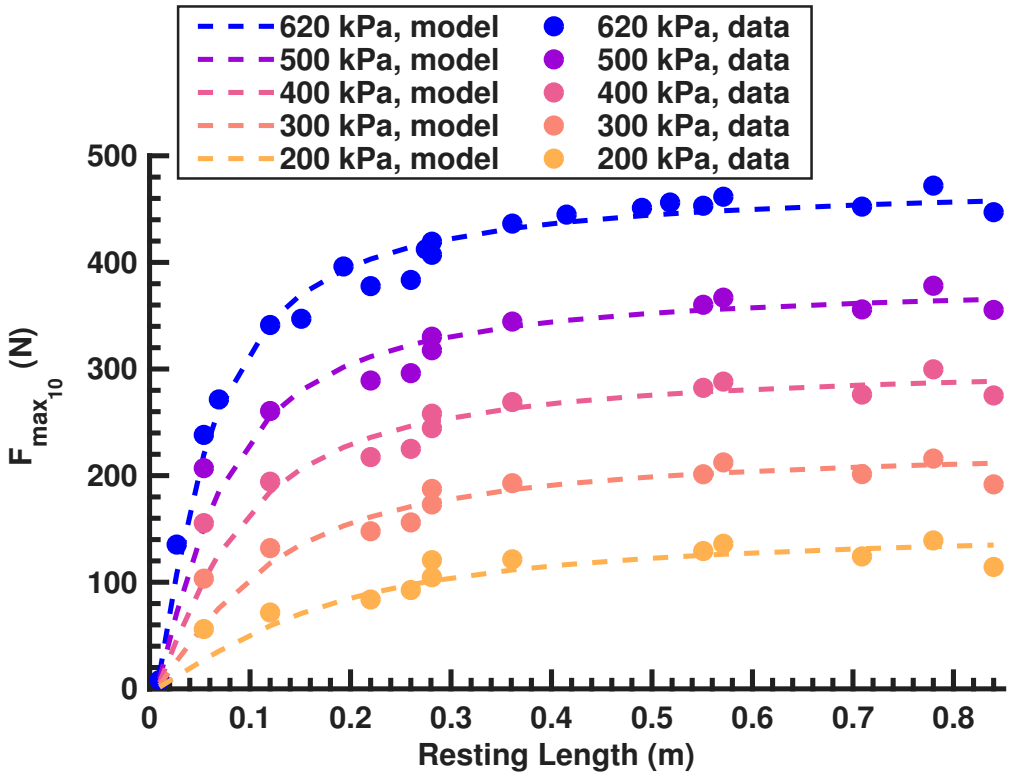
| Equation | Coefficient | CI (95%) | Our Model | | | Festo Tool | | |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| | | | Adj. $R^2$ | RMSE | Max. Error | Adj. $R^2$ | RMSE | Max. Error |
| (3.5) | $a_1 = 0.4895\,\mathrm{N\,kPa^{-1}}$<br>$a_2 = 0.030\,68\,\mathrm{kPa^{-1}\,m^{-1}}$ | (0.4822, 0.4968)<br>(0.0282, 0.03317) | 0.9945 | 11.61 N | 55.3 N | 0.9854 | 14.7 N | 30.9 N |
| (4.1) | $b_1 = 303.5\,\mathrm{N}$<br>$b_2 = 19.03\,\mathrm{m^{-1}}$ | (300, 308)<br>(17.48, 20.57) | 0.9854 | 14.72 N | 30.9 N | – | 189.9 N | 375.6 N |
| (4.2) | $b_1 = 922.4\,\mathrm{N}$<br>$b_2 = 15.37\,\mathrm{m^{-1}}$ | (914.2, 930.7)<br>(14.75, 15.98) | 0.9945 | 23.83 N | 62.1 N | – | 668.4 N | 1590.1 N |

Table 4.2: Normalized isometric BPA force equation (Equation (3.4)) coefficient values and goodness-of-fit measures.

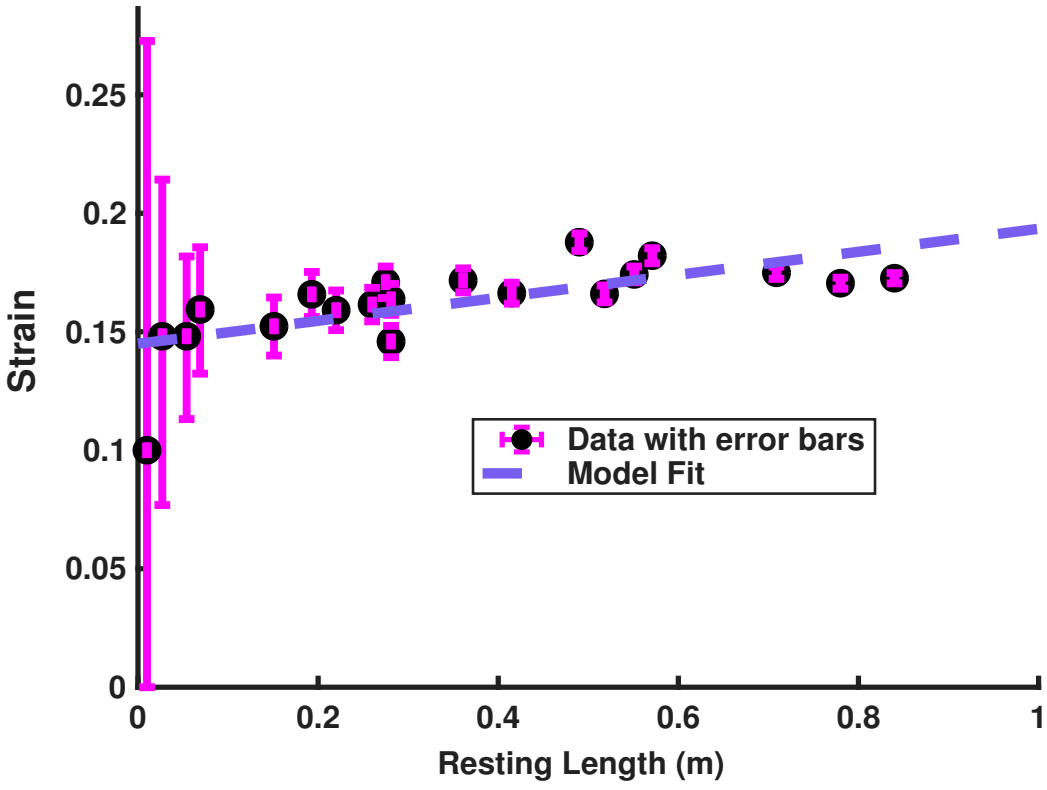
| BPA | Coefficient | CI (95%) | Model | | | Validation | | |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| | | | Adj. $R^2$ | RMSE | Max. Error | Adj. $R^2$ | RMSE | Max. Error |
| $\phi$10 mm | $c_0 = 0.5682$ | (0.5584, 0.578) | 0.9998 | 0.005118 | 10.3% | 0.9994 | 0.0245409 | 10.6% |
| | $c_1 = 4.254$ | (4.126, 4.383) | | | | | | |
| | $c_2 = 0.5597$ | (0.5429, 0.5766) | | | | | | |
| $\phi$20 mm | $c_0 = 0.2579$ | (0.2401, 0.2756) | 0.992 | 0.02294 | 6.8% | 0.9943 | 0.0231303 | 5.7% |
| | $c_1 = 6.477$ | (5.558, 7.396) | | | | | | |
| | $c_2 = 1.321$ | (1.239, 1.403) | | | | | | |

### 4.2.4 Force as a Function of Pressure and Contraction

In addition to being a function of the pressure and resting length, the force produced by the actuator is also a function of the amount of actuator contraction, with less force being applied as the actuator contracts. To build this model, the collected data of force, pressure, and contraction are normalized by dividing by $F_{620}$, $P_{620}$, and $\epsilon_{620}$, respectively. This had the effect of compressing the data into a 3D surface ranging from 0 to 1 on all axes. Normalized data are compared with pressure isoclines of force predicted by the Festo tool divided by the maximum force equation described in the previous section in Figure 4.3. With this comparison, it is clear that the Festo tool over-predicts the expected force, especially at lower pressures, contraction, and resting lengths.

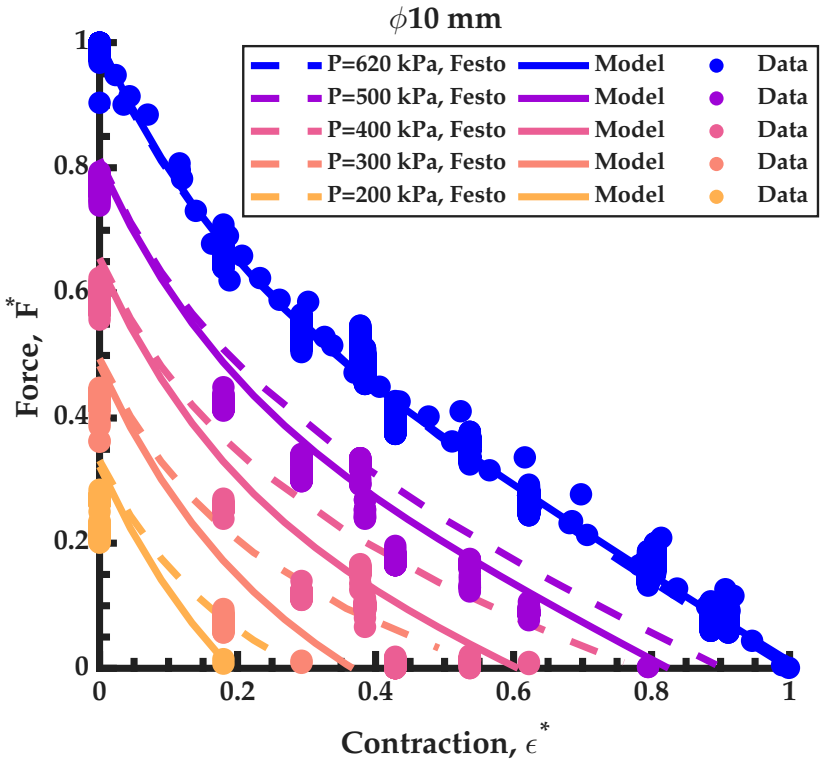



(a)

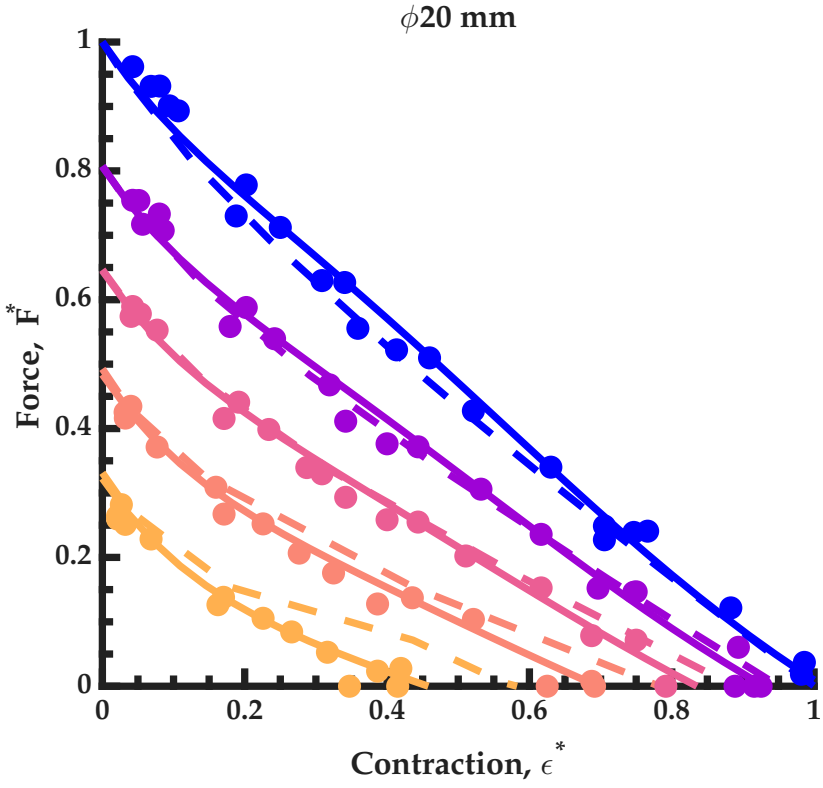



(b)

Figure 4.2: Results for finding the relationship between $F_{620}$, $l_0$, $P_{620}$, and $\epsilon_{620_{ss}}$. (**a**) Isoclines




(a)




(b)

Figure 4.3: Surface fit for $F^*(\epsilon^*, P^*)$. Solid lines are from our model. Dashed lines from

We therefore derived our own equation for isometric force in the BPA as a function of pressure and contraction. Visual analysis of the experimental data shows an exponential relationship between $\epsilon^*$ and $F^*$, and a linear relationship between $P^*$ and $F$. We fit a surface to the data using Nonlinear Least Squares and a Least Absolute Residual robustness such that it is described by Equation (3.4). For the $\phi$10 mm BPAs, the result of the improved fit can be seen in Figure 4.3a. The adjusted $R^2 = 0.9998$, a RMSE $= 0.004537$, and a maximum absolute residual of 10.6%. Solving (3.4) for the $\phi$20 mm BPA, yields different coefficients, and results are seen in Figure 4.3b. Coefficient values and goodness-of-fit statistics are found in Table 4.2.

## 4.3 Isometric Knee Torque

With the actuator force model validated at the actuator level, the same model was used to predict isometric torque about the knee joint for the test stands described in Sections 3.4 and 3.6. Measured torque is compared against three predictions: the original rigid-body torque model, a prediction using the improved BPA force characterization alone, and the improved torque model of Section 3.7 after optimization. The hybrid torque method (Section 3.6) is used to isolate the sources of error.

### 4.3.1 Flexor on Pin Joint

Experimentally measured torque is compared with various prediction methods while using flexor BPAs on the pinned knee joint (Fig. 4.4). These results show that the original model and the improved BPA force model overpredict the measured torque at the knee for

all joint angles, although the improved model performs slightly better (Fig. 4.4**A** and4.4**B**). However, when the measured parameters ($l_{\mathrm{m}}$ and $r_k$) are used in the hybrid model, then predictions closely match the experimental data. This indicates that the kinematics of the torque model are incorrectly predicting $l_{\mathrm{m}}$ and/or $r_k$.

The optimization yielded $\chi_0 = 11.9\,\mathrm{mm}$, $\chi_1 = 102\,\mathrm{kN\,m^{-1}}$, and $\chi_2 = 10.6\,\mathrm{kN\,m^{-1}}$ (Table 4.3). It can be seen that the model with these correction factors greatly improves the ability to predict the joint torque, even capturing the reduction in force at small joint angles that was completely missing from the previous model. The $l_0 = 45.7\,\mathrm{cm}$ BPA was used for validation (Fig. 4.4**D**). It can be seen that the improved model does a good job of predicting the torque with a different muscle length configured to operate over a different joint range of motion. The optimized torque prediction for the $l_0 = 48.5\,\mathrm{cm}$ BPA has an RMSE $= 1.616$, FVU $= 0.0958$, and a maximum absolute residual of 3.2527; validation on the $l_0 = 45.7\,\mathrm{cm}$ BPA gives RMSE $= 2.1214$, FVU $= 0.0878$, and a maximum absolute residual of 5.1690 (Table 4.4).

Table 4.3: Optimized coefficient values for flexor and extensor configurations. $X_0$ is a constant length offset (in meters), $X_1$ and $X_2$ are stiffness values (in N/m) in the bracket's X and Y directions, respectively, and $X_3$ is the unitless wrapping factor.

| | $\mathbf{X}_0$ | $\mathbf{X}_1$ | $\mathbf{X}_2$ | $\mathbf{X}_3$ |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| **Flexor** | 0.0119 | 1.02E+05 | 1.06E+04 | – |
| **Extensor** | -0.0109 | 1.02E+05 | 1.06E+04 | 0.123 |

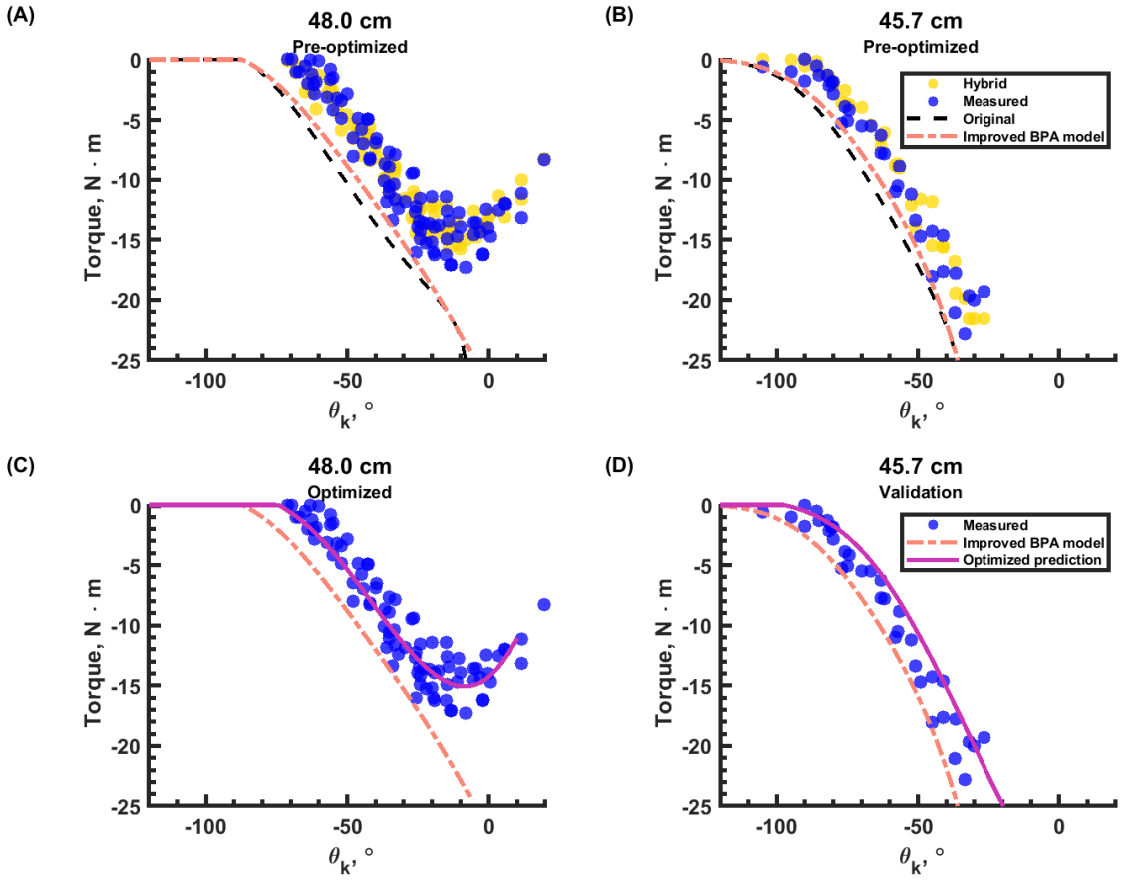



Figure 4.4: Results for the pinned knee joint using flexor BPAs. Dashed black line shows the torque predicted with our original model. Blue dots are the experimentally measured torque. Yellow dots represent the hybrid method of calculating torque. The magenta line represents the predicted torque. **(A)** Measured and pre-optimized torque prediction for the 48.5 cm BPA. **(B)** Measured and pre-optimized torque prediction for the $l_0 = 45.7$ cm BPA. **(C)** Theoretical and measured torque for the $l_0 = 48.5$ cm BPA using optimization results. **(D)** Predicted measured torque for the $l_0 = 45.7$ cm BPA using the optimization results

### 4.3.2 Extensor on Pin Joint

When the new stiffness and length offet model was used to predict torque for the knee extensor, measured torque was slightly higher than the original model calculates for the 48 cm resting length BPA, while it was slightly lower than expected in the 46 cm BPA, and it was much lower in the 42 cm. Only the $K_1$ and $K_2$ terms from the previous optimization results were used with the extensor configuration. Firstly, by inspection, the zero point for the measured torque was shifted to the right of the original model, indicating an offset that was at least opposite in sign from the $\chi_0$ term in the previous section. Secondly, if we look at the BPA $l_0 = 46\,\text{cm}$ as an example, we see good correlation between the hybrid-method calculated torque and the originally predicted torque, but a divergence in the actual measured torque.

Results are shown in Fig. 4.5. The solution was found while holding the $l_0 = 41.5\,\text{cm}$ BPA for validation. The optimization resulted in $\chi_0 = -10.9\,\text{mm}$ and $\chi_3 = 0.123$. It should be noted here that the length offset $\chi_0$ is almost equal in magnitude, but opposite sign, as the flexor configuration. The goodness of fit values for the torque prediction is found in table 4.4.

### 4.3.3 Extensor on Biomimetic Knee

We obtained results using the biomimetic knee with a $\phi 10\,\text{mm}$ BPA in the extensor configuration. The bracket frame origin is the centroid of the cantilevered segment that holds the muscle origin bracket to the proximal femur (see Fig. 3.5**C**, right side).

The torque results for a $l_0 = 51.8\,\text{cm}$ BPA are shown in Fig. 4.6. The torque values

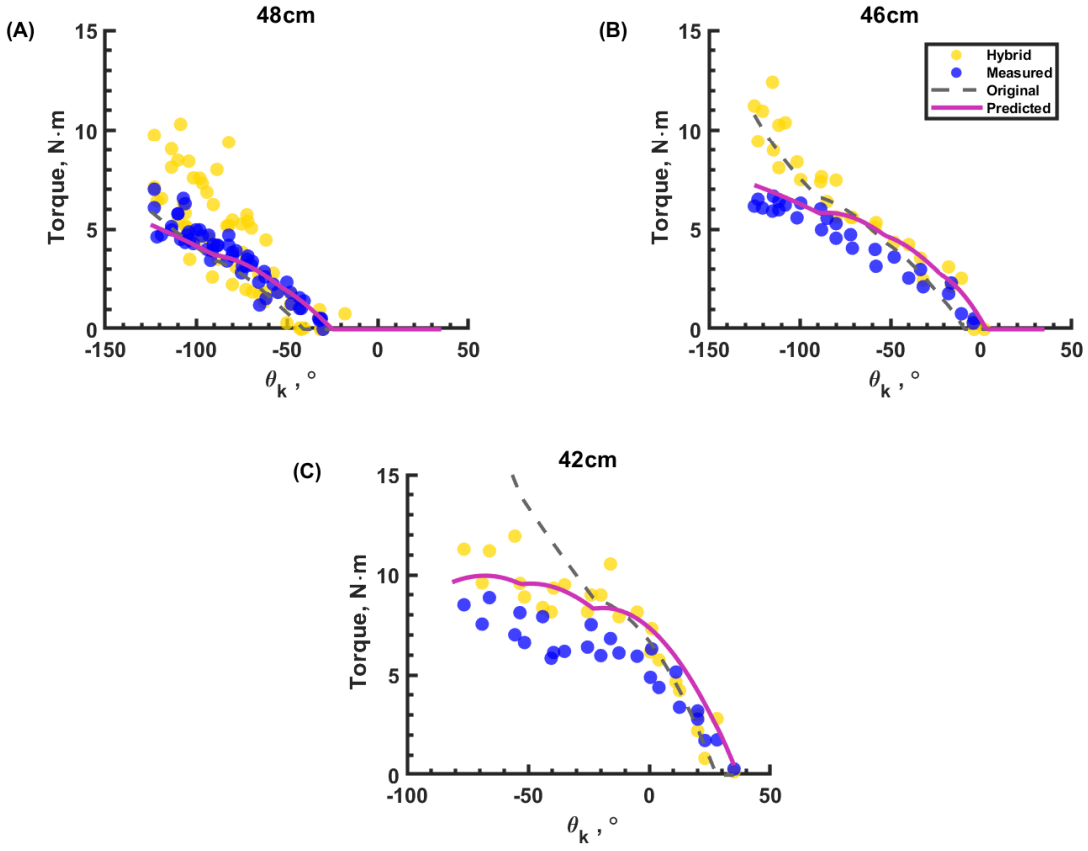



Figure 4.5: Pinned knee torque versus knee angle with the extensor BPAs. Blue dots are experimentally measured data, yellow dots are hybrid calculated torque, black dashed line is the original predicted values, and magenta line is the optimized predicted torque. For resting lengths, **(A)** 48.0 cm, **(B)** 45.7 cm, **(C)** and 41.5 cm.

measured are significantly smaller than both the original prediction and back-calculated torque using the hybrid method. The results from the previous extensor configuration lead to a better torque prediction. GoF values can be found in table 4.4. Fig.4.7 shows the difficulty of modeling a BPA path that passes through the femoral condyles. Using the optimization results for extensor BPAs on the pinned knee joint, the $l_0 = 51.8\,\text{cm}$ BPA has an RMSE $= 0.8920$, FVU $= 0.3396$, and a maximum absolute residual of 1.4188.

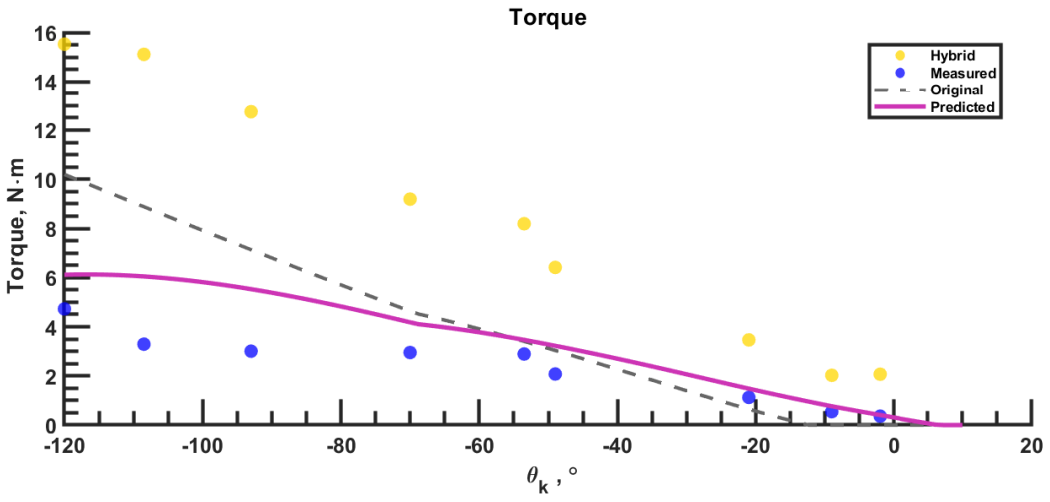



Figure 4.6: Measured versus expected isometric torque results using a $\phi 10\,\text{mm}$, $l_0 = 51.8\,\text{cm}$ extensor BPA on the biomimetic knee. Measured results are blue dots. Original prediction is a dashed black line. Optimized prediction is a solid magenta line. Hybrid calculation shown in yellow dots.

### 4.3.4 Flexor on Biomimetic Knee

Fig. 4.8 shows the isometric torque values of the biomimetic knee from measurements, the Hunt model [Hunt et al., 2017a], and the predictions of the updated model. The values

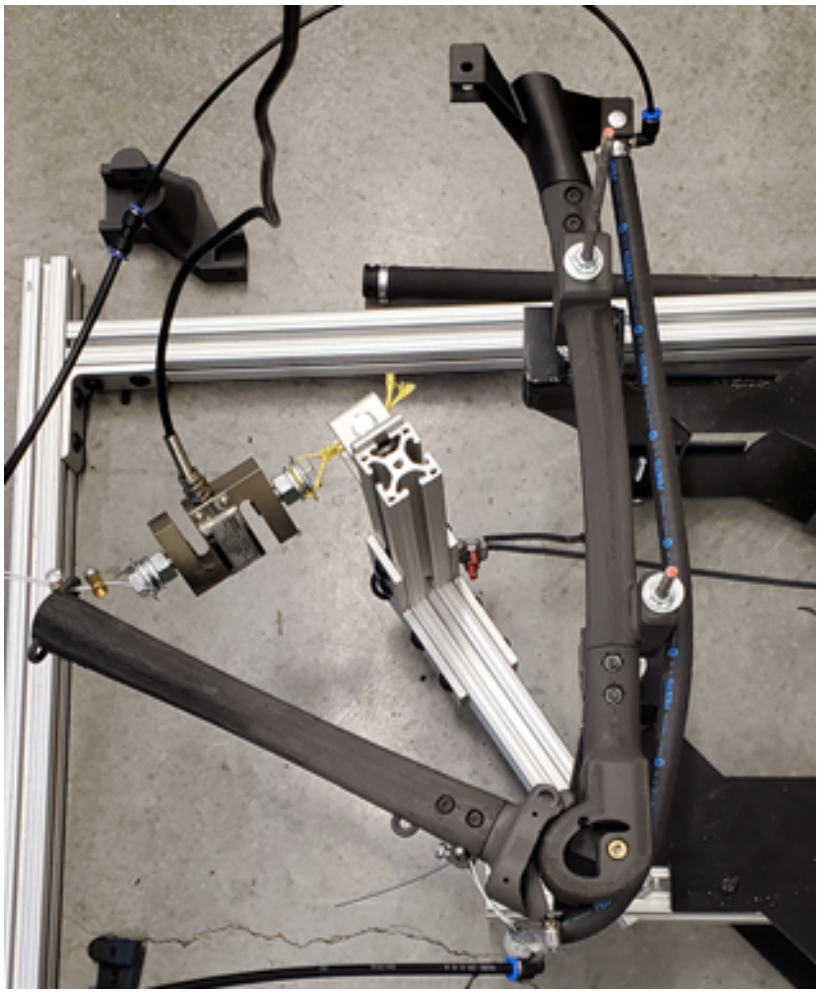


Figure 4.7: A configuration that is particularly hard to model. The BPA passes between the femoral condyles close to ICR.

for $\chi_0$, $\chi_1$, and $\chi_2$ derived from the flexors on the pinned knee were used. The bracket frame for the $\phi$10 mm BPA is shown on the left hand side of Fig. 3.5**C**, and for the $\phi$20 mm it is 3.5**D**. Fig. 4.8**A** represents a $\phi$10 mm $l_0 = 41.5$ cm BPA with a 21 mm artificial tendon made out of $\phi$1.5 mm Shimano bicycle brake cable. The brake cable was wrapped four times. The BPA was pressurized to 604 kPa. The predicted values have an RMSE $= 0.3007$, FVU $= 0.0102$, and a maximum absolute residual of 0.4647 $N \cdot m$. Fig. 4.8**B** represents a $\phi$20 mm $l_0 = 42.0$ cm BPA with a 15 mm artificial tendon made out of Shimano bicycle brake cable (wrapped six times). Maximum human isometric torque values are shown as the black dotted line. The experiment was performed at 620 kPa and 325 kPa. At 620 kPa, the predicted values have an RMSE $= 1.8024$, FVU $= 0.0499$, and a maximum absolute residual of 3.5678 $N \cdot m$. The BPA torque does not exceed the magnitude of the human torque from ca. 60 – 100 degrees knee flexion. Allowing for a $\pm$20% deviation from the human mean, the BPA does not produce human levels of torque from 78 – 103 degrees knee flexion.

Table 4.4: Goodness of fit for the improved torque model across test configurations. RMSE and maximum absolute residual are in N $\cdot$ m.

| **Configuration** | **RMSE** | **FVU** | **Max. residual** |
|---|---|---|---|
| Flexor, pin joint, $l_0 = 48.5$ cm (fit) | 1.616 | 0.0958 | 3.2527 |
| Flexor, pin joint, $l_0 = 45.7$ cm (validation) | 2.1214 | 0.0878 | 5.1690 |
| Extensor, biomimetic knee, $l_0 = 51.8$ cm | 0.8920 | 0.3396 | 1.4188 |
| Flexor, biomimetic knee, $\phi$10 mm, $l_0 = 41.5$ cm | 0.3007 | 0.0102 | 0.4647 |
| Flexor, biomimetic knee, $\phi$20 mm, $l_0 = 41.5$ cm (620 kPa) | 1.8024 | 0.0499 | 3.5678 |

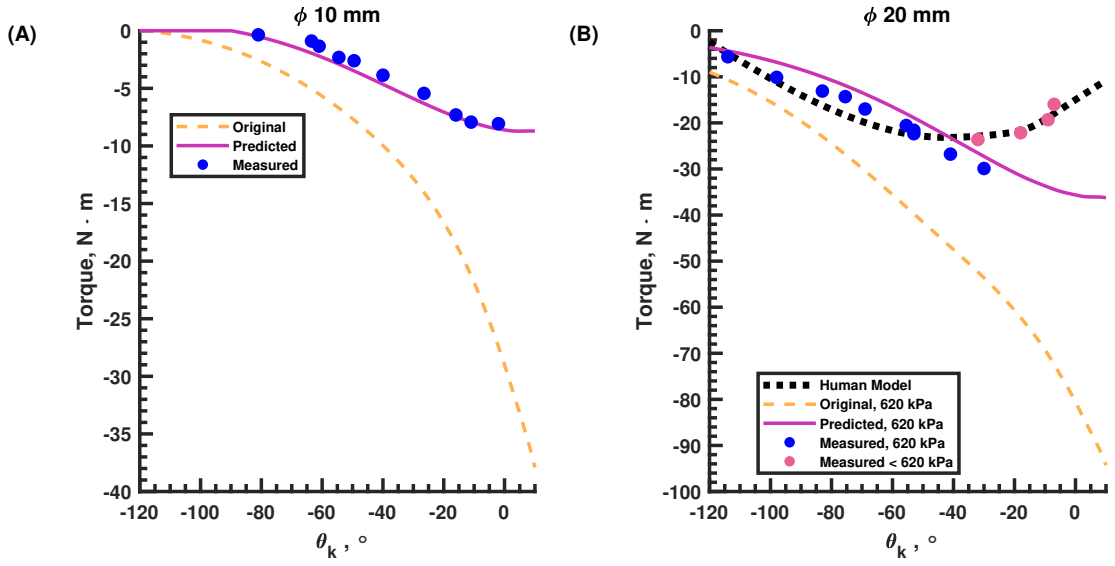



Figure 4.8: Biomimetic knee torque for **(A)** $\phi$10 mm $l_0 = 41.5$ cm flexor BPA with a 21 mm artificial tendon. Blue dots show the measured torque values. Magenta line is the predicted torque using the improved BPA characterization and optimization from the previous sections. The dashed light orange line shows the torque predicted using only the improved BPA characterization. **(B)** $\phi$20 mm $l_0 = 42.0$ cm flexor BPA with a 15 mm artificial tendon uses the same colors for 620 kPa results. Human values are given as a black dotted line. Due to the BPA exceeding the ultimate strength of the femur, torque measurements were taken at $P < P_{620}$ to show the desired RoM is achievable. Results for torque measurements at 560 kPa, 421 kPa, 325 kPa and 281 kPa (from left to right, respectively), are shown as pink dots.

### 4.4 Follow-Up Identification and Route Redesign

The identification work outlined at the close of the experimental chapters has since been completed, and its outcomes are summarized here; the coefficient values shown with the figures above (Table 4.3) belong to the initial single-bracket identification of those experiments.

The correction terms were re-identified over the full archived test sets with the two-stage procedure of Section 3.7: a two-bracket flexor fit cross-validated over the five pinned-flexor tests (the encoder-corrected 47 cm test held out), followed by an extensor refit with the stiffness pair locked to the flexor front. The adopted values are $\chi_0 = 3.94\,\mathrm{mm}$, $\chi_1 = 3.998 \times 10^4\,\mathrm{N\,m^{-1}}$, and $\chi_2 = 1.473 \times 10^4\,\mathrm{N\,m^{-1}}$ for the flexor (front row 77), and $\chi_0 = -6.38\,\mathrm{mm}$ with $\chi_3 = 0.158$ for the extensor on that same locked pair; full provenance is given in Appendix C, Table C8. This pair was adopted because it is the stiffness pair for which both redesign configurations meet the required 5 % torque-overshoot target simultaneously (flexor $+5.00\,\%$, extensor $+5.043\,\%$ at $-20.2^\circ$ in the 2026-09-20 campaign). At these values, the corrected flexor model predicts the five pinned-flexor tests with per-test RMSE of 2.16/1.37/2.29/1.61/1.08 N m (48, 46, 47, 40-tendon, 41 cm; FVU at most 0.17), the 47 cm test being pure held-out validation. On the six-test extensor validation pool, per-test RMSE spans 0.49–1.52 N m against 0.95–3.62 N m for the uncorrected rigid model — an improvement on every pool test, with FVU below unity on every pool test except the 43 cm-tendon test (FVU 1.33 against a rigid-baseline FVU of 4.73). On the biomimetic extensor test ($l_0 = 51.8\,\mathrm{cm}$) the corrected prediction improves substantially on the baseline (RMSE 1.17 vs. 3.03 N m, FVU 0.67 vs. 4.49), so the shared-pair model

now explains the bulk of that configuration's measured torque variance as well as its level. The solver question raised during the campaign was settled empirically: the genetic multiobjective solver was retained for the identification, where the Pareto front is required for holdout validation, and the surrogate-plus-pattern-search pipeline was reserved for the route redesign where it is already the method of record (Section 3.8).

The route redesign built on these values is likewise far advanced. The two-BPA flexor arrangement — motivated by the single-muscle shortfall at high flexion angles documented above — reached a feasible solution meeting the flexor torque target under the modeling assumption that both actuators share one attachment route rather than a physically mirrored pair; making the mirrored pair explicit is the next design refinement. The flexor re-run under the newly adopted correction terms is complete: its design of record (`Bifemsh_20mm_Result.mat`, 2026-09-21) meets the 5 % target with a minimum margin of $+5.01$ % at $-107^\circ$. The extensor route was redesigned directly under the adopted correction terms and meets or exceeds its human-scaled target with the required 5 % overshoot consumed as the thinnest margin at every angle of record: $+5.043$ % at $-20.2^\circ$ in the 2026-09-20 campaign, improved to $+5.02$ % by the 2026-09-25 re-run of record (`Vas_Pam_20mm_Result.mat`), while respecting the wrap-release schedule and contraction limits of the route-elimination rule (Appendix C). These redesign solutions are the plant definitions carried into the neuromechanical simulation work of Sections 3.11–4.6 and Chapter 6.

### 4.4.1 Redesigned-Route Results on the Gait2392 Robot-Body Model

The preceding paragraphs record the adopted correction terms and margin targets; this subsection records the quantitative outcomes of the redesigned routes on the Gait2392-derived robot-body model, whose muscle force and torque targets define the redesign objectives. All three result families were produced by the surrogate-plus-pattern-search pipeline of Section 3.8 under the adopted correction terms (Appendix C, Table C8) with one shared actuator plan: two 20 mm BPAs per route, a 620 kPa pressure ceiling, and a maximum usable contraction (KMAX) of 0.255 in the force model. Each family minimizes its own objective function (`objective_KneeExt20mm`, `objective_KneeFlexor20mm`, and the pulley variant `objective_KneeFlexorPulley` inside `Opt_run_pulley.m`): a unitless weighted sum of normalized penalty terms, in which zero corresponds to no violated penalty, led by the worst-angle and mean-square torque shortfall against the required 5 %-overshoot human envelope, followed by overshoot, rest-length, strain, contraction, and mild design-change penalties. The three functions differ in penalty families and normalizations (the flexor and pulley objectives add off-axis-excess, wrap-release, and second-BPA anchor terms, and the pulley objective evaluates its torque requirement on the insertion-side torque after the tackle's force loss), so their numerical values quoted below are not commensurable with one another. The human-scaled requirements quoted below are the redesign contexts' `ctx.humanTorque` targets, the OpenSim isometric torque profiles of the reference human muscles over the same design-grid angles (`OpenSim_Vasti_Results.txt` for the extensor and `OpenSim_Bifem_Results.txt` for the flexor, loaded by `buildKneeExtContext20mm.m` and `buildKneeFlexorContext20mm.m`).

The extensor route, solved by `Opt_run_Ext.m`, reached its design of record (`Vas_Pam_20mm_Result.mat`) at an objective of 0.1091, with the preceding 2026-09-20 campaign snapshot at 0.09770. Its minimum torque-margin fraction is 0.05025 at the worst-case point of the design grid (angle index 77 of the one-based MATLAB grid, the $-20.2^\circ$ point), so the required 5 % overshoot is consumed as the thinnest margin exactly as designed. Across the design range, the predicted two-BPA extensor torque spans $35.45\,\mathrm{N\cdot m}$ to $109.4\,\mathrm{N\cdot m}$ against the human-scaled requirement of $20.25\,\mathrm{N\cdot m}$ to $50.32\,\mathrm{N\cdot m}$: the route exceeds the human envelope in magnitude at every angle, with zero shortfall points.

The flexor route, solved by `Opt_run.m` with the same two-BPA arrangement sharing one attachment route, improved its objective from a seeded starting evaluation of 2894 to a best value of 74.47 and meets the flexor torque target with a minimum margin fraction of 0.05007 against the required 0.05. Its predicted knee-axis torque (`TorqueZ` in the route model) spans $-81.23\,\mathrm{N\cdot m}$ to $-3.864\,\mathrm{N\cdot m}$ against the human-scaled requirement of $-23.16\,\mathrm{N\cdot m}$ to $-2.461\,\mathrm{N\cdot m}$ (peak magnitude $23.16\,\mathrm{N\cdot m}$), again exceeding the human envelope at every angle. The flexor results of record carry $\chi_0 = 3.937\,\mathrm{mm}$, $\chi_1 = 3.998 \times 10^4\,\mathrm{N\,m^{-1}}$, and $\chi_2 = 1.473 \times 10^4\,\mathrm{N\,m^{-1}}$, the adopted flexor terms, together with $\chi_3 = 0.1583$ loaded from the extensor refit and adopted as the flexor value of record; the preflight value of 0.6209 that appears once in the 2026-09-20 campaign log is superseded.

The Mono/Bi-pulley algorithms extend the route search space by allowing the artificial tendon to be reeved over pulleys before insertion; Section 5.9 discusses what this buys. On the knee-flexor route of record, the pulley variant (`Bifemsh_20mm_Result_pulley_20260926_1652.mat`) converged to a collision-feasible layout with zero bound violations and a pattern-search exit flag of 1, at an objective of 0.08465 under its own objective function; because the

direct-route and pulley objectives are different functions, this value is not commensurable with the direct route's 74.47. The best configuration on file drives the same two BPAs over a single tackle-line part with the pulley gain fixed at 1, the gain not being re-optimized. The redirect alone deepened the peak predicted flexion torque from $81.23\,\mathrm{N}\cdot\mathrm{m}$ on the direct route to $85.74\,\mathrm{N}\cdot\mathrm{m}$ on the same knee-axis measure `TorqueZ` ($85.56\,\mathrm{N}\cdot\mathrm{m}$ on the insertion-side measure `TorqueInsZ`, which applies the force delivered at the insertion after the tackle's force loss), approximately $4.5\,\mathrm{N}\cdot\mathrm{m}$ more flexor torque, while holding the off-axis torque to at most $0.803\,\mathrm{N}\cdot\mathrm{m}$.

The Bi-pulley batch applied the same reeving freedom to five muscle sites of the robot-body model's OpenSim leg, and all five runs failed the torque requirement (Table 4.5): every run closed with a nonpositive torque margin, and the medial-gastrocnemius and biceps-femoris-short-head runs terminated at the infeasibility sentinel. For the four runs that report a finite route-to-route clearance, the binding constraint was geometry rather than torque: their minimum pair clearances spanned 4.260 mm to 19.14 mm against the 25 mm separation required between adjacent routes, the sum of two 10 mm actuator radii and the 5 mm bundle margin. The medial-gastrocnemius run records no finite minimum clearance (`Inf` in the batch summary), so its failure rests on the infeasibility sentinel and its worst-constraint value of 10 alone, not on a clearance measurement. For the biceps femoris short head site, whose torque target is $40.2\,\mathrm{N}\cdot\mathrm{m}$ at the robot-body model's maximum isometric force of 804 N, the pattern search exited with flag $-2$ and returned the sentinel objective of 101 from an initial objective of 1000.

The robot-body model itself carries one provenance update from this campaign. The adductor magnus attachment point P2 was restored to its full-precision location $(-0.1357, -0.0929, 0.0591)$ m

Table 4.5: Bi-pulley batch on five muscle sites of the robot-body model's OpenSim leg (2026-09-26). Objective 101 is the batch's infeasibility sentinel; all five runs closed with a nonpositive torque margin. The soleus and tibialis-anterior runs converged feasibly (pattern-search exit flag 1), and their objectives are the normalized torque shortfalls; the remaining three runs exited with flag $-2$.

| **Muscle site** | **Objective** | **Outcome** |
|---|---|---|
| soleus | 0.9968 | converged (flag 1), nonpos |
| tibialis anterior | 0.9288 | converged (flag 1), nonpos |
| rectus femoris | 3.423 (worst constraint 0.2423) | nonpositive torque margir |
| medial gastrocnemius | 101, infeasibility sentinel (worst constraint 10) | pattern-search exit flag $-2$ |
| biceps femoris short head | 101, infeasibility sentinel (worst constraint 10) | pattern-search exit flag $-2$ |

in the robot-body OpenSim model, displacing the rounded repository copy, which was disqualified for producing a zero-length via point that nullified the flexion torque; the regenerated mirrored model passed its validation with zero non-mirrored pairs. At the restored location, the muscle delivers 34.28 N · m of flexion torque, 1.12× the human target of 30.61 N · m, and 27.62 N · m of adduction torque, 0.82× the human target of 33.60 N · m. These redesigned routes remain optimizer-stage results: the robot-body OpenSim model contains no pulley entities, and no via points or markers were added to it for these redesigned routes (its eight pre-existing `MovingPathPoint` vias, the rectus-femoris and vastii patella-tracking points, one per muscle per leg, belong to the original muscle paths). The MuJoCo conversion tree of the simulation work (`mjc/gait2392_robot`, converted 2026-09-24) predates both the 2026-09-26 pulley batch and the adductor-magnus restoration, so it carries one stale path point, the pre-restoration rounded `add_mag3` P2. The physical torque tests of the redesigned routes are pending (Section 5.9).

## 4.5 Balance Platform and Inverted-Pendulum Demonstrations

The testbeds of Section 3.9 were demonstrated by the author and presented in three conference posters [Bolen et al., 2024b,a,c]; this section summarizes what they showed.

The first-generation pendulum — hinge ankle, selectable encoder/IMU angle feedback, and reverse-pulley transmission — demonstrated self-balancing: under proportional control of the antagonist 20 mm BPA pair with IMU pseudo-vestibular feedback, the leg held itself upright on flat ground, and balance was maintained when the same controller operated on the oscillating balance platform beneath the foot. The second generation, IP 2.0 — ball-and-socket ankle, the three-muscle plantarflexor/inverter/everter arrangement, and IMU-only feedback — also maintained balance, on flat terrain. Both demonstrations used the same family of Festo BPAs characterized in Section 4.2.

These demonstrations establish that balance of a BPA-actuated leg under pseudo-vestibular inertial feedback is achievable in hardware on both fixed and oscillating supports. They are reported qualitatively, however: the poster materials quote no balance durations, platform oscillation amplitudes or frequencies, ankle-angle envelopes, or valve and pressure levels, so no quantitative values are claimed here. Chapter 6 defines an extension protocol that measures disturbance rejection, sensor drift, and sustained operation under continuous platform oscillation before comparing the same feedback architecture on a full humanoid model.

## 4.6 Preliminary Neuromechanical Simulation Recordings

The AnimatLab phase-1 run described in Section 3.11 produced synchronized joint, neural, contact-sensory, and body-motion recordings over 10 s. Basic checks confirmed finite values and a uniform 0.2 ms sampling interval in both exported charts. Each chart contained 50,001 samples from 0 through 10 s; nine trailing zero-filled rows beyond the configured chart end were excluded. Figure 4.9 shows bilateral hip, knee, and ankle angles. Neural and contact-sensory recordings remain archived with the run; the contact-sensory channels record membrane voltage rather than contact force. These recordings demonstrate signal acquisition and alternating activity in this run, rather than validated locomotor performance. The model included an externally applied horizontal force during the first second, and neither stable walking nor effective ground-contact gating was established.

### 4.6.1 Cross-Engine Verification of the Contact-Driven Rhythm Core

The verification protocol of Section 3.11.4 was applied to the W2L rhythm core. Between the NumPy reference and the native Simulink reimplementation, both legs' rhythm-generator burst periods matched at 1.000 s versus 1.000 s (0.0% error), the left–right antiphase correlation reproduced the reference exactly ($r = -0.525$), and all ten expected bursts occurred in the scored window. The full voltage traces cross-correlate at $r = 0.99996$–$0.99998$ at a $-2$ ms lag with an RMSE of 0.099–0.111 mV (Figure 4.10); the residual lag is consistent with the one-step delay of the discrete Simulink solver. The same protocol surfaced an architectural fact rather than a defect: with the heel-contact trains removed, the full network holds a static latch under tonic drive with kickoff alone, in every implementation — so

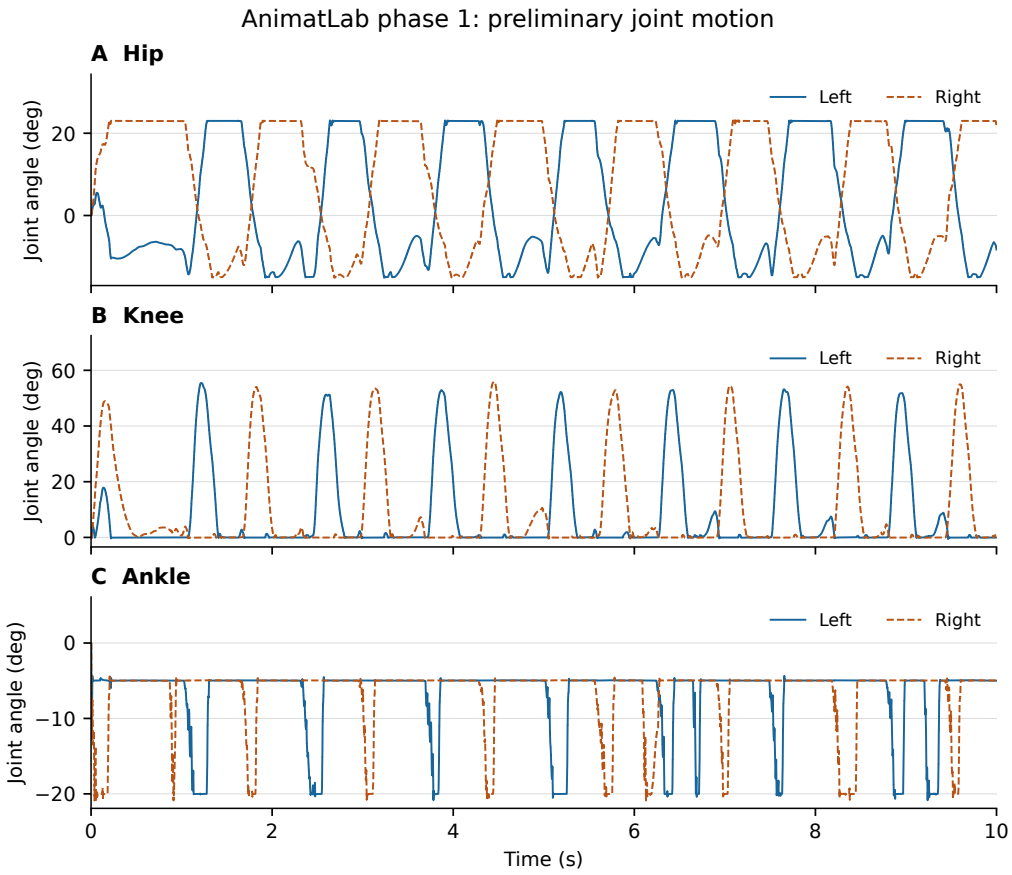



Figure 4.9: Preliminary AnimatLab phase-1 joint motion: **(A)** hip, **(B)** knee, and **(C)** ankle angles in the model's recorded joint conventions. Blue solid and orange dashed traces denote left and right sides. All 50,001 samples within the configured 0–10 s chart window are retained without filtering. The model includes an external horizontal force during the first second. These traces document joint motion in an instrumented run; they do not establish stable walking or effective ground-contact gating.

phasic contact feedback is part of the drive architecture of the W2L design, not an optional perturbation.

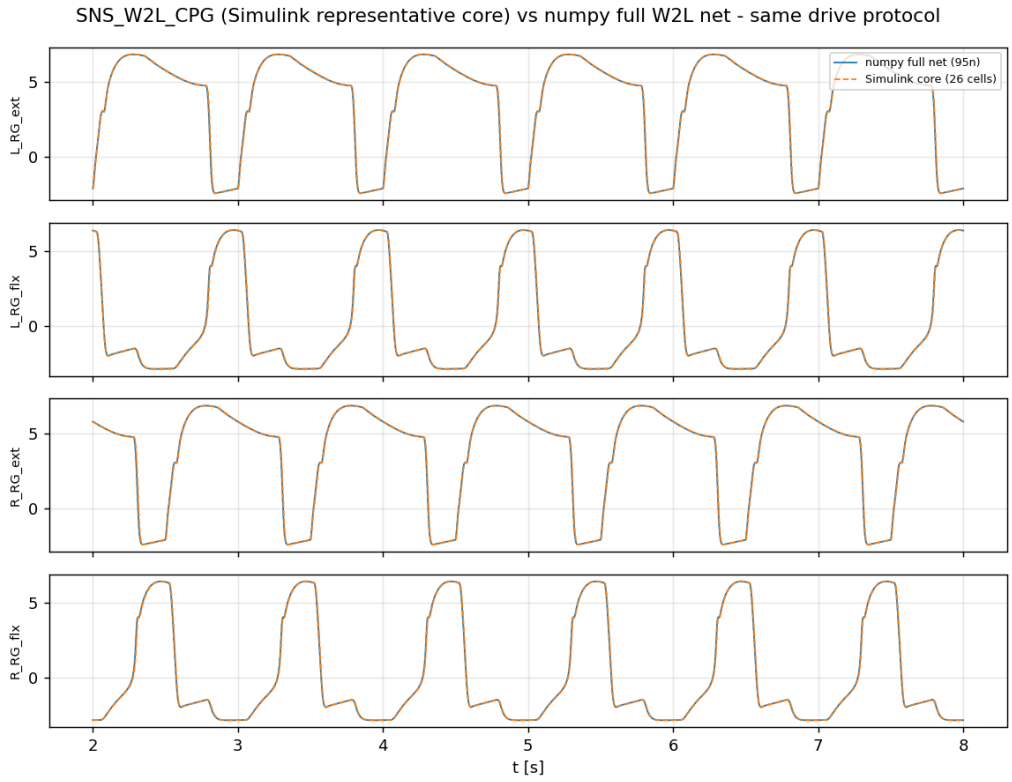



Figure 4.10: Left and right rhythm-generator extensor half-center voltages of the W2L contact-driven rhythm core under the shared verification protocol, from the NumPy reference (SNS-Toolbox backend) and the native Simulink reimplementation. Scored metrics — burst period, left–right antiphase correlation, and burst counts — agree exactly, and the full traces cross-correlate at $r \geqslant 0.99996$ at a $-2$ ms lag.

### 4.6.2 Headless Validation of the AnimatLab Reference Models

The archived AnimatLab reference models were re-run headless from their standalone simulators with instrumented charts, and eleven targetable rhythm and gait metrics were

extracted automatically; all eleven pass their acceptance bands. In the bilateral contact-driven model, the rhythm generators oscillate at periods of 0.450 s (left) and 0.467 s (right) with a left–right lag of 0.529 cycle (cross-correlation $r = 0.976$), confirming alternating gait timing. In the modern W2L model, the joints oscillate at 2.25 Hz; its flexor half-centers peak at $-56.4$ mV and never cross the $-55$ mV threshold, so the rhythm is carried by clean extensor/flexor antiphase ($r = -0.996$) through the graded pathway rather than by flexor spiking. The Li-model rerun [Li et al., 2017] walks at $0.637\,\mathrm{m\,s^{-1}}$ with right and left step periods of $1.299(24)$ s and $1.333(80)$ s and duty factors of 0.443 and 0.555, reproducing the published behavior of the original model in its original engine.

### 4.6.3 BPA-Actuated Walker in MuJoCo

The walker geometry of Section 3.10 was exported to MuJoCo and driven by antagonistic BPA actuator pairs under the split contact-driven network, with actuator forces computed by the BPA model of Chapter 3. In the air-stepping gate — the harness carrying 70% of the 411 N body weight — the walker produced clean knee-flexion excursions at a 1.542 s period with a knee flexion range of 63.5°, peak BPA forces of 880 N (left) and 1372 N (right) at a peak pressure of 372 kPa — 60% of the 620 kPa ceiling — and 7 and 5 heel-contact episodes on the left and right. This run demonstrates the complete chain from the characterized BPA force model to a multi-joint walker stepping under synthetic neural control, with actuator sizing operating inside the characterized pressure range.

The same campaign reported its failures with equal weight. On the ground, the W2L gate model stands (full-support stance) but does not walk: heel duty is zero and forward

displacement is $+0.001\,\mathrm{m}$ over the run. The MuJoCo port of the Li model produced no stance episodes in any of seven drop-protocol variants. Together with the latch result of Section 4.6.1, these negatives localize the open problem precisely: the contact-driven rhythm architecture itself transfers across engines intact, but translating it to unsupported ground locomotion requires the balance and weight-bearing layers defined in Chapter 6, and those layers are not present in these models.

### 4.6.4 Gait-Validation Sweep against the Locomotion Reference Library

The four production walking configurations of the converted robot-body model were evaluated against a library of 43 human locomotion reference cycles: 32 running trials from eight subjects at four speeds, ten walking references (seven at prescribed speeds from $0.5\,\mathrm{m\,s^{-1}}$ to $2.0\,\mathrm{m\,s^{-1}}$, plus three self-selected), and one further reference cycle, `Case_40_motion`, the predicted-walking cycle of the Falisse predictive-simulation dataset (period 1.11 s, duty factor 0.57). The four configurations span the two controller lineages of this program. The human-derived lineage contributes the production walking configuration (`s3k`), whose two-level network was tuned against the human walking reference, its pruned derivative (`s3kpruned`), and the six-synergy variant (`syn6`), whose pattern-formation layers drive the motor pools through a six-synergy basis extracted from human gait data. The robot-walker lineage contributes the W2L-layout variant (`w2lvar`), which restructures the rhythm and pattern-formation layers after the contact-driven W2L circuit of Section 3.11.4. Each configuration was scored with the production pipeline's cycle-shape kinematic score, in which 0 denotes perfect agreement and $-25$ is the fixed no-cycle fallback, both on its

tuning-reference evaluation and against every library cycle (Table 4.6).

Table 4.6: Gait-validation sweep of the four production walking configurations against the 43-cycle locomotion reference library. The score is the production pipeline's cycle-shape kinematic score (0 denotes perfect agreement); the tuning-reference score is each configuration's evaluation on the tuning pipeline's walking reference, and the library mean averages the same score over all 43 references (among genuine gait cycles, higher scores indicate closer agreement).

| | **Tuning-ref. score** | **Library mean score (43 refs)** | **Most negative reference (score)** |
|---|---|---|---|
| `s3k` | −186.4 | −8776 | `Case_40_motion` (−8841) |
| `s3kpruned` | −176.1 | −6924 | `Case_40_motion` (−6986) |
| `syn6` | −200.4 | −9961 | `Case_40_motion` (−10040) |
| `w2lvar` | −144.5 | −5808 | `subject08_Run_20002` (−5896) |

The ranking is identical in the two evaluations: the W2L-layout variant agrees most closely with both its tuning reference and the library on average (`w2lvar` at −144.5 and −5808), the six-synergy variant least closely (`syn6` at −200.4 and −9961), and the two production configurations fall between, with pruning moving `s3k` toward closer agreement (−186.4 and −8776 for `s3k`, against −176.1 and −6924 for `s3kpruned`). Every configuration's library scores are one to two orders of magnitude more negative than its tuning-reference score, which quantifies how far a network tuned to a single walking reference transfers to the library's diverse reference cycles; the gap is not an artifact of the 32 running trials, because the production configuration's mean over the ten walking references alone (−8816) is slightly more negative than its running-only mean (−8761) and essentially its overall library mean (−8776). The most negative single score for three of the four configurations falls on the same library reference, `Case_40_motion` (−8841 for `s3k`, −6986 for `s3kpruned`, and −10040 for `syn6`), while the W2L-layout variant's most negative reference is a running

trial, `subject08_Run_20002` ($-5896$). All four configurations produce right-leg-only or asymmetric gait in these evaluations. At the family level, the sweep's reading is that the robot-walker-lineage configuration, not the human-derived ones, agrees most closely with the library, while the six-synergy configuration, the most strongly human-derived in its pattern formation, agrees least closely.

### 4.6.5 Comparison of the Production Walker Variants

The same campaign removed individual pathway classes from each configuration and re-evaluated the tuning-reference score, identifying which pathways each lineage depends on (Table 4.7). In the production configuration, removing the Ia afferent pathway freezes the model outright: the evaluation detects no gait cycles and returns the fixed $-25$ fallback. Removing the Renshaw cells, the group-II afferents, or all afferent classes at once degrades the score to $-267.3$, $-255.2$, and $-267.8$, respectively, against the full model's $-186.4$, while removing the Ib, contact, or interleg commissural channels individually shifts the score by smaller amounts toward zero ($-180.3$, $-183.9$, and $-174.9$). The six-synergy variant behaves differently: with all afferents removed it scores $-190.5$ against its full model's $-200.4$ and still walks bilaterally, with ten cycles on each leg, a knee-flexion minimum of $-71.2^\circ$, and a 0.684 s period, so its afferent complement is not what sustains its gait. The W2L-layout variant depends on both the Ia pathway (removed: $-273.5$) and the weak rhythm-generator mutual excitation (removed: $-279.9$) against its full model's $-144.5$ with four right-leg and six left-leg cycles, while removing its Renshaw cells leaves a bilateral gait at $-142.4$.

Table 4.7: Pathway-removal sweep on the tuning-reference evaluation. The score is the production pipeline's cycle-shape kinematic score (0 denotes perfect agreement; −25 is the fixed no-cycle fallback, a failed evaluation that scores above every genuine gait in this table). The full-model rows repeat each configuration's unmodified production evaluation.

| **Configuration** | **Removed pathway** | **Score** |
|---|---|---|
| `s3k` (full model) | none | −186.4 |
| | Ia afferents | −25 (no cycles detected) |
| | all afferent classes | −267.8 |
| | Renshaw cells | −267.3 |
| | group-II afferents | −255.2 |
| | Ib afferents | −180.3 |
| | contact channels | −183.9 |
| | interleg commissural pathways | −174.9 |
| `syn6` (full model) | none | −200.4 |
| | all afferent classes | −190.5 |
| `w2lvar` (full model) | none | −144.5 |
| | Ia afferents | −273.5 |
| | weak rhythm-generator mutual excitation | −279.9 |
| | Renshaw cells | −142.4 |

Drive-perturbation and push testing splits the field along family lines. The production configuration never fell in 15 stand and push evaluations (maximum push sway 0.123 m), and its walk survives drive perturbations of $+0.01$, $-0.01$, and $-0.02$ (scores of $-201.9$, $-177.0$, and $-171.2$), freezing only at $+0.02$; its pruned derivative survives the unperturbed evaluation ($-176.1$) and the $-0.02$ perturbation ($-168.2$). The six-synergy and W2L-layout variants fall under every $\pm 0.01$ and $\pm 0.02$ drive perturbation tested, with pelvis tilt reaching $39^\circ$ to $40^\circ$. The sweep therefore identifies the production configuration and its pruned derivative as the robust pair of the family, and locates the fragility of the six-synergy and W2L-layout variants under drive perturbation.

## 4.7 Spiking-Neuron Mirror Results

The spiking-neuron mirrors of Section 3.11.5 were evaluated against their non-spiking twins in the same order in which the families were introduced: the MuJoCo spinal network, the Simulink demonstrations, and the AnimatLab walker family. All numbers in this section come from the gated verification campaign whose artifacts and reproduction commands are catalogued in Appendix B.

### 4.7.1 MuJoCo Spinal-Network Mirror

The non-spiking production baselines were first re-established on the machine of record: all three current production configurations reproduce their documented evaluation scores exactly, including the default build's kinematic score of $-161.56754173676563$, and after the mirror's selector was added the default build gate ($(410, 376, 1186)$ populations, inputs,

and connections) and that same baseline score reproduce digit for digit, proving the non-spiking pipeline untouched.

The topology gate passes exactly: under the default, fully tuned, and joint-layer pattern-formation gain configurations, the spiking mirror's directed connection multiset is identical to the non-spiking build's (1,186, 7,908, and 7,762 connections respectively), with identical input lists, identical motor-neuron maps, and exactly the expected number of readout taps (12, 12, and 16). The mirror is structurally the same network.

Under constant drive (network alone, 20 s), the rhythm gate splits. The spiking mirror self-sustains clean bilateral antiphase — rhythm-generator extensor and flexor cells firing at 4.9 Hz and 3.2 Hz per leg, with the swing readout sustained in every window — but its envelope period is 0.621 s against the analog build's 0.399 s, a 55.6 % lengthening that misses the gate's 20 % tolerance (Figure 4.11). The basin gate passes in full: the rhythm persists under 1 % multiplicative jitter on every scalar parameter in all 12 seeded trials, with a final-window swing minimum of 4.58 mV against the 5.13 mV baseline (margin $0.89\times$) and no divergent trials. In the deafferented suspended-air preparation, the mirror air-steps rhythmically with full-amplitude joint swings (knee range $106.0^\circ$ against the twin's $117.9^\circ$), but its cadence is roughly ten times faster than the non-spiking twin's 0.47 Hz air-stepping regime in this preparation, so the air-regime gate fails on the cadence clause alone.

One untuned ground-walking evaluation was run as a stretch attempt: the spiking mirror at the non-spiking winner's mapped parameters, with no re-tuning. It scores worse overall (kinematic score $-236.35$ against $-161.57$), as expected for an untuned mapped starting point, but it produces a genuine bilateral gait — eight right-leg and nine left-leg

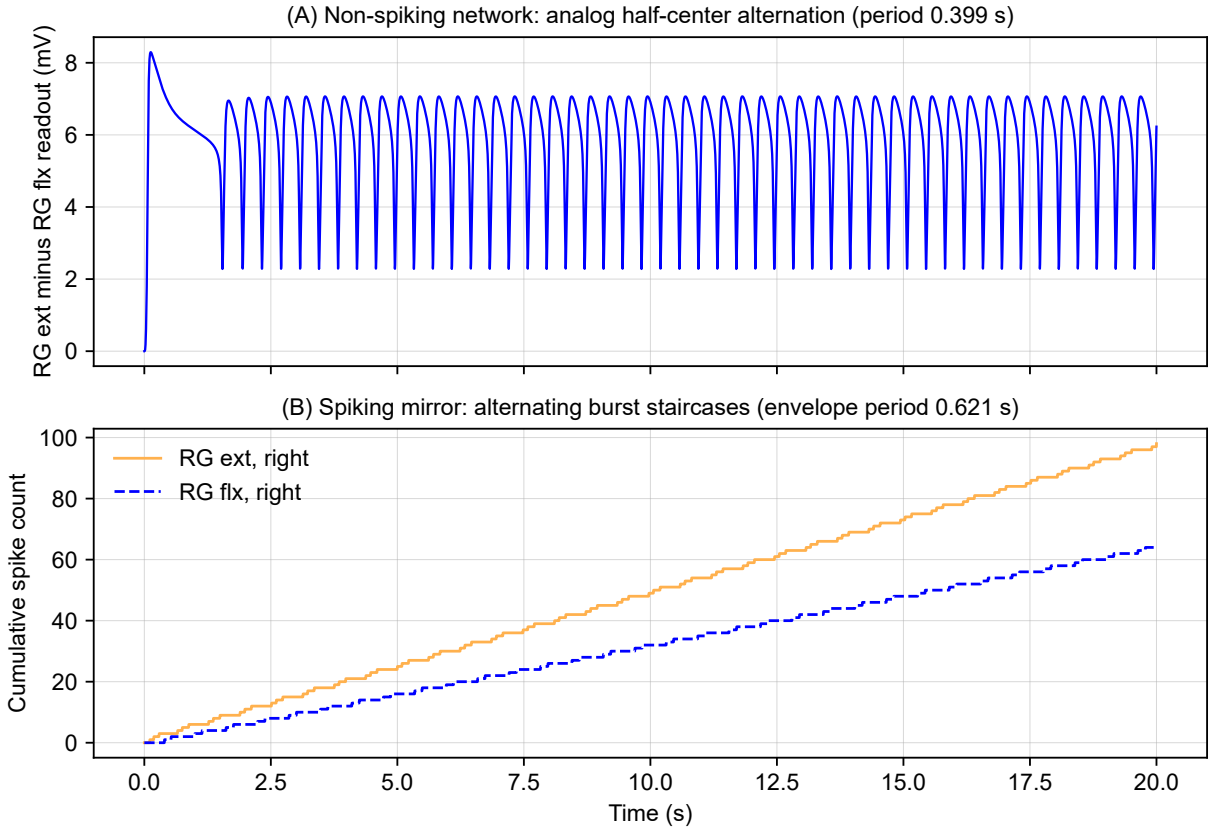



Figure 4.11: Constant-drive rhythm of the right rhythm-generator under network-only simulation. **(A)** The non-spiking network's extensor-minus-flexor readout voltage alternates irregularly about a 4.8 mV swing (larger only in the startup transient), with an average period of 0.399 s. **(B)** The spiking mirror's raw extensor (solid orange) and flexor (dashed indigo) cells fire in alternating bursts whose envelope period is 0.621 s, 55.6 % longer than the analog build.

cycles, a cycle-window knee flexion minimum of $-79.8^\circ$, no non-finite states, and the model stays up — whereas the non-spiking winner's left leg is frozen (zero cycles) in every recorded run of its study, including this session's baseline (Figure 4.12, Table 4.8). This is a single run with no statistics, reported as a lead for the fresh tuning campaign that the mirror's plan calls for, not as an established gait result.

Table 4.8: Untuned spiking mirror versus its non-spiking twin at the same winner parameters, ground evaluation (16 s). The cycle knee minimum and stance fractions are computed over detected gait cycles; the kinematic score is the cycle-shape error metric of the production pipeline (0 denotes perfect agreement; higher scores indicate closer agreement). The spiking mirror carries mapped parameters only, with zero re-tuning.

| **Metric** | **Non-spiking winner** | **Spiking mirror (untuned)** |
|---|---|---|
| Kinematic score | $-161.57$ | $-236.35$ |
| Gait cycles, right / left | 9 / 0 (left frozen) | 8 / 9 (bilateral) |
| Cycle knee minimum | $-64.3^\circ$ | $-79.8^\circ$ |
| Contact duty, right / left | 0.637 / 0.985 | 0.799 / 0.856 |
| Maximum pelvis tilt | $22.1^\circ$ | $19.2^\circ$ |
| Non-finite states / fell | no / up | no / up |

### 4.7.2 Simulink Spiking Demonstration Twins

The three new library blocks were verified at the unit level before any demonstration was rebuilt. The single-spike conductance transient matches the exact exponential to $6.2 \times 10^{-7}$ µS, saturating pulse-train accumulation matches to $4.6 \times 10^{-5}$ µS, and a hybrid two-neuron circuit matches a verbatim port of the SNS-Toolbox update equations spike for spike (62 of 62 spikes, maximum spike-time deviation 11.75 µs, maximum voltage deviation $1.2 \times 10^{-2}$ mV). The same circuit run through the SNS-Toolbox numpy backend

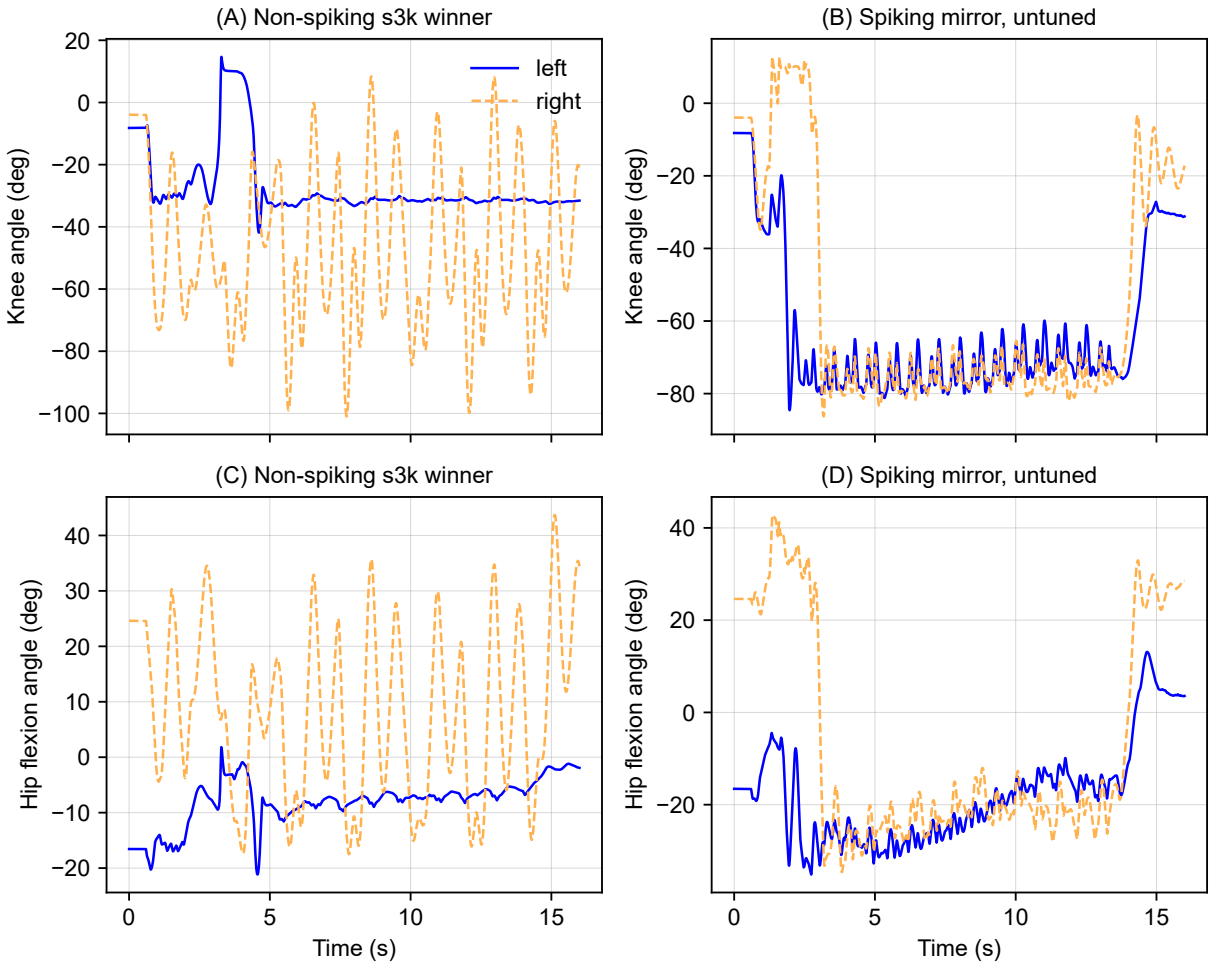



Figure 4.12: Ground-walking joint angles of the converted MuJoCo robot at the non-spiking winner's parameters. **(A, C)** The non-spiking winner steps with the right leg only; the left knee moves through a single slow excursion without cycling. **(B, D)** The untuned spiking mirror cycles both legs with deep knee flexion. Solid indigo traces denote the left leg, and dashed orange traces denote the right leg.

agrees with the Simulink copy to 0.19 µs in mean interspike interval and 0.81 µV in final voltage. With the spiking blocks present in the library, every committed demonstration and units test reproduces its recorded value exactly, including the committed two-neuron units test at $6.07 \times 10^{-4}$ mV.

At the matched operating point, the spiking twin of the knee-reflex demonstration is indistinguishable from the baseline in its transient and within one degree in its settle behavior (Table 4.9, Figure 4.13): both read 15.79° at 0.05 s, and the twin settles 0.9° higher with a slightly hotter, faster antagonist alternation, because the rate-coded pathway adds the synaptic filter time constant that graded synapses do not have. The spiking twin of the beverage-holding demonstration likewise holds the cup at essentially the same level, with the reflex-off sag identical to the baseline and the reflex modulation within 0.02° (Table 4.10).

Table 4.9: Knee-reflex demonstration, committed baseline versus spiking twin at the matched operating point (5 s runs; settle statistics over the last 2 s).

| **Metric** | **Baseline** | **Spiking twin** |
|---|---|---|
| Knee angle at 0.05 s | 15.79° | 15.79° |
| Settle mean (last 2 s) | 43.5° | 44.4° |
| Settle range | 41.6°–44.9° | 41.9°–46.7° |
| Extensor / flexor activation (window means) | 0.53 / 0.53 | 0.58 / 0.56 |
| Antagonist alternation | 0.5 Hz–2 Hz | 7.4 Hz (dominant peak) |
| Ia interneuron firing at settle | graded, subthreshold | 95 Hz; Ib 0 Hz |

A representative rhythm-generator-to-motor-pool subnetwork demonstrates the hybrid motif end to end: spiking half-centers with laminated inhibition drive a non-spiking three-motor-neuron pool whose voltage stays graded over a 5 mV depth (−52.0 to −46.9 mV) and tracks its rhythm generator's rate envelope. Burst alternation in that subnetwork is

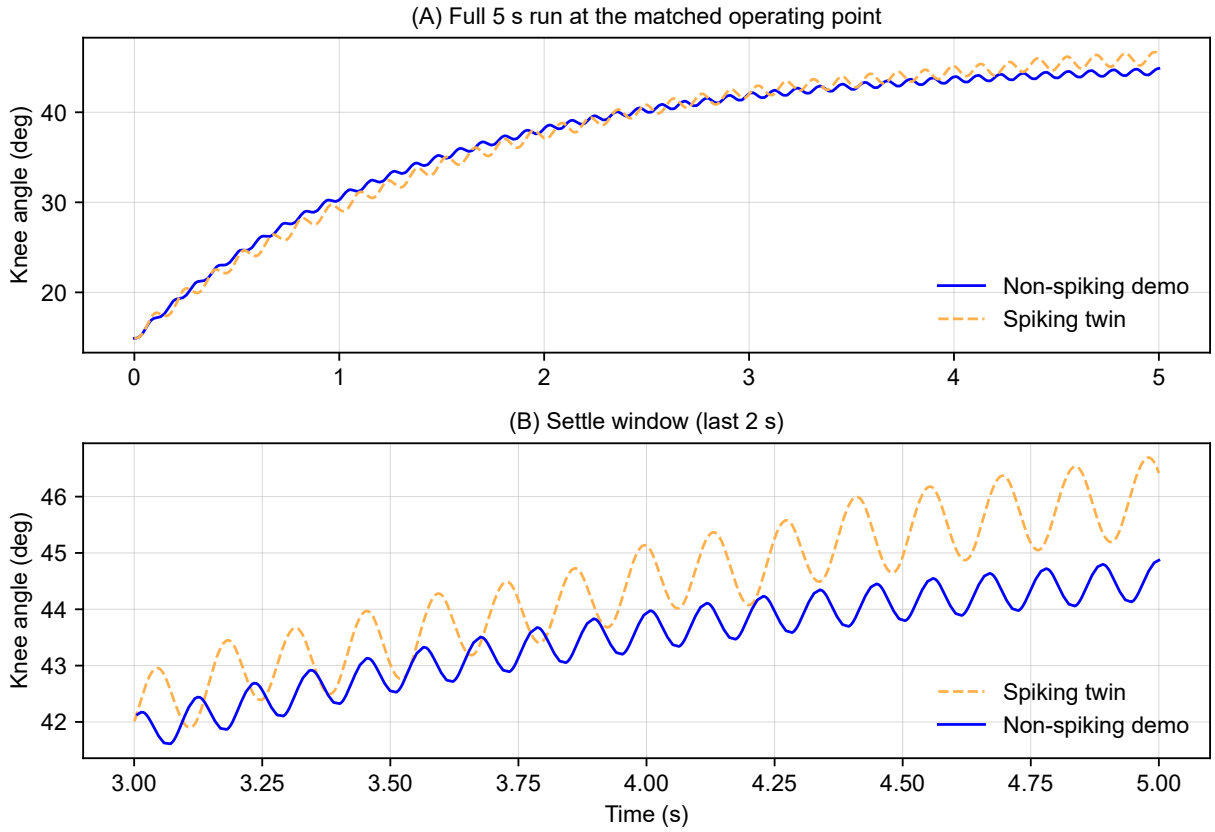



Figure 4.13: Knee angle of the Simulink knee-reflex demonstration: committed non-spiking baseline (solid indigo) versus spiking twin (dashed orange) at the matched operating point. **(A)** Full 5 s run. **(B)** Settle window (last 2 s); the spiking twin's alternation band is slightly wider.

Table 4.10: Beverage-holding demonstration, committed baseline versus spiking twin (10 s pour; sag measured after 2 s).

| Metric | Baseline | Spiking twin |
|---|---|---|
| Maximum sag, reflex on | 2.00° | 2.02° |
| Maximum sag, reflex off | 7.85° | 7.85° |
| Reflex modulation (off minus on) | 5.85° | 5.83° |
| Biceps activation over the pour | 0.392 → 0.417 | 0.392 → 0.447 |
| Triceps activation over the pour | 0.400 → 0.316 | 0.400 → 0.254 |
| Biceps Ia firing rate (reflex on) | graded | 166.6 Hz (mean) |

partial — the extensor half-center bursts four times in 12 s while the flexor half-center keeps a low-rate floor through the extensor bursts — and is reported as incomplete; the full 410-population Simulink spinal-network conversion is scoped as future work for the same reason.

### 4.7.3 AnimatLab Spiking Conversions

The AnimatLab family produces the campaign's clearest negative result, and it is reported as such. The graded baselines were re-established first: the two-layer walker's rhythm generator oscillates at 0.443 s (2.26 Hz), the bilateral variant at 0.462 s with the two legs folded near antiphase (lag $-0.42$ cycle, $r = 0.869$), and the already-spiking 2023-lineage model — the family's spiking reference — bursts at 1.305 s with folded antiphase of $+0.494$ cycle ($r = 0.703$), reproducing its period of record. The current reorganized project's standalone export remains latched under the tonic drives examined, consistent with Section 3.11.

No spiking copy of the three graded models preserves the rhythm (Table 4.11). The two-

layer conversions die at every threshold and decay tried (two or zero rhythm-generator spikes in 5 s); the bilateral variant latches with one side's half-centers saturated at 442 Hz–450 Hz; and the reorganized project's copy converts its latched baseline into strictly synchronous 11.8 Hz co-bursting with no alternation — the left extensor and flexor half-centers emit identical 58-spike trains whose spike-count envelopes correlate at $r = 1.000$ at zero lag. The thresholds-only ablation, which keeps the graded synapses, preserves near-baseline joint oscillations, isolating the synapse conversion as the breaking change (Figure B1): per-spike conductances at the graded amplitude either starve the reciprocal loop of inhibitory charge or saturate it, whereas the graded synapses read the membrane potential continuously and keep oscillating through subthreshold voltages. A spiking version of this family therefore needs its synaptic amplitudes and decays re-tuned as a rate code — which is how the 2023 spiking reference was built in the first place — rather than a parameter port.

Table 4.11: AnimatLab spiking conversions versus their graded baselines (5.1 s headless runs; joint ranges in degrees where the rhythm survives). The thresholds-only ablation converts the neurons but keeps the graded synapses.

| **Variant** | **Baseline (graded)** | **Spiking copy** |
|---|---|---|
| Two-layer walker | 0.443 s rhythm; hip $-15$ to $+23$, knee $-1$ to $+60$ | dead (2 spikes; hip pinned near $+6$) |
| Bilateral variant | 0.462 s; antiphase $-0.42$ cycle | latched; one side at 442 Hz–450 Hz |
| Reorganized project (standalone export) | latched (tonic drives) | synchronous 11.8 Hz co-bursting; same-leg envelopes $r = 1.000$ at lag 0 |
| Thresholds only (graded synapses) | hip $-15$ to $+23$, knee $-1$ to $+60$ | oscillates: hip $-15.1$ to $+23.2$, knee $-0.8$ to $+47.9$ |

The spiking conversions of the two-layer family, the calibrated-threshold variants,

and the decay probe are catalogued variant by variant — with neuron, synapse-type, and connection counts and the structural-validation outcome of each — in Appendix B (Table B5), together with the full gate table of the MuJoCo mirror (Table B4).

# 5 Discussion

Publication note: Sections 5.1–5.5 and the associated figures and tables appeared in Bolen et al. [2026] (Bolen, Elzein, Pang, and Hunt, *Actuators*, 2026). Section 5.6 is also the subject of an unpublished manuscript in preparation by Bolen, Burgess, Morrow, Elzein, Pang, Scharzenberger, and Hunt [Bolen et al., 2025]. This manuscript has not been submitted for publication. Author contributions for both works are stated in Chapter 3.

## 5.1 Effects of Resting Length

We have developed new $F_{620}$ equations for 10 mm and 20 mm diameter Festo BPAs that capture the change in maximum force produced by the actuators at 620 kPa as a function of their resting length. When examining Equation (4.1) and measured data in Figure 4.1b, it can be seen that as $l_0$ goes to infinity, $F_{620_{10}}$ goes to 470 N. When the Festo tool [Lang, Robert, 2005] was queried at $l_0 = 1$ m as an approximation of infinity, it predicts the $\phi$10 mm BPA can produce $F = 490$ N at $P_{620}$. This is within the 10% variability that Festo states may occur in manufacturing tolerances. Similarly, the Festo data predict a $\phi$20 mm BPA will produce $F = 1570$ N. Our results for Equation (4.2) show that $F_{620_{20}}$ goes to 1460 N as $l_0$ approaches infinity. Although the difference is much larger, it is also within the 10% manufacturing tolerance.

Our measured data differ significantly from the Festo model as $l_0$ goes to zero. For the measured data, as the length gets smaller, the force does as well, whereas the Festo tool

predicts exponential force increase (see Figure 4.1). As a specific example, when specifying $l_0 = 112\,\text{mm}$ for the 10 mm diameter BPAs, the Festo predicted $F_{620}$ is 498.6 N. However, using Equation (4.1), $F_{620}$ is calculated to be 335.3 N. Actual force in the $l_0 = 112\,\text{mm}$ was measured at 350.9 N. Therefore, the error in predicted $F_{620}$ for the $\phi 10\,\text{mm}$ BPA is 4.5% for our model and 42.1% using the Festo tool. Researchers using BPA resting lengths under 300 mm should take note of these results.

Festo AG & Co. KG [2026] (p. 12) states that force will be reduced by approximately 10% for a minimum nominal length. In Festo AG & Co. KG [2018] (p. 14) they say the force can deviate by 10% based on factors such as production variation, material variation, and deviation from nominal length ($l_0$). Festo AG & Co. KG [2013] (p. 13) notes that testing was done with BPAs that are ten times the uninflated diameter, and that theoretical force can increase by up to 10%. In each datasheet, the characteristic curves appear to be the same. As demonstrated above, the 100 mm $\phi 10$ mm BPA should have much less force than what is shown in the curve. This is our experience and the reason for the testing. It is unclear why the MuscleSIM tool [Lang, Robert, 2005] then predicts higher force as resting length decreases. It could be a reversed sign coefficient in their internal curve-fit model. We have shown here that as the nominal length goes to zero, so does force.

BPA models commonly predict higher forces than are measured experimentally because they do not account for end effects in regions of the pressure vessel where those effects dominate. Nominally, the clamped ends fix the inner and outer diameter while allowing axial and radial displacement. In the isometric case, there is only radial displacement. The boundary conditions force steep gradients in stress and strain near the ends. Near the boundary conditions, axial, radial, and circumferential strains deviate from analytic

solutions for a cylindrical model. For a constant pressure, the end effect region appears to have the same length. Therefore, in shorter BPAs, the end effects dominate. The axial length scale of the boundary section is comparable to $l_0$, and the active force differs substantially from that of an assumed perfect cylinder.

Manufacturing variations seem to play an important role in the behavior of these actuators. It remains to be seen how $\epsilon_{620}$ can be known a priori. We still suspect that it is a function of $l_0$, but it might also be a function of other factors such as product batch number or UV light exposure [Festo AG & Co. KG, 2026] (p. 15); [Festo AG & Co. KG, 2018] (p. 6); [Festo AG & Co. KG, 2013] (p. 13). We found there to be larger variations in the 10 mm BPAs than in the 20 mm BPAs. Modeling work on ideal McKibben actuators describes how the relationship between contraction and initial length is a function of the total number of twists and the angle of twist in the usable muscle area [Chou and Hannaford, 1996]. It is unclear if there are variations in the angle and number of twists in the Festo BPAs due to manufacturing. Uncovering the relationship between $\epsilon_{620}$ and $l_0$ for the Festo DMSP artificial muscles, if it exists in a meaningful way, will require additional controlled tests.

Similarly, it is not clear how the maximum force might change with manufacturing variations. This was reasonably corrected for by normalizing the equations to each individual's maximum contraction, but more nuanced details might emerge with more data collection. Not knowing these relationships a priori means there is still a need for robots and other systems to go through an iterative design stage if it is discovered that the system does not produce the torque or have the RoM that the design team expects. However, the data and models provided here should enable faster redesigns with fewer additional measurements.

## 5.2 Nondimensionalized Force Prediction

We have also introduced the concept of nondimensionalized isometric force that is a function of relative strain and relative pressure (Equation (3.4)). This elegant equation has only three coefficients with low error (see Table 4.2). In the work presented here, we introduce the relative pressure term, $P^* = P/P_{620}$. Our data show that by normalizing force, contraction, and pressure, we are able to create a simplified force equation as a function of contraction and pressure that scales well with initial actuator length, as expressed by Equation (3.6) in Section 3.2.

For example, given $l_0 = 54\,\text{mm}$ and $P = 300\,\text{kPa}$, the measured force was $F_{actual} = 103\,\text{N}$. Force prediction using only the Festo tool predicts the force to be $F_{predict} = 270\,\text{N}$. This is 161% greater than the measured force. Using Equations (4.1) and (3.4) with Equation (3.6) gives $F_{predict} = F^*(0, 0.48) \cdot F_{620}(0.054) = 0.49 \cdot 230\,\text{N} = 112\,\text{N}$. This is an error of 8%, which is much more accurate than using the Festo tool only.

The presented work is capable of predicting force output for 10 mm and 20 mm muscles with different initial muscle lengths, internal pressure, and contraction amount with minimal initial data collection. However, it remains to be seen if these relationships are maintained over the full lifecycle of the muscles. There are not yet any peer reviewed studies investigating the long-term behavior of these artificial muscles, though the Festo datasheet provides some indication of what can be expected [Festo AG & Co. KG, 2026] (p.19). They report that the 40 mm BPA can complete 1 million cycles at 6000 N (maximum rated load), or 10 million cycles at 4000 N. The service life of the other size BPAs is not reported; however, it is mentioned that thermal stressing may reduce the lifespan and they

should be inspected every 500,000 cycles for signs of aging [Festo AG & Co. KG, 2018] (pp. 10–11). Future research should look at the behavior of these muscles over time.

In our work, $P_{620} = 620\,\text{kPa}$ is the maximum supply pressure for our system, and other users of this actuator may use a different supply pressure. However, this supply pressure is not required, and normalizing by this value was chosen as a method for improving the optimization techniques by reducing the sensitivity of the term associated with pressure. This equation will work for any pressure supplies below 620 kPa. We also anticipate the equation will also work for pressures up to 800 kPa (the maximum rated pressure for Festo $\phi$10 mm BPAs); however, we do not have the data to confirm this.

### 5.3 Comparison with Other Published BPA Models

The proposed model was compared with the formulations by Sárosi [2012], Sárosi and Fabulya [2012], and Martens and Boblan [2017], to evaluate their predictive performance across actuator sizes and operating conditions (see Table 5.1 and Figure 5.1). For the $\phi$20 mm BPA, parameters from Sárosi [2012] were used, corresponding to actuators with resting lengths of 200 mm and 400 mm. These were compared against the experimental data at $l_0 = 300\,\text{mm}$ and $l_0 = 450\,\text{mm}$, respectively. For the $\phi$10 mm BPA with resting lengths of 257 mm and 233 mm, parameters from Sárosi and Fabulya [2012] were applied. In each case, the maximum contraction parameter ($k_{max}$) was determined numerically by solving $F(6.2\,\text{bar}, k_{max}) = 0$, ensuring consistency with the experimental maximum pressure condition.

Table 5.1: Goodness-of-fit comparison for the Bolen, Sárosi, and Martens and Boblan models at different resting lengths (in mm) for 10 mm and 20 mm BPAs. RMSE and maximum error are reported in newtons, and FVU denotes the fraction of variance unexplained.

| Diameter | Length | Bolen | | | Sarosi | | | Martens and Boblan | | |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| | | RMSE | FVU | Max. Error | RMSE | FVU | Max Error | RMSE | FVU | Max. Error |
| **10 mm** | 257 | 22.9 | 0.0353 | 46.0 | 143.8 | 1.3903 | 235.8 | 73.8 | 0.3668 | 122.9 |
| | 233 | 16.8 | 0.0187 | 30.3 | 132.7 | 1.1655 | 222.6 | 62.6 | 0.2590 | 101.2 |
| **20 mm** | 300 | 35.6 | 0.0144 | 114.0 | 132.1 | 0.1992 | 313.4 | 72.8 | 0.0605 | 137.8 |
| | 450 | 67.6 | 0.0258 | 166.6 | 177.7 | 0.1785 | 294.8 | 862.1 | 4.2022 | 1321.1 |

While the Sárosi [2012] and Sárosi and Fabulya [2012] models capture general trends in force–contraction behavior, discrepancies were observed when applying parameters derived from different actuator lengths. In particular, the model tends to over-predict force at higher pressures and low amounts of contraction, suggesting sensitivity to geometric scaling effects not explicitly accounted for in the formulation.

The Martens and Boblan [2017] model is derived from a geometric and material-based framework and provides a more physically grounded representation of actuator behavior. However, its accuracy depends strongly on precise geometric parameters, including braid angle, wall thickness, and fiber length. Small deviations in these parameters can lead to significant differences in predicted force, particularly at higher pressures.

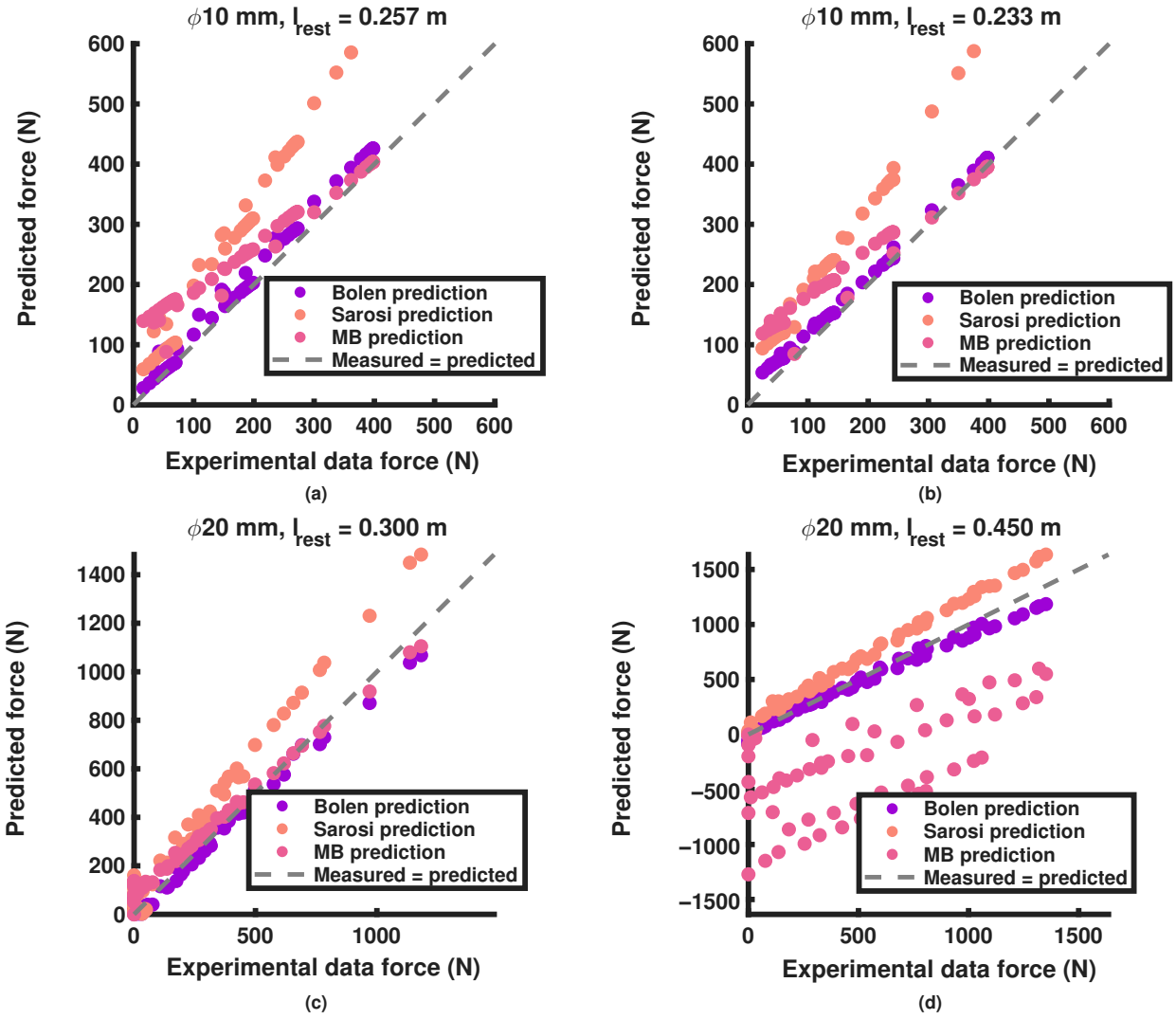



Figure 5.1: Comparison between measured and predicted BPA force at varying amounts of contraction and pressure. A $y = x$ perfect fit line is added for reference. The BPAs compared are: (**a**) $\phi$10 mm, $l_0 = 0.257$ mm, (**b**) $\phi$10 mm, $l_0 = 0.233$ mm, (**c**) $\phi$20 mm, $l_0 = 0.300$ mm, and (**d**) $\phi$20 mm, $l_0 = 0.450$ mm.

The Martens and Boblan model was first evaluated at the same pressure–contraction points as in their experimental data [Martens and Boblan, 2017] (Tables A1 and A2),

indicating that it reproduces the general published force map shape but is sensitive to the assumed initial geometry. Examining their $\phi$20 mm BPA, for example, using the explicitly stated $l_0 = 300\,\text{mm}$ and initial diameter $D_0 = 20\,\text{mm}$ significantly under-predicted the results compared to using the implied $l_0 = 296\,\text{mm}$ ([Martens and Boblan, 2017] (Table A1)) and $D_0 + H_0 = 21.8\,\text{mm}$, where $H_0 = 1.8\,\text{mm}$ is the material thickness. The diameter adjustment can be inferred from [Chou and Hannaford, 1996]. This adjusted diameter was also included for the $\phi$10 mm BPA to give a better fit. As can be seen in Figure 5.1 and Table 5.1, the highest accuracy is observed when $\phi$20 mm and $l_0 = 300\,\text{mm}$, which is at or very near their experimental measurements. For the $\phi$10 mm BPAs the accuracy decreases even though their experimentally measured $l_0 = 250\,\text{mm}$ is close to our $l_0 = 257\,\text{mm}$ and $l_0 = 233\,\text{mm}$. The largest error occurs at $\phi$20 mm and $l_0 = 450\,\text{mm}$ and the model starts to predict negative force. We have calculated that the $F_{PE} \cdot \frac{dD}{DL}$ term becomes very large compared to the others [Martens and Boblan, 2017] (p. 5). This suggests that the model is sensitive to geometric parameter selection and interpretation, particularly with respect to initial length and diameter definitions.

In comparison, the present normalized model demonstrates improved consistency across actuator lengths by incorporating experimentally derived scaling through $F_{620}$ and $\epsilon_{620}$. This normalization reduces sensitivity to geometric variation and enables a unified representation of actuator behavior, while maintaining predictive accuracy over the tested range of pressures and contractions.

## 5.4 Implications for Real-Time Control and Simulation

Although pneumatic muscle actuators exhibit hysteresis, thermodynamic effects, and other dynamic behavior, accurate and high-performance controller designs can still be achieved using a static force map approach when the underlying static force model is accurate. Martens and Boblan explicitly note that BPA dynamics are often dominated by the air dynamics inside the actuator and the mass flow behavior of the valve, such that precise modeling of the static force characteristic remains crucial for torque control accuracy [Martens and Boblan, 2017]. This view is consistent with more recent BPA control work, including a sensor-less torque control interface for BPA-driven joints [Martens et al., 2018], stable force/position/stiffness control of antagonistic pneumatic-muscle joints [Ugurlu et al., 2019, Hunt et al., 2017b], and sensor-less angle stiffness control of antagonistic BPA systems [Shin and Kogiso, 2022].

In this context, the present model is well suited for real-time use because it reduces the static isometric force prediction to a low-order normalized surface, $F^*(\epsilon^*, P^*)$, scaled by the resting-length-dependent term $F_{620}(l_0)$. This structure is computationally inexpensive to evaluate online and is also suitable for lookup-table implementation. While the present work does not model the full actuator–valve dynamics, it provides the static force relationship needed as a feedforward or inner-model component in real-time torque control, simulation, and preliminary design workflows. It is anticipated that improved real-time control for high-speed and high-precision systems will benefit more from improved modeling of airflow dynamics than from modeling actuator hysteresis, damping, and other dynamic behavior. Characterizing the actuators under dynamic operating conditions

— isokinetic (constant-velocity), isobaric, and isotonic (constant-load) contractions — is a natural next step beyond the isometric characterization reported here, for which the pressure–force dynamics model of Elzein et al. [2025] provides the modeling foundation.

### 5.5 Biomimetic Artificial Muscle Analogy

BPA artificial muscles are often said to be analogous to biological muscles because they have force–length curves and can produce force only in tension. This analogy is worth closer inspection. For example, the passive force–length curve has been described as an exponential function arising from connective tissue elements, while the active force–length relationship is typically modeled as a bell-shaped curve reflecting actin–myosin overlap [Winters, 1990]. These formulations emphasize that muscle force generation is governed by nonlinear geometric and material interactions rather than simple linear elasticity. McKibben-type pneumatic artificial muscles (of which Festo is an example) exhibit analogous nonlinear behavior, though arising from fundamentally different physical mechanisms. As shown by Chou and Hannaford, the force–length relationship of McKibben actuators is derived from geometric constraints imposed by the braided shell, leading to a nonlinear dependence of force on actuator length through the braid angle Chou and Hannaford [1996]. In their formulation, actuator force is proportional to pressure and a nonlinear geometric term $(3\cos^2\theta - 1)$, which governs both the maximum contraction limit and the curvature of the force–length relationship. The work presented here demonstrates that this nonlinear curve can be well approximated by an exponential as well.

However, the behavior of these artificial muscles differs distinctly from that of biological muscles. For example, the optimal fiber length of a biological muscle, $l_{OFL}$, is not equivalent to $l_0$ in an artificial muscle. Artificial muscles produce their maximum active force at their resting length, which is also their maximum length. In contrast, the maximum active force that a biological muscle can produce is somewhere in the middle of the total contractile length of the muscle.

Furthermore, biological muscles can adapt the optimal operating length through structural remodeling (e.g., sarcomere addition or tendon compliance) while BPAs have a fixed geometric configuration. This allows biological systems to self-optimize for the particular tasks the animal is subjected to. In order to re-optimize a robot for new tasks, new actuators would have to be swapped into the system. This distinction highlights a key limitation of BPAs in biomimetic applications, while also reinforcing the importance of accurate nonlinear modeling for control and design.

## 5.6 Sources of Error in Isometric Torque Generation

Our improved BPA characterization predicts torque more accurately than the original BPA model (see Fig. 4.4**A** and 4.4**B**). This only accounts for part of the error. There are certainly many factors that affect the torque results. Compliance in the testing system, positioning tolerances, flexibility of brackets, imperfect path modeling, and variation in individual BPAs are other factors.

Simplifying and testing the model revealed deficiencies in our previous analysis. The isometric system is not rigid. There is compliance in the winch cable, artificial tendons,

and brackets that bend and stretch. We introduced a constant length offset term $\chi_0$, axial stiffness $\chi_1$, and bending stiffness $\chi_2$. The bracket frame of reference was placed at the onset of the cantilevered section and rotated about $Z$. The optimization identified parameter values for a $\phi$10 mm BPA with $l_0 = 48.5$ cm in the simple pinned knee configuration. These results were validated with a second $\phi$10 mm BPA with $l_0 = 45.7$ cm.

The modeling of extensor BPA paths that wrap around the knee joint is an approximation with inherent error (Fig. 4.7). When the moment arm is short, small changes to it can have a large effect on the resultant torque [Young et al., 2019]. It was assumed that wrapping the BPA around the joint would be easier to account for than adding a patella, deterministically designing its location as a function of knee angle, and accounting for friction. At greater knee flexion angles, shorter $l_0$ BPAs were observed to stretch and compress (see Fig. 3.2**C**). The same loading sometimes caused the BPA to slip off the anterior head of the bolt that holds the femur to the knee. This produced a $\pm$ 20 mm displacement in the $Z$ direction, changing both the force vector and the torque. The system designer, too, must be mindful. Fig. 4.5 shows a deviation between measured and originally predicted results that widens as expected torque increases. This indicates system compliance. However, the hybrid-calculated torque matches or exceeds the predicted torque, except at greater flexion angles for the $l_0 = 41.5$ cm BPA, indicating a loss of functional $l_m$; this is why the $\chi_3$ term was created in (3.27). Fig. 4.5 shows the improved fit from running the optimization that includes this term.

The biomimetic knee joint with an extensor BPA was used to validate the extensor optimization results. The corrected prediction more closely matches the measured torque values, although it remains higher than the measurements.

The nonlinear biomimetic robotic system presented here replaces rigid-body simplifications commonly used in other robotic and biomechanical systems. Instead, progressing from simple to complex systems elucidated compliance mechanisms that can lead to more accurate first-iteration designs. Technologies have been developed to predict system bending and axial compliance, a constant length offset, and a loss of usable length that occurs as artificial muscle bends around a joint.

In equation $m\ddot{\varepsilon}^* + c(\dot{\varepsilon}^*)\dot{\varepsilon}^* + k(\varepsilon^*)\varepsilon^* = F$ given $k(\varepsilon^*, P^*) = \left.\frac{\partial F}{\partial \varepsilon^*}\right|_{P^*} = -c_0 c_1 e^{-c_1\varepsilon^*} - 2c_2\varepsilon^* P^* e^{-c_2(\varepsilon^*)^2}$ then if we set mass m and external force F to zero we get $c(\dot{\varepsilon}^*) = (k(\varepsilon^*)\varepsilon^*)/\dot{\varepsilon}^*$

## 5.7 Synthesis: From Actuator Characterization to Neuromechanical Control

Taken together, the actuator and joint level results of this dissertation form a coherent design chain for biomimetic legged robots. At the actuator level, the maximum isometric force of Festo BPAs was shown to depend strongly on resting length, correcting a systematic over-prediction by the manufacturer's tool at short resting lengths, and a nondimensional force surface was derived that predicts isometric force from relative strain and relative pressure with only three diameter-dependent coefficients. At the joint level, the improved actuator model was combined with a compliance-corrected musculotendon kinematics model to predict isometric knee torque across the full range of motion for pinned and biomimetic knee joints, and the biomimetic knee driven by optimized BPAs was shown to meet or exceed human isometric torque over most of the range of motion.

This chain was developed deliberately so that each stage can feed the next. The force model supplies the actuator terms for the torque model; the torque model supplies

the biomechanical model for designing joint controllers; and the validated biomimetic knee demonstrates that the actuator architecture can reproduce human joint-level force capabilities. The neural layer is no longer only a proposal: the OpenSim-to-MuJoCo conversion, BPA coupling interface, SNS-Toolbox spinal architecture, sensory channels, and staged validation workflow described in Sections 3.11–4.6 provide a working framework for neuromechanical experiments. The AARL's prior AnimatLab walker (Section 3.10) explains why that framework emphasizes systematic verification: its hand-tuned two-layer CPG produced gait-like suspended stepping, but its afferent feedback did not generalize to weight-bearing motion. Chapter 6 therefore presents closed-loop quantification, ground-robustness comparisons, and hardware transfer as independent research programs enabled by the completed framework.

The cross-platform verification campaign (Sections 3.11.4–4.6.3) adds a design constraint that runs through this chain: a synthetic nervous system is a mathematical object, and it must survive translation between the tools in which it is built, verified, and deployed. Reproducing the contact-driven rhythm core with exact period agreement and trace correlations above 0.9999 between independent NumPy and Simulink implementations — with the archived AnimatLab models reproducing their published rhythms headless in the same protocol — establishes that the SNS formalism, not any particular simulator, carries the dynamics. The persistent-sodium half-center with a fixed inactivation time constant, the graded synapse, and contact-driven rhythm are therefore portable primitives: they can be tuned in whichever engine is fastest and trusted in whichever engine is most physical. The campaign's negative results are equally structural. The feedforward CPG of the prior walker and the contact-driven core of the W2L architecture sit at deliberate, opposite points

of the sensory-dependence spectrum — the former oscillates without feedback but could not bear weight, while the latter will not oscillate at all without phasic heel feedback, a load dependence that echoes the decerebrate-cat locomotion of Section 2.6. The missing piece for unsupported walking is balance — a network layer, not an engine feature — and the BPA-actuated walker's peak forces at 60% of the pressure ceiling indicate that, once that layer exists, the actuation margin is already there.

## 5.8 What Spiking Changes and Does Not

The spiking-mirror campaign (Sections 3.11.5 and 4.7) allows the dissertation's neural-coding assumption to be examined directly, and its outcome divides cleanly into what the coding regime changes and what it leaves alone.

What spiking does not change is the plant-side behavior, provided the hybrid doctrine and the calibration hold. Because the motor-neuron layer stays non-spiking and the spikes onto it are calibrated by mean conductance, the interface that the actuator and torque models of this dissertation attach to — a continuous activation command per muscle — is unchanged by construction. The Simulink twins make the point quantitatively: with only the sensory interneuron layer converted, the knee-reflex transient is identical, the settle band moves by $0.9^\circ$, and the beverage-holding reflex modulation moves by $0.02^\circ$. To the plant, a calibrated 40 Hz train and the graded voltage it replaces are the same command; the activation dynamics of the muscle model filter the spike train the same way the biological membrane would. The actuator-level and joint-level conclusions of Chapters 3–4 therefore do not depend on the neural coding chosen above the motor-neuron

layer.

What spiking changes first is timing. The mirror's self-sustained rhythm runs 55.6 % slower than the analog build at the same constant drive, and its air-stepping cadence is roughly ten times faster than the non-spiking twin's in that preparation — deviations in opposite directions in the two tests, which is itself informative, since a single scaling error would move both the same way. The campaign traced the constant-drive period to two identifiable knobs, the threshold-increment magnitude and the adaptation time constant, and demonstrated alternation/period trade-offs along them; the untuned starting point, not a structural failure, is the honest reading. Any period-matched spiking controller is therefore a short tuning campaign away, and the mirror's mapped parameters are the correct starting point for it.

What spiking changes second is robustness, in the mirror's favor. The analog network's constant-drive rhythm sits close to a bifurcation — an exact port of it to a different integration stack can settle to the tonic fixed point — so marginal winners risk not surviving a solver change. The spiking half-centers passed the perturbation basin gate in full, with the rhythm persisting under 1 % jitter on every scalar parameter including the spiking-specific ones, at 0.89$\times$ of the baseline swing. For the hardware-transfer program of Chapter 6, where the network will be re-implemented on embedded hardware with finite-precision arithmetic, a rhythm whose basin is wide is the safer substrate, and the sub-stepping cost of resolving spikes (0.5 ms network steps inside the unchanged 2 ms plant step) is modest.

What spiking does not tolerate is a naive parameter port at the synapse level. The AnimatLab conversions show that converting graded synaptic amplitudes to per-spike increments of the same magnitude breaks the reciprocal half-center loop outright — the

loop is either starved of inhibitory charge or saturated — while converting only the thresholds changes nothing, and the 2023 spiking walker of the same lineage walks because it was tuned as a rate code from birth. Synaptic strength in a spiking network is a rate-code quantity that must be derived from the presynaptic firing rate and the conductance decay, exactly as the MuJoCo mirror's calibration script derives it, not copied from the graded value. This is the one place where the campaign's negative results should temper expectations: spiking conversion is an exercise in re-derivation, and the calibration-first, gate-everything procedure of Section 3.11.5 is the transferable method.

Finally, the one place where the untuned spiking mirror outperforms its tuned non-spiking twin — producing a bilateral ground gait where the winner's left leg is frozen — is a single run with no statistics, and it is claimed only as a lead. But it points at the mechanism the hybrid doctrine was after: the mirror's afferents are event-coded, its adaptation is spike-history-based, and its inhibitory charge arrives in discrete quanta, so the phase relationships that the analog build locks in around a frozen leg are not the only stable operating regime of the same topology. Establishing whether that regime survives tuning, and whether event-coded contact afferents are what unlock it, is precisely the closed-loop CPG comparison program defined in Chapter 6, and the mirror is now the instrument for running it.

## 5.9 What Mono- and Bi-Pulley Routing Buys

The route redesign of Section 4.4 placed both 20 mm actuators on direct attachment routes. The Mono/Bi-pulley algorithms extend that search space by allowing the artificial tendon

to be reeved over pulleys before insertion, and the flexor pulley run of 2026-09-26 quantifies what the added routing freedom is worth on the knee-flexor route of record. The pulley variant converged to a collision-feasible layout with zero bound violations (pattern-search exit flag 1) at an objective of 0.08465 under its own objective function, which differs from the direct route's objective of 74.47, so the two values are not commensurable. The best configuration on file reeves the two actuators over a single tackle-line part at a gain fixed at 1:1, so the pulley acts as a redirect rather than a force multiplier; even so, the redirect alone deepened the peak predicted flexion torque from 81.23 N · m to 85.74 N · m, a gain of 4.51 N · m (5.6 %), while holding the off-axis torque to at most 0.803 N · m, under 1 % of the peak on-axis value; the predicted peaks of the direct and pulley routes exceed the human flexor torque scale of 23.16 N · m by factors of 3.51 and 3.70. The Bi-pulley batch establishes where that freedom runs out on anatomical routes. Across the five OpenSim muscle sites attempted (soleus, tibialis anterior, rectus femoris, medial gastrocnemius, and biceps femoris short head), every run closed with a nonpositive torque margin (objectives of 0.929 for tibialis anterior, 0.997 for soleus, and 3.42 for rectus femoris with a residual worst-constraint value of 0.242), and the medial-gastrocnemius and biceps-femoris-short-head runs terminated at the infeasibility sentinel (objective 101, worst-constraint value 10, exit flag $-2$). For the four runs that report a finite route-to-route clearance, the binding constraint was geometry rather than torque: minimum pair clearances spanned 4.26 mm to 19.14 mm against the 25 mm separation required between adjacent routes (two 10 mm actuator radii plus a 5 mm bundle margin); the medial-gastrocnemius run records no finite clearance, so its failure rests on the infeasibility sentinel alone. What the two algorithms buy is therefore reach and screening: the mono-pulley converts routing freedom into

4.51 N · m of additional predicted flexion torque without mechanical advantage and with off-axis torque below 1 % of the peak, and the bi-pulley sweep screens candidate anatomical sites, showing that its reeved routes do not yet fit these corridors and redirecting the design effort toward clearance-relaxed attachment sites. These pulley solutions are optimizer-stage results; they have not yet been propagated into the OpenSim or MuJoCo model trees used for the simulation work of Sections 3.11–4.6, and the hardware torque tests of the updated compliant system are pending, so the block below is reserved for their results.

*[FLAG-BEN, PENDING TORQUE-TEST RESULTS: Once the pending torque-test runs land, this paragraph will state that the updated compliant system lets* `Opt_run` *and* `Opt_run_Ext` *meet or exceed human torque magnitude, and it will report the measured torque-versus-angle results for the redesigned flexor and extensor routes. TODO(Ben): insert the measured numbers.]*

# 6 Future Work

The experimental work of Chapters 3–4 characterizes the biomechanical system: the actuators and the joints they drive. The remaining task of the dissertation project is the controller — a synthetic nervous system that schedules those actuators the way the nervous system schedules muscles — and eventually the physical robot that the controller runs on. This chapter lays out the planned work in four stages: a neuromechanical simulation pipeline (Section 6.1), a two-layer CPG with full proprioceptive and contact feedback (Section 6.2), extension of the sensorium with vestibular, ocular, and cerebellar contributions (Section 6.3), and physical realization on a treadmill robot with real-time neural control (Section 6.4). Some of the work described here is planned for the remainder of the dissertation; the later stages extend naturally into postdoctoral research.

## 6.1 A Neuromechanical Simulation Pipeline

The first stage converts the validated biomechanical design into a physics simulation that a neural controller can drive. The pipeline has three parts. Much of this stage is now in place (status as of this writing, detailed in Section 3.11): the OpenSim-to-MuJoCo conversion is complete and audited, the SNS-Toolbox coupling runs at a 0.1 ms neural step with force feedback, and the full two-layer spinal network has been assembled and its rhythm generator verified in isolation. What remains of this stage is the blocker described below — non-finite leg-joint states in full-body co-simulation, with the foot-contact meshes the

primary suspect — after which the plan shifts from assembly to tuning and validation.

### 6.1.1 From OpenSim to MuJoCo

The starting point is the author's modified OpenSim model: the Gait2392-derived robot variant in which the actuator set has been reduced and adapted to the BPA hardware and the muscle origin, insertion, and wrapping points have been updated to the optimized robot routing [Bolen and Hunt, 2019, Morrow et al., 2020]. The model will be kept in OpenSim 4.x format and converted to MuJoCo [Todorov et al., 2012] using MyoConverter [Caggiano et al., 2022, Wang et al., 2022], which converts OpenSim musculoskeletal models to MuJoCo models with optimized muscle kinematics and kinetics. The conversion will be sanity-checked by inspecting the generated model, verifying joint naming and ordering for later sensor and actuator mapping, confirming that the expected number of muscle-tendon actuators exists with plausible attachment geometry, and fixing any conversion gaps by revising the OpenSim model or accepting manual edits in the MuJoCo model.

The MuJoCo model will represent actuation with muscle-like actuators that carry an internal activation state, so that SNS outputs can drive them through activation dynamics. Each timestep, MuJoCo updates the kinematics and the muscle variables (e.g., muscle-tendon lengths and velocities) needed to compute proprioceptive signals.

### 6.1.2 Coupling the Synthetic Nervous System

The neural controller will be implemented with SNS-Toolbox [Nourse et al., 2023], which supports large networks of spiking and non-spiking neurons and couples directly to

MuJoCo. At each timestep, SNS receives Ia, Ib, and II proprioceptive channels plus binary heel and toe contact signals from the MuJoCo model, processes them through the neural core described below, and returns per-muscle activation commands that are fed into the MuJoCo muscle activation states.

The coupling will be brought up incrementally. Before any gains are tuned against human gait, the mechanics-only loop will be verified with open-loop activation patterns, confirming the sign and magnitude behavior of torques and forces. The SNS will then be added with a minimal sensor set — contact signals plus a single proprioceptive channel — and only later expanded to the full Ia/Ib/II set. Once stable, the activation strengths and neuron-to-muscle mapping parameters will be tuned across a few walking speeds. A Simscape-based mechanical model could substitute for MuJoCo for validation of specific mechanical subsystems, but Simscape does not natively host the spiking and non-spiking neuron models of an SNS, so MuJoCo remains the primary platform. The AARL's quadruped has already traveled part of this road: a MuJoCo model of the BPA quadruped was coupled to SNS-Toolbox, produced closed-loop coordinated stepping, and was transferred to hardware with potentiometer and pressure feedback on a treadmill [Lutz, 2025]; the present pipeline extends that approach from the quadruped to a leg built on human anatomy. Comparable neuromechanical simulation frameworks, such as FARMS, are emerging in parallel [Arreguit et al., 2023], underscoring the timeliness of the approach.

### 6.2 A Two-Layer CPG with Sensory Feedback

The author's prior AnimatLab walker (Section 3.10) demonstrated both the promise and the limitation of this architecture, and its outcome belongs on record here because it defines the requirements for the work below. With the rhythm-generator, pattern-formation, and sensorimotor layers oscillating in phase, the suspended model produced alternating stepping-like motion at approximately 4 Hz — faster than the ∼1 Hz of typical human gait, but adjustable through the sodium-channel activation parameters, and, once ground contact exists, subject to further slowing from ground-reaction forces and load-dependent feedback. When the earlier demonstrated configuration was lowered onto a simulated ground plane, however, the same patterns could not support the body or generate forward motion: afferent pathways had been wired but not tuned, and functional ground-contact gating of stance and swing had not been implemented. Preliminary results from that model were presented at the 2021 NIH BRAIN Initiative Investigators Meeting [Bolen and Hunt, 2021]. The current instrumented phase-1 model records left and right foot and toe contact channels, but their use for closed-loop phase control has not yet been validated. In the suspended walker, the CPG acts as a feedforward controller: rhythm generation alone, without functional ground-contact feedback, produced gait-like stepping, exactly as the deafferented-CPG physiology of Section 2.6 predicts. What feedforward stepping cannot do is support the body against the ground, so the critical path from stepping-like motion to weight-bearing walking is the proprioceptive and contact feedback channels described below, and the verification tests that tune them. That premise is well supported: biomechanics and sensory feedback have been shown to regularize the behavior

of different locomotor CPG architectures [Deng et al., 2022], so the present work contributes an application of this principle to the suspended walker. The AnimatLab walker model, a direct descendant of that earlier work, continues to serve as the prototyping environment for the network while the MuJoCo pipeline is brought up.

### 6.2.1 Architecture

The neural core follows the two-level organization of the mammalian locomotor CPG established by the Rybak group [Rybak et al., 2006, McCrea and Rybak, 2008, Rybak et al., 2015]: each leg has a rhythm generator (RG) circuit, which produces the basic locomotor rhythm and controls its period, and a pattern formation (PF) circuit, which shapes the rhythm into phase-appropriate activation of the flexor and extensor motoneuron populations. A left–right rhythm generator circuit coordinates the two legs through commissural inhibition and excitation, following models of left–right coordination [Molkov et al., 2015, Danner et al., 2016]. The per-leg PF output drives the motoneuron pools — here, the BPA activation commands for the hip, knee, and ankle muscle groups of each leg.

### 6.2.2 Sensory Feedback Channels

Three classes of proprioceptive feedback, together with discrete contact feedback, will close the loop between the MuJoCo model and the CPG, mirroring the biological afferents organized in the Sensory Afferent Database [Bolen et al., 2023]:

- **Ia afferents** (muscle spindle primary endings) signal muscle length and velocity, providing stretch reflex pathways and phase-dependent modulation of the PF network.

- **Ib afferents** (Golgi tendon organs) signal muscle force, providing load-dependent regulation of stance-phase extensor activity.
- **II afferents** (muscle spindle secondary endings) signal length, contributing to position sensing and interjoint coordination.
- **Contact receptors** on the heel and toe provide discrete stance and swing boundary signals, driving phase transitions and weight-support switching.

### 6.2.3 Verification Tests

Before attempting locomotion, the network will be verified with simple simulation tests in which a tonic stimulus is applied to the muscle motoneurons, to the pattern-formation layer, and to the rhythm-generator layer, and the resulting outputs are compared with the corresponding experimental literature. The first of these tests is complete at the rhythm-generator level: under tonic drive, the isolated SNS-Toolbox rhythm generators of the assembled spinal network oscillate with a period of approximately 0.9 s with the two legs in antiphase (Section 3.11); in the AnimatLab instance of the network, conductance tuning toward robust rhythm-generator oscillation is still under way. The closest biological analogue is the tonic-stimulation air-stepping protocol of Selionov et al. [2009], in which tonic central and sensory stimuli facilitate involuntary stepping in humans; analogous deletion and stimulation phenomena are reproduced by the two-level CPG model itself [Rybak et al., 2006] and by neuromechanical implementations [Markin et al., 2010, Shevtsova et al., 2016]. Comparing the simulated tonic-stimulation responses with these studies will validate the sign, gain, and phase structure of the implemented circuits before any

walking-speed tuning is attempted.

### 6.3 Extending the Sensorium: Vestibular, Ocular, and Cerebellar Contributions

Once stepping is stable, three supraspinal contributions will be added. First, vestibular feedback will be simulated with IMU-like sensing of body orientation and angular velocity, extending the AARL's balance-platform work, in which an inverted pendulum with pseudo-vestibular IMU feedback maintained balance on an oscillating platform [Bolen et al., 2024b,a,c] and analytic neural networks reproduced human balance dynamics [Hilts et al., 2019]. Second, ocular feedback will be modeled to investigate how visual stabilization cues can help reset IMU drift — a well-known practical problem for inertial sensing on robots — by treating visual measurements of the horizon and surroundings as a low-frequency correction to the vestibular estimate. Third, a cerebellar layer will be explored as an adaptive gateway between higher-level locomotion commands and the CPG: a structure that can gate between different gaits or movement patterns (e.g., walking, running, and turning) and tune the phase relationships among them, in line with the cerebellum's established role in adaptation and coordination. Multilevel spinal-plus-cerebellar synthetic nervous systems have already been demonstrated for insect-like legs [Grummer et al., 2024], and hierarchical cortico-cerebellar-spinal models have been proposed for adaptive step-length control in bipedal locomotion [Chen et al., 2025]. The proprioceptive–vestibular interaction literature [Akay and Murray, 2021] will guide how these signals are weighted.

### 6.4 Physical Realization: A Treadmill Robot with Real-Time Neural Control

The final stage returns to hardware. The robot will walk on a treadmill with real-time feedback and control implemented on an embedded computing stack: Teensy microcontrollers for the low-latency per-joint loops (valve control, pressure sensing, contact sensing) and an NVIDIA Jetson-class companion computer for the SNS network evaluation and activation computation. A serial connection to a host computer will be used only for data logging and high-level commands (e.g., run, walk, or stimulate a named neural pathway), keeping the control loop fully embedded. Walking control of a physical musculoskeletal biped with McKibben muscles has recently been demonstrated with spring-loaded inverted pendulum controllers [Li et al., 2024], supporting the feasibility of embedded control on anthropomorphic pneumatic legs. An actuation-level design lever also remains open: the BPA's limited contraction can force long musculotendon routings — a burden visible in the extensor redesign bounds of Appendix C and encountered in the author's master's routing work [Bolen and Hunt, 2019]. A block-and-tackle "reverse pulley" arrangement, demonstrated on the AARL's self-balancing inverted-pendulum platform, addresses this by trading transmitted force for travel: paired BPAs pulled through compound pulleys on a tendon coupled to the limb, increasing range of motion at the cost of reduced transmitted force and increased reaction force on the structure [Bolen et al., 2024b,a,c]. Because joint torque is computed in the body frame, configurations that turn that reaction force to advantage may exist, making the arrangement a candidate for joints whose optimized routes demand impractically long actuators. This division of labor mirrors the SNS-Toolbox backend philosophy, which targets embedded computing platforms for real-time neural

simulation [Nourse et al., 2023].

Because the static force and torque models of Chapters 3–4 are computationally inexpensive lookup-table candidates, they will serve as the feedforward model inside the real-time controller, while the dynamic pressure–force behavior under pulse-modulated control will draw on the state-space model of Elzein et al. [2025]. Embedded execution of the complete CPG-plus-reflex network on this stack is the intended demonstration of the dissertation project: a robot that walks with human-like biomechanics under a biologically grounded neural controller, and whose nervous system — unlike a living animal's — can be instrumented, stimulated, and lesioned at will.

### 6.5 Toward Dynamic Whole-Body Maneuvers

Beyond steady walking, the long-term goal of this line of research is dynamic, whole-body maneuvering: transitions between gaits, reactive balancing, and ultimately ballistic maneuvers that require coordinating the full actuator set through brief, precisely timed activation bursts. The author's aspiration for this program is a robot that can perform a kickflip — a maneuver that, like its skateboard namesake, demands explosive coordinated extension, precise timing, aerial body orientation, and controlled landing. It is exactly the kind of behavior that exercises every layer of the proposed architecture, from contact receptors and spinal pattern generation to vestibular orientation sensing and cerebellar coordination, and it would demonstrate that biomimetic actuation and neuromechanical control scale from steady locomotion to dynamic whole-body movement.

# 7 Conclusion

This dissertation moved the biomimetic humanoid robot project from an unvalidated design concept to a quantitatively characterized actuator set and a validated knee-level biomechanical design, and it defined the path from those experimental foundations to neuromechanical control.

At the actuator level, the analysis in Chapters 3 and 4 produced novel equations for calculating isometric force in Festo 10 mm and 20 mm-diameter BPAs. The work elucidated the relationship between maximum BPA force at 620 kPa and resting length, $F_{620}(l_0)$, a previously unreported characteristic of these actuators that the manufacturer's tool predicts with the opposite trend, and it produced a nondimensional force surface, $F^*(\epsilon^*, P^*)$, with only three diameter-dependent coefficients. Taken together, these fits predict isometric BPA force across resting lengths from a small number of measurements, correct the large over-predictions of the manufacturer's tool at short resting lengths, and outperform published single-length models. In a design workflow, these equations make it possible to select actuator diameter and resting length and to evaluate whether a proposed muscle routing can meet force and range-of-motion requirements, before committing to a prototype.

At the joint level, the improved actuator model was combined with a compliance- and wrapping-corrected musculotendon kinematics model and validated on two knee designs. The hybrid torque calculation method isolated the sources of error between prediction and measurement, and the resulting correction terms — a constant length offset,

an equivalent-stiffness representation of series compliance, and a wrapping-loss term — substantially improved torque prediction on the pinned knee and transferred to the biomimetic four-bar knee. The biomimetic knee driven by optimized BPAs was shown to meet or exceed human isometric knee torque over most of the range of motion, confirming that the optimized muscle routing of the author's earlier work is realizable in hardware and identifying the high-flexion regime where additional flexor capacity is needed.

Beyond the specific models, the dissertation's methodological contribution is the actuator-to-joint design chain itself: characterize the actuator, correct for the compliance and geometry of the transmission, validate against human biomechanics, and only then close the loop with a controller. The remaining gap — the neural layer — is scoped in Chapter 6: a MuJoCo model converted from the AARL's OpenSim models via MyoConverter (the conversion, the SNS-Toolbox coupling, and the assembled two-layer spinal network with its verified antiphase rhythm generator are already in place), wrapped in an SNS-Toolbox synthetic nervous system implementing a two-layer CPG with per-leg rhythm generation and pattern formation, left–right coordination, and Ia, Ib, II, and contact feedback, verified first by tonic-stimulation tests against the literature, then extended with vestibular, ocular, and cerebellar layers, and finally deployed on embedded hardware controlling a treadmill-walking robot. The portability of these neural primitives was verified directly: the contact-driven rhythm core reproduces with exact period agreement and trace correlations above 0.9999 between independent NumPy and Simulink implementations, the archived AnimatLab reference models reproduce their published rhythms headless, and a BPA-actuated walker in MuJoCo air-steps under synthetic neural control with peak actuator forces at 60% of the pressure ceiling — while the honest negatives of the same

campaign localize the remaining gap in the balance layer, not in the rhythm, the actuators, or the engines. The biomimetic platform that results will permit neuromechanical experiments — neural lesions, sensory deletions, and pathway stimulation — that are impossible in living animals, closing the cycle between better robots and better biological understanding, and opening the way toward dynamic whole-body maneuvers.

## Bibliography

Turgay Akay. Sensory Feedback Control of Locomotor Pattern Generation in Cats and Mice. *Neuroscience*, 450:161–167, 2020. doi: 10.1016/j.neuroscience.2020.05.008.

Turgay Akay and Andrew J. Murray. Relative Contribution of Proprioceptive and Vestibular Sensory Systems to Locomotion: An Overview. *International Journal of Molecular Sciences*, 22(3):1467, 2021. doi: 10.3390/ijms22031467.

Turgay Akay, William G. Tourtellotte, Silvia Arber, and Thomas M. Jessell. Degradation of mouse locomotor pattern in the absence of proprioceptive sensory feedback. *Proceedings of the National Academy of Sciences*, 111(47):16877–16882, 2014. doi: 10.1073/pnas.1419045111.

Efe Aksöz, Marco Laubacher, Robert Riener, and Kenneth Hunt. Design of an isokinetic knee dynamometer for evaluation of functional electrical stimulation strategies. *Medical Engineering & Physics*, 73, August 2019. doi: 10.1016/j.medengphy.2019.07.010.

J. G. Andrews. A General Method for Determining the Functional Role of a Muscle. *Journal of Biomechanical Engineering*, 107(4):348–353, November 1985. ISSN 0148-0731. doi: 10.1115/1.3138568. URL `https://doi.org/10.1115/1.3138568`.

Bryson Armstead, Christian Jackson, William Nourse, and Roger D. Quinn. Design and validation of a robotic cat hindlimb. In *Biomimetic and Biohybrid Systems*, Lecture Notes in Computer Science. Springer, 2025. doi: 10.1007/978-3-032-07448-5_6.

Edith M. Arnold, Samuel R. Ward, Richard L. Lieber, and Scott L. Delp. A Model of the Lower Limb for Analysis of Human Movement. *Annals of Biomedical Engineering*, 38(2): 269–279, February 2010. ISSN 0090-6964, 1573-9686. doi: 10.1007/s10439-009-9852-5. URL `http://link.springer.com/10.1007/s10439-009-9852-5`.

Javier Arreguit, Shruthi Tata Ramalingasetty, Simon M. Danner, and Auke Ijspeert. FARMS: Framework for animal and robot modeling and simulation. *bioRxiv*, 2023. doi: 10.1101/2023.09.25.559130. Version 4 posted 2025-02-21.

Yuki Asano, Kei Okada, and Masayuki Inaba. Design principles of a human mimetic humanoid: Humanoid platform to study human intelligence and internal body system.

*Science Robotics*, 2(13), December 2017. ISSN 2470-9476. doi: 10.1126/scirobotics.aaq0899. URL https://robotics.sciencemag.org/content/2/13/eaaq0899.

Yuki Asano, Kei Okada, and Masayuki Inaba. Musculoskeletal design, control, and application of human mimetic humanoid Kenshiro. *Bioinspiration & Biomimetics*, 14 (3):036011, April 2019. ISSN 1748-3190. doi: 10.1088/1748-3190/ab03fc. URL https://iopscience.iop.org/article/10.1088/1748-3190/ab03fc.

K.S. Aschenbeck, N.I. Kern, R.J. Bachmann, and R.D. Quinn. Design of a Quadruped Robot Driven by Air Muscles. In *The First IEEE/RAS-EMBS International Conference on Biomedical Robotics and Biomechatronics, 2006. BioRob 2006.*, pages 875–880, February 2006. doi: 10.1109/BIOROB.2006.1639201. URL https://ieeexplore.ieee.org/abstract/document/1639201.

Charles Audet and J. E. Dennis, Jr. Mesh adaptive direct search algorithms for constrained optimization. *SIAM Journal on Optimization*, 16(3):988–1015, 2006. doi: 10.1137/040603371.

B. P. Bolen and A. J. Hunt. Torque Values About Artificial Knee Using Braided Pneumatic Actuators, June 2021. URL https://www.braininitiative.org/event/the-7th-annual-brain-initiative-investigators-meeting/. Poster 4008. Work funded by NSF NeuroNex C3NS #2015317. Includes bipedal walker CPG results (Bipedal Walker and CPG Architecture sections).

B. P. Bolen and A. J. Hunt. Using AI Tools to Enhance the Sensory Afferent Database: A Comparative Study, October 2024. URL https://www.sfn.org/Meetings/Neuroscience-2024. Poster presentation, Neuroscience 2024, Society for Neuroscience, Chicago, IL.

B. P. Bolen, K. Deng, and A. J. Hunt. Sensory Afferent Database: Advancing towards a comprehensive understanding of sensory afferents and motor control, November 2023. URL https://neuronex5.io/. Poster presentation, Neuroscience 2023, Society for Neuroscience, Washington, D.C.

Ben Bolen. Bipedal Robot Legs Project. MSME project paper, Portland State University, Portland, OR, 2019.

Ben Bolen, J. Stu McNeal, Sunil Williams, and Alexander J. Hunt. Self-balancing robot leg with vestibular feedback, April 2024a. URL https://nwrsymposium.github.io/2024/. Poster presentation, Northwest Robotics Symposium (NWRS), April 26, Corvallis, OR, United States.

Ben Bolen, Lindie Burgess, Connor Morrow, Mohammad Elzein, Lawrence Pang, Cody Scharzenberger, and Alexander Hunt. Isometric Torque Values About Robotic Knee Using Braided Pneumatic Actuators. Unpublished manuscript in preparation; not submitted for publication, 2025.

Ben Bolen, Mohammad Elzein, Lawrence Pang, and Alexander Hunt. Isometric Force Characterization of Braided Pneumatic Actuators. *Actuators*, 15(5):230, 2026. doi: 10.3390/act15050230.

Ben P. Bolen and Alexander J. Hunt. Determination of Artificial Muscle Placement for Biomimetic Humanoid Robot Legs. In Uriel Martinez-Hernandez, Vasiliki Vouloutsi, Anna Mura, Michael Mangan, Minoru Asada, Tony J. Prescott, and Paul F.M.J. Verschure, editors, *Biomimetic and Biohybrid Systems*, volume 11556, pages 15–26. Springer International Publishing, Cham, 2019. ISBN 978-3-030-24740-9 978-3-030-24741-6. doi: 10.1007/978-3-030-24741-6_2. URL http://link.springer.com/10.1007/978-3-030-24741-6_2.

Ben P. Bolen, J. Stu McNeal, Sunil Williams, and Alexander J. Hunt. Balance Platform and Inverted Pendulum for Robotic Vestibular and Proprioceptive Control, May 2024b. URL https://nwbs2024.wixsite.com/uoregon. Abstract and poster presentation, Northwest Biomechanics Symposium 2024, May 17–18, Eugene, OR.

Ben P. Bolen, J. Stu McNeal, Sunil Williams, and Alexander J. Hunt. Self-balancing Robot Leg, May 2024c. URL https://pdxscholar.library.pdx.edu/studentsymposium/2024/posters/60/. Poster presentation, Portland State University Student Research Symposium, May 8, Portland, OR.

R. A. Brand, R. D. Crowninshield, C. E. Wittstock, D. R. Pedersen, C. R. Clark, and F. M. van Krieken. A Model of Lower Extremity Muscular Anatomy. *Journal of Biomechanical Engineering*, 104(4):304–310, November 1982. ISSN 0148-0731, 1528-8951. doi: 10.1115/1.3138363. URL https://asmedigitalcollection.asme.org/biomechanical/article/104/4/304/453784/A-Model-of-Lower-Extremity-Muscular-Anatomy.

T. Graham Brown. The intrinsic factors in the act of progression in the mammal. *Proceedings of the Royal Society B: Biological Sciences*, 84(572):308–319, 1911. doi: 10.1098/rspb.1911.0077.

Vittorio Caggiano, Huawei Wang, Guillaume Durandau, Massimo Sartori, and Vikash Kumar. MyoSuite: A Contact-rich Simulation Suite for Musculoskeletal Motor Control.

In *Proceedings of The 4th Annual Learning for Dynamics and Control Conference*, volume 168 of *Proceedings of Machine Learning Research*, pages 492–507. PMLR, 2022.

Jiahao Chen, Shanlin Zhong, Erlong Kang, and Hong Qiao. Realizing human-like manipulation with a musculoskeletal system and biologically inspired control scheme. *Neurocomputing*, 339:116–129, April 2019. ISSN 0925-2312. doi: 10.1016/j.neucom.2018.12.069. URL https://www.sciencedirect.com/science/article/pii/S0925231218315315.

Z. Chen, Y. Yu, F. Han, and K. Deng. A cortico-cerebellar–spinal hierarchical model for adaptive step-length control in bipedal locomotions. *The European Physical Journal Special Topics*, 234:9129–9145, 2025. doi: 10.1140/epjs/s11734-025-02028-6.

Ching-Ping Chou and B. Hannaford. Measurement and modeling of McKibben pneumatic artificial muscles. *IEEE Transactions on Robotics and Automation*, 12(1):90–102, February 1996. ISSN 2374-958X. doi: 10.1109/70.481753. URL https://ieeexplore.ieee.org/document/481753/.

David Cofer, Gennady Cymbalyuk, James Reid, Ying Zhu, W. J. Heitler, and Donald H. Edwards. AnimatLab: A 3D graphics environment for neuromechanical simulations. *Journal of Neuroscience Methods*, 187(2):280–288, 2010. doi: 10.1016/j.jneumeth.2010.02.005.

Simon M. Danner, S. D. Wilshin, Natalia A. Shevtsova, and Ilya A. Rybak. Central control of interlimb coordination and speed-dependent gait expression in quadrupeds. *The Journal of Physiology*, 594(23):6947–6967, 2016. doi: 10.1113/JP272787.

Friedl De Groote and Antoine Falisse. Perspective on musculoskeletal modelling and predictive simulations of human movement to assess the neuromechanics of gait. *Proceedings of the Royal Society B: Biological Sciences*, 288(1946):20202432, 2021. doi: 10.1098/rspb.2020.2432.

Kalyanmoy Deb, Amrit Pratap, Sameer Agarwal, and T. Meyarivan. A fast and elitist multiobjective genetic algorithm: NSGA-II. *IEEE Transactions on Evolutionary Computation*, 6 (2):182–197, 2002. doi: 10.1109/4235.996017.

Decerebrated. Decerebrated cat treadmill experiments [video]. urlhttps://www.youtube.com/watch?v=hAteWL78NMc, n.d. Archival footage of a decerebrate-cat locomotion experiment; restored and colorized copy archived with the dissertation materials. Accessed October 2026.

Scott L. Delp, Frank C. Anderson, Allison S. Arnold, Peter Loan, Ayman Habib, Chand T. John, Eran Guendelman, and Darryl G. Thelen. OpenSim: Open-Source Software to Create and Analyze Dynamic Simulations of Movement. *IEEE Transactions on Biomedical Engineering*, 54(11):1940–1950, November 2007. ISSN 0018-9294. doi: 10.1109/TBME.2007.901024. URL http://ieeexplore.ieee.org/document/4352056/.

S.L. Delp, J.P. Loan, M.G. Hoy, F.E. Zajac, E.L. Topp, and J.M. Rosen. An interactive graphics-based model of the lower extremity to study orthopaedic surgical procedures. *IEEE Transactions on Biomedical Engineering*, 37(8):757–767, August 1990. ISSN 00189294. doi: 10.1109/10.102791. URL http://ieeexplore.ieee.org/document/102791/.

Kaiyu Deng, Nicholas S. Szczecinski, David Arnold, Emanuel Andrada, Martin S. Fischer, Roger D. Quinn, and Alexander J. Hunt. Neuromechanical model of rat hindlimb walking with two-layer CPGs. *Biomimetics*, 4(1):21, 2019. doi: 10.3390/biomimetics4010021.

Kaiyu Deng et al. Biomechanical and sensory feedback regularize the behavior of different locomotor central pattern generators. *Biomimetics*, 7(4):226, 2022. doi: 10.3390/biomimetics7040226.

Timothy R. Derrick, Antonie J. van den Bogert, Andrea Cereatti, Raphael Dumas, Silvia Fantozzi, and Alberto Leardini. ISB recommendations on the reporting of intersegmental forces and moments during human motion analysis. *Journal of Biomechanics*, 99:109533, January 2020. ISSN 0021-9290. doi: 10.1016/j.jbiomech.2019.109533. URL https://www.sciencedirect.com/science/article/pii/S0021929019307870.

A. Di Russo et al. Investigating the roles of reflexes and central pattern generators in the control and modulation of human locomotion using a physiologically plausible neuromechanical model. *Journal of Neural Engineering*, 20(6):066006, 2023. doi: 10.1088/1741-2552/aceb85.

Volker Dietz and Jacques Duysens. Significance of load receptor input during locomotion: a review. *Gait & Posture*, 11(2):102–110, 2000. doi: 10.1016/S0966-6362(99)00052-1.

W. Duan, W. Chen, J. Wang, J. Liu, Z. Pei, and J. Chen. Gait-generation strategy for lower limb exoskeleton based on central pattern generator. *IEEE/ASME Transactions on Mechatronics*, 29(6):4191–4200, 2024. URL https://ieeexplore.ieee.org/document/10460752.

Mohammad Elzein, Jack Lutz, Ben Bolen, and Alexander Hunt. Pressure and Force Dynamics in Artificial Muscle Actuators: A State-Space and Optimization-Based Approach.

In *Biomimetic and Biohybrid Systems*, pages 592–605. Springer Nature Switzerland, Cham, 2025. ISBN 978-3-032-07448-5. doi: 10.1007/978-3-032-07448-5_49.

Festo AG & Co. KG. Fluidic Muscle DMSP/MAS. Product Datasheet, Festo AG & Co. KG, April 2013. URL https://ftp.festo.com/Public/PNEUMATIC/SOFTWARE_SERVICE/Documentation/2015/EN/DMSP-MAS_EN.PDF.

Festo AG & Co. KG. Fluidic Muscle DMSP/MAS. Product Datasheet, Festo AG & Co. KG, January 2018. URL https://www.festo.com/net/en_us/SupportPortal/Files/732773/DMSP_MAS_2018-01f_8081496g1.pdf.

Festo AG & Co. KG. Fluidic Muscle DMSP. Product Datasheet, Festo AG & Co. KG, January 2026. URL https://www.festo.com/media/catalog/202851_documentation.pdf.

Jonas Frey, Roi Mattamala, Hae-Won Park, Mayank Mittal, Georg Martius, Michael A. Osborne, Robert Sparrow, and Marco Hutter. Advances, challenges, and opportunities for legged robots. *Science Robotics*, 11:aee0787, 2026. doi: 10.1126/scirobotics.aee0787.

Yasuhiro Fukuoka, Yasuyuki Habu, and Ning Inoue. Autonomous speed adaptation by a muscle-driven hind leg robot modeled on a cat without intervention from brain. *International Journal of Advanced Robotic Systems*, 18, 2021. doi: 10.1177/17298814211044936.

Hartmut Geyer and Hugh Herr. A muscle-reflex model that encodes principles of legged mechanics produces human walking dynamics and muscle activities. *IEEE Transactions on Neural Systems and Rehabilitation Engineering*, 18(3):263–273, 2010. doi: 10.1109/TNSRE.2010.2047592.

C. A. Goldsmith, R. D. Quinn, and N. S. Szczecinski. Investigating the role of low level reinforcement reflex loops in insect locomotion. *Bioinspiration & Biomimetics*, 16(6):065008, October 2021. ISSN 1748-3190. doi: 10.1088/1748-3190/ac28ea. URL https://dx.doi.org/10.1088/1748-3190/ac28ea.

Ryan Grummer, Christian B. Jackson, and Roger D. Quinn. Multilevel synthetic nervous system control for legged locomotion. In *Biomimetic and Biohybrid Systems*, volume 14930 of *Lecture Notes in Computer Science*, pages 382–396. Springer, 2024. doi: 10.1007/978-3-031-72597-5_26.

Sehoon Ha et al. Learning-based legged locomotion: State of the art and future challenges. *The International Journal of Robotics Research*, 2025. doi: 10.1177/02783649241312698.

Daniel F. B. Haeufle, Benjamin Schmortte, Hartmut Geyer, and Andre Seyfarth. The benefit of combining neuronal feedback and feed-forward control for robustness in step down perturbations of simulated human walking depends on the muscle function. *Frontiers in Computational Neuroscience*, 12:80, 2018. doi: 10.3389/fncom.2018.00080.

Jun He and Feng Gao. Mechanism, Actuation, Perception, and Control of Highly Dynamic Multilegged Robots: A Review. *Chinese Journal of Mechanical Engineering*, 33(1):79, November 2020. ISSN 2192-8258. doi: 10.1186/s10033-020-00485-9. URL https://doi.org/10.1186/s10033-020-00485-9.

Wade Hilts, Nicholas S. Szczecinski, Roger D. Quinn, and Alexander J. Hunt. A Dynamic Neural Network Designed Using Analytical Methods Produces Dynamic Control Properties Similar to Human Test Subjects. *IEEE Control Systems Letters*, 3(2):320–325, 2019. doi: 10.1109/LCSYS.2018.2871126.

Arne Hitzmann, Hiroaki Masuda, Shuhei Ikemoto, and Koh Hosoda. Anthropomorphic musculoskeletal 10 degrees-of-freedom robot arm driven by pneumatic artificial muscles. *Advanced Robotics*, 32(15):865–878, August 2018. ISSN 01691864. doi: 10.1080/01691864.2018.1494040. URL http://stats.lib.pdx.edu/proxy.php?url=http://search.ebscohost.com/login.aspx?direct=true&db=aph&AN=131926820&site=ehost-live.

Melissa Hoy, Felix Zajac, and Michael Gordon. A musculoskeletal model of the human lower extremity: the effect of muscle, tendon, and moment arm on the moment-angle relationship of musculotendon actuators at the hip, knee, and ankle. *Journal of Biomechanics*, 23(2):157–169, 1990.

Alexander Hunt, Alexander Graber-Tilton, and Roger Quinn. Modeling length effects of braided pneumatic actuators. In *Volume 5A: 41st Mechanisms and Robotics Conference*, volume 58172, page V05AT08A008, Cleveland, OH, August 2017a. ASME. ISBN 978-0-7918-5817-2. doi: 10.1115/detc2017-67458. URL https://asme.pinetec.com/detc2017/data/pdfs/trk-8/DETC2017-67458.pdf.

Alexander Hunt, Nicholas Szczecinski, and Roger Quinn. Development and Training of a Neural Controller for Hind Leg Walking in a Dog Robot. *Frontiers in Neurorobotics*, Volume 11 - 2017, April 2017b. ISSN 1662-5218. doi: 10.3389/fnbot.2017.00018. URL http://journal.frontiersin.org/article/10.3389/fnbot.2017.00018/full.

Daisuke Ichimura and Tetsuro Yamazaki. A pathological condition affects motor modules in a bipedal locomotion model. *Frontiers in Neurorobotics*, 13:79, 2019. doi: 10.3389/fnbot.2019.00079.

Auke J. Ijspeert. Amphibious and Sprawling Locomotion: From Biology to Robotics and Back. *Annual Review of Control, Robotics, and Autonomous Systems*, 3(1):173–193, 2020. doi: 10.1146/annurev-control-091919-095731. URL https://doi.org/10.1146/annurev-control-091919-095731. _eprint: https://doi.org/10.1146/annurev-control-091919-095731.

Marco Iosa, Andrea Cereatti, Antonio Merlo, Ilaria Campanini, Stefano Paolucci, and Aurelio Cappozzo. Assessment of waveform similarity in clinical gait data: the linear fit method. *BioMed Research International*, 2014:214156, 2014. doi: 10.1155/2014/214156.

Shunichi Kurumaya, Koichi Suzumori, Hiroyuki Nabae, and Shuichi Wakimoto. Musculoskeletal lower-limb robot driven by multifilament muscles. *ROBOMECH Journal*, 3 (1):18, December 2016. ISSN 2197-4225. doi: 10.1186/s40648-016-0061-3. URL https://robomechjournal.springeropen.com/articles/10.1186/s40648-016-0061-3.

Tania Lam and Keir G. Pearson. The role of proprioceptive feedback in the regulation and adaptation of locomotor activity. *Advances in Experimental Medicine and Biology*, 508: 343–355, 2002. doi: 10.1007/978-1-4615-0713-0_40.

Lang, Robert. MuscleSIM, 2005. Dept. TK-ES / Robert Lang.

Ronald Leibach. *Development of a Tunable Compliance Energy Return Actuator*. PhD thesis, Case Western Reserve University, 2020. URL https://etd.ohiolink.edu/apexprod/rws_olink/r/1501/10?p10_etd_subid=184456&clear=10.

Jianfeng Li, Shiping Zuo, Chenghui Xu, Leiyu Zhang, Mingjie Dong, Chunjing Tao, and Run Ji. Influence of a Compatible Design on Physical Human-Robot Interaction Force: a Case Study of a Self-Adapting Lower-Limb Exoskeleton Mechanism. *Journal of Intelligent & Robotic Systems*, 98(2):525–538, May 2020. ISSN 0921-0296, 1573-0409. doi: 10.1007/s10846-019-01063-5. URL http://link.springer.com/10.1007/s10846-019-01063-5.

Wansheng Li, Nicholas S. Szczecinski, and Roger D. Quinn. A neural network with central pattern generators entrained by sensory feedback controls walking of a bipedal model. *Bioinspiration & Biomimetics*, 12(6):065002, 2017. doi: 10.1088/1748-3190/aa8290.

Yinlong Li, Yinlai Jiang, and Kou Hosoda. Controller design and experimental validation of walking for a musculoskeletal bipedal lower limb robot based on the spring-loaded inverted pendulum model. *Frontiers in Robotics and AI*, 11:1449721, 2024. doi: 10.3389/frobt.2024.1449721.

Wei Liang, Hao Liu, Kunyang Wang, Zhihui Qian, Luquan Ren, and Lei Ren. Comparative study of robotic artificial actuators and biological muscle. *Advances in Mechanical Engineering*, 12(6):1687814020933409, June 2020. ISSN 1687-8140. doi: 10.1177/1687814020933409. URL https://doi.org/10.1177/1687814020933409.

Xiangxiao Liu, Andre Rosendo, Shuhei Ikemoto, Masahiro Shimizu, and Koh Hosoda. Robotic investigation on effect of stretch reflex and crossed inhibitory response on bipedal hopping. *Journal of the Royal Society Interface*, 15(140):20180024, March 2018. ISSN 1742-5689. doi: 10.1098/rsif.2018.0024. Place: London WOS:000428576200018.

M. J. Lutz. Mechanical improvements and control implementation on a biomimetic quadruped model. Master's thesis, Portland State University, 2025.

J.D.W. Madden, N.A. Vandesteeg, P.A. Anquetil, P.G.A. Madden, A. Takshi, R.Z. Pytel, S.R. Lafontaine, P.A. Wieringa, and I.W. Hunter. Artificial muscle technology: physical principles and naval prospects. *IEEE Journal of Oceanic Engineering*, 29(3):706–728, July 2004. ISSN 1558-1691. doi: 10.1109/JOE.2004.833135. Conference Name: IEEE Journal of Oceanic Engineering.

Sergey N. Markin, Alexander N. Klishko, Natalia A. Shevtsova, Michel A. Lemay, Boris I. Prilutsky, and Ilya A. Rybak. Afferent control of locomotor CPG: insights from a simple neuromechanical model. *Annals of the New York Academy of Sciences*, 1198(1):21–34, 2010. doi: 10.1111/j.1749-6632.2010.05435.x.

Martin Martens, Alexander Passon, and Ingo Boblan. A Sensor-Less Torque Control Interface for Pneumatic Muscle Actuators. *Actuators*, 7(4):82, 2018. doi: 10.3390/act7040082.

Mirco Martens and Ivo Boblan. Modeling the Static Force of a Festo Pneumatic Muscle Actuator: A New Approach and a Comparison to Existing Models. *Actuators*, 6(4):33, November 2017. doi: 10.3390/act6040033. URL http://www.mdpi.com/2076-0825/6/4/33.

David A. McCrea and Ilya A. Rybak. Organization of mammalian locomotor rhythm and pattern generation. *Brain Research Reviews*, 57(1):134–146, 2008. doi: 10.1016/j.brainresrev.2007.08.006.

Luciano Luporini Menegaldo, Agenor de Toledo Fleury, and Hans Ingo Weber. Moment arms and musculotendon lengths estimation for a three-dimensional lower-limb model. *Journal of Biomechanics*, 37(9):1447–1453, September 2004. ISSN 0021-9290. doi: 10.1016/j.jbiomech.2003.12.017. URL https://www.sciencedirect.com/science/article/pii/S0021929003004809.

Matthew Millard, Thomas Uchida, Ajay Seth, and Scott L. Delp. Flexing Computational Muscle: Modeling and Simulation of Musculotendon Dynamics. *Journal of Biomechanical Engineering*, 135(2):021005, February 2013. ISSN 0148-0731, 1528-8951. doi: 10.1115/1.4023390. URL https://asmedigitalcollection.asme.org/biomechanical/article/doi/10.1115/1.4023390/371394/Flexing-Computational-Muscle-Modeling-and.

Yaroslav I. Molkov, Bartholomew J. Bacak, Adolfo E. Talpalar, and Ilya A. Rybak. Mechanisms of Left-Right Coordination in Mammalian Locomotor Pattern Generation Circuits: A Mathematical Modeling View. *PLOS Computational Biology*, 11(6):e1004270, 2015. doi: 10.1371/journal.pcbi.1004270.

Connor Morrow, Benjamin Bolen, and Alexander Hunt. Optimization of Artificial Muscle Placements for a Humanoid Bipedal Robot. In *Biomimetic and Biohybrid Systems*, volume 12413 of *Lecture Notes in Computer Science*, pages 257–269. Springer, Cham, July 2020. ISBN 978-3-030-64312-6. doi: 10.1007/978-3-030-64313-3_25. URL https://doi.org/10.1007/978-3-030-64313-3_25.

J. E. Nash and J. V. Sutcliffe. River flow forecasting through conceptual models part I — A discussion of principles. *Journal of Hydrology*, 10(3):282–290, 1970. doi: 10.1016/0022-1694(70)90255-6.

K. Nishizaki, R. Adachi, Y. Ambe, S. Aoi, et al. Gait transition mechanism from quadrupedal to bipedal locomotion in the Japanese macaque based on inverted pendulum. *eLife*, 2026. doi: 10.7554/eLife.109826.1. Reviewed preprint.

William R. P. Nourse, Nicholas S. Szczecinski, Alexander J. Hunt, and Roger D. Quinn. Analyzing the Interplay Between Local CPG Activity and Sensory Signals for Inter-leg Coordination in Stick Insect. In *Biomimetic and Biohybrid Systems*, pages 342–345. Springer International Publishing, 2019. doi: 10.1007/978-3-030-24741-6_34.

William R. P. Nourse, Axel Jackson, Nicholas S. Szczecinski, and Roger D. Quinn. SNS-Toolbox: An Open Source Tool for Designing Synthetic Nervous Systems and Interfacing Them with Cyber-Physical Systems. *Biomimetics*, 8(2):247, 2023. doi: 10.3390/biomimetics8020247.

H. Pery, T. Ben Eli, and E. Holdengreber. Benchmarking open-loop central pattern generator controllers for lower-limb exoskeleton walking trajectories. *IEEE Access*, 2026. URL https://ieeexplore.ieee.org/document/11523455.

Vladimir Rancic and Simon Gosgnach. Recent Insights into the Rhythmogenic Core of the Locomotor CPG. *International Journal of Molecular Sciences*, 22(3):1394, 2021. doi: 10.3390/ijms22031394.

Neider Romero, Edwin Rua Ramirez, and Gonzalo Moreno. FOUR-BAR MECHANISM'S ROTATION CENTER DETERMINATION USING NATURAL COORDINATES. *Journal of Engineering and Applied Sciences*, 15, November 2020.

William M. S. Russell and Rex L. Burch. *The Principles of Humane Experimental Technique*. Methuen & Co. Ltd, London, 1959. Reissued 1992 by the Universities Federation for Animal Welfare.

Ilya A. Rybak, Natalia A. Shevtsova, Myriam Lafreniere-Roula, and David A. McCrea. Modelling spinal circuitry involved in locomotor pattern generation: insights from deletions during fictive locomotion. *The Journal of Physiology*, 577(Pt 2):627–639, December 2006. ISSN 0022-3751. doi: 10.1113/jphysiol.2006.118703.

Ilya A. Rybak, Kevin J. Dougherty, and Natalia A. Shevtsova. Organization of the Mammalian Locomotor CPG: Review of Computational Model and Circuit Architectures Based on Genetically Identified Spinal Interneurons. *eNeuro*, 2(5):ENEURO.0069–15.2015, 2015. doi: 10.1523/ENEURO.0069-15.2015.

József Sárosi and Zoltán Fabulya. Mathematical analysis of the function approximation for the force generated by pneumatic artificial muscle. *Scientific Bulletin of the Politehnica University of Timişoara, Transactions on Mechanics*, pages 59–64, 2012.

Cody Warren Scharzenberger. Design of a Canine Inspired Quadruped Robot as a Platform for Synthetic Neural Network Control. Master's thesis, Portland State University, Digital, May 2019. URL `https://www.proquest.com/docview/2289587100?pq-origsite=gscholar&fromopenview=true`.

Malte Schilling, Jan Paskarbeit, Helge Ritter, Axel Schneider, and Holk Cruse. From Adaptive Locomotion to Predictive Action Selection – Cognitive Control for a Six-Legged Walker. *IEEE Transactions on Robotics*, 38(2):666–682, April 2022. ISSN 1941-0468. doi: 10.1109/TRO.2021.3106832. Conference Name: IEEE Transactions on Robotics.

V. A. Selionov, Yuri P. Ivanenko, Irina A. Solopova, and Victor S. Gurfinkel. Tonic Central and Sensory Stimuli Facilitate Involuntary Air-Stepping in Humans. *Journal of Neurophysiology*, 101(6):2847–2858, April 2009. doi: 10.1152/jn.90895.2008.

Ajay Seth, Michael Sherman, Jeffrey A. Reinbolt, and Scott L. Delp. OpenSim: a musculoskeletal modeling and simulation framework for in silico investigations and exchange., 2011.

Ajay Seth, Jennifer L. Hicks, Thomas K. Uchida, Ayman Habib, Christopher L. Dembia, James J. Dunne, Carmichael F. Ong, Matthew S. DeMers, Apoorva Rajagopal, Matthew Millard, Samuel R. Hamner, Edith M. Arnold, Jennifer R. Yong, Shrinidhi K. Lakshmikanth, Michael A. Sherman, Joy P. Ku, and Scott L. Delp. OpenSim: Simulating musculoskeletal dynamics and neuromuscular control to study human and animal movement. *PLOS Computational Biology*, 14(7):e1006223, July 2018. ISSN 1553-7358. doi: 10.1371/journal.pcbi.1006223. URL https://dx.plos.org/10.1371/journal.pcbi.1006223.

Michael A. Sherman, Ajay Seth, and Scott L. Delp. What is a Moment Arm? Calculating Muscle Effectiveness in Biomechanical Models Using Generalized Coordinates. In *Volume 7B: 9th International Conference on Multibody Systems, Nonlinear Dynamics, and Control*, page V07BT10A052, Portland, Oregon, USA, August 2013. American Society of Mechanical Engineers. ISBN 978-0-7918-5597-3. doi: 10.1115/DETC2013-13633. URL https://asmedigitalcollection.asme.org/IDETC-CIE/proceedings/IDETC-CIE2013/55973/Portland,%20Oregon,%20USA/256002.

Natalia A. Shevtsova, Khaldoun Hamade, Samit Chakrabarty, Sergey N. Markin, Boris I. Prilutsky, and Ilya A. Rybak. Modeling the Organization of Spinal Cord Neural Circuits Controlling Two-Joint Muscles. In Boris I. Prilutsky and Donald H. Edwards, editors, *Neuromechanical Modeling of Posture and Locomotion*, Springer Series in Computational Neuroscience, pages 121–162. Springer, New York, NY, 2016. ISBN 978-1-4939-3267-2. doi: 10.1007/978-1-4939-3267-2_5. URL https://doi.org/10.1007/978-1-4939-3267-2_5.

Hirofumi Shin, Shuhei Ikemoto, and Koh Hosoda. Constructive understanding and reproduction of functions of gluteus medius by using a musculoskeletal walking robot. *Advanced Robotics*, 32(4):202–214, February 2018. ISSN 0169-1864. doi: 10.1080/01691864.2018.1434015. URL https://www.tandfonline.com/doi/citedby/10.1080/01691864.2018.1434015.

Takaya Shin and Kiminao Kogiso. Sensorless angle and stiffness control of antagonistic PAM actuator using reference set. *Advanced Robotics*, 36(9):423–437, 2022. doi: 10.1080/01691864.2022.2046502.

Seungmoon Song, Łukasz Kidziński, Xue Bin Peng, Carmichael F. Ong, Jennifer Hicks, Sergey Levine, Christopher G. Atkeson, and Scott L. Delp. Deep reinforcement learning

for modeling human locomotion control in neuromechanical simulation. *Journal of NeuroEngineering and Rehabilitation*, 18:126, 2021. doi: 10.1186/s12984-021-00919-y.

Alexander G Steele, Alexander Hunt, and Appolinaire C Etoundi. Development of a Bio-inspired Knee Joint Mechanism for a Bipedal Robot. In *Biomimetic and Biohybrid Systems*, Lecture Notes in Computer Science, pages 418–427. Springer, Cham, July 2017. ISBN 978-3-319-63536-1 978-3-319-63537-8. doi: 10.1007/978-3-319-63537-8_35. URL https://link.springer.com/chapter/10.1007/978-3-319-63537-8_35.

Alexander G. Steele, Alexander Hunt, and Appolinaire C. Etoundi. Biomimetic Knee Design to Improve Joint Torque and Life for Bipedal Robotics. In Manuel Giuliani, Tareq Assaf, and Maria Elena Giannaccini, editors, *Towards Autonomous Robotic Systems*, pages 91–102, Cham, 2018. Springer International Publishing. ISBN 978-3-319-96728-8.

Alexander Gabriel Steele. *Biomimetic Design and Construction of a Bipedal Walking Robot*. Thesis, Portland State University, Portland, Oregon, USA, 2018.

Bethany L. Suderman and Anita N. Vasavada. Moving muscle points provide accurate curved muscle paths in a model of the cervical spine. *Journal of Biomechanics*, 45(2): 400–404, January 2012. ISSN 0021-9290. doi: 10.1016/j.jbiomech.2011.10.014. URL https://www.sciencedirect.com/science/article/pii/S0021929011006373.

Koichi Suzumori and Ahmad Athif Faudzi. Trends in hydraulic actuators and components in legged and tough robots: a review. *Advanced Robotics*, 32(9):458–476, May 2018. ISSN 0169-1864. doi: 10.1080/01691864.2018.1455606. URL https://doi.org/10.1080/01691864.2018.1455606. _eprint: https://doi.org/10.1080/01691864.2018.1455606.

Nicholas S. Szczecinski, Clarissa A. Goldsmith, William R. P. Nourse, and Roger D. Quinn. A perspective on the neuromorphic control of legged locomotion in past, present, and future insect-like robots. *Neuromorphic Computing and Engineering*, 3(2):023001, 2023. doi: 10.1088/2634-4386/acc04f.

József Sárosi. New approximation algorithm for the force of fluidic muscles. In *Applied Computational Intelligence and Informatics (SACI), 2012 7th IEEE International Symposium on*, pages 229–233. IEEE, 2012. URL http://ieeexplore.ieee.org/xpls/abs_all.jsp?arnumber=6250007.

József Sárosi, Zoltán Fabulya, János Gyeviki, Gábor Keszthelyi-Szabó, and Péter Szendr Ho. Investigation of Accuracy of the Newest Function Approximation for the Force Generated by Pneumatic Artificial Muscle. *Analecta Technica Szegedinensia, Review of Faculty of*

*Engineering*, 2013:1–2, 2013. URL http://www.analecta.hu/index.php/issues/201312/60-investigation-of-accuracy-of-the-newest-function-approximation-for-the-force-gener file.

József Sárosi, Ján Piteľ, Mária Tóthová, Alexander Hošovský, and István Bíró. COMPARATIVE SURVEY OF VARIOUS STATIC AND DYNAMIC MODELS OF PNEUMATIC ARTIFICIAL MUSCLES. *Transactions of the Canadian Society for Mechanical Engineering*, 41(5):825–844, December 2017. ISSN 0315-8977. doi: 10.1139/tcsme-2017-514. URL http://www.nrcresearchpress.com/doi/10.1139/tcsme-2017-514.

Jerrold Tannenbaum and B. Taylor Bennett. Russell and Burch's 3Rs then and now: The need for clarity in definition and purpose. *Journal of the American Association for Laboratory Animal Science*, 54(2):120–132, 2015.

Karl E. Taylor. Summarizing multiple aspects of model performance in a single diagram. *Journal of Geophysical Research: Atmospheres*, 106(D7):7183–7192, 2001. doi: 10.1029/2000JD900719.

The MathWorks, Inc. Optimization Toolbox, release r2025b, 2025. URL https://www.mathworks.com/products/optimization.html. Software documentation for gamultiobj, surrogateopt, and patternsearch.

Emanuel Todorov, Tom Erez, and Yuval Tassa. MuJoCo: A physics engine for model-based control. In *2012 IEEE/RSJ International Conference on Intelligent Robots and Systems*, pages 5026–5033, October 2012. doi: 10.1109/IROS.2012.6386109.

Barkan Ugurlu, Paolo E. Forni, Hadi Dallali, Darwin G. Caldwell, and Nikos G. Tsagarakis. Stable Control of Force, Position, and Stiffness for a Pneumatic Muscle Actuator Joint. *IEEE Transactions on Industrial Informatics*, 15(2):1240–1251, 2019. doi: 10.1109/TII.2018.2849330.

Henry W. A. A. Van de Crommert, Theo Mulder, and Jacques Duysens. Neural control of locomotion: sensory control of the central pattern generator and its relation to treadmill training. *Gait & Posture*, 7(3):251–263, 1998. doi: 10.1016/S0966-6362(98)00010-1.

Allan Joshua Veale and Shane Quan Xie. Towards compliant and wearable robotic orthoses: A review of current and emerging actuator technologies. *Medical Engineering & Physics*, 38(4):317–325, April 2016. ISSN 1350-4533. doi: 10.1016/j.medengphy.2016.01.010. URL https://www.sciencedirect.com/science/article/pii/S135045331600031X.

Huawei Wang, Vittorio Caggiano, Guillaume Durandau, Massimo Sartori, and Vikash Kumar. MyoSim: Fast and physiologically realistic MuJoCo models for musculoskeletal and exoskeletal studies. In *2022 IEEE International Conference on Robotics and Automation (ICRA)*, pages 10410–10417, 2022. doi: 10.1109/ICRA46639.2022.9811684.

Barbara Webb. Can robots make good models of biological behaviour? *Behavioral and Brain Sciences*, 24(6):1033–1050, 2001. doi: 10.1017/S0140525X01000127.

Barbara Webb. Robots in invertebrate neuroscience. *Nature*, 417(6886):359–363, 2002. doi: 10.1038/417359a.

Uwe Windhorst. Muscle proprioceptive feedback and spinal networks. *Brain Research Bulletin*, 73(4):155–202, 2007. doi: 10.1016/j.brainresbull.2007.03.010.

Uwe Windhorst. Spinal Cord Circuits: Models and Reality. *Neurophysiology*, 2022. doi: 10.1007/s11062-022-09927-7.

Jack M. Winters. Hill-Based Muscle Models: A Systems Engineering Perspective. In Jack M. Winters and Savio L.-Y. Woo, editors, *Multiple Muscle Systems: Biomechanics and Movement Organization*, pages 63–93. Springer, New York, NY, 1990. doi: 10.1007/978-1-4613-9030-5_5.

Ge Wu and PeterR Cavanagh. FOR STANDARDIZATION IN THE REPORTING OF KINEMATIC DATA. *Journal Biomechanics*, 28(10):1257–1261, 1995. doi: 0021-9290(95)00017-8.

Ge Wu, Sorin Siegler, Paul Allard, Chris Kirtley, Alberto Leardini, Dieter Rosenbaum, Mike Whittle, Darryl D D'Lima, Luca Cristofolini, Hartmut Witte, Oskar Schmid, and Ian Stokes. ISB recommendation on definitions of joint coordinate system of various joints for the reporting of human joint motion—part I: ankle, hip, and spine. *Journal of Biomechanics*, 35(4):543–548, April 2002. ISSN 0021-9290. doi: 10.1016/S0021-9290(01)00222-6. URL https://www.sciencedirect.com/science/article/pii/S0021929001002226.

Ge Wu, Frans C. T. van der Helm, H. E. J. (DirkJan) Veeger, Mohsen Makhsous, Peter Van Roy, Carolyn Anglin, Jochem Nagels, Andrew R. Karduna, Kevin McQuade, Xuguang Wang, Frederick W. Werner, and Bryan Buchholz. ISB recommendation on definitions of joint coordinate systems of various joints for the reporting of human joint motion—Part II: shoulder, elbow, wrist and hand. *Journal of Biomechanics*, 38(5):981–992, May 2005. ISSN 0021-9290. doi: 10.1016/j.jbiomech.2004.05.042. URL https://www.sciencedirect.com/science/article/pii/S002192900400301X.

Gary T. Yamaguchi and Felix E. Zajac. A planar model of the knee joint to characterize the knee extensor mechanism. *Journal of Biomechanics*, 22(1):1–10, January 1989. ISSN 0021-9290. doi: 10.1016/0021-9290(89)90179-6. URL http://www.sciencedirect.com/science/article/pii/0021929089901796.

Fletcher Young, Christian Rode, Alex Hunt, and Roger Quinn. Analyzing Moment Arm Profiles in a Full-Muscle Rat Hindlimb Model. *Biomimetics*, 4(1):10, March 2019. doi: 10.3390/biomimetics4010010. URL https://www.mdpi.com/2313-7673/4/1/10.

Felix E. Zajac and Michael E. Gordon. Determining Muscle's Force and Action in Multi-Articular Movement. *Exercise and Sport Sciences Reviews*, 17(1):187–230, January 1989. ISSN 0091-6331. URL https://journals.lww.com/acsm-essr/Citation/1989/00170/Determining_Muscle_s_Force_and_Action_in.9.aspx.

Altynai Zhagiparova, Viktor Golubev, and Daekyu Kim. Recent developments in pneumatic artificial muscle actuators. *Actuators*, 14(12):582, 2025. doi: 10.3390/act14120582.

# APPENDICES

# Appendix A: Muscle Force and Joint Torque Calculations

This appendix documents the reference implementation of the force, torque, and compliance equations used in Chapters 3–4. When present in Matlab code, file names are given so that any number in this dissertation can be traced to the code that produced it.

## A.1 Human muscle force calculations

### A.1.1 OpenSim Thelen2003 and Millard2012 Formulations

OpenSim's Thelen2003Muscle comprises a contractile element (first-order activation dynamics with distinct rise and fall time constants; active force–length curve; Hill-type force–velocity curve) in series with a compliant tendon, plus a parallel passive fiber element, with fiber pennation. Unlike the MuJoCo actuator, the fiber length is *not* the musculotendon length: at every instant the model solves the force equilibrium $F_{\text{tendon}}(L_{\text{mt}} - L_{\text{fiber}} \cos\alpha) = F_{\text{fiber}}(L_{\text{fiber}}, \dot{L}_{\text{fiber}}, a)$, so tendon compliance filters and delays force transmission and stores energy. The tendon is a quadratic-then-linear "strip" curve anchored at the slack length $L_s$ (force zero until $L_{\text{mt}}$ stretches the tendon beyond $L_s$). Millard2012EquilibriumModel, OpenSim's newer default, retains the same equilibrium structure but replaces the curve shapes (an asymmetric Gaussian active-force–length curve with a plateau, an exponentially stiffening tendon) and adds fiber damping; it is numerically better behaved at extreme lengths. Both OpenSim models therefore differ from the

converted MuJoCo model in the same single respect: series-elastic compliance.

### A.1.2 OpenSim Moment Arms and Human Torque Targets

The human torque targets of Section 3.8 are OpenSim tendon-excursion moment arms: for each muscle, the moment arm about the knee is the partial derivative of muscle-tendon length with respect to the knee coordinate, $r(\theta_k) = \partial l_{\mathrm{MT}} / \partial \theta_k$, evaluated across the range of motion. The exported analysis tables archived with the test data (`OpenSim_Vasti_MomentArm.txt`, `OpenSim_Vasti_Results.txt`, `OpenSim_Bifem_MomentArm.txt`, `OpenSim_Bifem_Results.txt`) carry the per-muscle moment arms and the corresponding maximum-isometric torque curves — moment arm multiplied by each muscle's maximum isometric force — for vastus intermedius, lateralis, and medialis, and for the biceps femoris short head; the optimization loads the vastus medialis and biceps femoris short-head columns as its targets (`buildKneeExtContext20mm.m` lines 119–140; `Knee_Flexor_Data_20mm.m` line 546). This derivative definition and the geometric perpendicular-foot construction of Equation (A4) below are equivalent for a straight muscle path crossing a planar revolute joint; the derivative form remains correct for the wrapping and moving-path-point geometry of the biological knee, which is why the human targets are computed in OpenSim rather than by the robot-side construction.

## A.2 Muscle Model Formulations and Cross-Platform Force Comparison

### A.2.1 MuJoCo Muscle Actuator (as converted)

The conversion from OpenSim to MuJoCo re-expresses each Thelen2003 muscle as a MuJoCo `general` actuator with the built-in muscle dynamics. Activation is a first-order process with distinct rise and fall time constants (0.01 s and 0.04 s in the converted model). Force is computed from the actuator's normalized length $\bar{L} = (L - L_{\min})/(L_{\max} - L_{\min})$, where the length range is taken from the converted geometry, as

$$F = F_{\max} \left[ a\, f_L(\bar{L})\, f_V(\dot{L}) - f_P(\bar{L}) \right], \tag{A1}$$

with $a \in [0, 1]$ the activation, $f_L$ a force–length curve that peaks inside the normalized range, $f_V$ a force–velocity curve, and $f_P$ a passive element. The peak force scale $F_{\max}$ (actuator parameter `gainprm[2]`) is set by the converter such that the peak force over the model's range of motion matches the OpenSim `max_isometric_force`; audited across all 84 active muscles, the deviation is $\leqslant 15\%$ (Sec. A.2.2). Two properties matter for interpretation: (i) the tendon is *rigid* – there is no series-elastic element and no tendon slack length; force at the joint equals the contractile-element force immediately; and (ii) all curve parameters are shared defaults of the converted model rather than per-muscle fits.

### A.2.2 Cross-Platform Force Comparison

Both models were driven with identical kinematics and identical activations along the subject01 walking trajectory (the same IK frames used for the static-optimization back-solve).

The OpenSim side is the StaticOptimization solution's own muscle forces (full Thelen dynamics with compliant tendon); the MuJoCo side replays the identical joint trajectory with those activations. Table A1 reports, per muscle, the coefficient of determination $R^2$ between the two force time series, the shape correlation, and the best-aligning lag.

Table A1: MuJoCo vs. OpenSim muscle force along the subject01 walk at matched activations. Lag in analysis frames ($\approx$ 17 ms each).

| Muscle | $R^2$ | shape corr$^2$ | lag [frames] |
|---|---|---|---|
| soleus | 0.742 | 0.800 | 1 |
| med. gastrocnemius | 0.888 | 0.894 | 2 |
| lat. gastrocnemius | 0.884 | 0.887 | 2 |
| tibialis anterior | 0.945 | 0.945 | 0 |
| vastus lateralis | 0.941 | 0.945 | 1 |
| rectus femoris | $-1.15$ | 0.384 | 0 |
| semimembranosus | 0.565 | 0.621 | 0 |
| biceps femoris short | $-0.26$ | 0.868 | 0 |
| psoas | 0.927 | 0.934 | 1 |
| gluteus maximus (2) | 0.926 | 0.943 | 1 |
| tensor fasciae latae | 0.933 | 0.935 | 0 |
| peroneus brevis | 0.977 | 0.989 | 0 |

For ten of twelve representative muscles the two formulations agree with $R^2 = 0.87$–$0.98$ and mean-force ratios within $\pm 22\%$, with *no* systematic phase shift (best-aligning lag 0–2 frames, $\leqslant$ 34 ms). The absence of a phase lead in the rigid-tendon model indicates that, along physiological trajectories, missing tendon slack compliance does not desynchronize force transmission; its signature is instead visible in waveform *shape*: for the soleus (the largest series-elastic energy store in human gait), the OpenSim compliant tendon carries substantial force through mid-stance while the MuJoCo rigid-tendon force follows the activation dips — the expected smoothing of the series elastic element, visible in the soleus

panel of Figure A1. The two outliers are anatomically explained: rectus femoris was rerouted in the conversion over the vastii's patella-tracking via point, and its moment-arm polyfit deviates from OpenSim's path (the same coupler artifact noted for the vastii); biceps femoris short head agrees in shape ($r^2 = 0.87$) but carries a scale offset. We conclude that the converted model reproduces OpenSim muscle force generation along physiological trajectories to a degree sufficient for neural-control studies, and that if tendon-elasticity phenomena (energy storage, force smoothing) become material to a claim, the appropriate upgrade is a compliant-tendon formulation rather than parameter retuning of the rigid-tendon model.

## A.3 BPA Force Model Implementation

### A.3.1 Goodness-of-Fit Metrics

All fitted quantities in this dissertation are scored by the shared routine `Functions/Go_OfF.m`: the root-mean-square error RMSE $= \sqrt{\frac{1}{n}\sum_i (y_i - \hat{y}_i)^2}$, the adjusted fraction of variance unexplained FVU $= \frac{n-1}{n}\ \sum_i (y_i - \hat{y}_i)^2 \ /\ \sum_i (y_i - \bar{y})^2$ (so that $R^2 = 1 - \text{FVU}$), and the maximum absolute residual $\max_i |y_i - \hat{y}_i|$ (`Go_OfF.m` lines 45–52). Lower is better for all three, which makes the triplet directly usable inside optimization objectives.

### A.3.2 Strain Measures

The musculotendon path length $l_{LMT}$ is the sum of straight segments between route via points, transformed into a common frame at each frame crossing. The contractile strain

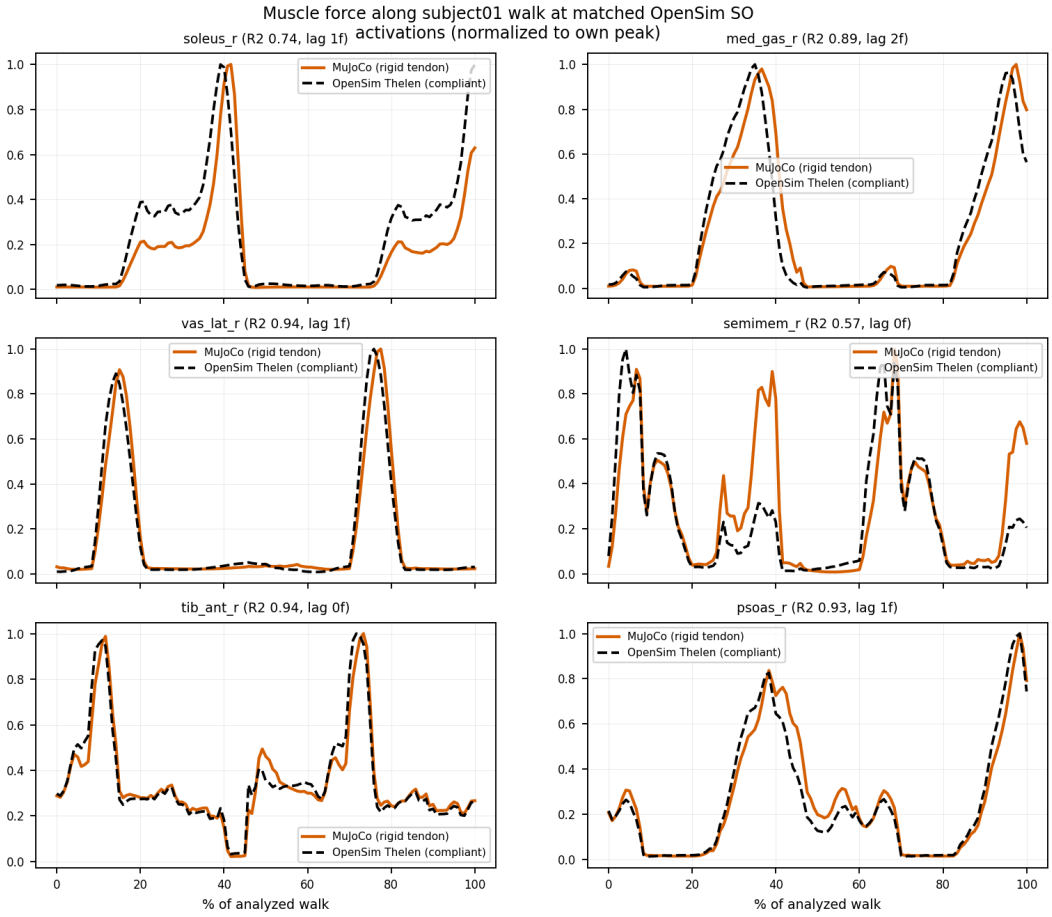



Figure A1: Normalized muscle force along the analyzed walk at matched OpenSim static-optimization activations (MuJoCo: rigid tendon; OpenSim: Thelen compliant tendon). Soleus illustrates the signature of the missing series compliance: OpenSim force is carried through mid-stance by tendon stretch while MuJoCo force follows the activation.

used by the force model subtracts the artificial tendon and both end-cap fittings from the path length before normalization by the resting length,

$$\varepsilon \;=\; \frac{l_0 - \left(l_{LMT} - l_{ten} - 2\,l_{fitting} - \chi_0\right)}{l_0}, \tag{A2}$$

where $\chi_0$ is the constant length offset of Section 3.7 (zero in the uncorrected model). [Provenance: `MonoPamDataExplicit.m` get.Contraction, lines 210–217; `minimizeFlxPin.m` lines 415–426. End-cap fitting length $l_{fitting} = 25.4$ mm is a constructor default, `MonoPamDataExplicit.m` line 69.]

The maximum free-load contraction at 620 kPa is $\varepsilon_{620} = (l_0 - l_{620})/l_0$, where $l_{620}$ is the BPA length at 620 kPa with no external load (code variable `KMAX`; `MonoPamDataExplicit.m` line 278). The relative strain is $\varepsilon^* = \varepsilon/\varepsilon_{620}$ (line 281).

### A.3.3 Normalized Force Surface

The normalized isometric force surface of Equation (3.4) is implemented in closed form in `Functions/f_festo.m` (lines 1–26),

$$F^* = c_0\left(e^{-c_1\varepsilon^*} - 1\right) + P^*\,e^{-c_2(\varepsilon^*)^2}, \qquad F^* \leqslant 0 \;\Rightarrow\; 0, \tag{A3}$$

with $P^* = P/620\,\text{kPa}$. The zero-clamp $F^* \leqslant 0 \Rightarrow 0$ is applied by the callers (e.g. `Functions/festo4.m` line 35), not inside `f_festo.m` itself. The coefficients were fitted with `fittype` nonlinear least squares and least-absolute-residual robustness (`Testing_Data/bpaFits.m`, lines 45–60 and 115–140, lower bounds $[0, 0, 0]$) and are reported in Table 4.2. The code

additionally holds a 40 mm fit not used in this dissertation ($c_0 = 0.1224$, $c_1 = 10.47$, $c_2 = 2.023$; `f_festo.m` lines 17–20).

At runtime the torque model may alternatively evaluate a spline interpolation of the manufacturer's datasheet curves (`Functions/festo4.m`, backed by `FestoLookup.mat`), with force clamped to zero for $\varepsilon^* > 1$ or $F^* < 0$. Equation (A3) replaced this lookup in the corrected model.

### A.3.4 Maximum Force

The resting-length-dependent maximum force of Equation (3.5) is implemented in `Functions/maxBPAforc` (10 mm: line 46; 20 mm: line 57; duplicate for 20 mm in `Functions/Fmax20.m`) with the fixed 7.5 mm end-contact offset. The fitted 20 mm coefficients carry confidence intervals $a_1 \in [1.4745, 1.5011]\,\mathrm{N\,kPa^{-1}}$ and $a_2 \in [0.0238, 0.0258]\,\mathrm{kPa^{-1}\,m^{-1}}$ (`Fmax20.m` lines 26–27). Total force is the product $F = F^*(\varepsilon^*, P^*)\, F_{620}(l_0)$, resolved into a vector along the force direction (`MonoPamDataExplicit.m` lines 283–287).

## A.4 Muscle Path Length and Moment Arm

Path length accumulates the Euclidean norm of each segment between via points, applying the body-frame transformation whenever the path crosses between the femur and tibia frames (`MonoPamDataExplicit.m` lines 78–95, total at lines 122–133).

The vector moment arm is implemented as the perpendicular foot of the joint origin onto the line of action,

$$\vec{r} \;=\; \vec{p} \;-\; \hat{u}\,(\hat{u} \cdot \vec{p})\,, \tag{A4}$$

where $\vec{p}$ is the vector from the joint origin to the muscle-path crossing point and $\hat{u}$ is the unit force direction (`MonoPamDataExplicit.m` lines 156–168; identical implementations in `MonoMuscleData.m` lines 111–123, the `Mom` function of `minimizeFlxPin.m` at line 539, and `MonoPam_mult.m` lines 186–201). This is the same quantity as the cross-product projection of Equation (3.7); the planar scalar moment arm about the joint axis is the magnitude of the in-plane components, computed as `hypot(mA(:,1), mA(:,2))` (`predictKneeFlexor20mm.m` line 217). Torque about the joint $z$-axis is $\vec{M} = \vec{r} \times \vec{F}$, evaluated only where the BPA is in tension (values are discarded for $\varepsilon < -0.02$, the excessive stretching region; `MonoPamDataExplicit.m` line 308).

### A.5 Compliance Model Implementation

The compliance-corrected muscle length entering Equation (3.10) is computed as $l_m = l_{LMT} - \chi_0 - l_{ten} - 2\,l_{fitting}$ (`minimizeFlxPin.m` lines 415–426; identically `minimizeExtX3.m` line 345). In the two-bracket fit of record, the insertion-bracket stiffness matrix and the projected scalar stiffness along the force direction are

$$\mathbf{K}_{br} = \mathrm{diag}(\chi_1,\, \chi_2,\, \chi_1), \qquad k_{\hat{u},br} = \left(\hat{u}^{\,T}\mathbf{K}_{br}^{-1}\hat{u}\right)^{-1}, \tag{A5}$$

matching Equation (3.12), and the origin-side second bracket contributes an additional scalar compliance $c_{b2}$ in series (Appendix C, Table C6). As executed by the evaluator of record, both bracket frames are assembled pitch-only — insertion frame at `minimizeFlxPin.m` line 289 and origin frame at line 306, with the two-rotation assemblies carried as commented alternatives — with the insertion array $[X_1, X_2, X_1]$ (line 387) and the origin array

$[X_1, X_1, X_2]$ (line 400); the two-rotation-capable twin of the same block is `minimizeFlxPin2brk.m` lines 387–418. The 2026-09-08 arm-1 array $[X_1, X_2, X_2]$ is superseded and survives only in the provenance comment at line 387, and the legacy single-bracket evaluator uses $[X_1, X_2, X_1]$ (`minimizeFlxPinX3.m` line 267).

The artificial tendon is modeled as an axial spring with stiffness

$$k_{ten} \;=\; \frac{n\,A_c\,E}{L_{ten}}, \tag{A6}$$

with $n = 2$ parallel cable strands ($\times 6$ for the 20 mm assembly), $A_c = 1.51 \times 10^{-6}\,\mathrm{m}^2$ (19-strand cable), and $E = 193 \times 10^9$ Pa (`MonoPam_mult.m`, function `Spr()`, lines 627–637; the evaluators obtain the spring rate through `Spr(bpa_i)`, `minimizeFlxPin.m` line 156). Series combination with the projected bracket compliance gives $k_{eq} = \left(k_{\hat{u},br}^{-1} + k_{ten}^{-1}\right)^{-1}$ (`minimizeFlxPin.m` lines 394–409).

The scalar compliance displacement $\delta$ of Equation (3.26) is found numerically with `fzero` on the bracket $[0,\, l_m - l_{620}]$,

$$F_{620}(l_0)\,F^*(\varepsilon^*(\delta), P^*) - k_{eq}\,\delta = 0, \tag{A7}$$

with $\delta \equiv 0$ when the uncorrected relative strain already exceeds unity (`minimizeFlxPin.m` lines 434–441). The vector bracket deflection is then $\boldsymbol{\epsilon}_{br} = \mathbf{K}_{br}^{-1}\left(\|\vec{F}\|\,\hat{u}\right)$ (line 461), the cable stretch is $\|\vec{F}\|/k_{ten}$ (line 478), and the attachment point, path, moment arm, and torque are recomputed. For the two-BPA flexor grouping, the coupled balance shares one common force between both muscles and is solved analogously on $[0, F_{620}]$ (`MonoPam_mult.m` lines 556–612).

## A.6 Wrapping-Loss Implementation

For the pinned-knee extensor, Equation (3.27) is implemented segment-wise over the wrap arc with radii $R_1 = 12\,\text{mm}$ and $R_2 = 40\,\text{mm}$ and segment boundaries $\theta_1 = 27^\circ$ and $\theta_2 = -23^\circ$ (`minimizeExtX3.m`, nested `Contraction`, lines 327–370). For the biomimetic-knee 20 mm cell, the arc-length factor is the routed bend measure $b(\theta_k)$ (arc length swept by the wrap, built with the `wRap` bend radius in `buildKneeFlexorRoute20mm.m` lines 265–268), giving $\Delta l = \chi_3\, b(\theta_k)\,(1-\varepsilon^*)^2$ (`MonoPam_mult.m` lines 398–441), with a hardcoded-geometry fallback for degenerate routes (lines 428–434). The loss enters only the force-producing strain; the kinematic (prediction) strain excludes it (`minimizeExtX3.m` lines 236–240).

# Appendix B: Neuron Model Equations

This appendix documents the neuron and synapse models used by the synthetic nervous systems in this project, both in the AnimatLab walker model and in the SNS-Toolbox implementation of the MuJoCo pipeline (Chapter 6). The authoritative model state is the working AnimatLab project file (`Biped_2xCPG_wSubs/Biped_2xCPG_wSubs.aproj`); after the network reorganization described in Section 3.11, a fresh standalone export (`Biped_2xCPG_wSubs_Standalone.asim`) runs headless and carries the rhythm-generator charts, and the earlier phase-1 instrumented export (`walk new new tester added 2 axis_phase1.asim`) records the run reported in Section 4.6.

## B.1 Spiking Neuron Model

Each spiking neuron is a conductance-based leaky integrator with threshold and adaptation,

$$C_m \dot{V} \;=\; -\,g_{\text{leak}}\,(V - E_{\text{rest}}) \;+\; I_{\text{syn}} \;+\; I_{\text{app}}, \tag{B1}$$

where $V$ is the membrane potential, $C_m$ the membrane capacitance ($g_{\text{leak}} = C_m/\tau_m$ with membrane time constant $\tau_m$), $E_{\text{rest}}$ the resting potential, $I_{\text{syn}}$ the summed synaptic current, and $I_{\text{app}}$ any applied (tonic stimulation) current. A spike is emitted when $V$ exceeds the firing threshold, after which $V$ resets and an after-hyperpolarization (AHP) of amplitude $A_{\text{AHP}}$ with time constant $\tau_{\text{AHP}}$ is applied; the threshold itself accommodates with the firing

history (relative accommodation $r_{\text{acc}}$, time constant $\tau_{\text{acc}}$). Optional calcium channels are defined but disabled in the current model ($G_{\text{max,Ca}} = 0$).

The parameter values shared by the neurons in the walker model are given in Table B1.

Table B1: Spiking neuron parameters in the AnimatLab bipedal walker model (`Biped_2xCPG_wSubs`). All neurons share these values except the motor neuron threshold noted below.

| **Parameter** | **Symbol** | **Value** |
|---|---|---|
| Resting potential | $E_{\text{rest}}$ | $-60\,\text{mV}$ |
| Membrane time constant | $\tau_m$ | $5\,\text{ms}$ |
| Initial firing threshold | $V_{\text{th}}$ | $-55\,\text{mV}$ (motor neurons: $-59\,\text{mV}$) |
| Relative accommodation | $r_{\text{acc}}$ | 0.3 |
| Accommodation time const | $\tau_{\text{acc}}$ | $10\,\text{ms}$ |
| AHP amplitude | $A_{\text{AHP}}$ | $1\,\text{mV}$ |
| AHP time constant | $\tau_{\text{AHP}}$ | $3\,\text{ms}$ |

### B.2 Non-Spiking (Graded) Chemical Synapses

Pattern-formation and motoneuron-drive connections in the walker use graded chemical synapses, whose conductance is a clipped linear ramp of the presynaptic potential,

$$g_{\text{syn}}(V_{\text{pre}}) \;=\; g_{\max}\;\text{clamp}\!\left(\frac{V_{\text{pre}} - V_{\text{th}}}{V_{\text{sat}} - V_{\text{th}}},\,0,\,1\right), \qquad I_{\text{syn}} = g_{\text{syn}}\left(V_{\text{post}} - E_{\text{syn}}\right), \tag{B2}$$

where $V_{\text{th}}$ and $V_{\text{sat}}$ are the synaptic threshold and saturation potentials and $E_{\text{syn}}$ the reversal potential. The walker model instantiates three non-spiking synapse types:

- **Nicotinic ACh (excitatory drive):** $E_{\text{syn}} = -10\,\text{mV}$, $g_{\max} = 0.5\,\mu\text{S}$, $V_{\text{th}} \to V_{\text{sat}} = -65\,\text{mV} \to -20\,\text{mV}$.

- **Hyperpolarizing IPSP (inhibition):** $E_{\text{syn}} = -70\,\text{mV}$, $V_{\text{th}} \rightarrow V_{\text{sat}} = -55\,\text{mV} \rightarrow -40\,\text{mV}$.
- **Depolarizing IPSP:** $E_{\text{syn}} = -55\,\text{mV}$, $V_{\text{th}} \rightarrow V_{\text{sat}} = -60\,\text{mV} \rightarrow -40\,\text{mV}$.

Spiking chemical synapses and electrical synapses (rectifying coupling weight 0.1, non-rectifying 0.2) are also defined in the model and are available for the sensory afferent pathways of the MuJoCo/SNS implementation.

### B.3 Relation to the SNS-Toolbox Implementation

These are the standard AnimatLab firing-rate/conductance models. SNS-Toolbox [Nourse et al., 2023] implements corresponding classes of non-spiking and spiking neurons with conductance-based synapses, and the AnimatLab parameters above served as the physically motivated initialization for the first SNS-Toolbox instantiation of the spinal network: a 406-neuron network with per-leg rhythm-generator half-centers, phase-shifted pattern-formation groups, motoneuron pools for all 92 muscle-tendon actuators of the converted model, and Ia, Ib, and II afferent populations. In that implementation the non-spiking membrane and graded-synapse equations take the same forms as Equations (B1) and (B2) with the spiking threshold and accommodation terms removed, and the afferent resting-tone offsets are zeroed so that Ia and Ib signals are pure activity measures; the rhythm-generator layer has been verified to oscillate at a human-like period with the two legs in antiphase under tonic drive (Section 6.2). An explicit parameter-mapping and validation campaign between the two implementations remains future work; the tonic stimulation tests of Section 6.2 correspond to constant $I_{\text{app}}$ injections into Equation (B1) at the motoneuron,

pattern-formation, and rhythm-generator layers respectively.

## B.4 Spiking-Mirror Implementation, Calibration, and Verification

This appendix documents the numeric details behind the spiking-neuron mirrors of Section 3.11.5, in the same file-traceable form as Appendix A: the cell and synapse equations as implemented, the calibration factors of record, the full verification-gate table of the MuJoCo mirror, and the variant-by-variant AnimatLab conversion table. The campaign's artifacts live under `Code/MuJoCo_SNS/spinal/reports_spiking_20261002/` (reports, gate scripts, logs, and metric files) and `Code/MuJoCo_SNS/spinal/` (the mirror builder `build_network_spiking.py` and its calibration script `calibrate_spiking.py`); the Simulink blocks are built by `Code/Matlab/SNS_Sims` and tested by `sns_units_test_spiking.m` in the same folder.

### B.4.1 Adapting Integrate-and-Fire Cells and Hybrid Synapses

Between spikes, every spiking cell of the MuJoCo mirror obeys the membrane equation

$$C_m \dot{V} \;=\; -\,g_m\,(V - V_{\text{rest}}) \;+\; I_{\text{syn}} \;+\; I_{\text{bias}}, \tag{B3}$$

with a spike emitted when $V$ reaches the firing threshold $\theta$, after which $V$ resets to $V_{\text{reset}}$ and $\theta$ increases by the increment $\Delta\theta$; between spikes $\theta$ decays back toward its initial value with time constant $\tau_\theta$, bounded by the adaptation floor. The tonic bias $I_{\text{bias}}$ parks the equilibrium a few millivolts below threshold, reproducing the analog cells' near-threshold operating point. Table B2 lists the per-class values as coded (SNS-Toolbox's `SpikingNeuron`

class; the toolbox's membrane update is dimensionally consistent only at $g_m = 1\,\mu\text{S}$, which the mirror therefore uses throughout). The rhythm-generator adaptation time constant reuses the analog network's persistent-sodium inactivation value, so that tuned adaptation values transfer between builds; at the rhythm gate's operating point it is 0.35 s.

Table B2: Spiking cell parameters of the MuJoCo mirror (real millivolts; `build_network_spiking.py`, `SPIKE` table, with the rhythm-generator increment superseded by the calibration of record). All cells rest at $-70\,\text{mV}$ with membrane conductance 1 µS and the tonic bias of Table B3.

| **Cell class** | $\theta$ **(mV)** | $V_{\text{reset}}$ **(mV)** | $\Delta\theta$ **(mV/spike)** | $\tau_\theta$ **(s)** |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| Rhythm generator E/F | $-50$ | $-60$ | 4.0 (calibrated) | 0.35 (analog value) |
| Pattern-formation | $-50$ | $-60$ | 0.3 | 0.15 |
| Interneurons, commissurals | $-50$ | $-60$ | — | — |
| Afferent encoders | $-52$ | $-58$ | — | — |
| Renshaw | $-52.5$ | $-58$ | — | — |

Spiking chemical synapses — both the toolbox class used in the MuJoCo mirror and the Simulink `SpikingSynapse` block — carry a conductance that decays between events and jumps by a fixed increment per presynaptic spike, saturating at its maximum,

$$\dot{g} \;=\; -\,g/\tau_{\text{syn}} \;\text{ between spikes,} \qquad g \leftarrow \min(g_{\max},\, g + g_{\text{inc}}) \;\text{ per spike,} \tag{B4}$$

with $I_{\text{syn}} = g\,(E_{\text{syn}} - V_{\text{post}})$ as for the graded synapse of Equation (B2). The Simulink `HybridSpikingSynapse` implements the same dynamics with the spike detected from the presynaptic voltage crossing a detection threshold that must sit strictly between the presynaptic resting and firing potentials (a detection threshold equal to the firing potential fires nothing, because the presynaptic voltage resets at threshold). Reversal potentials are

0 mV (excitation, above rest) and $-70$ mV (inhibition, shunting at rest) in the spiking frame, and $+8/-5$ mV in the motor neurons' 0–5 mV frame. The graded-to-spiking command pathways (descending drive, posture, and bias surrogates) keep the graded synapse of Equation (B2).

### B.4.2 Calibration of Record

Table B3 lists every calibration factor produced by `calibrate_spiking.py` (`spiking_calibration.json`), with the measured residual of each. The spike-to-motor-neuron factors are bisected so that a steady 40 Hz presynaptic train reproduces the non-spiking steady-state motor-neuron voltage; the spike-to-spiking factors are rate-calibrated (a 40 Hz source drives a relay cell at 40 Hz, and a calibrated inhibitory factor silences a 40 Hz-driven cell); the readout-tap factor maps a 50 Hz train to the full-scale analog level. The rhythm-generator threshold increment was set by an isolated-pair sweep followed by a full-network sweep over alternation quality and period target.

### B.4.3 Verification Gates of the MuJoCo Mirror

Table B4 records the complete gate set of Section 3.11.5 with verdicts and headline numbers. The two failures are reported as failures: the constant-drive period misses its tolerance with the tuning knobs identified, and the air-regime cadence clause misses while every structural clause passes. Gate scripts, logs, and machine-readable outputs are archived in the campaign folder (`tools/`, `logs/`, and the `json` metric files respectively).

Table B3: Calibration of record for the spiking mirror (`spiking_calibration.json`, 2026-10-02). Residuals are the measured deviation at each factor's calibration target.

| Factor | Value | Calibrated against | Residual |
|---|---|---|---|
| Graded saturation reference | 0.9567 | analog network measurement | — |
| Spike-to-MN, excitatory ($k_{sn,exc}$) | 5.4087 | MN steady voltage | $1.0 \times 10^{-4}$ n |
| Spike-to-MN, inhibitory ($k_{sn,inh}$) | 1.2284 | MN steady voltage | $2.6 \times 10^{-4}$ n |
| Graded-to-spiking drive ($k_{ns}$) | 0.35 | relay firing rate | $-0.67$ Hz |
| Spike-to-spiking, excitation | 1.8754 | 40 Hz rate transfer | 0.0 Hz |
| Spike-to-spiking, inhibition | 0.9996 | silences 40 Hz cell | 0.0 Hz |
| Readout tap ($g_{inc}$) | 1.7093 | 50 Hz → full scale | 5.00 mV che |
| RG threshold increment | 4.0 mV/spike | pair + full-net sweeps | period targ |
| Tonic bias current | 16 nA | equilibrium $-54$ mV | — |
| Synaptic time constants | 5 ms (exc), 20 ms (inh) | analog values | — |

### B.4.4 AnimatLab Conversion Variants

Table B5 catalogues every spiking copy built from the AnimatLab standalone exports. The conversion rules, applied by `tools/make_spiking.py` to copies (no original file touched), are: thresholds of neurons with unreachable (positive) thresholds move into the spiking regime — $-55$ mV, $-59$ mV for motor-neuron-named cells in the v1 copies, and per-class calibrated values from the measured graded peaks in the v2 copies (rhythm-generator/pattern-formation/interneuron $-53.5$ mV, motor neurons $-44$ mV, Renshaw $-44.5$ mV); relative accommodation is zeroed; every graded chemical synapse type is re-emitted as a per-spike type with the same identifier and amplitude, 10 ms decay, and maximum conductance $\max(5,\ 2\times\text{amplitude})$; and each connection's own class tag is flipped to the spiking enum. That last rule is a documented format trap: the per-connection `<Type>` tag is stored independently of the synapse type, and converting only the type kills

Table B4: Complete verification-gate table of the spiking-mirror campaign (2026-10-02). Baseline scores reproduce digit for digit; "split" denotes a gate whose clauses pass and fail in part.

| Gate | Verdict | Headline numbers |
|---|---|---|
| Pipeline compile | PASS | runner, curriculum, parameters, and network builder all compile. |
| Defaults gate | PASS | (410, 376, 1186) populations, inputs, and connections after the selector edit; variant build (888, 382, 7430). |
| Non-spiking bit-identity | PASS | default baseline score $-161.56754173676563$ identical before and after the edit (all 17 digits); other baselines $-144.46440311078322$ and $-200.37955834081458$. |
| Topology mirror | PASS | directed edge multisets identical in three gain configurations (1,186 / 7,908 / 7,762); inputs and motor-neuron maps identical; readout taps 12 / 12 / 16. |
| Constant-drive rhythm | SPLIT | sustained bilateral antiphase (E 4.9 Hz, F 3.2 Hz per leg; swing 5.13 mV in every window) = PASS; period 0.621 s versus analog 0.399 s ($+55.6\,\% > 20\,\%$) = FAIL. |
| Perturbation basin | PASS | 12/12 trials under 1 % jitter on every scalar; final swing minimum 4.58 mV (margin $0.89\times$); zero explosions. |
| Air-regime smoke | FAIL (cadence) | finite, 53 envelope rises, knee range $106.0^\circ$ of twin's $117.9^\circ$, hip $50.4^\circ$ of $71.1^\circ$; period 0.215 s versus 2.108 s. |
| Untuned ground evaluation | ran | score $-236.35$; bilateral (8 right / 9 left cycles); cycle knee minimum $-79.8^\circ$; no non-finite states; stayed up. Single run, no statistics. |
| Simulink regression | PASS | all committed demonstrations and units tests reproduce exactly with the spiking blocks in the library (two-neuron test $6.07 \times 10^{-4}$ mV). |
| AnimatLab baselines | PASS | five headless baseline runs, exit 0, periods and antiphase reproducing the records (0.443 s, 0.462 s, 1.305 s). |

the run at load with no diagnostic detail. Structural validation confirms for every copy that neuron, connection, synapse-type, chart, and stimulus sets are identical to the original and that every class tag matches its synapse type.

Figure B1 shows the ablation result at the joint level for the two-layer family: with graded synapses kept, spiking-regime thresholds leave the joint oscillation essentially intact, while the full conversion pins the joints — the visual form of Table 4.11's conclusion that the synapse conversion is the breaking change.

The spiking copies are headless-run artifacts only: none has been opened in the AnimatLab graphical environment, and graphical verification — or an equivalent acceptance ruling — remains outstanding for every `.asim` listed in Table B5. The mirror work also scoped, but did not attempt, two further conversions: the full 410-population Simulink spinal network (whose every one of 1,392 gains is tuned for graded voltages, making a spiking conversion a full re-tune rather than a parameter port) and the spiking mirrors of the alternative MuJoCo network variants (separate architectures whose fresh tuning is future work).

### B.5 Connectomes of the Spinal-Network Models

The connectome of the production gait2392 spinal network (the 410-neuron SNS-Toolbox instantiation of Section 6.2) is documented in Figures B2 and B3. Both schematics are generated by `Code/MuJoCo_SNS/spinal/draw_circuit.py` from the compiled network at the fitted walking configuration (`fitted_walk_params.json`, the IK/NNLS back-solve refit; 410 neurons, 201 per leg plus 8 shared, and 376 inputs; the eight shared cells are the

Table B5: AnimatLab spiking-conversion variants (2026-10-02 campaign). "Connexions" counts flipped per-connection class tags; the ablation converts thresholds only. All copies validate structurally and run headless to their configured end; rhythm outcomes as in Table 4.11.

| Variant | Thresholds | Neurons | Synapse types | Connexions | Rhythm outcome |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| Two-layer v1 | −55/−59 mV | 80 | 17 | 150 | dead (2 spikes / 5 s) |
| Two-layer v2 | calibrated | 80 | 17 | 150 | dead |
| Two-layer v3 | v1, 30 ms decay | 80 | 17 | 150 | dead |
| Bilateral v1 | −55/−59 mV | 96 | 20 | 208 | latch, one side 442 Hz–450 Hz |
| Bilateral v2 | calibrated | 96 | 20 | 208 | latch |
| Project export v1 | −55/−59 mV | 122 | 50 | 243 | synchronous 11.8 Hz co-burstir |
| Project export v2 | calibrated | 122 | 50 | 243 | dead (passive settle) |
| Ablation | spiking, graded synapses | 80 | 0 | 0 | oscillates, near-baseline ranges |
| 2023 reference (baseline) | spiking from birth | 56 | 3 (spiking) | 84 | 1.305 s bursts, antiphase +0.49 |

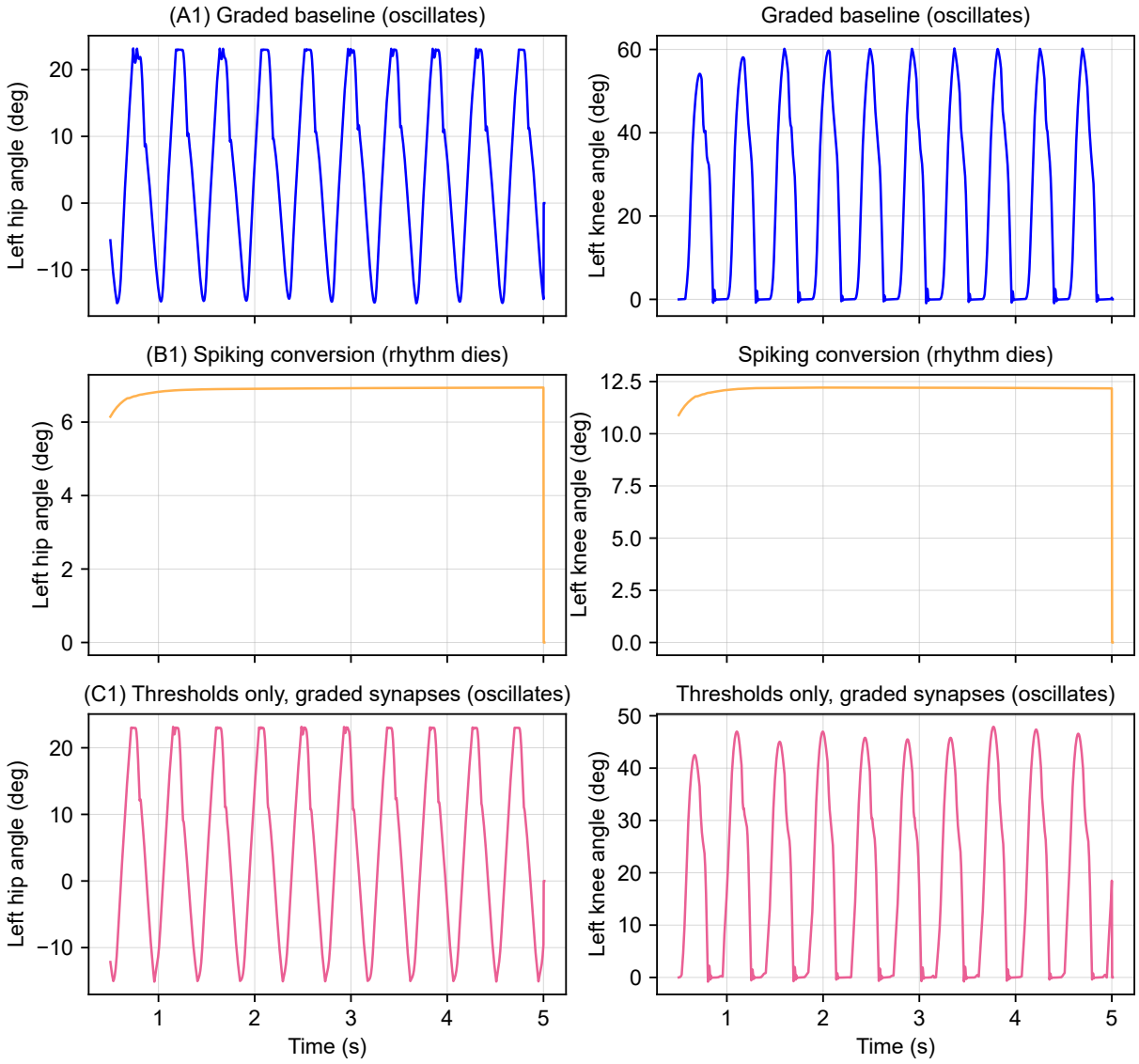



Figure B1: Left-leg joint angles of the AnimatLab two-layer walker family over the 0.5 s–5 s chart window: **(A, B)** graded baseline; **(C, D)** full spiking conversion (rhythm dies, joints pin); **(E, F)** thresholds-only ablation with graded synapses kept (oscillation preserved). Left column: hip angle. Right column: knee angle.

single DRIVE and POSTURE descending neurons and the six balance cells BAL_PF, BAL_DF, BAL_TRK_EXT, BAL_TRK_FLX, BAL_LAT_R, and BAL_LAT_L), with every motoneuron-pool membership pulled live from muscle_map.py rather than hardcoded, so the drawings cannot drift from the built network. The caption of Figure B2 and its alt-text sidecar repeat these population counts, so prose, caption, and alt text cannot drift apart either. Synapse markers follow the project convention throughout: open circles are neurons, white triangles mark excitatory synapses, and solid black dots mark inhibitory synapses.

Figure B2 draws both legs in full. A vertical dashed midline separates the sides and a pale central corridor gathers the interleg commissural inhibition. Each side is organized in labeled layer bands: descending DRIVE (MLR surrogate), POSTURE, and balance inputs; the rhythm-generator half-centers with their mutual inhibition and adaptation cells; the phase-window pattern-formation cells; the Ia, II, and Ib afferent populations with the stance-gated Ib load-sharing interneurons; and the ten motoneuron pools per side (HIP-E 7, HIP-F 4, KNEE-E 4, KNEE-F 4, ANK-PF 9, ANK-DF 3, HIP-AB 6, HIP-AD 6, TRK-E 1, and TRK-F 2, that is 46 motoneurons per leg) driving their muscles. Figure B3 shows the same network for one leg as a DRIVE/POSTURE to rhythm-generator to pattern-formation to motoneuron hierarchy, with the solved standing bias injected into every pool, the sensory column of Ia, II, and Ib afferents, and a boxed key listing every pool abbreviation with its member muscles. The spiking mirror of Section B.4 replicates this topology exactly (Table B4, topology-mirror gate), so these two figures also serve as the connectivity reference for that model.

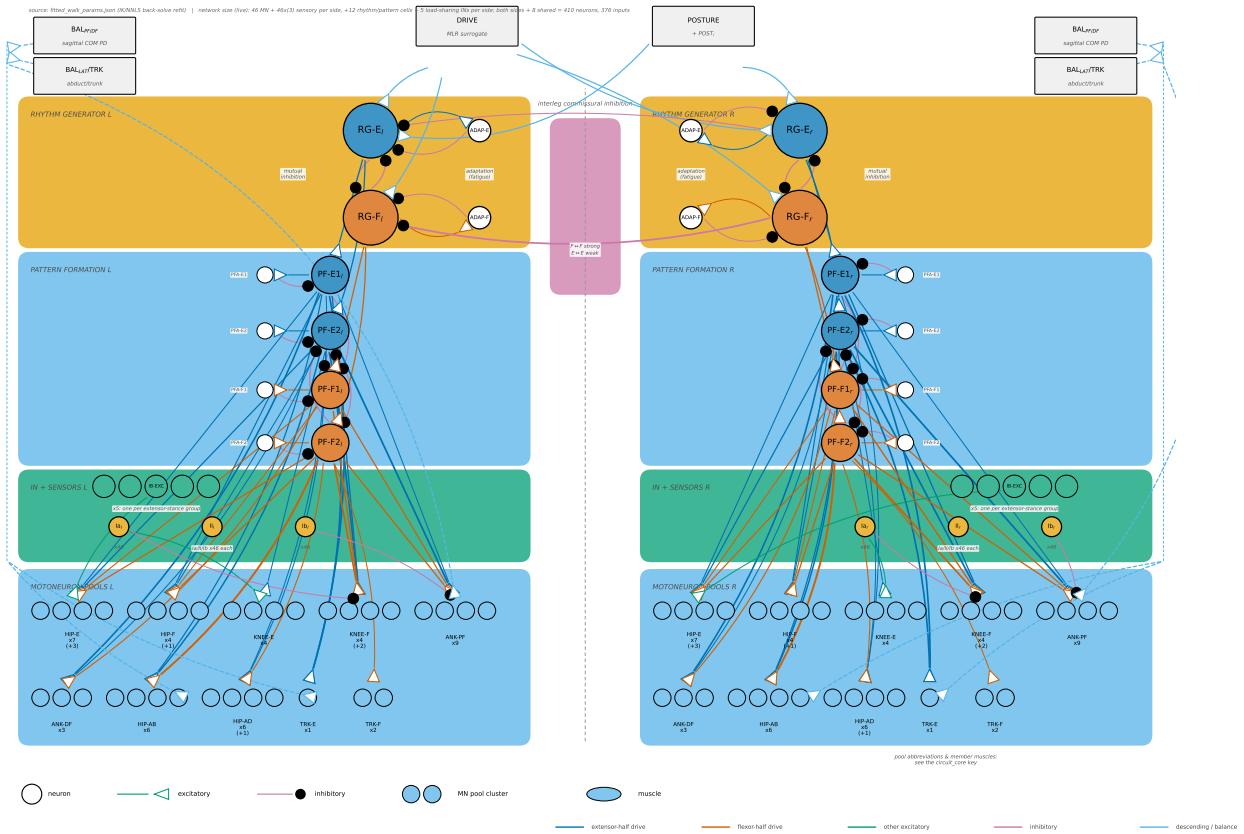



Figure B2: Bilateral connectome of the gait2392 spinal network rendered from the compiled network at the fitted walking configuration (410 neurons, 201 per side plus 8 shared; 376 inputs). Each side is organized in labeled layer bands: descending DRIVE (MLR surrogate), POSTURE, and balance inputs; rhythm-generator half-centers with mutual inhibition and adaptation cells; phase-window pattern-formation cells; Ia, II, and Ib afferents with the stance-gated Ib load-sharing interneurons; and the ten motoneuron pools per side driving their muscles. The central corridor gathers the interleg commissural inhibition across the dashed midline. Open circles are neurons, white triangles mark excitatory synapses, and solid black dots mark inhibitory synapses; the gray note names the source files.

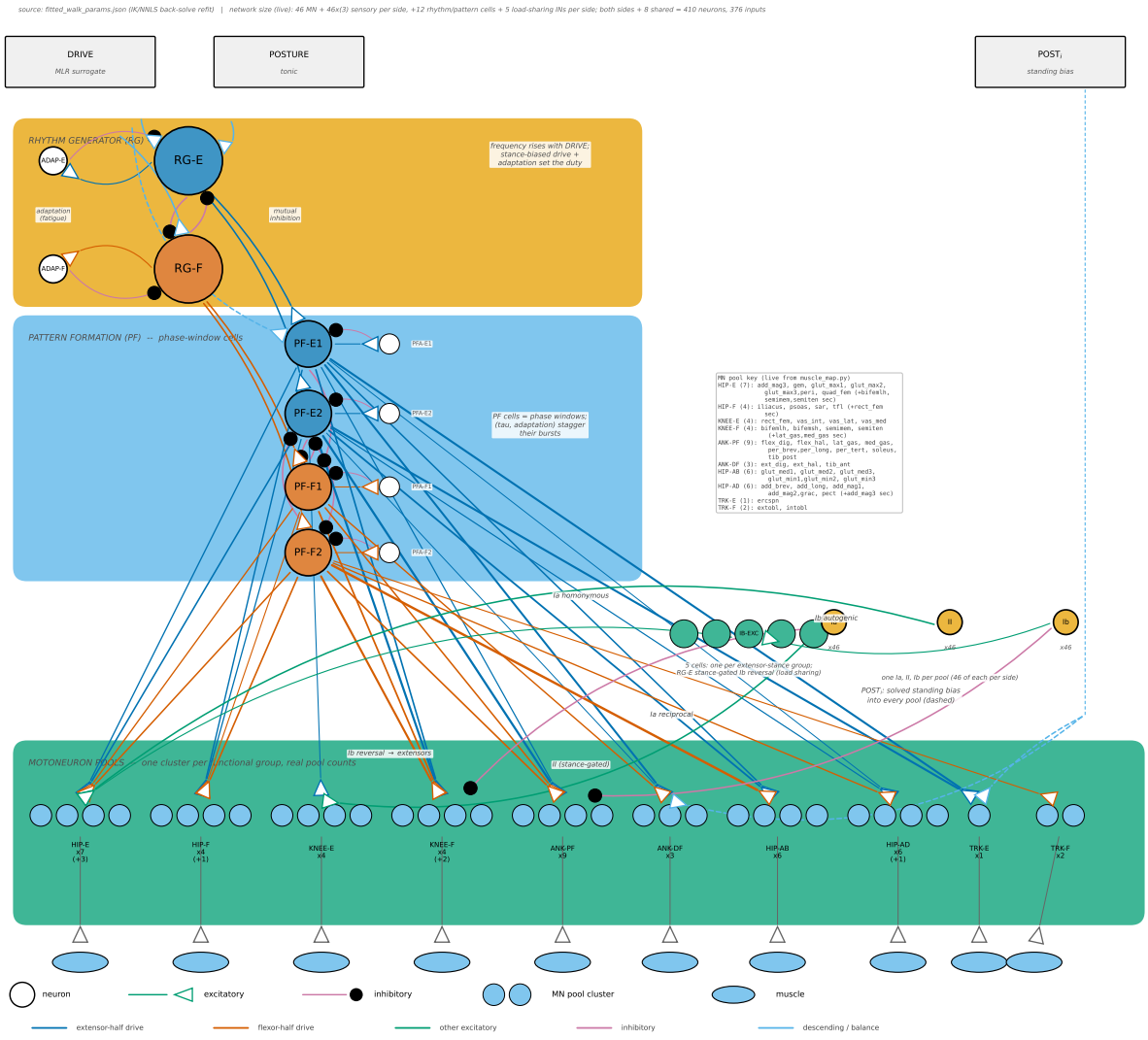



Figure B3: One-side hierarchy of the same gait2392 spinal network: descending DRIVE (MLR surrogate) and POSTURE inputs, the solved standing bias injected as dashed lines into every motoneuron pool, the persistent-sodium rhythm-generator half-centers, the phase-window pattern-formation cells, the Ia, II, and Ib afferent column, and the motoneuron pools (46 per leg) projecting to their muscles. A boxed key lists every pool abbreviation with its member muscles.

## Appendix C: Model Geometry, Bracket Frames, and Compliance Parameters

This appendix documents the numeric geometry and compliance parameters behind the torque models of Chapters 3–4 as they exist in the project's MATLAB code, with file names given so that any value can be traced to the code that produced it. Route and bracket coordinates are coded in meters and reported here in millimeters; stiffnesses are coded and reported in newtons per meter. The bracket reference points are interpretation choices for the 3D-printed (Onyx FDM) attachment hardware, set from CAD by the author; moving a reference point changes the identified stiffness values, so the points are recorded here alongside the values they produced.

### C.1 Static BPA Pathway Data

The static BPA model routes each actuator as a straight-segment polyline through via points stored in a per-test `Location` array of dimensions $M \times 3 \times N$, where $N$ is the number of joint frames in the motion sweep and $M$ the number of via points; the first row in the distal link frame is marked by a cross-point index. There are no binormal or surface-frame quantities: at each frame the force direction is the normalized vector from the cross-point row to the previous row transformed into the crossing frame,

$$\hat{\mathbf{u}} \propto \mathbf{R}^{-1}\,\mathbf{p}_{C-1} \;-\; \mathbf{p}_{C}, \tag{C1}$$

where $\mathbf{p}_C$ is the cross-point row, $\mathbf{p}_{C-1}$ the previous row, and $\mathbf{R}$ the frame-crossing rotation [Provenance: `minimizeFlxPin.m` lines 160 and 524–537 (`UD`) and 201–235 (`computeForceVector`); `minimizeExtX3.m` lines 687–700; BPA struct fields, `minimizeFlxPin.m` lines 28–35].

Table C1 lists the five pinned-knee flexor tests; their routes are two points, femur-frame origin $\mathbf{p}_1 = [-75.0,\ 100.0,\ 32.8]$ mm and tibia-frame insertion $\mathbf{p}_2 = [-50.1,\ -45.0,\ 32.3]$ mm (test 1; `FlxPinBPASet.mat`, kf(1), frame 1). Table C3 lists the extensor pinned-knee route of test 1 at $\theta_k = -125^\circ$; rows 1–6 are femur-frame and row 7 is tibia-frame, and as the knee extends, rows 2–6 release onto $\mathbf{p}_1$ (wrap released at $+35^\circ$). Table C4 lists the per-test constants of the nine extensor tests; the validation pool used for the correction terms of Section 3.7 is tests $\{1, 2, 5, 6, 7, 8\}$ [Provenance: `Dig_crossPredict.m` line 46].

Table C1: Pinned-knee flexor test BPA constants, read directly from `FlxPinBPASet.mat` (kf(1)–kf(5)). Labels are the laboratory shorthand used in the fitting logs (`minimizeFlxPin10mm_2brk.m` line 51); $l_0$, tendon, and pressure are the values used by the model. All tests use $\phi$10 mm BPAs; the 47 cm test's measured angles carry the $+5.3^\circ$ encoder correction at load time (`minimizeFlxPin.m` lines 77–80), and it was held out of the two-bracket identification as validation.

| **Test** | **Label** | $\boldsymbol{l_0}$ (m) | Tendon (m) | $P$ (kPa) | $F_m$ (N) | **Use** |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| kf(1) | 48 cm | 0.485 | 0 | 605.7 | 443.4 | training |
| kf(2) | 46 cm | 0.457 | 0 | 614.2 | 441.4 | training |
| kf(3) | 47 cm | 0.479 | 0 | 623.2 | 443.0 | held-out validation |
| kf(4) | 40 cm-tendon | 0.406 | 0.035 | 623.4 | 436.9 | training |
| kf(5) | 41 cm | 0.410 | 0 | 615.4 | 437.3 | training |

The biomimetic flexor route (`buildKneeFlexorContext20mm.m`) is a three-point path — femur-frame origin $\mathbf{p}_1$, a moving wrap point $\mathbf{p}_{\text{wrap}}$ on the tibia, and tibia-frame insertion $\mathbf{p}_{\text{end}}$ — with the wrap point held on a standoff surface of radius `bpaRb` about the joint and its $z$ placed on the projected $\mathbf{p}_1$–$\mathbf{p}_{\text{end}}$ line; the optimizer seed is $\mathbf{p}_{1,0} = [-50.0,\ 35.0,\ 50.0]$ mm

Table C2: Biomimetic knee, extensor 20 mm BPA route seed (femur frame: p1–p5; tibia frame: p6–p9; `buildKneeExtContext20mm.m` lines 431–440, Ben's fcec-ray construction of 2026-09-21; the prior SolidWorks seed is kept commented at lines 421–430). Release schedule of the verified elimination, read from the 2026-09-25 redesign of record (`Vas_Pam_20mm_Result_20260925.mat`, `routeInfo.eliminatedAngleD`): p5 at $-89.8^\circ$, p4 at $-55.7^\circ$, p6 at $-47.8^\circ$, p7 at $-20.2^\circ$, p3 at $+6.1^\circ$, p8 at $+7.4^\circ$.

| **Point** | $x$ (mm) | $y$ (mm) | $z$ (mm) | **Frame** | **Role** |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| p1 | 40.00 | 35.00 | 0 | femur | BPA origin (attachment) |
| p2 | 83.90 | −274.76 | 0 | femur | BPA contacts mounting base |
| p3 | 64.06 | −426.80 | 0 | femur | femoral contact |
| p4 | 52.83 | −441.88 | 0 | femur | femoral condyle contact |
| p5 | 37.77 | −452.14 | 0 | femur | femoral condyle contact |
| p6 | 69.85 | 34.33 | 0 | tibia | tibial contact (upper) |
| p7 | 73.50 | 19.13 | 0 | tibia | tibial contact (mid) |
| p8 | 71.98 | −12.23 | 0 | tibia | tibial contact (lower) |
| p9 | 34.06 | −66.87 | 0 | tibia | patellar ligament ring (distal, pEnd) |

Table C3: Pinned-knee extensor BPA route of test 1 at $\theta_k = -125^\circ$ (`ExtPinBPASet.mat`, ke(1), frame 1; mm).

| **Point** | $x$ (mm) | $y$ (mm) | $z$ (mm) |
|---|---|---|---|
| p1 | 30.00 | −50.00 | 0 |
| p2 | 65.00 | −350.00 | 0 |
| p3 | 42.40 | −408.50 | 0 |
| p4 | 28.20 | −421.60 | 0 |
| p5 | 10.50 | −425.20 | 0 |
| p6 | −8.60 | −422.80 | 0 |
| p7 | 42.50 | −75.90 | 0 |

Table C4: Pinned-knee extensor test BPA constants, read directly from `ExtPinBPASet.mat` (ke(1)–ke(9)). Labels are the laboratory shorthand used in the fitting logs (`Dig_resultsTable.m` line 32); $l_0$, tendon, and pressure are the values used by the model — note that the shorthand rounds several lengths (e.g. "42 cm" is $l_0 = 0.415$ m and "43 cm-tendon" is $l_0 = 0.432$ m). All tests use $\phi$10 mm BPAs. The correction terms of Section 3.7 were identified on the validation pool $\{1, 2, 5, 6, 7, 8\}$; tests 3, 4, and 9 were excluded.

| **Test** | **Label** | $\boldsymbol{l_0}$ (m) | Tendon (m) | $P$ (kPa) | $F_m$ (N) | **Use** |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| ke(1) | 40 cm | 0.400 | 0 | 624.9 | 436.3 | pool |
| ke(2) | 40 cm-tendon | 0.400 | 0.040 | 618.4 | 436.3 | pool |
| ke(3) | 42 cm | 0.415 | 0 | 605.2 | 437.8 | excluded |
| ke(4) | 42 cm-tendon | 0.415 | 0.040 | 605.2 | 437.8 | excluded |
| ke(5) | 43 cm | 0.436 | 0 | 621.8 | 439.7 | pool |
| ke(6) | 43 cm-tendon | 0.432 | 0.022 | 622.9 | 439.3 | pool |
| ke(7) | 46 cm | 0.457 | 0 | 605.9 | 441.4 | pool |
| ke(8) | 47 cm | 0.465 | 0 | 605.9 | 442.0 | pool |
| ke(9) | 48 cm | 0.480 | 0 | 605.9 | 443.1 | excluded |

and $\mathbf{p}_{2,0} = [-12.24,\ -8.87,\ 27.87]$ mm with $l_0 = 415$ mm and 25 mm tendon [Provenance: `buildKneeFlexorContext20mm.m` lines 209–218; `buildKneeFlexorRoute20mm.m` lines 98–186].

### C.2 Joint Transformation Matrices

The knee transform is planar: every joint frame is a rotation about $z$ by the knee angle $\varphi$ composed with a translation fitted to robot CAD tables of the migrating instantaneous center of rotation. With $\mathbf{R} = \mathbf{R}_z(\varphi)$, the robot (femur→ICR) transform is $\mathbf{T}_{\mathrm{Pam}} = [\mathbf{R},\ [f_3(\varphi),\ f_4(\varphi),\ 0]^\top;\ \mathbf{0}^\top\ 1]$ with $f_3, f_4$ cubic-spline fits (ICR $x$: 23.30 to 10.47 mm; $y$: $-416.65$ to $-395.66$ mm over $\varphi = 0.17$ to $-2.62$ rad), and the ICR→tibia transform is the pure translation $[f_{13}(\varphi),\ f_{14}(\varphi),\ 0]^\top$ ($x$: 29.66 to $-7.58$ mm; $y$: 25.97 to 22.33 mm), composed as $\mathbf{T}_{t1\to f} = \mathbf{T}_{t1\to\mathrm{ICR}}\ \mathbf{T}_{\mathrm{Pam}}^{-1}$ over 100 frames spanning $\varphi \in [-120^\circ, +10^\circ]$ [Provenance: `buildKneeFlexorContext20mm.m` lines 34–80; `buildKneeExtContext20mm.m` lines 30–78; `Functions/ModernRobotics/RpToTrans.m`]. In the archived test sets the per-frame transform maps tibia to femur/ICR; at $\theta_k = -120^\circ$ (test kf1),

$$\mathbf{T}_k \;=\; \begin{bmatrix} -0.5000 & 0.8660 & 0 & 0.0045 \\ -0.8660 & -0.5000 & 0 & -0.3958 \\ 0 & 0 & 1 & 0 \\ 0 & 0 & 0 & 1 \end{bmatrix}, \tag{C2}$$

i.e., $\mathbf{R}_z(-120^\circ)$ with constant translation $[4.5,\ -395.8,\ 0]$ mm, rotating to $\mathbf{R}_z(+10^\circ)$ at full extension (`FlxPinBPASet.mat`, kf(1)).

### C.3 Bracket Reference Points and Frames

Table C5 lists the bracket reference points. Each compliant bracket carries an instantaneous body-fixed frame anchored at its reference point, constructed by two rotations (yaw about $z$, then pitch about the yawed $y$). With $\mathbf{p}_b$ the vector from the reference point to the bracket-to-BPA attachment target, the yaw and pitch angles are

$$\theta_{br} = \operatorname{atan2}(p_{by},\, p_{bx}), \qquad \phi_{br} = \operatorname{atan2}(p'_{bz},\, p'_{bx}) \quad \text{with} \quad \mathbf{p}'_b = \mathbf{R}_z(\theta_{br})^\top \mathbf{p}_b, \tag{C3}$$

and the bracket-frame pose is

$$\mathbf{R}_{kbr} = \mathbf{R}_z(\theta_{br})\, \mathbf{R}_y(\phi_{br})^\top, \qquad \mathbf{T}_{kbr} = [\mathbf{R}_{kbr},\ \mathbf{p}_{br};\ \mathbf{0}\ \ 1]\,, \tag{C4}$$

so the frame's $x$ axis aims along the nominal load path. The angles are computed per configuration from the bracket geometry, not fixed [Provenance: `minimizeFlxPin2brk.m` lines 252–298; `minimizeExtX3.m` lines 461–483]. As executed, however, the flexor evaluator of record assembles *both* of its bracket frames from the yaw rotation alone (the pitch-only, one-transform pose $\mathbf{T}_{kbr} = [\mathbf{R}_z(\theta_{br}), \mathbf{p}_{br}; \mathbf{0}\ \ 1]$): insertion bracket at line 289 and origin bracket at line 305 of `minimizeFlxPin.m`, with the matching pitch-only point reconstructions at lines 318 and 331; the two-rotation assembly of Eq. (C4) is computed but left commented at lines 288, 304, and 330. For the pinned extensor the two-rotation assembly is live (transMode default `2trans`; `minimizeExtX3.m` lines 3–6 and 479–482). Force is transformed into the bracket frame by $\mathbf{RowVecTrans}(\mathbf{T}_{kbr}^{-1}, \mathbf{F}_k)$ and deformed points are mapped back by $\mathbf{RowVecTrans}(\mathbf{T}_{kbr}, \cdot)$. Because the insertion array $[X_1, X_2, X_1]$ is

$y$-symmetric, the assembly choice is numerically immaterial there; for the origin bracket it is not (see Table C6). The pitch-only (yaw-only) variant that the earlier one-transform fit used survives in `minimizeFlxPinX3.m` lines 200–209.

Table C5: Bracket reference points (mm, as coded; divided by 1000 in code). All are Ben-set CAD interpretation points; frame denotes the frame the vector is expressed in.

| **Point** | $x$ | $y$ | $z$ | **Configuration / meaning** |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| Pbri | −48.11 | −107.81 | 13.80 | pinned-knee flexor, insertion bracket (knee-ICR frame) |
| Pbr2 | −52.61 | 0 | 75.06 | pinned-knee flexor, origin-side 2nd bracket (hip frame) |
| Pbr | −3.84 | −46.44 | 62.50 | pinned-knee extensor, rib midpoint, medial side (hip frame) |
| Pbr | 8.38 | 20.75 | 25.10 | biomimetic extensor 10 mm, cantilever centroid |
| Pbr | 9.48 | −33.38 | 33.90 | biomimetic flexor 20 mm, bolt-pattern centroid |
| Pbr | −19.00 | 22.00 | 27.60 | biomimetic flexor 10 mm, cantilever centroid |

### C.4 Stiffness Arrays and Compliance

Every configuration models bracket compliance as a diagonal Hooke-law spring in the bracket frame, $\mathbf{K}_{br} = \mathrm{diag}(k_1, k_2, k_3)$ newtons per meter. The scalar compliance along the force path and its series combinations are

$$c_b = \hat{\mathbf{u}}\,\mathbf{K}_{br}^{-1}\hat{\mathbf{u}}^{\top}, \qquad c_{\mathrm{eff}} = c_b + c_{\mathrm{ten}}\ (+\,c_{b2} \text{ for the second bracket}), \tag{C5}$$

exactly as in Equations (3.12)–(3.22); when an artificial tendon is present its axial spring ($\times 2$ cables, effective steel area $1.51 \times 10^{-6}$ m$^2$, $E = 193$ GPa) adds in series, and the force balance $F_{\max} F^*(\varepsilon^*(\delta), P^*) = k_{\mathrm{eff}}\,\delta$ is solved per frame by `fzero` on the contraction interval [Provenance: stiffness arrays — `minimizeFlxPin.m` lines 387 and 400; `minimizeExtX3.m`

lines 575–584; `minimizeExt.m` line 352; `minimizeFlx.m` line 314. `fzero` force balance — `minimizeFlxPin.m` line 438; `minimizeExtX3.m` line 611; `minimizeExt.m` line 389; `minimizeFlx.m` line 352]. The per-configuration stiffness arrays and their series combinations are given in Table C6.

Table C6: Bracket stiffness arrays by configuration ($K = [k_1, k_2, k_3]$ in bracket-frame axes, N/m; optimizer solves $X_1, X_2$ assigned as shown), as executed by the evaluators of record. The flexor evaluator has no frame switch: both brackets use the pitch-only assembly (see the Bracket Reference Points and Frames section above). The pinned-extensor evaluator carries a `transMode` argument (default `2trans`, env `EXTX3_TRANS`); its axis assignment was revised by Ben on 2026-09-16, with the previous assignment kept commented in the file.

| **Configuration** | $\boldsymbol{K}$ array | **Source** |
|---|---|---|
| Pinned flexor, single bracket (legacy) | $[X_1,\ X_2,\ X_1]$ | `minimizeFlxPinX3.m` line 267 |
| Pinned flexor, insertion bracket (pitch-only frame) | $[X_1,\ X_2,\ X_1]$ | `minimizeFlxPin.m` line 387 (frame li |
| Pinned flexor, origin bracket (pitch-only frame) | $[X_1,\ X_1,\ X_2]$ | `minimizeFlxPin.m` line 400 (frame li |
| Pinned extensor, 2trans (with $X_3$) | $[X_1,\ X_2,\ X_2]$ | `minimizeExtX3.m` line 575 |
| Biomimetic extensor | $[X_1,\ X_2,\ X_1]$ | `minimizeExt.m` line 352 |
| Biomimetic flexor | $[X_1,\ X_2,\ X_2]$ | `minimizeFlx.m` line 314 |

The wrapping-loss term $X_3$ (Equations 3.27–3.29) is evaluated as $X_3\, R\, |\Delta\theta|\, \zeta^2$ per contact arc. On the pinned extensor the two physical contact arcs use $R_1 = 12$ mm (27° to −23°) and $R_2 = 40$ mm, with arc-length normalizers $27.75/(ang_1 - ang_2)$ and $92.46/(ang_2 + 120^\circ)$; on the biomimetic configurations the bend measure is $w_{\text{rap}}|\theta_{\text{turn}}|$ with $w_{\text{rap}} = 25$ mm [Provenance: `minimizeExtX3.m` lines 333–359; `buildKneeFlexorRoute20mm.m` line 268; `MonoPamDataExplicit_balanceX3.m` lines 489–494]. Table C7 records the optimizer parameterization and bounds of the adopted identification campaign: the two-bracket flexor fit solves all three terms, and the extensor refit locks $(X_1, X_2)$ to the adopted flexor-front values — the 2026-09-20 extensor front was generated with the pair fixed to flexor front

row 77 and only $(X_0, X_3)$ searched — enforcing a single stiffness pair across configurations.

Table C7: Optimizer parameterization and bounds of the adopted identification. Length offsets are carried in centimeters and stiffnesses on a base-10 logarithmic scale; the initial population of the flexor run was drawn from $X_0 \in [5, 15]$ mm, $X_1 \in [5 \times 10^4, 5 \times 10^5]$ N/m, $X_2 \in [7 \times 10^3, 1.5 \times 10^4]$ N/m.

| **Identification** | **Solved terms** | **Bounds** |
|---|---|---|
| Two-bracket pinned flexor | $X_0, X_1, X_2$ | $X_0 \in [0, 20]$ mm; $X_1 \in [3 \times 10^4, 10^6]$, $X_2 \in [5 \times 10^3, 2 \times 10^4]$ |
| Pinned extensor refit | $X_0, X_3$ | $X_0 \in [-20, +5]$ mm; $X_3 \in [0, 1]$ |

[Provenance: `minimizeFlxPin10mm_2brk.m` lines 82–83 (bounds) and 424–432 (parameterization); `minimizeExt10mmX3.m` lines 23–26 (lock load) and 67–68 (bounds); `Collect_ExtPinX3_sweep.m` lines 59–60.]

### C.5 Adopted Correction-Term Values

Table C8 records the correction-term values adopted at the time of writing, together with the results file and front row each value was taken from. The initial single-bracket identification reported with the results figures (Table 4.3) was superseded by the two-stage campaign described in Section 4.4: a two-bracket flexor identification over the four training tests of Table C1 (encoder-corrected, cross-validated), followed by an extensor refit that locks $(X_1, X_2)$ to a member of the same flexor Pareto front and solves only $(X_0, X_3)$ on the extensor validation pool. The pinned-flexor data do not uniquely determine $(X_1, X_2)$ — the cross-validation fronts contain a family of stiffness pairs of comparable fit quality — so the adopted flexor row (front row 77) and the locked extensor refit (flxr77 front row 32, generated with the pair fixed to that same row-77 pair) are two operating points tied to one

and the same stiffness pair. The row-77 pair was adopted because it is the pair for which both redesign configurations meet the required 5 % torque-overshoot target simultaneously: in the 2026-09-20 campaign the flexor redesign reached a minimum margin of $+5.00$ % and the locked extensor redesign $+5.043$ % at $-20.2^\circ$ (`Dig_out/frommat_flx_20260920.log` and `Dig_out/Opt_flxr77_20260920.log`); the refined redesigns of record improve this to $+5.01$ % (flexor, 2026-09-21) and $+5.02$ % (extensor, 2026-09-25).

Table C8: Adopted correction-term values of record. Flexor source: `minimizeFlxPin10_results_20260908_2brkt_2trans_noT3.mat`, pooled two-bracket Pareto front (212 members), row 77. Extensor source: `minimizeExt10mmX3_results_20260920_flxr77.mat`, row 32 — a front generated with $(X_1, X_2)$ locked to flexor row 77 (mat fields: `LOCKSRC` "soft-Xi2 lock from flexor 2trans_noT3 front row 77", `xi1lock` 39978.7285, `xi2lock` 14733.7523, `flxRow` 77) with only $(X_0, X_3)$ searched. The redesign context builders load exactly these values: `buildKneeFlexorContext20mm.m` pick 77 at lines 171–182 with $X_3$ from flxr77 row 32 at lines 188–191, and `buildKneeExtContext20mm.m` pick 32 at lines 164–171. Regenerating the results files updates this table.

| **Term** | **Value** | **Source** | **Row / pick** |
|---|---|---|---|
| Flexor $X_0$ | $+3.94$ mm ($3.937 \times 10^{-3}$ m) | flexor mat | 77 |
| Flexor $X_1$ | $3.998 \times 10^4$ N/m | flexor mat | 77 |
| Flexor $X_2$ | $1.473 \times 10^4$ N/m | flexor mat | 77 |
| Extensor $X_0$ | $-6.38$ mm ($-6.378 \times 10^{-3}$ m) | extensor flxr77 mat | 32 |
| Extensor $X_1$ (locked) | $3.998 \times 10^4$ N/m | flexor mat | 77 |
| Extensor $X_2$ (locked) | $1.473 \times 10^4$ N/m | flexor mat | 77 |
| $X_3$ | 0.158 | extensor flxr77 mat | 32 |

At the adopted flexor values, per-test torque-prediction RMSE against the five pinned-flexor tests is 2.16/1.37/2.29/1.61/1.08 N m (48, 46, 47, 40-tendon, 41 cm; FVU 0.17/0.05/0.16/0.04/0.03), the 47 cm test being pure held-out validation. At the adopted extensor values, per-test RMSE on the six-test validation pool spans 0.49–1.52 N m against 0.95–3.62 N m for the

uncorrected rigid model, improving on the baseline in every pool test; the fraction of variance unexplained stays below unity on every pool test except the 43 cm-tendon test (FVU 1.33, against a rigid-baseline FVU of 4.73). The three excluded tests (3, 4, 9) are not part of the fit of record. On the biomimetic extensor test ($l_0 = 51.8$ cm) the same values give RMSE 1.17 N m, FVU 0.67, and maximum residual 2.21 N m, against a rigid baseline of 3.03/4.49/5.59 — the shared-pair correction now explains the bulk of that configuration's measured torque variance as well as its level. The redesign optimizations load these values directly: `buildKneeFlexorContext20mm.m` reads the flexor front, pick 77, for $(X_0, X_1, X_2)$ at lines 171–182 (its $X_3$ from flxr77 row 32 at lines 188–191), and `buildKneeExtContext20mm.m` reads the flxr77 extensor results file, pick 32, at lines 164–171. Regenerating the results files updates this table.

### C.6 Redesigned Extensor Route Geometry

This section documents the geometry of the redesigned extensor route of record (Section 4.4) as saved by the 2026-09-25 optimization run (`Vas_Pam_20mm_Result_20260925.mat`, the run cited in Table C2). Figure C1 reproduces the optimizer's tiled route-geometry view from that mat: eight pose panels sweep the 100-frame solution, drawing full flexion ($\theta_k = -120.0^\circ$), the solver frame immediately before each of the six contact-elimination events, and full extension ($+10.0^\circ$). The panel angles are the last poses at which the released row is still active; the release angles of Table C2 are the first poses at which each row is off, one pose spacing of $1.31^\circ$ later. Beyond the release schedule, the 2026-09-25 mat also carries a top-level `removedText` field reading '`-p8`'. This field is a plotting leftover rather

than a route statement: the plotting block of `Opt_run_Ext.m` (lines 730–736) computes `removedText` only as part of each interior pose-panel title, naming the point released in the next frame, and the value left in the mat is the one from the last interior panel, the p8 release-event panel at $+6.06^\circ$ in Figure C1. The route of record does contain p8: like p3, released at $+6.1^\circ$, p8 stays active from full flexion through 97 of the 100 design-grid frames until its release at $+7.4^\circ$ near full extension (Table C2), so the seed table and release schedule document the route as run. Each panel draws the active p1:p9 route in the femur frame (tibia-side rows transformed through the ICR) over the femur-cylinder, femur-wall, corrected-condyle, and tibia clearance envelopes of the route-elimination rule, with the local bend-radius checks at p2 and p8 drawn dashed. The optimized endpoint values of this design are $\mathbf{p}_1 = [40.0,\ 137.0,\ 0]$ mm (femur frame) and $\mathbf{p}_{\mathrm{End}} = [34.4,\ -197.1,\ 0]$ mm (tibia frame), with resting length 827.7 mm and 36.8 mm of tendon.

Figure C2 places the same optimized route on the OpenSim bone-surface point clouds (`Open_Sim_Bone_Geometry`) at exactly zero knee angle: the full skeleton (femur, tibia, pelvis and hip, sacrum, lumbar spine, and foot) is drawn behind the three human vastus reference paths, and the optimized p1-to-pEnd route carries a total BPA-plus-tendon path length of 0.784 m at this pose. Animated sweeps of both redesigned routes over the full flexion range are archived with the optimization results (`Knee_Extensor_20mm.gif`, 2.3 MB, and `Knee_Flexor_20mm.gif`, 4.7 MB, in `Code/Matlab/Mesh_Optimization/Results`).

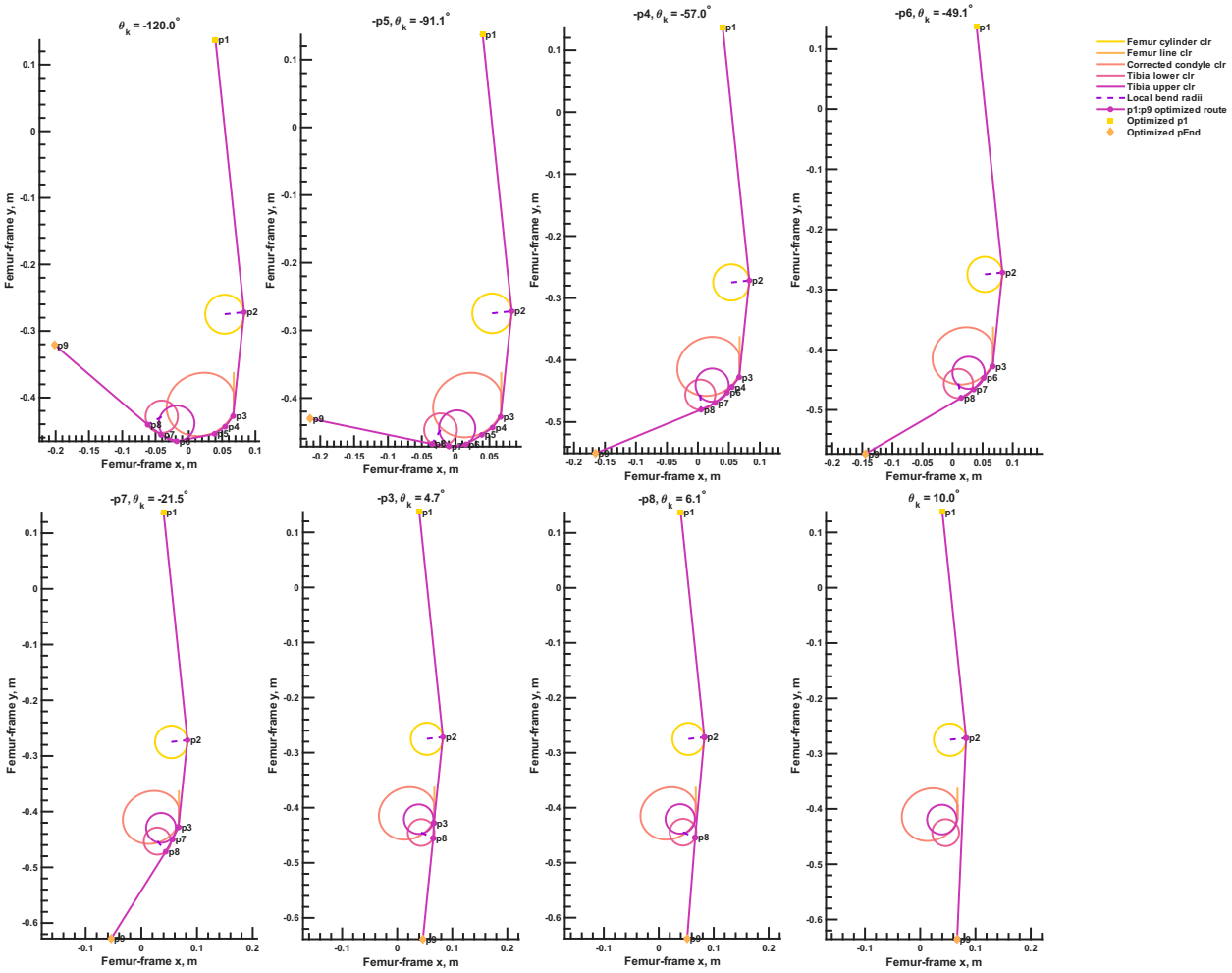



Figure C1: Eight-panel route-geometry view of the optimized 9-point extensor route of the 2026-09-25 design of record (`Vas_Pam_20mm_Result_20260925.mat`), drawn in the femur frame. Panels show full flexion ($\theta_k = -120.0^\circ$), the solver frame immediately before each contact-elimination event (before p5 at $-91.11^\circ$, p4 at $-56.97^\circ$, p6 at $-49.09^\circ$, p7 at $-21.52^\circ$, p3 at $+4.75^\circ$, and p8 at $+6.06^\circ$), and full extension ($+10.0^\circ$); each interior panel title names the point released in the next frame. The circled polyline is the active p1:p9 route over the femur-cylinder, femur-wall, corrected-condyle, and tibia clearance envelopes; dashed lines mark the local bend radii at p2 and p8; the square marks the optimized origin p1 and the diamond the optimized distal endpoint pEnd. Regenerated by `Export_AppendixRouteGeo.m`, which ports the plotting block of `Opt_run_Ext.m` verbatim.

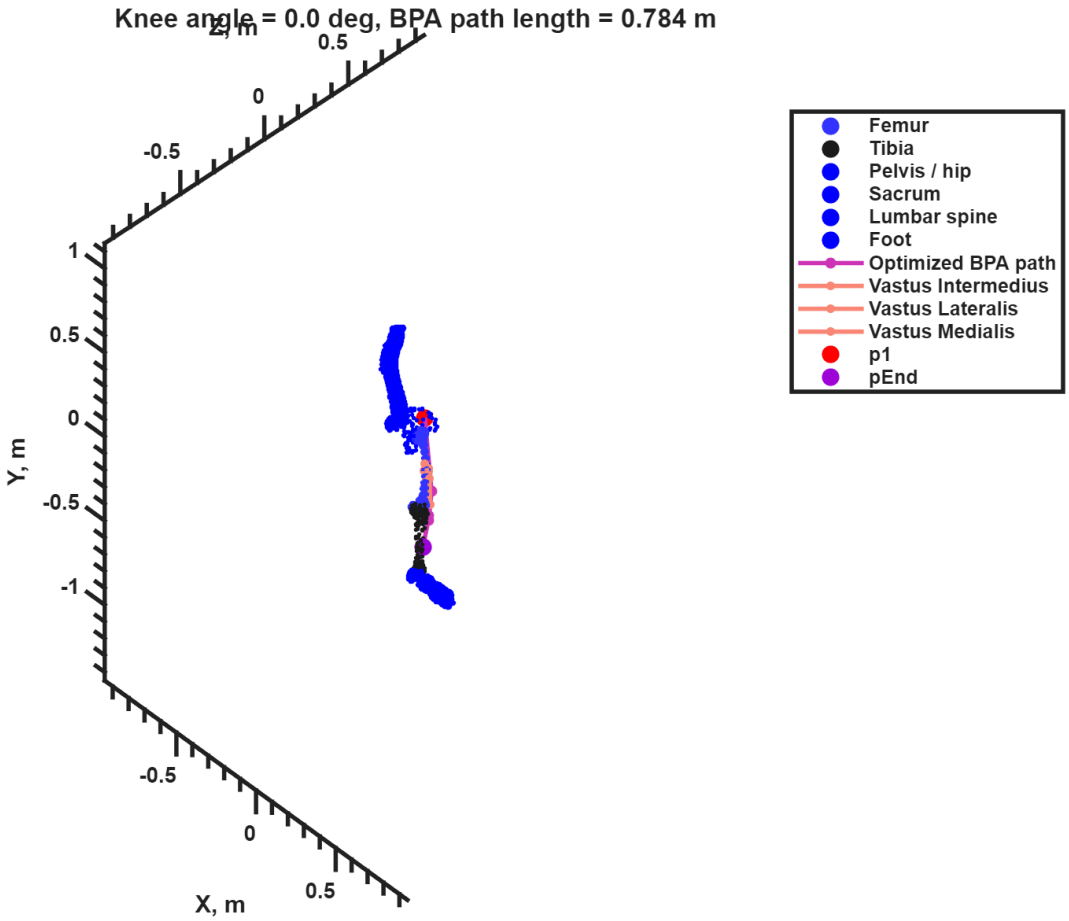



Figure C2: Static bone-mesh view of the optimized 20 mm extensor route at $\theta_k = 0°$: OpenSim bone-surface point clouds of the full skeleton (femur, tibia, pelvis and hip, sacrum, lumbar spine, and foot) with the Vastus Intermedius, Vastus Lateralis, and Vastus Medialis reference paths in light orange and the optimized p1-to-pEnd route in magenta with its endpoints circled. The axis title records a BPA path length of 0.784 m at this pose. Rendered by the static section of `Results/Knee_Extensor_20mm.m` pointed at the dated design-of-record mat (`Export_AppendixBoneMesh.m`).